

KARINA WISTERA

IN A BUBBLE



In A Bubble (Book I)
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*To those living through tough times,
thinking they'll never come to an end.
Remember, even the weariest day draws to an end.*

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Wistera's note

I'm infinitely grateful for your desire to dive into the world of shadows. This is my debut book. It is an allegory of a rough time in my life. And, before it begins, I'd like to warn you: this story is as grim and terrifying as the characters inhabiting it. The novel includes the use of *swearing, mentions of existential crisis, jealousy, blood, death, cruelty, human trafficking, kidnapping, depression, suicidal thoughts, suicide attempts, bereavement, drug use, emotional violence, physical violence, dubious consent/non-consensual, sexual assault, indecent assault, murder attempts, homicide and sex scenes.*

This book is in no way meant to normalize violence, emotional or physical. I stand against it in any shape or form.

This book was written for the fans of dark romance, for those capable of drawing a clear, heavy line between real life and fiction.

I urge you only to proceed with the book if you feel that your emotional state is stable. If, at any point, reading the novel makes you feel unwell, please, take a break and put the book aside.

Your mental health truly matters.

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PART I

Tenebrae animae

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CHAPTER 1

~~The road to the great unknown always terrified me. What if I don't make it? What if I fail? What if I'm not good enough? What if I make a mistake...?~~

“Zoe?”

Bell's clear voice pulled me out of daydreaming, dragging me back to reality.

“What?”

I kept staring at her cup, finally looking up after a while.

“Is it the headache again?”

I nodded, feeling the sharp, pulsating pain grow stronger, the effect clearly showing on my face. I grimaced, rested my elbows on the wooden table and tried rubbing my temples with my cold fingertips. The whining pain persisted, and I soon gave up.

I rested my head on my left arm with a heavy sigh. Bell leaned over to get to my eye-level.

Her eyes were overflowing with worry, and I tried my hardest to smile back.

I would rate today's ache a seven out of ten. It's gnawing, dull, annoying, but not as maddening as it can be when it's a ten out of ten pain.

When my pain is a ten, it gets so excruciatingly bad that my head feels like a volcano ready to erupt right from the top.

“Here. Take these.”

Bell handed me a blister of pills and I took it meekly, popping a few out.

I looked at Bell while washing the pills down with some water. I liked how her comely appearance matched her personality. Her impeccably straight dark chocolate hair reflected her composure, diligence,

determination, and, at times, her aloof and no-nonsense attitude. Her soft features gave away her inner kindness and sensitivity. Her eyes bore the color of fallen leaves, glimmering with more care and humanity some can have in their entire being.

“Thanks.”

“Did you quit taking your meds?”

“I’m sick of them. They take the symptoms away, but they don’t treat the cause.”

“But they make the pain go away.”

“They do.”

I took the silver spoon and carefully gathered the foam at the edges of my white porcelain cup with a blue pattern.

“Why make yourself suffer, then?”

I lifted the foam-filled spoon and licked it.

It was sweet.

“Guess I hope it would go away on its own.”

I mumbled, still holding the spoon in my mouth.

“And it doesn’t, does it?”

“No. I’m waiting for the right moment.”

I looked up, smirking mischievously.

“Zo-Zo.”

“Bell, you clearly have some kind of disorder, you should really see a...”

She dipped fingers in water and sprinkled some on me.

“Hey.”

Smiling, I wiped off the droplets with a sleeve of my wool sweater.

“Don’t you talk back to me, Zo-Zo.”

I laughed, only now noticing a small part of the pain dissolving, like ice in warm milk.

Bell and I are roommates. She never told me this, but I know she’s afraid of leaving me alone.

Last semester my headache got so bad I fainted while trying to get up, dropping to the floor like a broken doll.

Luckily, Bell came back for a textbook she’d left behind and called an ambulance once she saw me.

I remember opening my eyes and hearing her soft sobs. She was sitting at my hospital bed, hiding her face in the sheets in an attempt to

muffle them.

That incident reminded me of a story I'd forgotten, the story I used to think about a lot.

Sophomore year.

Late at night.

We were in our beds, chatting, not feeling like sleeping just yet. Bell decided to share a childhood memory with me.

Back when she was little, her parents took her to stay at grandma's. And one morning she woke up, and her grandma very much didn't. At the time she didn't know what death was and what it was like to never speak to someone you love ever again. She thought her grandma was sick. She'd bring her food and lie down next to her. She would tell her stories mom used to read her. She could barely read back then, but her memory was great.

When her parents came to pick her up, their faces were frozen in horror. The body began decomposing, filling the air with the smell of rotting flesh. They approached the bed and saw little Bell, lying next to grandma. She was talking to the body, stroking its discolored arm.

Thinking back about it as an adult, Bell told me she actually knew what was going on at the time. She was just so scared she didn't want to believe it. She thought death won't take your family if you don't believe in it.

At the hospital, I opened my eyes and ran my hand over Bell's head. Through tears, she uttered: "I'm so sorry." I told her she had nothing to be sorry for, that it was my fault for scaring her like that. She shook her head and said, "I thought you were dead. I'm sorry."

She would never leave me on my own after the fall. She would leave the room less and spend more time with me. Despite my efforts to persuade her I was fine and a promise to try and fall on the bed next time to lessen the dramatic effect, I could still see her struggle with it, trying to dig her heels in.

Bell opened her textbook notes and got started on the homework.

Sweltering, stuffy summer made way for a cool, refreshing fall. Lush treetops switched color from green to gold before losing their leaves altogether. Cool breeze played with my hair, the sun caressing my face with its vibrant rays.

We were sitting at the Deaf coffee shop. This was Bell's favorite spot. She loved taking us here. To be honest, Ilion didn't really offer many options when it came to going out. It all boiled down to choosing one of the two places. You'd keep going to Deaf, ordering the same thing until you're sick of it. Or you'd go to the other coffee shop, aptly named The Coffee Shop, and have an instant coffee, feeling glad to have some semblance of a choice.

Ilion was a town that evoked no desire to stop by and have a stroll. You'd just drive right through it without a second thought. There was nothing interesting or worthwhile there. It felt barren. Most people living here were retirees who saw no reason to leave, and students who came to study and leave as soon as they're done.

"Aren't you going to do your homework?"

"I want to drop out."

"This is our last year."

My gaze dropped back to the cup.

"And where are you going to work?"

"I don't know."

"What do you want to do?"

"Nothing."

I went on stirring the rest of my coffee, the spoon softly clinking at the sides of the cup.

"You should really hold your horses, don't you think? Look, how about you finish what you started, and maybe you'll get some clarity along the way."

"It's too late for the clarity, Bell."

I tapped the spoon on the cup, trying to get rid of the leftover foam and dregs.

"That doesn't mean it won't come to you. We're free now, and we probably don't even realize our privilege, but..."

"It's called burden, not freedom."

I laid the spoon on the saucer and looked up, folding my arms.

"I want to cheer you up, but I don't want to spew clichés."

I glanced back at my cup.

"When you don't know what you like, you try things. When you're studying and can't decide what you like, you keep learning and trying stuff."

“I’m sick of classes and the university. They’re sucking the life out of me. How am I supposed to try anything?”

“Do you really want to drop out?”

“Yes.”

“Zo-o.”

“My parents won’t let me anyway. I talked to them about it back at the hospital. I thought it was the right time, a solid reason for them to hear me out. But they’d hear nothing about it. It was a slap in the face for them.”

I remember enrolling in my first year here, everyone had so much drive, such aspirations, so much hope for the future. It felt like the world was ours, and we’d be the ones to change it, for sure. Thinking about it now, we were so pathetic.

The question of “What comes next?” began gnawing at me during my sophomore year. It was compelling, pressing, uncomfortable and suffocating at times.

In the end, I found no answer to it, and I was so jealous of people like Bell. People who know who they want to be practically from the cradle.

Bell always wanted to be a teacher. As a teenager, she grew fond of Philosophy books. From this equation she derived a dream, transforming it into a goal. She wants to teach Philosophy at a university. She likes studying and does so remarkably well.

Once she gets her bachelor’s degree, she’ll apply for a master’s degree. With a master’s degree, she’ll enter a grad school. Get her doctorate and undertake an internship. And once the internship is complete, she’d teach at some university.

She knows what she wants. She can see her future ahead of her, and it’s crystal clear.

Which can’t be said about me.

“Maybe you just don’t feel like doing your homework?”

Bell looked at me with a playful smirk.

“Maybe.”

I couldn’t resist smiling back.

My phone vibrated, the screen lighting up to a family photo. Dad on the left, mom on the right and me in the middle. We were hugging, glowing with joy.

The phone was moving on the table like a wind-up toy.

“Aren’t you gonna take it?”

“Don’t feel like it. Mom’s been calling way too often recently.”

I declined the call, vibration immediately coming to a halt, and turned the phone over.

“They’re worried about you.”

“Had they been worried, they’d let me drop out when I was in a hospital bed, begging them.”

“But there’s not much left.”

“A year is too long for me.”

Bell closed her notes.

“I don’t get you, Zoe. You don’t want to study, yet you have no idea what you want to do if you drop out.”

“I’ll bus tables.”

I picked up the spoon and began stirring the dregs at the bottom of the cup.

“But you don’t like that.”

“I don’t like it here, either. At least they’d pay me over there.”

“And you’re gonna leave me here on my own? I don’t have anyone but you around here.”

“You’re smart. You’ll make new friends.”

I stopped fiddling with the spoon.

“But no one can take your place, Zo... Then again...”

She got a far away look in her eyes, raising her pencil to her lips.

“Come to think of it, there is this girl in our year. Her and I...”

I splashed Bell with water again, cutting her off.

She dipped fingers in her glass of water and splashed some back at me.

We were laughing out loud, sprinkling each other with water.

“If you stay at the university, I’m going to help you out with the homework. But!”

She raised her index finger, pastel pink manicure glimmering on her fingertip.

“In return, you have to promise to attend all the lectures with me.”

I sighed mournfully.

“Aaand...”

“Aren’t the lectures enough?”

“You will come to Deaf with me on Sundays.”

“But I’m coming here with you every Sunday anyway.”

“See. You’re doing it. You’ve already made the first step on the road to your bright future.”

I sprinkled her again.

“Thanks.”

She splashed me back.

“You’re welcome.”

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CHAPTER 2

~~When I think of easiness, I always think of emptiness. How often one hides behind the other. Easiness is balmy, unobtrusive, soft, like a fluffy cloud. Emptiness is the expression of inertness and stasis in the face of dynamic inner changes.~~

~~I want to be at ease forever.~~

~~I want to stay in the emptiness for good.~~

~~I don't want to change.~~

~~I want to stay.~~

“Quiet, please. The class will be over soon.”

I glanced at the black hand of the clock hanging above the green chalkboard.

Too slow.

Time has forgotten it's not a snail. This is our third class today, but it feels like the sixth. Thinking gets increasingly more difficult, and the allure of skipping the rest of classes feels highly tempting.

Teacher's voice was so monotone it was hard to keep track of the lecture. I actually began dozing off. My brain was on the verge of shutting down, while my right hand kept taking notes, as if possessed by a separate entity.

I turned my head to look at Bell, she seemed as cheery and invested as ever. How does she do it?

Fatigue ate away at my brain, and I could no longer comprehend information. I felt like an overflowing can. No matter how hard you try, you won't add more to it.

Faint headache was throbbing in my temples. The piercing sound of recess bell only made it worse. The auditorium buzzed with voices like a beehive. I stayed in my seat. It's lunch time, and the noon recess, too. Everyone was in a hurry to get in the line and snatch a good table at the cafeteria.

I closed my eyes and began to breathe deeply.

When I was at the hospital, doctors suspected I had a regular anemia, but the lab tests dismissed the initial diagnosis. Next, they made a barrage of hypotheses, from common fatigue to a brain cyst pressing on the surrounding tissues and disrupting the circulation. They did an MRI, but learned nothing new. In the meantime, headaches kept tormenting me even at the hospital. They began giving me saline drips that would alleviate the pain for a time. Eventually, they prescribed me vitamins and painkillers and I was discharged.

I opened my eyes and saw Bell talking to the teacher.

My phone began vibrating and I walked out of the auditorium.

My family set up a group chat to stay in touch. I like sharing pics to show where I've been and what I've been doing, as well as checking the snippets of the life back home. I like learning what mom cooked or where dad and her went over the weekend.

They began having date nights more often once I left. They have been spending more time together. I'm happy for them, and I miss them terribly. I miss my room, and my noisy Rayville. As much as Rayville was my city, Ilion felt completely alien. I was used to crowds, the buzzing energy of the city, its wild rhythm and the easy access to things, food and fun things to do. When I arrived to Ilion, the town looked dead.

I could never understand how places could turn into ghost towns, but Ilion really felt like a fitting candidate to become one.

I only go back to Rayville on holidays, if ever. My city is over twelve hundred miles away from Ilion. Ilion has no airports, no railway, I have to take a bus to visit home.

I rested against a cool wall and left a message in the chat, saying I was okay and the headache was gone.

"A rose for the fair lady. Red like her lips. As vibrant as she is."

Oscar held a red rose out to me. The rose bud was bulky and lush, its stem long and sturdy. It looked like it was just snipped off a large blooming bush in a greenhouse somewhere.

I was so confused by the sudden gesture, I grabbed the rose with my right hand roughly. As soon as the rose touched my hand, its fine thorns pierced my skin like tiny needles. I hissed in pain and dropped it.

Tiny droplets of blood beaded at my fingertips and the skin of my palm. A few thorns got stuck in my hand, sticking out, as if refusing my touch.

"Damn. Doll face. Who takes a rose like that? Roses have thorns."

Oscar jerked my hand towards him and began pulling the thorns out one by one painfully.

Once done, he gave me a wide smile, showing off his straight pearly whites. He felt like a hero.

I smiled back at him.

Just to be nice.

Oscar was a tall, athletic guy with dirty blond hair and deep blue eyes. Interestingly, he had blue blood flowing in his veins, too. He was born into a wealthy family with an imposing lineage and a grand estate. And, being a man who hadn't worked a day in his life and never struggled when it came to money, he enjoyed flashing his cash.

As the only child, he was used to being the first at everything.

A dozen times I saw his smile grow wider, eyes bulging, breath hitching in his chest as he realized he was the first.

Last generations of the Staffords attended the Roncalli University. Our university was considered one of the oldest, which automatically added to its prestige.

The aristocratic presence also improved its reputation. That had to be the reason why it still got to keep the lights on while the rest of the town was slowly withering away around it, like an old man in a rocking chair.

Each academic year, his father would give him a new car, actually thinking his son was a diligent student. He wasn't aware, however, of the bribes he'd give out to skip classes, or the blank envelopes he'd hand over to pass the finals. He threw parties, drinking until he blacked out, struggling to remember who he had fights with the next day.

Latest word on the street said he'd gotten so drunk, he ended up punching a girl at a party for spilling beer on him on accident. The girl pressed charges, but the very next day there was no police report, nor were there any accusations from the girl herself.

Oscar bent over and picked the rose up.

"Now, are you gonna take my rose, doll?"

I smiled weakly and carefully took the rose in my hand.

"Have you had lunch yet?"

"No. But I'm waiting for Bell. We always have lunch together."

I turned around to try and look for her.

"I saw her leave. Come on."

Oscar rested his heavy arm on my shoulders and began dragging me towards the cafeteria.

The lunchroom was so loud, my headache grew stronger. People were chatting, trying to talk over each other, their cutlery clattering. They laughed loudly and called friends over to their tables.

A long line stretched from the entrance to the register. There were so many people, it seemed like there'd be no room left for us, which was more than likely.

Oscar led us to the lunch counter. He rudely pushed away a couple of guys in the line and squeezed me in. They glared at him before taking a spot behind us without a word.

"Take whatever you want, doll, it's on me. I'm gonna have a word with my bros."

I nodded and began picking out the food, placing it on a tray.

Oscar was a Sports major. He told me once, "I like doing more than I like thinking." And that's how it was.

Oscar never thinks. Moral dilemmas about his actions rarely graced his brain. He's confident in himself and his actions. He knows what he likes or doesn't like. He isn't used to thinking or following a schedule. His life path is already padded with lily-white feather-beds, with daddy standing guard over him, ready to save him from any grievances.

Oscar has never actually been worried or anxious about anything. He has no idea what it's like not to know, who you want to become or what you want to do. He barely cares about it. He lives for the moment and enjoys life.

I like this nonchalance about him.

I want to be tainted by it.

"Zoe, why didn't you wait for me? We always have lunch together. Besides, it's my turn to pay today."

Bell looked at me with her eyes of tree-bark umber, knitting her neat eyebrows together.

"I'm sorry. It's Oscar. He told me he saw you leaving."

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"The donkey-boy lied to you."

"Don't call him that. He might hear you," I whispered, looking back.

"Oh, right. Why would I call him that," Bell said, smirking.

Bell was moving tea glasses around, looking for a perfect one. The one with no chips, no fingerprints, and the right amount of tea. She reached out to the far corner and placed one on her tray.

I took the glass of tea nearest to me and turned my hand to take a look at my hurt palm.

“He gave me a rose.”

Bell looked down.

“What happened to your hand?”

“I gripped the rose too hard. Forgot about the thorns.”

“You don’t even like roses. He could have asked what kind of flowers you like.”

Bell placed a small bowl of salad on her tray.

“Guys can’t be as thoughtful as we are. It’s alright.”

I picked up another bowl of the same salad and put in on my tray.

“What is? That he doesn’t know how to ask?”

I smirked and added a pear to my tray.

“I don’t like roses, but I’m glad he gave me one.”

“Zo, you’ve heard the tale, didn’t you?” Bell asked, lowering her voice.

“What tale?”

Oscar cut in out of nowhere. Startled, I jumped a little.

He laid his left arm on my shoulders. The moment he saw the pear, he reached out to grab it. Once he bit into it, I could see it wasn’t a ripe one.

“The one where you punch girls in the face.”

Bell was annoyed.

He huffed.

“That’s nothing but gossip, Isabella. Why are you listening to it? I never hit anybody.”

“I saw the pictures. Half her face was bruised up.”

“You don’t have to be Sherlock to see it’s Pho-to-shop. She knew I had money and wanted to rip me off.”

“Just admit, you’ve done it. Why can’t you own up to it?”

He pulled his arm off my shoulders and began to fling about.

“Because I didn’t do it. And yes, I paid her.”

Bell clicked her tongue.

“Now we know why she won’t talk about it.”

“I didn’t pay for her silence, I paid off to make her stop blackmailing me. Don’t you get it? I’m the victim, not her.”

Bell waived him away and kept moving her tray.

He turned to me and laid his arm back on my shoulders.

“Bad things happen to good people, Zoe. I know why she came up with it, and I’m ready to help out. I was told to always help those in need.”

Bell smiled crookedly at his words and took her wallet out to pay at the register.

“Do you believe me, Zoe?”

He looked me in the eye, waiting for my response.

“Zo, I left my card in the dorms. Can you pay today?”

He broke into a broad smile.

“I’ll pay.”

Oscar placed his card on the terminal and it pinged, announcing the payment was successful.

“That wasn’t necessary.”

Bell looked at him coldly, her gaze nothing short of hateful.

“No problem. I like helping people. Especially those in need.”

He winked at her, took my tray and led me away, to his friends.

I turned to look at Bell and she rolled her eyes.

CHAPTER 3

~~Once I became entangled in the twists and turns of life, I resigned myself to living for the sake of breathing.~~

~~I'm walking to get up.~~

~~Doing things to lie down.~~

~~Talking to say nothing at all.~~

~~Thinking to chase thoughts away.~~

“Ms. Torn, are you going to answer the question, or has the cat got your tongue?”

I looked up at Professor Wales, my mouth open, but no words came out.

He kept looking at me with a peeved expression, waiting for my answer.

Anxiety squished my stomach.

“I’m sorry, could you repeat that?”

The recess bell rang, followed by the screeching of chairs.

“Ms. Torn, come over here, would you?” he said, walking to his desk.

I began to pack stuff into my backpack. I glanced at Professor, who was now shuffling papers at his desk. I sighed and got up. Bell looked at me, her lips pursed, eyes filled with sympathy.

“I’ll wait for you outside.”

Ronald Wales taught our class on Existentialism. He looked younger than his age. One could easily mistake him for a senior student. However, he would always stand out thanks to his sheer devotion to wearing vests over his shirts, which made him look older.

Bell and I counted around twenty different vests of varying colors in his collection.

He was always noticeable, even from afar, due to his peculiar walk. It’s like he was walking with a skip. He wore glasses, and we could tell his mood by them.

If he’s in good spirits, he wouldn’t touch the glasses. But the moment something spoiled his mood, he would keep readjusting them regardless if

they were in place or not. And if he was really out of sorts, he'd take them off.

"Ms. Torn, are you aware that you won't be able to pass my class this semester to graduate from the university?"

My right hand clasped around my left index finger, rubbing and squeezing it.

"Why?"

He looked down at the desk and took the glasses off, placing them tentatively to the left of himself.

"Your latest test results were poor. And I haven't even got your essay yet."

"I'm sorry. May I still bring the essay in?"

His gaze lowered to the papers on the desk. I felt like I was wasting his time at this point.

"Yes, you may. Bring it over on Monday. This is the latest date. Otherwise, I won't allow you to take the exam."

I nodded readily, my hand still rubbing my finger, squeezing harder.

He crumpled up an essay sheet and threw it in the bin before raising his annoyed gaze back to me.

"My subject is fairly complex, and I expect more engagement from my students. I get it, this is your final year and you're exhausted, but you have to get a grip and make it to the end. Would be a shame if you're unable to graduate with your classmates."

He picked up a pen and began circling words on a page so vigorously it made the pen squeak.

"I'll hand everything in."

He didn't say anything, still crossing out words, leaving question marks next to them.

I turned to leave, but he carried on,

"Please, do. You're about to enter adulthood, and it rarely gives second chances," he said, proceeding to guide the red pen over the page arduously.

He let out a heavy sigh and looked up at me.

"And, please, try to be more focused at my seminars. I can't recall the last time you answered at least one of my questions. You always say you don't know the answer or ignore me altogether."

Shame insidiously showed up on my cheeks, guilt and fear curled into a ball, fighting for dominance.

“I’m sorry.”

“Is everything alright with you?”

Concern in his voice was clear.

“Yes. I’m sorry. It’s nothing.”

He put the pen down and folded his arms.

“If that’s so, Ms. Torn, I’ll have to ask you to be more responsible when it comes to my class, and prepare more diligently.”

“Of course.”

“Put thinking about boys and dates on the back burner. You’ll have plenty of those. Right now you need to focus on your studies. I don’t think I’m the only one complaining about your grades.”

“I understand.”

“I sure hope so.”

He cast a disapproving glance over me and returned to grading the papers.

I pursed my lips.

“You may leave.”

Once I left the auditorium, I realized how much strain I was under as the tension began to fade.

Bell was standing across from the auditorium, her long nails tapping on her phone screen.

“How bad is it?” she asked, not lifting her head.

“I need to bring in an essay by Monday and take the test again.”

She raised her head and slipped the phone into the pocket of her pants.

“I’ll help you out.”

She put her arm around me and we walked down the hall.

“You’re blushing so hard,” Bell put her hand on my left cheek,

“He didn’t hit on you, did he?”

“Bell.”

I cast her an accusatory look and pushed her away. Chuckling, she returned to my side.

“Oh, no, don’t tell me you...”

“What?”

“You’re actually into that?”

I pinched her side, making her let out a piercing squeal as she tried to get away from me.

Once we came back to our room, I dropped my backpack on the floor and sat on my bed.

My lush ash brown hair was gathered into a tall ponytail, held tight with hair tie. I pulled at it, ripping out and freeing my hair from the tiny torture device. Feeling a rush of blood, I slipped fingers into my hair, massaging the scalp. I closed my eyes, feeling a rush of pleasure.

After a few minutes I looked at my wild hair and reached for my bra. The underwires dug into my skin so hard, I felt like I could breathe again when I unclasped it. Unrestricted chest breathing felt strange, too easy.

I lay back on the soft mattress, still wearing the bra. My head was ringing, body relaxing, the bed felt increasingly softer, while my eyelids got heavier.

Loud music coming from my phone woke me up. My eyes opened, heart jumping out of my chest.

Night shrouded the room in darkness, and only the dull light of the street lamps allowed me to see the outlines of the furniture.

I rested on my elbows and reached for the phone, taking the call without checking the caller ID.

“Hello,” I croaked.

“You’re coming to my party tonight.”

I could hear loud music on the other end.

“I don’t know about that.”

“I’ll pick you up in an hour.”

Oscar hung up and I fell on my back, dropping the phone on my stomach.

This wasn’t an invitation. Nor was it a question. He was stating a fact.

Screw it. I’m going.

What kind of party is this going to be? What should I wear? Who’s gonna be there? Where is it held? Who’s gonna take me back home? Is there gonna be anyone I know?

I let out a sigh and kept staring at the ceiling, unaware I was falling back to sleep. My body jerked awake when I realized I’d fallen asleep. I got up and went to the wardrobe.

I took a milky white blouse out, along with a burgundy skirt.

I was pulling on my brown high-heeled boots meant for a more frigid weather when I realized I wasn’t wearing my makeup. I didn’t look at the time because I knew an hour had passed anyway.

I was working on my eyeshadow, trying to match my icy blue eyes, when I saw Oscar was calling again. I ignored it, trying to apply my makeup faster. I put on some cherry red lip gloss to hide my usual pallor. Next, I made a few steps towards my trench coat when I remembered my hair was still a mess.

My hair was all over the place after a nap and I began to brush it feverishly, holding it in the middle with my left hand and brushing with the right. I tucked a few strands behind my ears and saw my locks get even frizzier than before. This was pissing me off so bad.

Turning my makeup bag inside out looking for a tiny hair tie, I began making a French braid. I was annoyed. I could feel myself begin to sweat, my hands going numb. The braid turned out messy, but I was out of time.

I slipped into my long trench coat and began walking downstairs when his name lit up on my phone screen once again. My heels clicked loudly on the stairs, drawing much unwanted attention from the other students.

Once I walked outside, the cool breeze welcomed me. It played with my locks, sending shivers down my spine and making me pull the flaps of my coat together like it was a bathrobe.

The night was unmistakably cold, but Oscar couldn't care less. He sat in a blue open-top convertible. Loud music was roaring inside.

This was his new car. It glistened under the street light, practically screaming about its crazy price tag.

Once he saw me, Oscar ran out to open the car door and give me a peck on the cheek.

I smiled at him.

"Did something happen?"

"No."

"Why didn't you answer my calls for so long?"

"I was on my way downstairs anyway, so I ignored it."

"I told you to be outside, waiting for me by nine."

I didn't answer and began buttoning my coat.

"Doll," he turned to me, holding the wheel with his left hand, "If I tell you to be outside by nine, you come out and wait for me by nine. You aren't stupid, are you?"

He smiled, chewing on a piece of gum. I reached for the seatbelt when he hit the gas hard enough to make the tires screech, leaving black marks on the pavement, letting everyone know Oscar was on the road.

I kept quiet not just because I didn't want us to fall out right before the party. I also really didn't feel like featuring in the morning news, with a tagline saying something along the lines of "Man and woman in their twenties swerved off the road, lost control of the car." Or worse yet, calling us a couple.

Hanging with Oscar felt easy and fun for the most part, but times like these really pissed me off. He never fails to remind me why I pulled away from him last time round.

I swallowed my anger and tried to enjoy the ride.

While driving, Oscar was ignoring all possible traffic rules, getting us to the party spot faster than the GPS suggested.

The party was held in a large house in dire need of repairs. People didn't build new houses in Ilion, they'd only destroy the old ones. The house stood in the outskirts, by a forest. Most houses in the neighborhood were abandoned. The street was lit with just a few lamps.

I opened the door, and Oscar simply climbed out of the car window. He ran up to me, resting his heavy arm on my shoulders. We walked to the entrance without a word, accompanied by the gum chewing noises and the bass sounds coming from the house.

CHAPTER 4

~~Best of times give rise to good people. Dark times breed the best ones. Dreadful times take away everything you have, leaving a trail of deafening vacuum and questions with no answers. There's nothing left to regret. No point in dreaming. All that is left is to lie down and wait.~~

The party was absolutely insane, as always anyway. Almost everyone we met was drunk and ready to spill their guts right at our feet.

Doors and walls were covered in spray-paint junk. Crumpled up cans, wrappers and other trash were strewn about all over the place. The door to the living room was ripped off the hinges and thrown to the floor like a carpet. There were holes in the walls, a new one being made right before my eyes.

A DJ mixer was on in the living room. The music boomed so loud it felt like my eardrums were about to explode. Everyone was dancing, drinking and playing cards.

Oscar took his hulking arm off the moment he saw his friends. They hollered and gave him a can of beer. He drank it in one swig, crumpled up the empty can in his hand and cheered.

I stood aside, looking at it like it was a rite of passage. I took a can of beer and tried to look for a spot on the couch, but it was covered in beer stains, so I moved to an armchair. I took a sip from the can and realized I still hated beer. Its bitter, yeasty taste made me want to rinse my mouth.

I searched the crowd for any familiar faces. I saw Lea enter the room. I wanted to wave at her, but decided it'd be a bit awkward.

Lea and I were friends our freshman year. She was the first person I met at the university. I don't know how, but our friendship faded away the sophomore year. We didn't argue or bicker. We simply drifted apart and stopped hanging out like we used to.

I watched as she walked up to Francis, her boyfriend. She was whispering something in his ear when he placed his right hand on the small of her back, stroking it. She giggled and took his hand. As they were walking out of the room, our eyes met and she smiled at me. I returned it.

I got bored of watching everyone party, so I decided to check the kitchen for my kind of fun.

I pushing my way through gaggles of drunk, gaudy dudes. One tried hitting on me and I quickly mixed in with the crowd. As I was walking, I saw a guy lying on the floor, out cold, as his friends stood about and laughed. And a flock of girls, dancing and yelling the song lyrics out. A couple fighting, the girl waving her arms furiously while the guy looked at her with an unreadable face. Some friends drinking on a dare. Another couple making out, more like licking each other's faces, really.

The kitchen was no different from the rest of the rooms. But the music was quieter here and there were fewer people, which was definitely a plus.

I began rummaging through the top cabinets, looking for some strong liquor. But all I found were boxes of expired food, some dishes and a few other things of little interest to me.

I squatted down in my miniskirt and went on opening the bottom cabinets. I had a hunch someone had hidden their stash around here. And what you find at a party is yours by default.

I opened the cabinet under the sink, pushed an empty bin aside and found a sealed tequila bottle. A smile lit up my face.

I opened the bottle right away and had a few sips. I could feel the liquid blaze from my tongue to my stomach like a flame.

I hid the bottle in my trench coat and decided to go to the back yard. I opened the back door and, to my surprise, discovered a glass greenhouse. It's just me, a bottle of tequila, the echo of music and nobody else.

Turning my head to the right I saw a round coffee table and a couch. It looked like the greenhouse had been turned into a storage for clutter, piled up haphazardly around the place, collecting dust.

A ripped-up floor lamp stood next to the couch. I placed the bottle on the coffee table, leaned my knee against the couch and reached for the floor lamp.

"You found my bottle."

I knocked over the lamp, grabbing it before it fell down. Turning back, I saw a blue-eyed guy.

How did I not see him?

He was sitting in an old armchair to my right. The guy looked me up and down. He took a swig from my bottle, still looking me in the eye.

“It’s mine.”

He smirked and handed me the bottle. I took it, sat on the couch and took two sips myself.

He kept swirling a large silver ring on his index finger with his left thumb. Still staring at the ring, he asked,

“What are you doing here, Zoe?”

“How do you know my name?”

“You don’t recognize me, do you?”

He looked up, staring at me sullenly.

I passed him the bottle. He touched my fingers and smirked.

“Freshman year. The roof. At dawn.”

I shook my head and he set the bottle on the table with a thud, taking a seat next to me. He leaned to sit on his right leg, resting his arm on the back of the couch.

“Let’s start all over again, then.”

He offered me his left hand.

“I’m Justin.”

I took his hand.

“Zoe.”

He shook my hand gingerly.

“Nice to meet you, Zoe.”

I realized my smile never once faded throughout this encounter. I felt like an idiot and picked up the bottle to take another sip.

I liked his genuine interest. His stare was so explicitly obvious, it felt blunt and cocky.

Looking into his eyes I noticed how clear they were, no limbal rings, heterochromia or other discolored spots. The deep azure of his eyes reminded me of the lagoon my family and I spend our last summer vacation in.

“In our first year, there was a freshman party, which I did not attend. I woke up early and decided to go for a run. I saw you walking down the alley to our dorms, if you could really call that walking. I wanted to keep running, but then I saw you fall. I ran up and helped you up. You asked me to take you to the roof. The seniors told you it offered a stunning view of

the sunrise. I tried talking you out of it, but you wouldn't listen. You just kept saying, *take me to the roof* over and over, it's like you were hypnotized. I told you I wasn't gonna do that, because you were drunk. At that point you pushed me away and said, *Screw you.*"

It all seemed so funny and awkward that I laughed way too loud.

His smile didn't fade for a second. He put the bottle to his lips and said, "You have a cute laugh."

While he was taking another swig, I felt my cheeks turn crimson, like ripe cherries on a tree. And I knew it wasn't just because of the liquor.

He handed me the bottle.

"I watched you walk, still swaying from side to side. I followed you back to the dorms, but kept my distance. Once you made it, you dropped to the steps and began crawling up the stairs. At one point you turned around and said, *Are you gonna keep staring, or will you come over here and help me?* I could see nothing's gonna stop you. I knew you were going there anyways, or crawling there, really, so I took you to the roof. To my surprise, it was unlocked."

"And my state wasn't surprising to you?"

He chuckled. He had a vibrant, balmy laugh.

"At that point, I was already used to it."

I took a small sip.

"We climbed to the roof. You were standing there, staring at the sunrise without a word for what felt like ten minutes. And then you said, "Why do I feel this soul-crushing sadness while I'm watching a sunrise?"

I took two big gulps.

"You sat down and kept watching the sunrise. I was scared of leaving you there alone, so I decided to join in. We sat in silence, and I didn't even notice you falling asleep. I didn't have a jacket, so I had nothing to cover you with. I was worried you'd catch a cold, so I decided to run back to my room. And when I came back, you weren't there. I'm gonna be honest, at first I thought you jumped. And that I was an idiot for leaving you. I ran up to the edge of the roof and breathed a sigh of relief when I didn't see you down on the pavement."

He smirked, calling memories back to mind.

"What a horrible story," I said in a hushed whisper.

"Why?"

"I was acting crazy and dragged you into this madness."

“I was happy to dive in myself.”

His smile was so sincere, I wanted to carve it into my memory for good.

He got up and turned on a dirty, dust-covered heater.

I didn't even notice my fingers get cold. Alcohol kept me warm, somehow completely avoiding my limbs.

Justin walked up to me, took the bottle and set it on the dusty plastic table made to look like wood. He held his left hand out to me.

I shook my head, but he kept smiling at me.

“It's just you and me. No need to be shy.”

I took my trench coat off and took his hand.

He led me to the middle of the greenhouse. Wooden floor squeaked under our feet. I placed my right hand on his shoulder. He rested his on my waist. Our eyes were on the same level.

A hip-hop song was playing.

“Wrong music.”

“As long as the person's right.”

His words breathed life into the dead butterflies in my stomach.

I usually felt awkward, shy and anxious when a person I barely know tried to touch me. Yet, I wanted Justin's touch to go on, it felt like a walk in an amusement park. My flesh was tingling, begging for more, like a wild, voracious beast finally waking up from a long slumber.

“Do you remember now?”

His voice was alluring, I longed to trust him, to share all my thoughts and emotions.

I remember the sunrise, and I remember meeting him. The next day I had an insane hangover, so I took a sleeping pill and knocked myself out, only waking up late at night. That night, bleeding into the morning, would take a while to fade from my memory.

“I barely remember anything about that party. It's been three years since then. Why didn't you come talk to me?”

“You were dating someone. Can't recall the name, but everyone knows the guy. This is his party, isn't it?”

“Then why are you dancing with his girlfriend now?”

“Got tired of waiting for three years.”

His words pushed an invisible button in my heart, making it race. My lips were quivering so bad. Had I not been biting the lower lip, it would have taken off.

We were swaying to the music without a word, desire to find out everything there is to know about him gnawing at me. I wanted to know it all, from his favorite color to the things he thinks about when thoughts suffocate his mind at night.

“What do you major in?”

“Literature.”

My eyes lit up.

“Do you write poetry?”

He chuckled.

“A bit.”

“What building is your dorms in?”

“Number two.”

“How old are you?”

“23.”

“Will you read me your poems?”

“If you’re gonna be a good girl.”

“I am a good girl.”

I frowned.

“Good girls only dance with their boyfriends.”

“Am I bad then?”

“Very much so.”

My face went beet red at that point. I could feel my cheeks burn, blood rushing in my veins like my body was coming undone.

“Why were you here all alone?”

“Same reason you were.”

“And why was I alone?”

“Because you want to run away from everyone.”

He twirled me around and dipped me softly.

“Do you always blush when talking to guys?”

“I blush from the alcohol.”

He smirked.

“Why aren’t you asking me anything?”

“Because I know the answers.”

CHAPTER 5

~~Reluctance and excitement.~~
~~Disgust and attraction.~~
~~Repulsion and chemistry.~~
~~Fear and euphoria.~~
~~Everything blurred together in a symphony of feelings from a time long lost.~~

We sat back on the couch and went on sharing the bottle between the two of us. I hadn't had anything to eat since that afternoon, and could feel myself getting tipsy by the minute.

I smirked, staring into nothingness.

"Life really is absurd, isn't it? So much about it is utterly senseless. Us assigning the meaning to life is nothing but a pathetic attempt to escape the reality and the fear of realizing there is no meaning. There really isn't."

He rested head on his arm and kept listening silently as liquor loosened my tongue.

"Sometimes I think, if life has no meaning, I'm not going to do anything. What's the point? I'm gonna die anyway. Then I remember how much time I've still got to waste, and I have to look for the damn meaning. I have to keep looking for it. I have to do something. Live my life out of spite. At times like these, it really feels like I have no other choice."

"You can make a mark on the world, if you want. That way you can live forever."

"To me, that's an illusion. Even if I managed to leave a mark in history, be it a hefty contribution to the world or my offspring, all of it would be gone eventually. Everything comes to an end. I don't believe in living while you're remembered. What about those living all alone? No one remembers them, and yet, they live their little lives just fine. Aren't they living now? They are. And once they die, they're gone."

I could see Justin's gaze wander deep into the realm of memories.

"I don't know, what it's like to lose a loved one. All my loved ones are alive. Maybe once I do lose someone, I'll convince myself they're still alive. Since memories of them will keep on living in my heart until I die. And to be fair, what really scares me is not the thoughts of them being forgotten, it's the idea of them being dead."

"Isn't it liberating?"

"What?"

"To have a chance to find your own meaning. You don't get a guide, and you don't need one. How do you write one guide to a billion of unique lives, compressing everything there is to know into three hundred, or even a thousand pages? It's impossible. Okay, fine. Let's say the book exists. What kind of life follows some book? What is that life worth? It definitely wouldn't have made you happier. It would have tied you down, and you're longing for freedom. Now you can do anything you want. You can choose any path. Any calling and any man. Doesn't it make you appreciate life even more for its uniqueness?"

"It makes me feel scared, because I don't know, who I really am," I whispered, "I mean, I appreciate life, but my fear of it is far stronger. The burden of huge responsibility is piled on us from birth. You have to figure yourself out, choose your path, make an insane amount of decisions you are completely clueless about. And it all has to be done yesterday, because today it's already too late."

"Frankly, I don't give a damn what happens to me after I die, whether anyone would remember me and all that stuff. Right now I'm crystal clear about this: I like this lousy tequila, I like our discussion, I like sharing a drink with you, and I like y-..."

Loud rumble interrupted us. Three drunk guys stumbled into the greenhouse.

One of them saw us and whistled.

"My bad."

The guy with blond highlights began to speak, but his speech was slurring bad. His friends stood close by, cackling.

"Do we, wait, do you have any smokes?"

"No."

We answered in unison, letting me know Justin also wasn't too happy about the sudden company.

The second guy pointed a finger at me.

“Oh, hey. You’re Oscar’s girlfriend.”

I’m not his fucking girlfriend.

The highlights guy shoved him back towards the house and slammed the door behind them.

All was quiet once more. Awkward tension hung in the air.

Justin opened his mouth to say something, but I spoke first.

“I need a bathroom break.”

I got up and went upstairs.

Walking up the steps, I could feel I was almost drunk enough to be rewarded with bad coordination for the rest of the night. I was happy about it, because that way my shame, embarrassment and self-consciousness would no longer be visible on my face, like they usually were.

Afterwards I went downstairs and was just a few steps away from the door when Oscar suddenly came into view.

All the air got knocked out of my lungs, it felt like a punch in the guts.

He looked drunk.

Off his face.

His glassy eyes were half-lidded. Shirt stained with beer. Hair a mess. He was staggering on level ground.

“Where did you go? I’ve been looking for you.”

He was slurring, but I could still make out his words.

“I don’t feel so good. I want to go outside, get some air.”

I wanted to walk around him, but he wasn’t going to let me pass. My pulse quickened.

Oscar grabbed me by the left shoulder and slammed me into the wall hard enough for me to bang my head on it.

“I knew something was up.”

He was breathing heavily, looking me in the eye. For a moment, his stare went blank, and then he slammed a fist into the wall right next to my face.

I froze, my feet stuck to the ground. I watched him, fighting off a trembling fit.

Was I gonna be next?

Oscar staggered back, swaying left to right. He wasn’t a tall guy, but he was bulky. He looked down, and it took me a minute to realize, why. His gaze began dragging lewdly along my body. It snaked up my legs, waist,

then my chest. I felt a sense of lingering fear, crawling from my pelvis. The fear of what was coming next.

Finally, his eyes reached mine. Fear was clear in my eyes. His gaze showed a complete loss of control.

It's terrifying to be with someone who can do anything they want to you with no real consequences. People like him and his parents would step over you without a passing glance. They have connections, money isn't a problem for them. Their problem is a person with an open mouth.

The walls seemed to have grown arms holding me firmly in place.

He broke into a crooked smile.

"Zoe."

He grabbed my cheeks with his sticky hands.

Let me go.

"Zoe. You know how much I appreciate you. You mean a lot to me."

I kept nodding, like a bobble-head doll on a dashboard.

"You're so beautiful, but you know there are girls much prettier than you. They're dreaming of taking your place."

I kept nodding.

"Then don't fucking ruin it," he spat.

He was mad, but I couldn't understand what I did wrong. Had his pals told him about Justin and I, his fist would have landed on my face instead of the wall. That meant, he didn't know anything.

"Of course. I won't."

I said it under my breath, looking into his glazed-over eyes.

His right hand began stroking my hair. Next, he leaned closer and pressed his wet, liquor stained lips to mine.

I didn't want to return the kiss, but I was afraid of what would happen if I didn't.

I opened my mouth and he pushed his tongue in. It wasn't a kiss, it seemed more like he was trying to devour me. I felt numb and repulsed.

"You're so hot."

A drunken grin stretched across his face.

"Oscar! Oscar! Get over here!"

"Coming," he barked loud enough to make my ears ring.

He stroked my hair and left.

I let out all the air I'd been keeping in my lungs. I stood there, feeling frustrated and disgusted. Disgusted with myself.

Shock was fading away, and the brain was in control again. I ran to the greenhouse, running outside from it. I stopped and looked at the dark forest until my heart stopped racing. Forest at night used to scare me, but not tonight.

I turned back to the house when I heard the door open. Justin was walking towards me, bottle in hand.

I looked down, ignoring his smile. Once he came closer, I snatched the bottle from his hand and gulped the liquor down like I was dying of thirst.

“What happened?”

“Idiot,” I spat.

“Didn’t realize I was making such an impression.”

“No. Not you.”

“Do you want me to talk to him?”

He clenched his teeth, looking stern.

I bit down my lover lip and shook my head a little, moving the lip under my teeth anxiously.

“You’re all red.”

His cool hands touched my cheeks.

His touch relieved the heat I was already getting used to.

I knew it was the perfect time for us to kiss. But the moment was ruined. I didn’t want to kiss him. Not after what happened only five minutes ago.

I pressed the bottle to his chest and went towards the greenhouse.

“I believe, it’s my turn to ask questions.”

I smiled weakly.

I shouldn’t have gone to the house.

“Did you come here alone?”

Wish I didn’t come at all.

“No.”

I had to say “No”.

“You?”

Why was I standing there like a fool?

“No.”

Shitty day.

“You don’t go to parties all that often, do you?”

Shitty party.

“No.”

Justin got quiet and we kept sharing the rest of the bottle in silence.

I tried to calm down my whirlwind of thoughts. It's no use, but I didn't want to give up.

"Wanna play a game?"

"Sure."

Justin's smile melted my heart, and his blue lagoon eyes drew all my thoughts back to him.

"Each one of us says three things about themselves, and only one of them has to be true. You go first."

"I'm on our soccer team. I major in Literature. I don't drink alcohol."

I burst out laughing.

"You aren't even trying. Be serious."

He reached behind the couch and pulled a new bottle.

Opening it, he said,

"This'll help me get more serious."

I laughed even harder.

"Alright. My turn. I'm allergic to red pepper. I dream of living in a large house. I have a boyfriend."

"Oh. I'd like to believe you no longer have a boyfriend. Otherwise, how do you explain him leaving you alone at a party."

"Choose faster."

"The red pepper one is true."

"No, come on."

We laughed together.

The second bottle plunged me into a drunken haze. It got harder to think, and everything seemed hilarious. My tongue got loose enough to be dangerous for me.

Once we stopped giggling, Justin's face got serious.

"You're dreaming of a large house. And that's true."

"Yeaah. You got that right."

I cried out gleefully. I jumped up and reached out to hug him.

We kept playing, the game ramping up in difficulty as the slur in my speech got worse. Seeing this, Justin would no longer pass me the bottle.

I rested my head on the back of the couch, still smiling at him. He brushed a few strands of hair out of my face and tucked them behind my ear.

My gaze slowly began to slide down his body. He had a fine nose with a slight crook. A small beauty mark over one eyebrow. His light blond hair

grew out. Soon it would get in his way.

My eyelids grew heavy. I wanted to let sleep overtake me, but I also really wanted to stay.

“I like you.”

Did I hear that right? Or was it my mind playing tricks on me? What if he actually said that?

I like you, too.

I stopped resisting the tender embrace of balmy darkness and gladly let it finally take me.

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CHAPTER 6

~~The good and the bad come and go, spinning around in a timeless dance of life itself. Good things always come after the bad ones, and the bad times take over the good.~~

~~But how we long to stay in the good times a little longer.~~

Cold, heavy drops of the fall rain fell from the ashy blanket of clouds covering the clear, flawless sky. Wild and free, they landed on top of the glass greenhouse roof deprived of the glow of the rising sun. Ethereal drops exploded on the glass, breaking into a myriad of tiny beads. They dripped down slowly, showing the world the nature could cry, too.

The rain was tapping out a tune on the glass of the greenhouse. It woke me up from deep slumber, but didn't help me open my heavy eyelids. It felt like someone poured glue on them, blew some air and sealed them shut.

Rubbing the sleep from my eyes, I lifted my head and felt a dull, persistent ache in my neck from sleeping in an odd position. The ache spread from my neck right to my head. My head was throbbing, like it was about to crack into two hemispheres. My throat felt dry, like it hadn't seen a drop of water for the longest time. The alcohol and the early rise were modern-day tortures, designed to keep humanity from relaxing.

I tried sitting up on the couch, fighting the urge to lie back down.

Turning my head to the right, I didn't see Justin. I saw an open bottle of water on the table.

I began rummaging through the pockets of my trench-coat. I only wore that coat to parties. It had deep enough pockets to allow me to leave my small handbag at home, knowing I could easily lose it at a party. I could drop on my knees before myself when I realized aspirin and charcoal tablets were still in it.

I took a sip from the bottle and guessed it was mineral water.

Perfect.

I bit down on the pills and downed them with water.

Justin entered the greenhouse, holding a plate of sandwiches.

“Breakfast?”

I took one of the sandwiches and took a bite.

“I thought you left.”

“What?”

He watched me, smiling, waiting patiently for me to swallow the food.

“I thought you left.”

“I’m a gentleman after all, and gentlemen don’t act that way.”

Still smiling, I took another bite.

He rested his elbow on the armcap and began rolling the silver ring with his thumb.

Once I was done gulping down the bottle of mineral water, thoughts about how I looked began to creep into my brain.

I took my phone and began fixing my makeup. The mascara flaked a bit. I ran my middle finger under the eyes to clean up the black specks. I untied my French braid and moved my hair to the left.

I looked up and saw he’d been watching me this entire time. My cheeks flushed with a tell-tale blush, making me look down at my phone to hide it.

No missed calls.

I got up, ready to go, and he followed me silently.

I saw a bright flash of lightning out of the corner of my eye. When I turned my head, a thunder clap caught me.

“Afraid of thunder?” Justin asked.

“No. You?”

I turned to look at him. His hair was a bit ruffled, wrinkles on his pine green sweater bringing back the memories of the odd night.

We were standing too close to each other despite the generous size of the patio.

The wooden floor creaked. He was getting closer. I was about to get on my tiptoes, but took a step back at the last second.

I didn’t want him to get in trouble because of me.

“I’m freezing. Let’s go inside.”

I looked at the door, having no courage to meet his gaze. I was afraid I’d see disappointment in them. Justin said nothing and I pulled the handle.

The house was permeated by the combined stench of vomit and alcohol. It was stuffy, and I could see how filthy the rooms were in the daylight.

We walked to the exit, watching our step.

“Oh, Zoe. Did you stay the night?”

I looked up and saw one of Oscar’s friends.

“Yes.”

“Oscar was looking for you yesterday. I think he hit the booze too hard yesterday. Kept saying your name over and over, like a maniac. He got so hammered! Picked fights with anyone he saw. We could barely calm him down.”

He chuckled, like that was a really funny joke.

“I’m going home. Tell Oscar.”

“Okay.”

I walked around him and headed for the exit.

We left the house and I worked up the guts to look at Justin. He looked groggy and a little tired. I wanted to explain everything, but he spoke first.

“My car’s parked not far from here. I’ll give you a lift.”

I nodded.

Did he offer it just to be nice? Would he ever hang out with me after this?

We got into his worn down plum-colored pickup truck. The car was old. The paint was peeling off in places, looking like scales. Rust was eating away at the metal like acid, leaving an amber trace behind. I crack was visible on the windshield. The doors screeched so loud I could swear they woke up the next-door neighbors.

Justin turned the radio on and we were off.

“Is this your car?”

“No.”

He smiled.

“I’m a shop hand at the warehouse behind the old shopping mall,” he turned to look at me, “this is my work car.”

My headache was still thumping, so I decided to roll a window down and let some crisp fresh air in.

After a short pause, Justin spoke up again.

“I answered wrong yesterday.”

“What?”

I frowned, looking at him and trying to follow what he was talking about. Justin kept looking at the road.

“You don’t want a house.”

We entered a short tunnel and the radio went silent. The car got dark.

Oscar and I became friends our freshman year. We would hang out a lot. Then we'd stop talking altogether. I couldn't tell what we were to one another myself sometimes. One thing I knew for sure, we were never a couple. He never asked me out, and I never wanted it. Yesterday Oscar slammed the door on our friendship for good.

Justin got it all wrong, and I didn't clear things up. I wanted to see he still liked me yesterday. And now I could see this.

"Oscar's not my boyfriend. We weren't dating three years ago, and we aren't dating now. There has never been, nor will there ever be anything going on between us."

Justin turned his head to me, gave me a quick glance and turned back to watch the road.

"Alright."

I saw the corners of his lips perk up and my heart skipped a beat.

I remember Justin and the party perfectly fine. It was hard not to notice him our freshman year. You'd have to be completely blind and dumb to ignore the man's stare lingering on you. Or how often you'd stumble upon him, even though his classes were held at the end of another wing. How he'd peer at you for a while. How his eyes would light up. How all his attention is immediately drawn to you the moment you enter the room.

We exchanged glances all the time our freshman year. I thought a look back from me would be enough for him to come over and talk to me. And yet, he didn't. And I'd never make the first move.

First you ask him out, and next thing you know you're the one proposing to him, standing on one knee and all. That shit's not for me.

I wanted to be conquered. I wanted to be desired. I wanted to be dreamed of. I wanted poetry written about me. I wanted someone to be infatuated with me. I wanted someone to live and breathe me. I wanted to drive someone mad. I wished to be the center of the universe for the man brave enough to let me into his mind and heart. So I set my feelings for him aside and went on with my life like nothing happened.

Justin parked his car at the university entrance. We got out and met in front of the truck.

We looked at one another and smiled, like we'd just had the best night of our lives.

"Thanks for giving me a ride."

"Thanks for keeping me company."

“Will you say yes if I ask you on a date?”

“Yes.”

“I haven’t asked yet.”

“Yep.”

We broke into laughter.

“Now you’ll be wondering if I said yes because you asked me or because I wanted to myself.”

“Damn it.”

He slammed his hand on the hood dramatically.

“Now I’ll never know the truth.”

“Close your eyes.”

He smirked.

Once his eyes were closed, I began walking backwards slowly, getting further and further away.

“I hope you’re not gonna run away while I’m standing here with my eyes closed.”

I pursed my lips, holding back a laugh. It seemed like a great idea at the time to do our first encounter over and disappear from his field of view, to see what he’d do.

He opened his eyes and I ran.

I squealed when he grabbed me from behind, lifting me up.

He put me down, and I turned to face him. His palms rested on my waist. His eyes of aquamarine blue sparkled in the daylight. I could feel his hands slide up and down my waist. I locked my arms around his neck.

His lips came closer to mine as he whispered,

“Can I kiss you?”

“Yes,” I exhaled.

His lips met mine. He pulled me flush against him. Our bodies felt each other’s warmth through our clothes. I ran my hand through his hair. I wanted the kiss to get deeper. I wanted our tongues to intertwine, but he kept kissing me softly, gently, like it was our very first kiss.

We broke the kiss, and I rested my hands on his cheeks as he closed his eyes.

“Your lips are so soft, I never want to let them go.”

His lips locked with mine as we melted into the kiss. His left hand began caressing my neck.

I realized we were making out in the parking lot by the main entrance to the university. I didn't want any of the professors to see us, so I pulled back and touched my forehead to his.

"I want to love you."

He was breathing heavily.

I gave him a peck on the lips.

"Does that mean yes?"

"Yes."

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CHAPTER 7

~~Years flew past like birds heading south. Houses vanished beneath the wheels of bulldozers. People change like trees shedding leaves after a storm. Memories become distorted, but our love for them stays the same.~~

The sun had already set. Street lamps illuminated the road. Old cinema sign was buzzing quietly overhead.

I turned my head to the ticket booth, shifting my feet.

I unlocked my phone and saw Justin hadn't read my texts yet. The movie's starting soon, we might be late.

"And I was the only one who could catch him."

A girl's ringing laugh made me turn my head. Oscar was walking with a blonde sophomore girl. She was from the Journalism Faculty. I remembered her. I saw her trying to talk to him a few times, but he'd always shrug her off.

Her eyes were gleaming. She looked at him with blind adoration. His arm rested on her shoulders as he stared me down.

They came up to the ticket booth and he gave her his credit card.

"Which row should we pick?"

"Don't care."

He kept staring at me.

She nodded and picked a row, swiping his card.

When she passed the card back to him, he grabbed her neck and kissed her. He didn't close his eyes. He kept looking at me, his eyes filled with spite.

I felt awkward and went to the parking lot.

The moment I got there, I saw Justin's purple pickup truck.

My smile grew wider when our eyes met.

He jumped out of the car and gave me a quick kiss.

"Sorry, I got held off."

“Did you get the tickets?”

“Damn. I forgot. Let’s hurry, maybe there’s still time to get some.”

We ran back to the ticket booth, but saw the “Closed” sign staring back at us.

“I’m sorry, baby. I forgot all about the tickets.”

“It’s alright. We’ll go another time.”

“I have my laptop in the car. We could watch a movie on it if you want.”

I smirked.

“A drive-in cinema?”

“A mini version.”

Bottles and trash were littering the car. Justin began throwing it all off to the floor.

“Take a seat.”

I plopped on the seat. He opened the laptop and turned to me.

“Horror movie? A thriller? Drama? A comedy?”

“The comedy one.”

“Great choice. I hate horror movies.”

“So do I. Life’s disturbing enough without them.”

He turned the movie on and set the laptop on the dashboard.

The film wasn’t bad, but the dirty jokes got old real fast. They made the movie seem dumb and completely unfunny. Does anyone really laugh at those?

I looked outside and saw our car was the only one in the empty parking lot. It felt like there was no one left in town but us.

Justin didn’t try touching or kissing me while the movie was on. He sat back, eyes fixated on the film like he was going to take a test on it the next day.

“Maybe we could go back to the dorms?”

He closed the laptop and turned to me, smiling.

“Let’s go.”

The car started, radio blaring out. He turned the volume down a notch and we’re off.

I felt certain awkwardness in our relationships. I didn’t understand what I was supposed to do, what he expected from me, what he wanted. My whole idea of relationships was built on pop-culture and my friends’ dating stories. Sometimes I felt like we weren’t gonna make it, because nothing went the way it was supposed to go. But I had no idea how it all worked.

I wanted to skip the stage of uncertainty and move to the point where we'd know everything about one another already, where we could share peaceful silence together.

"Do you want to come to my place?"

"No," I blurted out.

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean it in a weird way. And yet... it did come out weird."

I smiled at him.

"It's not what you think."

"I didn't like the movie."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"I thought you liked it."

"So? We could have found something for both of us."

Justin's palm covered my hand. He gave it a reassuring squeeze.

"Say something next time. I want you to enjoy yourself with me."

I squeezed his hand back and smiled.

"Maybe we could go out tomorrow?"

"What do you have in mind?"

"I don't know."

I shrugged and checked the time.

"I have to go. I promised Bell I'll come home early. She wants to help me with an essay."

"Okay. Sure," he nodded.

I watched the second hand reach twelve and heard the recess bell.

I got my things, stepped out into the hall and saw Justin. He was standing there with a large bouquet of baby blue hydrangeas. I was beaming.

His eyes met mine. He came closer and handed me the bouquet.

Hydrangeas looked exuberant and delicate, and the green spurs of eucalyptus intertwining with them complemented their beauty. The flowers were elegantly wrapped in white paper, giving the bouquet an even more refined look.

"How did you know they're my favorite flowers?"

"Bell tipped me off."

I closed the distance between us and kissed him on the cheek.

"Do you like them?"

"No one's ever given me a bouquet before. And this one has all the future ones beat already."

He grinned, his featherlight touch caressing my cheek.

Oscar shoved him in the shoulder, making him bump into the wall. Justin turned around, scowling, ready to follow him.

I took his hand.

“I don’t have a vase. Maybe we could go to the mall today and pick one together?”

“I work today. Maybe you could come over during my break?”

I nodded my head enthusiastically.

“Zoe. Raise the bouquet a bit higher.”

“Why?”

“I want to kiss you.”

I lifted the bouquet and Justin gingerly pulled me by the waist as our lips met.

He kissed me deeply. I could feel our tongues intertwine, twirling in a dance of passion.

I rested my left hand on his neck.

“Ms. Torn, is that you?”

I sprang back from Justin and put the bouquet down.

“Yes, yes, professor Wales.”

He adjusted his glasses. His gaze lingered on my lips a little too long. I frowned, and his eyes met mine.

“You did pretty well on the essay. Not great, but not bad at all. I’ll be waiting for you in Room 404 tomorrow for the test retaking.”

He adjusted his glasses once again and left.

I turned to Justin and frowned.

“Your lips.”

He began wiping his lips with the back of his hand as I chuckled.

“Yours, too.”

I took my phone out and saw my lipstick smudged all over, going beyond the contours of my lips.

I was holding back the laughter, trying to wipe the lipstick off.

I smacked him with the bouquet playfully and he hugged me.

CHAPTER 8

~~Months passed with no hope of a return, now only alive in memories. They keep me warm, like a thick blanket. They embrace me like a loving soul. Bring me happiness like it's a holiday.~~

The last three months felt like living in an island Paradise, where people were the decorations and classes seemed more like quests for coconuts. Days flew by in a hectic race. We no longer felt the rush of time. It no longer existed.

Talking away until sunset, hanging out in each other's rooms and going to cafes became our favorite things to do. Classes in different buildings on campus, tons of homework and Justin's job turned our lives into a daily challenge.

I'd wake up and think of how many classes I had left until our next date. During class, I'd count down hours to it. Waiting for him after work, I'd mark off minutes left until the end of his shift.

Bell told me once that Justin was my best friend now. I grinned and thought he really wasn't just a boyfriend, he was my best friend, my go-to guy. We weren't just two halves of one, finally growing together. He changed me, made me better.

His personality surpassed all my made-up expectations. I still can't believe how one person could have so much love, care and compassion to give.

Justin grew up in Rayville, too. He was raised by his mom, so he didn't know what fatherly love was like. In his teenage years, he tried taking odd jobs to help her out, since she had to work two jobs. Even then he kept sending her half his paycheck.

Still in school, he tried many things to earn some money before coming to a realization that he wasn't half-bad at writing. At 16, he wrote lyrics for a song and posted it on his blog. A few weeks later he got a knock on the

door, someone offered a hefty sum for the song, enough to take care of his mom's loans. The song was a hit. Every radio station played it. That's when he knew he wanted to become a writer.

"Penny for your thoughts?"

I smiled, holding the pencil at my lips.

"It's nothing."

I was on his bed, reading the same paragraph over and over, trying to focus on the text as thoughts about him distracted me.

Justin was a lot more serious about his studies. He was sitting on the floor at a small rolling table, stroking my leg and studiously writing in his workbook.

"My roommate isn't coming back tonight. You can stay here if you want."

I looked up from the book and met his cyan eyes.

"Okay."

We smiled and returned to our textbooks.

Faint anticipation was stirring me up like a gentle breeze on the sea. We both knew what was coming.

Every time I knew we're going to hang out in his room, I'd put on my jade green lingerie set. I got it back in Rayville years ago but never actually used it. I'd use half a bottle of body mist, do my hair and makeup.

Last time I dated someone was back in high-school. We'd hold hands and kiss, but we were more like a couple of friends. Adult relationships were still new to me. I had no idea what they were supposed to be like, what I should or shouldn't do. I tried to trust Justin.

I slammed the book shut.

"I never asked you. And you never offered."

"What?" he asked, smiling at me.

"Write a poem about me."

He chuckled.

"A poem?"

Confused, I kept looking at him.

"Yes," I said hesitantly.

"Baby, my entire day planner is covered with poems about you."

My eyes lit up and he immediately knew what I wanted to do next.

"Second shelf from the bottom. It's the blue one."

I reached for the planner and pulled it from the shelf.

I bit my lower lip as I held it in my hands, giving him a cheeky smile.
He grinned, shaking his head.

I flipped it open, and Justin jumped to his feet. I tried getting away, but he pulled me by my legs as I kept kicking and crawling up the bed to break free. Justin sat on top of me and snatched the planner out of my hand.

We froze, looking at each other. He tossed the planner aside and kissed me. His lips covered mine and our tongues intertwined. He leaned back, slowly took off his hoodie and dropped it to the floor.

My gaze fell on his chiseled body.

“Like what you see?”

I looked up and met his sultry gaze. I could feel how flushed my face was.

“You do. I see.”

He took my right hand and put it on his chest. I ran my hand down languidly, stopping at his belt.

“Wanna take it off?”

I nodded and slowly undid his belt.

Anticipation and slight excitement made my heart race.

“May I?”

I gave him a quick nod, and he took off my white shirt, leaving it on the floor.

“Cute. Is that for me?”

My blushing cheeks gave away how awkward and shy I felt.

“You’re too tense, baby. We don’t have to do it, if you don’t want to. We can try another time.”

“No. It’s fine. I want it now.”

His left hand caressed my cheek.

“Do you wanna be on top?”

“Yes.”

I sounded as unsure as I felt.

We changed positions and I could feel some of my tension melt away.

“I like your bra.”

“Stop.”

“What?”

One corner of his lips perked up.

“I’m shy.”

“Baby, you look like you can do anything you want to me, and if you see me crying, that’ll be tears of joy.”

I couldn’t control my awkwardness anymore and pressed my lips to his.

My body jerked when I heard a loud man’s cry coming from the hall. The scream startled me, speeding my pulse up. It was filled with pain and suffering. The clatter of boots from a crowd shouting something incoherent followed the scream. Or was it running away from it? Some kind of chaos broke out outside the door. Next thing we knew, it all fell dead silent again.

I froze, staring at the door, and then turned to look at Justin. We looked at one another without a word, waiting for what’s coming next.

“It’s Saturday. Maybe someone’s having a party,” Justin said.

The scream made me think. Had I actually heard men screaming before? Never.

What about woman’s cries? I heard those plenty of times.

Justin began unbuttoning my jeans.

“Cute bow. Stand up a bit.”

I got on my knees as my pulse was racing, but not because of him. He leaned over to kiss my stomach. His lips slowly moved up, leaving behind a trail of kisses. His hand was stroking my neck as he kissed my shoulder, slowing down and sucking on the skin. His right hand was about to slide past my bow, when a long and piercing woman’s shriek rang outside. The cry made my stomach turn, sending a wave of terror through my body. We heard a thud at the door, as if someone stumbled into or was thrown at it. There was ruckus in the hall again. Then we heard a frantic, dread-filled voice cry out, “They’re coming!”

I jumped to my feet and Justin followed me.

Once the screams and the clatter of shoes faded, Justin picked up my shirt and put his hoodie back on.

Pulse was ringing in my ears.

Was the university under attack? Were they terrorists? One of the students? Should we start running? What was going on? What was outside?

“I’ll go check what’s up. Lock the door behind me.”

I grabbed his arm. My heart was beating wildly, all my instincts screaming for us to stay away.

“Don’t go out there.”

He stopped and turned to look at me.

I was shaking already.

He came closer, gave me a tight hug and pressed his lips to my forehead.
“I’m only gonna check what’s going on out there. Maybe it’s some kind of a prank. Don’t worry.”

He pulled back, took my face in his hands and gave me a quick kiss.

“If it’s unsafe, run. Okay?”

One corner of his lips perked up. His eyes were filled with warmth and affection.

Gently caressing my cheek, he uttered,

“I love you.”

The way he said it, so openly and sincerely, completely disarmed me.

I opened my mouth to say the same, but the words got stuck somewhere deep inside me, finding no release. Fear pinned them down.

He gently took my shaking hand, turning it palm up and leaving his silver ring in it.

“My mom gave me this ring for my eighteenth birthday. About a year ago I found out she didn’t buy it. She got her favorite silver earrings remelted, the ones she got from her own mother.”

“Why are you telling me this?”

“I want you to keep it, as a promise that I’ll come back. And that you have nothing to worry about.”

“Why does it sound like you’re saying goodbye?”

He smiled.

“I’m not. I’m sure it’s gonna be fine.”

“What if it’s not?”

My brain kept playing the screams on repeat in my head, like a tape.

His smile faded and he gave me a determined look.

“Then I’ll come back for you and we’ll get as far away from here as possible.”

I kept nodding my head, trying to convince myself to trust him.

He took my face in his hands again, looking me in the eyes.

“Promise you won’t leave this room and wait for me.”

“I promise.”

A smile appeared on his lips again.

“Okay.”

He tucked a strand of hair behind my ear, his left hand stroking my head.

I pressed myself against his body, hugging him tightly, not wanting to let go.

“I’ll stay here and wait.”

“Don’t worry, baby. We’re gonna be fine.”

He kissed my forehead and left the room.

For several minutes I just stood there like an ice statue, watching the door.

Finally, I reached for the door and locked it.

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CHAPTER 9

~~I never fully understood the feeling of terror. How deep it could go, how fast it could change us, how crippling it felt. Terror can protect or destroy us with equal fervor.~~

I sat on the bed, not daring to tear my eyes from the door. I kept listening for any movement outside, but there wasn't any. Ilion wasn't a crime hub. Burglaries and murders weren't common around here. Students like to shoplift booze for fun, but that's about it.

Not too long ago, mom sent me the news about one of the private universities in Rayville. An armored minivan stopped at the main entrance of the university and whoever was in the car shot up the first floors. Over a hundred people were killed, and around three hundred were injured. The minivan was never found.

Some said the chancellor owed money to the wrong people and the attack was a warning. That's because the attackers didn't shoot at the windows to his office overlooking the main street, right above the main entrance sign.

Some said it was a payback from the enemies of rich kids' families for their misdeeds.

Theories and gossip came out in droves, overlapping and mixing up, so I just stopped reading about it and decided to wait for a formal statement.

I put the ring on my left index finger, but it was too large. So I moved it to my middle finger and rolled it with my thumb like Justin often did.

I looked down and noticed the blue planner on the floor. I picked it up and put it on the desk. I sat on the bed, playing with the ring and looking at the planner intently.

My curiosity got the best of me, so I picked it up and opened the planner to a random page.

His handwriting was hard to read. Every word he wrote looked more like a signature. Some words were crossed out and new ones were written over them.

*So precious, vivid, so profound,
Your eyes are glowing, darkness-bound.
They call, they beckon, tantalize,
Two wild storms spelling my demise.*

*Like flowing sprays of silky willow-trees,
Your locks cascade in lovestruck breeze.
Those gentle, supple lips
Would bring a peach to shame.
Your dainty, loving hands
In mine I wish to claim.*

I could feel anxiety drawing near like an ominous stranger. I closed the planner and ran my hand across it, stroking it like the pages could feel something. The gears in my head were grinding feverishly, looking for the right choice I'd already made.

I left the planner on the bed and went to the door. Resting my hand on the handle, I unlocked the door but couldn't bring myself to open it. My heart was pounding in my chest at the uncertainty waiting on the other side. I opened the door and stepped into the hall.

The hall was quiet and empty. Silence felt tense, suffocating. I wondered if I really heard it wrong. Maybe nothing bad's really happening and I was overreacting.

I turned left and kept walking down the hallway. I looked back before turning right and still saw no one there. I headed to the exit and suddenly noticed a guy in checkered shirt and jeans sprawled on the floor. He was lying face down. An opened glass bottle lied next to him. Some of the yellow liquid spilled out and soaked the dirty carpet.

He looked like he'd got drunk and passed out before he got to his room. That wasn't uncommon in the dorms. Many could already be drunk by lunchtime. The reason for it? Weekend was a good enough reason to have a few drinks with friends.

As I came closer, I began to worry he'd suffocate or choke on his own vomit.

I crouched down beside him and pulled at his right shoulder, trying to help him sit up. He was so heavy I couldn't even stir him at first. I had to get on my knees and brace myself. Gripping him tightly, I lifted the guy a little in one swift motion and turned him on his back. He fell face-on, and I was met by his eyes frozen in sheer horror. Wide-open. Empty. Lifeless.

His face was pale, twisted in fear.

I staggered back, hitting the wall behind me. My gaze fell on the knife stuck deep in his chest. I covered my mouth, too afraid to let out a scream. I lost my voice. It was stolen by the eyes that witnessed death itself as fear was spreading through my body like poison, leaving me voiceless. My heart was racing, screaming for me to "run away, run as fast as you can." My body was shaking helplessly, my brain was felt scrambled.

I thought I could hear footsteps, as if someone was approaching. I quickly turned my head and saw Lea.

Pressing a finger to her lips, she held out her left hand to me. She didn't look scared, more like tense and alert.

She waved for me to follow her. I got to my feet carefully, still looking at the body when Lea gripped my arm and dragged me with her.

Lea was walking slowly and quietly. She'd turn to me whenever I stepped on a creaky floorboard, gesturing for me to keep it down. She came to a stop at a wall by the spiral staircase leading outside. My brain screamed for me to run and I was about to do just that when we heard men's voices and someone's quiet sobs downstairs. I couldn't decide if they were coming from a man or a woman. The pulse ringing in my ears was distracting me, muffling all other sounds.

Lea got on her knees and began crawling quietly. Trying to keep calm and avoid looking at what was going on downstairs, I did the same.

Passing the stairs, we crept softly down the hall. I saw another guy's body, but Lea only shook her head grimly.

We caught sight of many more bodies on our way. Some of them looked familiar, others I'd never seen before. Every right turn, every hallway felt like torture. My anxiety would reach its peak every time we stumbled upon a body, dissipating each time I realized it wasn't Justin.

Whenever I saw a girl's body, I'd pray it wasn't Bell. I felt guilty whenever relief washed over me. How could I feel relieved at a sight of a human being humiliated, robbed and turned into nothing. All of them used to be somebody.

I kept telling myself they were alive. Justin was alive. Bell was alive. Lea could make it, I could make it, and they could, too.

We were about to take the fire escape staircase when we heard men's voices bouncing off the concrete walls. We froze, listening closely. The clatter of boots going up the steps echoed off the hollow walls.

They're going up.

Lea slowly opened the door to an auditorium next to the stairs, peeking inside. She went in and I quickly followed her.

The auditorium was small. Nothing but a few desks and chairs inside. We were on the fourth floor. There's no way we could jump and make a run for the forest.

There was nowhere to hide!

Panic overtook my mind, I couldn't think straight any more. I wanted to scream. To run. Bawl my eyes out. Do anything to avoid them.

"Pull the chairs right up and curl up on them. The front of the desk will hide you."

Lea's whisper pulled me out of a trance.

I watched Lea make her way to the back and squeeze herself under one of the desks while lying on the chairs. I did the same, ignoring the buzzing in my ears. We curled up in the fetal position and looked up at each other.

The voices were close enough for us to hear what they were saying clearly. They were standing outside the door.

I tried listening in on their conversation, but then the door flew open with a crash, startling me. I barely held back from knocking my elbow on the desk, dooming both myself and Lea.

I gave her a fearful look. Her face was expressionless. She held her index finger at her lips.

It was shaking.

A chair flew over my head, hitting the wall and landing next to me.

"Well, where the fuck are they? I'm tired of chasing them. The chickenshit pussies scattered all around the place."

“If you keep yelling and making noise, we’ll never find them. So shut your mouth and make yourself useful.”

I heard one man shove the other.

“You shut your mouth. I don’t give a shit that he changed his mind last minute. That wasn’t part of the deal.”

The other man sighed heavily.

“What? Am I wrong? Say it to my fucking face. Say it!”

“Shut the fuck up already. If we don’t do as he says, we’ll not just lose the money, we’ll lose our lives.”

“What’s he gonna do to us? What can he do to me? He can come over here and chase these pigs himself.”

He took a few steps towards us.

Nothing could calm my quivering body. It wouldn’t stop. It’s like it wasn’t even mine anymore.

“What’s he gonna do? Wanna know what he did to Liam’s team? He killed them. Every single one. His snipers offed both Liam and all his guys the same day he crossed him. We had a choice before we made a deal with him. And now we fucking don’t. Now, quit whining like a bitch and do your job.”

The first guy loudly spat on the floor. I heard them leave the auditorium. Their steps and voices were moving away.

Lea quietly got out, moving the chairs carefully. My body grew stiff. I didn’t want to leave, but I forced myself to keep going. Lea came to the door, opened it soundlessly, waited for a few moments and took a peek outside.

It’s clear.

We went to the stairs. It was hard to keep walking slowly. I wanted to bolt out of there, but Lea stopped me, whispering for me to keep it as quiet as possible. We could hear them any time, but they couldn’t find out we’re here.

We got to the second floor and Lea headed into the hall.

“We can escape.”

“No.”

She shook her head.

“Why?”

“They surrounded the building. We won’t make it to the forest. We have to hide with the others and wait until help gets here.”

Are they still alive?

We went down the hallway until we reached the library.

She carefully opened the door and we got in. A smell of books and mildew greeted us.

Lea closed the door quietly and came up to me.

“Whisper if you need to say something, but it’ll be better if we stay quiet.”

I saw eyes peeking from the shelf stands. They were watching us.

“They’ve searched the place once already, but it doesn’t mean they’re not coming back. If they return, get on the floor and don’t move. We moved a couple of stands to the windows, but you’d better stay away from them. There were three of us here when they came. Now there are seven.”

I turned my head to the bookcases. I felt like I’d be trapped in the back, blocking my escape, so I headed to the front shelf stands, the ones by the exit. Lea grabbed my arm to stop me.

“You won’t make it. That’s how they got my friend. They don’t check everything, but they always check the first rows. Better pick a place in the back.”

I looked at her, trying to say something, but no words would come out. A heavy lump of harrowing emotions smothered me, stealing my voice. I was on the verge of tears and she gave me a tight hug.

“It’s okay. You’re in shock. I know you’re thankful.”

I kept wiping away the tears as I walked to the back shelf stands.

Passing the shelves, I saw a few of my classmates, who gave me a quick nod. In the back I came across a girl sitting in a corner. She sat on the floor, leaning on her knees, face hidden in her arms. I sat beside her quietly, leaned on a cold wall and closed my eyes.

I could still see the dead bodies, their empty eyes and pools of blood. My mind kept jumping to grim thoughts about Bell being the one weeping at the bottom of that staircase. That they still might be abusing and torturing her out there. That she needed my help, and I walked away. I left her.

I opened my eyes and wasn’t going to close them anytime soon. I looked down at my hands and saw them shaking like leaves in the wind. I no longer noticed my racing heart. I got used to my feverish pulse and the heart jumping out of my chest.

I no longer allowed myself to think, analyze or dwell on anything.
I was alive, but for how long more?

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CHAPTER 10

~~My actions result from my choices and ignorance. I always know, what I'm choosing, but I can't know something I don't yet know. My life is a chaos I'm desperately trying to organize.~~

The girl next to me lifted her head, wiping tears with the sleeve of her shirt. It wasn't her first time doing it, her eyes and cheeks were already red.

My gaze fell on her left hand, haphazardly dressed with a blood-stained piece of cloth.

"I tried to protect my friend, but she saved me first."

I saw a large tear roll down her flushed cheek. She quickly wiped it off.

"My boyfriend left his room and I don't know, if he's still alive or not," I blurted out.

I was surprised how easy it was for me to share my suffocating fears with a person I'd never met before.

She lifted her teary blue eyes to look at me. I could see sympathy in her eyes, making me bite my tongue to hold back the tears.

"Has anyone called the police?"

"There's no service. They're jamming it. We tried, many times."

Terror, despair and anger overwhelmed me.

My gaze fell on her arm.

"I could dress the wound on your hand, if you want."

She nodded and I scooted closer.

The bandage was soaked in blood. A little longer, and it would have started to leak.

"I'm gonna go ask if anyone has any kind of gauze here."

"I already have. There's nothing here but the books."

I undid the wet bandage and saw a deep wound still oozing blood.

"Tell me if it hurts too bad."

"I can't feel it anymore."

Hearing her say that made my heart ache like someone crushed it in their hand.

I could have been in her shoes. I could have witnessed my friend being slaughtered while I could do nothing to help. I could only run. Run away like a coward to escape the same fate. Survive knowing she didn't. Realize she sacrificed herself to save my life. The life I could lose any moment now.

And I could have been in her friend's place. Lying on the floor, choking on my own blood, powerless to do anything about it. What would I have been thinking? What thoughts would have crossed my mind? Would there even be any?

I looked down at my hands. Blood covering them looked like paint. I wiped them on my jeans.

"I envy you."

"Why?"

"You have a hope. You still believe he's alive. And hope keeps you going. Can't do much without it."

"I'm afraid of hoping."

"We... you have no choice."

I sat and looked out the window through the gap between the shelf stands. I saw gray haze overtake sheer white clouds. I watched the rain drizzle, thinking how fresh the air outside would be soon.

Time flew by. I sat in the same spot for too long and decided to stretch my legs. I got up and saw Lea. I was going to come up to her, but Francis beat me to it.

"You aren't going out there."

He gripped her arm.

"You got a better idea? Wanna play rock-paper-scissors to decide who goes out?"

"No one has to go there. We should stay here and wait until help arrives."

She tore her arm from his grasp.

"You don't get it, do you? No one's coming. Phones aren't working. Guards are dead. I pressed the emergency alarm button. The police was supposed to be here already, but they aren't. No one's gonna save us. We have to save ourselves."

"What are you on about?"

“I heard them talking to one another. They’re mercenaries. Sent here to kill us.”

“Kill for no reason? That makes no sense.”

“Someone wants to get back at the university higher-ups. We’re just pawns for them to take it out on.”

“Fuck.”

Francis went to punch the wall, but caught himself and slid his hand on it instead.

“I’ve been watching the windows all this time. They gathered up and left almost an hour ago. And they haven’t been back since. I’m gonna go down and check the exits. If it’s clear, we’ll all go out and run for the woods. It’ll be harder for them to find us there.”

“Lea, this is suicide. No matter the outcome.”

“What do you suggest? Huh?”

“I suggest we sit tight, keep quiet and wait for them to leave.”

“This might not happen. They can find us before that.”

“They haven’t yet.”

Loud clatter of boots was heard outside again. Everyone crouched down, hiding behind the shelf stands. The room went dead silent, as if no one dared to even breathe.

I could feel tension rise inside me, accompanied by my thumping pulse. I turned to look at the girl with the bandage. She was still sitting there, motionless, her head hanging low.

I got closer and took her by the hand. She didn’t look up, just gripped my hand tighter.

I was mad at my own helplessness. Mad that someone else got to decide what to do with my life for me. Mad that I couldn’t help anyone, not myself, not her, not anybody in this shitty library. Thinking about it made me feel a lump in my throat, my body barely holding it together. I took two deep breaths.

Panic was the worst thing I could condemn myself to. I was not dead yet. No one in the library was. We were alive, and we were many. I was not alone. We weren’t alone.

The door slammed open, hitting the wall hard enough to leave a dent. A large bald man with a red band on his arm and a limp body hanging over one shoulder entered the room. He threw the body on the floor like a sack of cement.

I was trying to convince myself to look away from the body, but failed. My eyes wandered the body on the floor. It was badly mutilated, seeing it made my stomach turn. I felt nauseous. He'd been mangled like he was game, not a human being.

"Come out, piggies!"

The bald guy sounded so jolly, it made me feel more mad than terrified.

No one moved a muscle. My heart was beating so loud I felt it'd jump out of my chest.

The man looked to be about 35. He had scars on his scalp, and a few more on his face. He was wearing black boots, blue jeans and a black sweatshirt with "Born to Kill" printed on it in white font.

He went to a shelf stand and pushed it like it was weightless. The stands began to fall like dominoes, raising clouds of dust. Everyone began jumping out from behind the bookcases, afraid to be left buried under them.

The girl with the bandage gripped my hand harder. I looked at her and saw how tightly she'd shut her eyes.

Through the stands I saw him approach our row. I jumped to my feet and dragged her with me. We got away in time.

We watched the stands fall over, all the books landing at our feet.

I turned to look at the bald guy and noticed the machete in his hand. The smile lingering on his face made my blood run cold.

Was he going to kill us there and then, or did he want to torture us first?

"Three, five, seven. Seven little piggies. Why, it's a fucking jackpot."

He was definitely going to torture us.

"Samael! Where the fuck are ya? We have a room full of piggies here."

There's one of him, and seven of us.

Before I could even finish that thought, a guy in red shirt threw a book in the bald guy's face. I don't know why he did it. Maybe he wanted to distract him, but the bald guy didn't move.

He slowly got down and picked up the book. His nasty smirk grew wider. Holding the book, he came closer to the guy.

"You dropped this."

He shoved the book at him so hard the guy staggered back.

With one swift move he slashed him across the body with the machete. Everyone gasped, someone screamed.

I just stood there, silently watching the bald guy's neck and chest get sprayed with blood. The guy dropped to the floor like a rag-doll.

I looked down at the now-dead guy's shirt and realized it wasn't red. It was burgundy.

A large pool of blood was growing on the floor, staining our shoes.

The bald guy was wiping the blade on his sweatshirt, grinning ear-to-ear.

"So. Who wants to go next?"

It all began to feel like a nightmare. Like it wasn't real. All of this couldn't be real. I refused to believe that reality could be like this.

I didn't want to cry. I wasn't nauseous any more. I could only feel adrenaline, which I still desperately tried to hold back, fighting my body's impulses.

Another man soon entered the library. That was Samael probably. He was wearing sneakers and a dark gray sweat suit.

"Damn. That your handiwork?"

"Yeah."

The bald guy kept smiling, clearly proud of his work.

"Outside!"

Samael barked.

"You heard that, piggies. We're taking you to grass. Oink-oink."

Everyone froze, as if becoming a part of the library. I knew every one of us wanted to turn invisible at that moment, like we used to pretend as kids when we played hide-and-seek.

I wanted it so bad.

The bald guy stopped laughing abruptly.

He gave us a disgusted look and bellowed, "Out, all of you!"

The girl with the bandage jerked.

Everyone began to move towards the exit slowly. We were taken down the corridor, going down the emergency staircase. I was still holding the girl's hand. Samael led us to the exit, while the bald guy followed behind.

The weather outside greeted us with cool fall breeze. The rain was still drizzling.

I tried inhaling the fresh air, but could only feel the fear filling my chest.

"Halt, piggies!"

The bald guy yelled, and we stopped.

"Face me, piggies," he said, smiling.

Everyone turned to look at him.

We were lined up, like soldiers in formation.

My classmate was standing to the left of me. The girl with the bandage was on my right. We weren't holding hands anymore.

Samael and the bald guy began whispering and arguing with one another.

Once they were done, the bald guy pointed his machete at us.

"You're lucky, piggies. Very lucky. You have a chance to walk away from this."

I heard a few heavy sighs.

"Let's play a game. The one who chooses someone to kill gets to live."

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CHAPTER 11

~~Instincts move us to act. They always protect us. They're always fighting for us. They always choose us. But it's for us to decide, whether to follow or to go against them.~~

We're going to die. No, we were not. We're going to die.

"We'll give you a blade. No funny business. Try turning on us, and we'll cut your throats. Before you even know it. Now. Who goes first?"

Everyone stood still, not making a sound. No one wanted to become a murderer.

"This isn't a trick, is it?"

Francis broke the silence.

Why was he asking? We weren't supposed to agree. We couldn't pander to them. There were more of us. We had to do something.

But what could we do?

The bald guy sneered and turned to look at Samael. The other guy was smiling, too. It's like we were at a bar, playing darts.

"What choice do you have?"

There was none.

"Who hired you? Why are you killing everyone?"

Everyone's head snapped to look at my classmate.

"Is this an interrogation, officer?"

The bald guy chuckled and nudged Samael. Once he was done cackling, the bald guy came up to him, pushing the smaller guy back with his whole body. He was a head taller and much bigger than him. My classmate looked back at him defiantly. Some could say he was brave. I thought he had a death wish. Why was he drawing attention to himself?

"Because we fucking can. Any more questions, whelp?"

Think. Think. Think.

If someone were to distract them somehow, we'd find a way out. We'd have time to run to the woods. If we started running, what were the chances they'd start throwing knives or shooting at us?

Could they shoot us?

I didn't see firearms on them, but that didn't mean they had none. Maybe they got off on torture and guns were too boring for them. If they missed their chance to throw a knife, they'd open fire. We'd have to zig-zag.

It'd take about a minute to get to the woodline.

So long.

Is there another way out? Going back to the dorms wasn't an option. Might as well stay here. I couldn't run into the town, their tinted minivans with no license plates were parked on the lawn, blocking the road back to town.

There's only the woods. Nothing but the woods.

People used to party in the woods. I knew where the party spot was, but had no idea, how wide the woods really were. What if I get lost? What if I never find my way back?

Doesn't matter. I'd rather get lost than killed.

Screams to the left of us pulled me out of my thoughts. Everyone turned towards it and saw a guy fall to the ground. A knife was sticking out of his back, and one of the freaks kept throwing knives at his wounded frame. I quickly turned away.

"If you don't wanna play, suit yourself."

The bald guy took a few steps back, turned around and slammed the machete into my classmate's head. Blood sprayed the left side of my face and my clothes.

Everyone screamed, but I just stood there, too shocked to react. I didn't make a sound. Didn't turn my head. Didn't wipe the blood off. I stared at the forest.

Run to the forest. Run. Hurry. Run.

I heard the machete being pulled out of the skull with a squelch that made my stomach turn, threatening to expel its contents. The sound was becoming familiar. Like a nauseating song stuck in my head.

The guy's body dropped to the ground, hitting my legs.

I was afraid to look down. Too afraid to look or think. I tried not to panic, to still my shaking knees.

Was I next?

“I’ll do it.”

Francis yelled and took a step forward.

The bald guy grinned, shaking his machete. Dark blood splatter stained the green grass, mixing with the crystal-clear raindrops.

Francis came up to Samael and the guy put the blade in his hand. Francis looked all of us over.

Was he going to choose? Was he really going to do it? Was he ready to kill?

I stood there, watching the woods, trying to ignore my own thoughts screaming at me.

“You.”

The choice was made.

I turned my head and saw Francis pointing at Lea.

Why her? He could have chosen anyone.

She came forward, like that was an order.

Francis approached her and put the blade to her neck. Lea looked him right in the eye. Her face was expressionless.

“I’ve never done this before. Show me how to do it right.”

Was he kidding? Was he really asking these freaks to show him the way to slaughter his girlfriend?

The bald guy and Samael broke into laughter.

“Grab it from the other side. You’re twisting your arm too much. Can’t cut a throat like this. And hold it closer to the base,” Samael explained.

“Like that?”

“No.”

Samael dropped his machete to the ground and came up to him, snatching the knife from his hand. He showed him how to hold the knife and gave it back to Francis.

Francis took it, turned back to Samael and drove the knife deep into his wind pipe in one swoop. The bald guy was about to strike them when Lea pulled out a pepper spray, spraying him in the face.

“Run!”

The moment Lea shouted, a knife hit her chest. It went in halfway. The bald guy threw it.

Run. Run. Run!

I tore off and ran so fast I got to the woodline in less than a minute. Adrenaline fueled me. Twigs slashed my face, leaving tiny scrapes. I was

sliding on the wet grass. I almost fell, grabbing a tree branch to catch myself and scratching my right hand in the process. It was like the woods were trying to stop me, but I didn't care. I didn't feel pain, there were only soil under my shoes and adrenaline in my body.

I ran by the spot we used to party at. The circle of gray ash turned black. The grass here had been trampled down.

I looked at it for too long and tripped, falling on my left side. I hurt my hip on the solid ground. All the air got knocked out of my lungs.

I heard footsteps approaching and struggled to get to my feet. My hip hurt, feet were sliding in the mud. The girl with the bandage ran out from behind a tree.

What was her name?

She gave me a panicked, disoriented look. She ran up and put my left arm around her shoulder to help me up.

"He's coming. He's after us."

She could barely speak through heavy breathing.

Her words hit me with a new wave of adrenaline, forcing me to get up through the pain.

"To the right," I exhaled.

He knows we're running straight ahead. We had to change our trajectory.

I ran so fast I lost sight of the girl for some time. I saw tall, dense bushes and hid behind them.

I saw the girl again after some time. Blood was dripping down her hand. She held her right hand close, trying to stop the bleeding. I peeked from behind the bushes and waved at her. She crouched down beside me and we began listening for any noises in the woods, trying to steady our breathing.

My heart was beating so fast I could feel the taste of blood in my mouth. We stayed quiet, looking ahead when we heard branches crunch to the left of us. I covered my mouth to hide the sounds of me breathing. I wanted to breathe through my mouth, but held myself back.

The bald guy ran, moving branches out of the way with one hand and holding the machete in the other. Suddenly, he stopped, listening for any sounds. His machete was stained crimson, just like the print on his sweatshirt.

Not this way.

He swore and ran ahead. Adrenaline began pumping through my body again, screaming for me to flee as fast as possible. The girl was about to get

up, but I pulled her arm. I shook my head and she sat back down.

A few minutes passed, and we got to our feet.

We kept running. We ran so fast we didn't even notice the woods had ended at first. A field with haystacks stretched out before us. We ran towards it and saw the bald guy to the left of us. He was standing there with his back to us. We got down quickly, hiding behind the first haystack.

"Piggies, I know you're here. Come out."

He was looking the opposite way. He's bluffing. He didn't know where we were.

I gripped the girl's hand tight, looking in her eyes. She was pale, her eyes looked tired.

We were going to make it. We could. We just had to get to the next woodline.

I looked out gingerly and saw him walking by the haystacks on the opposite side of the field, checking them. We need to run. Run, while we still had the chance.

I peeked from the haystack again and saw him still jogging between the rolls of hay, looking for us. We ran out of our hide-out on bended knees, trying to crouch down as we ran.

We passed several more haystacks when I caught him walking towards us. I turned to look at her and saw her eyes were rolling back.

I slapped her cheeks lightly.

She raised her eyes to look at me.

"Run away."

"No. We'll go together."

"Leave me here."

"No."

"Piggies, I'm getting really fucking sick of this shit. Come the hell out, or I'll fucking kill you," the bald guy's voice was stomach-churning.

"I'm still scared of death, but I can feel it coming. I want to die knowing I paid her back."

I pulled her right hand.

"Put your arm over my shoulder. We got only two haystacks left. Don't give up. We'll hide. I'll hide you and run to find help."

I tried lifting her up.

"I feel weak, my head's spinning. Let me die. Let me repay my debt. I don't want to die in vain."

“You won’t die for nothing. I won’t let you die. I’ll stay with you.”

I lifted her up a bit.

She stood up straight. I tried pulling her back down before he noticed us, but she pushed me aside.

“Don’t,” I whispered.

She yelled out, looking his way,

“Hey, you, bald fuck, I’m here. Your dumbass couldn’t even find me right under your nose. And you call yourself a butcher?”

I jumped up and pulled her towards the woods.

“Please, let’s go. Please. We can still escape.”

Tears welled up in my eyes.

“You’re dead, bitch,” he roared.

I saw the bald guy running our way. Time was running out for us. He was too close.

“I made my choice. I choose death. Now make yours and choose this God-damn life.”

My heart broke when she said that.

Was I supposed to stay? Run? Fight him off together? With what? Should I look for a stick? Should I cover her? Was I supposed to die with her? What was I to do? What?

She got down on the ground and threw a handful of sand in his face when he was close. The bald creep screamed, spitting curses and swinging his machete every which way.

“Run!”

She yelled out, turning towards me, and the next moment I saw her head fly off her shoulders. It fell and rolled on the ground like a soccer ball. Her open eyes stared at me. Her body dropped on the side like it never even knew life.

The bald guy wiped the blood from his face in disgust, like it was her fault he got sprayed with it.

Adrenaline ran through my entire body like a high-voltage current, filling it with powerful energy.

I took off to the woods, only one word ringing in my head, “run”.

CHAPTER 12

~~There were so many reasons for my hatred, I lost count a while ago. I no longer believed my life could go on without it. It was a part of me. My fuel. My meaning. The reason I hadn't given up yet.~~

I could hear the clatter of boots. They were crushing every twig in their path, turning my body into an adrenaline machine. It felt like he was breathing down my neck. I thought my head would roll off just as fast as the girl's if I were to turn it to look back even for a second.

To my surprise, this forest was even smaller than the first. I ran out into a field covered in tall grass.

I looked right and saw an old gray wooden fence. It looked like a fence someone used to keep cows or some other cattle behind.

I ran to it and was about to climb over the flimsy logs. The wood was rotten, but it held up pretty good.

I could see a grove with tall grass and oaks ahead of me.

How long did I have to keep running for? I didn't have much energy left in me. I needed to hide. To sit it out. Confuse him.

I climbed over the fence and looked back.

He wasn't there.

I began looking around in panic. I could hear him. He was somewhere close-by.

Where did he go? Where was he hiding?

There's no way he got ahead of me. He definitely didn't have time to hide.

I was moving forward through the tall weeds, some of which reached my stomach.

The sounds got louder and clearer. I realized those were the sounds of fine metal clashing. I saw two men knife fighting behind the trees to the

left. One of them was dressed in a suit, like he'd just left the office, while the other guy looked like one of the bandits back at the university.

They're here already.

I stopped dead, as if something pulled me back. They were fighting fiercely, paying me no mind. That meant I could run by them unnoticed or hide and wait it out.

I was about to run to the left when a black cloak suddenly appeared from behind a tree, like a creature from the underworld. The cloak was long and covered the entire body. The hood covered the face, giving me no chance to see who it was. I could tell it was a man from his broad shoulders.

I turned my head back and saw the bald guy run out of the forest like a horror-movie killer, looking around wildly. His bloodlust-fueled crazy eyes met mine. He was chasing after me like he was hired to kill me.

Which way do I run? Which way?!

My heart was torn with fear. I looked in front of me and saw the man slowly move his black hood back. His coal-black hair was styled back in small waves. A tiny stubborn black strand broke loose, falling handsomely on his forehead. His eyes were black. Like bottomless void staring into my soul. The darkness in them looked ready to pounce and slaughter me.

His dead gaze sent a wave of freezing cold through my body.

He looked like a grim reaper.

My gaze went lower. The cloak sleeves were long and covered his hands. When I noticed a machete in his right hand, I wanted to scream.

The weapon looked clean and polished. It was shiny.

I saw a leg on the ground behind him. There was a dead body there. I began to shake like I was burning with fever. I was looking around feverishly, trying to figure out a way to escape.

There was nowhere to run. If he didn't kill me, the bald psycho would. If the bald freak didn't get to me, the one who wins the knife fight would do the trick. Or they could all get together and chop me into chunks in this grove.

I was trapped.

Taking slow, yet broad steps, the reaper was coming closer. His terrifying eyes never leaving mine.

I took small steps back, not letting his machete out of my sight. He was swinging it about, making his way to me through the tall grass. His

movements were nimble and effortless. The machete made a soft swish as it touched the grass.

My heart was thumping in my chest as if about to explode like a balloon.

My head was ringing from the tension and the cruel fate I was about to face.

“What’s your name?”

I looked up.

Did I hear that right? Did he say that? Or was it in my head?

His expression didn’t change. It was just as cold and aloof as before. His aura didn’t just scare me, it petrified me, chilled me to the bone.

I wanted to look back to see where the bald man was. But it was like the reaper was the male version of the Gorgon, there’s no other way to explain the stupor I felt. My body would not obey me. It was ready to meet death.

Once he got lethally close to me, I took a big step back and slipped, falling down. He caught me by the waist and pulled me flush against his wet cloak. I could feel the warmth of his body through it.

“Zoe. My name’s Zoe.”

My voice was shaking.

Would these be my last words? Was he going to kill me now? Did he always ask for a name before killing someone?

I took one deep breath and closed my eyes tight while my body kept shaking.

His left hand stroked my hair, or did I imagine it? Then he pulled back and stepped around me.

I opened my eyes and turned back.

He kept walking straight ahead.

Towards the bald guy.

Was he going to kill him? Was he about to protect me? Was he going to save me? Was he on my side?

My eyes met the bald guy as he climbed over the fence. Bloodlust was clear in his crazed eyes. He licked his lower lip and grinned at me with that ugly smile of his.

My face scrunched as I felt a wave of chilling terror envelop me.

The reaper stopped right by him, staring me down with his bottomless eyes.

What was going on?

“That bitch is mine.”

The bald guy pointed his machete at me paying no attention to the reaper. Were they together?

“You want her? Come and get her.”

His voice was deep and stone-cold.

My hope was crushed right before my eyes.

The reaper kept standing still, looking at me. I wanted to run, but my body was bound by invisible chains.

It all happened so fast I could barely recreate it in my head. The bald guy didn't make it another step forward when my eyes went wide. Machete exited from his belly. Blood was leaking from his mouth, flowing down his chin, spilling on the ground in spurts. He didn't make a sound as his eyes went hazy, body falling to his knees.

The reaper put his black boot on his back, pulling the bloody machete out effortlessly. The dead body lay on the ground, the white “Born to Kill” print now soaked in brownish blood.

The blood on reaper's machete dripped down from the base along the very tip of the deadly blade.

The reaper was spotless. His black cloak was a mantle protecting him from blood splatter. I saw so much blood that day. The Earth changed color from green to blood red that day.

I looked up. The reaper walked slowly, watching me with the same grim look in his eyes, the one that gripped and squeezed the life out of me.

The men who attacked the university might have looked terrifying, which they definitely were. But they were no match for him. He had this air of calm, hidden danger about him, and only his black eyes would give it away. You couldn't run or hide from the likes of him. You could stand in a crowd silently, drawing no attention to yourself, but he would not let you by. He'd notice you, dragging you with him to the heart of the purgatory itself.

His looks radiated toxic magnetism. It could befuddle and trick you. He was like the sun, tempting you to fly closer and get scorched by its rays. But once you reached it, you'd realize it was all an illusion. He was never the sun, but a black hole, ready to devour you, reduce you to nothing.

Was he not going to kill me? Was he going to kill me? Was he not going to kill me? Was he going to kill me? Was he not going to kill me?

The reaper came closer and gripped my hand firmly. He dragged me after him. I followed, not gripping his hand back. I had to resist, hit him.

Even try to break free. But instead I quietly followed him, leaving the wild grove.

When I heard footsteps behind me, my heart began racing all over again, hurting my chest. I tried to break free from his grasp, but he gripped my hand tighter, causing pain.

I could only turn my head. I remembered the man he was the one at the knife fight. His eyes met mine and looked away almost immediately.

He was wearing a shirt with rolled-up sleeves and dark pants. His white shirt was stained with blood.

We walked in silence. We were surrounded by dead silence. No birds were singing. No screams could be heard. There was nothing but the monotonous rustle of his black cloak to accompany our footsteps.

The gears in my brain were grinding, trying to work out an escape plan. I knew I wouldn't be able to talk my way out of it. Just because they weren't with the bandits didn't mean they're on my side.

My brain was swimming in feverish junk, and an idea to tell them I needed to pee and then run away seemed like the only worthwhile one. Hitting him, snatching the machete, getting out of his grasp and running was impossible. There were two of them, and I was alone. I was only going to waste my strength or even make them angry, giving them a reason to kill me sooner.

I had a fleeting thought that maybe they were helping me. Maybe they're taking me to a hide-out, a place where I'd meet everyone else who made it out safely.

But who would force their victim to hold hands with them? I had to run, run until I pass out from exhaustion.

My life was on the line, and I didn't want to test just any theory. I knew I had to get away as soon as possible, before they took me to their lair.

Out of all the ideas scolding my panicking brain, the idea to tell them I need to pee seemed like a real way out. I've regained some of my strength, I would be able to act fast.

Through the still green trees up ahead I saw a glimpse of an old, abandoned-looking manor. Time clearly wasn't too kind to it. I could see part of a time-stained statue with an eroded face and cracked body.

We were walking straight ahead, and I saw a body out of the corner of my eye. I turned away, only to turn back to it right away. My head went dead silent.

My left hand tried freeing my palm from his grip, scratching him while tears were streaming down my face, landing on our hands like raindrops.

He didn't react. He kept holding my hand in his iron grip silently until I raised my teary eyes to look at him.

His jet-black eyes, darker than a moonless night, stared me down with disgust and disdain. Suddenly, he released my hand, as if ridding himself of the burden of me.

I took off and when I was close to the body, my foot tripped over a thick tree root sticking out of the ground. I fell and hit my knees on the still wet soil. Refusing to get back to my feet, I began crawling to him, like I forgot how to walk.

My chest felt crushed. I felt like I couldn't breathe. It's like I forgot how to inhale the air. Tears blurred my eyes like a shroud of mist. I did not want to believe it.

That wasn't him. It was not him. It couldn't be him.

My shaking hands reached out for his cheeks. They were ice-cold. His lips were blue, and blood from the deep cut on his neck had already dried up. His clothes, clean and smelling of him that morning, was now soaked in blood and dirt.

I took his hand and pressed it to my right cheek.

"You promised," I whispered.

I let his hand go and it fell lifelessly on my knees.

Tears were streaming down my face. Salty dew stung the cuts on my cheeks. I could barely breathe. It felt like an invisible hand was choking the life out of me. My heart was broken, torn apart by death. My brain refused to comprehend it. Refused to accept it. I wanted to wake up. I wanted him to wake up. For this nightmare to end. I wanted to wake up and see it was all okay. Because good people shouldn't die. People in love shouldn't die. What kind of world allows evil to win?

I could feel my body turning into one big bleeding open wound. I felt physically sick. I couldn't calm down, couldn't control myself anymore. I was ripped apart, my bloody shreds thrown back together haphazardly with no intent to ever let me heal.

I screamed at the top of my lungs. I screamed, splitting my ears and wearing my vocal cords out. Screamed until there was no air left in my lungs. Time stood still, and I was frozen with it.

When I stopped, I realized there was no relief. That it still hurt just as much. It hurt so bad I thought the pain would devour me, erase me from this world. This deep, invisible wound on my body would never close, I could feel it. It would never heal. It would turn into a soaring, festering wound bleeding more and more day after day.

I grabbed his hand and stared at his face, not moving an inch. It felt like my mind and all my emotions got turned off. I was no longer thinking or feeling. All felt quiet and hollow. I wanted to stay in his stillness until his body slowly disintegrated and the nature swallowed his remains once and for all.

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CHAPTER 13

~~The feeling of being robbed would never leave me. It's lonely, cold and harrowing. The emptiness longs to be filled. It craves revenge.~~

My body was shivering. The cold wrapped around me, forcing me to lean against it. I heard a voice and slowly opened my dry tear-stained eyes. Bright yellow light from a lamp hanging outside the cage made it all worse. I closed my eyes and heard the voice again. Listening closely, I realized those were woman's sobs.

I slept for half a day, maybe even the whole day. The concrete cage had no daylight, no toilet or anything else that caught the eye. I was sitting on a flimsy mattress, stained with filth and someone else's suffering.

My clothes captured all of the monstrous events of that blood-drenched day like a photograph. I didn't let myself think about it, couldn't let it all come back to me. I wasn't going to linger in the dark corners of my mind, savoring every memory like a poison apple. I locked them behind an oak door, leaving the key in the lock for when the time comes to see them once more.

This was not the time. It was not the time to cry, pity myself or throw a fit. It was the time to fight. I was still breathing, seeing and feeling. That meant I was still alive. I wasn't going to let them break me, take me down or bring me to my knees.

I would fight back, lie and fit in, but I'd stay true to myself. I knew I had to survive, whatever it takes. I had to find Bell, get back to my family, tell the truth.

I had to pay them back.

I sat by Justin's body, losing track of time. The reaper grabbed me, snapping me out of my trance, and began dragging me to the manor. I was struggling, scratching him, but I knew it was no good. Before I knew it, I got to the manor steps, and then found myself behind bars here.

I slowly got up and went to the steel door, grasping the rusty bars.

All the cages were lined up, making it impossible for me to see the people in the other cells. I could only hear them.

“What’s upstairs?”

I asked the void outside, still hoping for an answer.

The sobs cut out for a moment before picking up again.

“Hell.”

A woman’s voice seemingly coming from the cage next to me replied, making my heart race.

“Are there only girls here?”

“Yes.”

“How many?”

“Four.”

“How long have you been here?”

“Don’t know. Two days, I think. They brought us here at the same time probably.”

I held my breath, trying to catch every word.

“What does he want?”

“I don’t know. Few girls got to come back. And if they did, they’d not talk again.”

“What’s he doing to them?”

“You can take a guess.”

My imagination was too wild and boundless for that. So I didn’t even try guessing to keep my sanity and avoid panicking ahead of time.

“What’s your name?”

“Zoe.”

“I’m Cass. I worked at the Roncalli University library, part-time. They asked me to work after hours yesterday. I’m always the last one to leave and lock the library doors. As I was closing the library for the day, someone came up from behind and pressed a rag soaked in some chemicals to my face. And I woke up in here.”

“Our university has been attacked today. They came in black tinted minivans without license plates, machetes in hand. It was a bloodbath. No one knows what their motives are. They tortured and killed anyone they could find.”

“And the cops?”

“We pulled the emergency alarm, but no one came. Our phones wouldn’t work. Maybe the police are in on it, or they’re all dead.”

“Did they seize the town?”

“Most likely. I was running through the forest near the manor, and they were there already.”

“Have you lost someone?”

“Yes.”

We fell silent.

“Are they in on it?” Cass asked.

“Doesn’t matter. They might not be working together, but the fact that we’re here, and not free to leave, speaks volumes. They’re just as bad. Same vile bastards.”

Loud clatter of boots echoed through the place. They were getting louder and louder. I moved to the back of the cell and waited.

Two large men passed by my cage and opened the next one.

I saw one of them walking ahead while the other man led Cass away.

She gave me a smile as she passed by my cell. She looked cheery and jovial, like she was going for a walk and not to meet her death.

My heart was crushed by how unfair it all was. This wasn’t supposed to be happening. This wasn’t right. She didn’t deserve this. No one here did.

Why did it happen to us? Why us? What did we do wrong? What did we do to deserve this?

They thought they could do anything. But that wasn’t true, they were people just like us, they weren’t gods. We had the law. It worked for everyone. They had to pay for this. Pay for every life they ruined and took away. Their power wasn’t limitless. They would be found out. They had to be found and punished. Monsters like them had no right to walk among us. They defiled the very word “human”. They deserved to be deprived of this privilege. They deserved to be left to rot in solitary confinement for the rest of their days.

I didn’t notice anger consuming me, making me roll the silver ring on my middle finger hard enough to hurt. My cheeks and ears flushed red.

With a heavy sigh I sat on the mattress and leaned back on the cold concrete wall.

How much time did I have left? If I knew my death was coming soon, what would be my last thing to do? What could I do while I was locked in

the cage? Forgive everyone? Ask for forgiveness? Pray? What was I supposed to do?

I closed my eyes and concentrated on deep breathing.

I should have dropped out. Why didn't I? Had I dropped out, I would've been back in my hometown now, with mom and dad. They wouldn't have been too happy about it, but at least I would be alive.

We'd eat mom's delicious meals, and in the evening I'd talk them into going to our favorite drive-in cinema. I'd take a large popcorn, the largest one they have. Caramel flavored, hands down. And a coke. Yes. A large coke.

I definitely wouldn't have wasted my time watching my weight. Bothering about wearing makeup, looking puffy-eyed and ugly. Worrying that no one liked me. I wouldn't have beat myself up over eating too much at lunch or having an ice-cream late at night.

It seemed so shallow and pointless now. Why did I waste so much energy on these silly thoughts when I could have enjoyed life and that stupid ice-cream? I could have lived a perfectly normal, happy life because I had everything.

I regretted that.

I was mad at myself for only just now realizing that, when everything was already lost.

Life is a priceless gift. If you want to show how thankful you are for it, you've got to live it with dignity.

CHAPTER 14

~~Have I always had a choice? Is free will just an illusion? Am I free now?
Have I ever been free? Will I ever be free? Will I get to feel freedom again?
Will I have a chance to choose once more? Will I want to make a choice?~~

I opened my eyes and saw the lamp hanging outside my cell was no longer working. Pale-yellow lights by the other cells kept blinking, throwing light only at my barred cell door. My body was freezing, but I wasn't trembling anymore.

I closed my eyes and heard footsteps. I thought I was imagining it, but now I knew they were real.

The footsteps were getting louder and louder. I got to my feet, gripped the bars of my cage and waited.

I saw a man walk with Cass on his arm as her legs stumbled. Her body looked like it was ready to slump over and spill onto the floor in a puddle.

Her face didn't show horror, fear or pain. It looked blank. She was still alive, but her face said otherwise.

It didn't take them a long time to get her back to the cell, but I used it to look her over, searching for any obvious signs of torture on her body. Thinking about it made me sick, but I had to get real. I had to know what to expect.

I was expecting a beat-up face, stab wounds, clothes torn apart, anything that would help me get ready for my turn. But she looked the same as before.

Panic was rising from the pit of my stomach, growing like a balloon.

This damn uncertainty was eating me alive like sizzling acid.

I sat on the floor and began to rub every finger on my left hand.

It was quiet today. No one was screaming or crying. Cass didn't make a sound. Who was next?

My heartbeat was so heavy, I felt like a marathon runner.

All these thoughts weren't helping. They were bullies poking my wounded body with sticks.

I had to calm down and stop overthinking.

Monotonous footsteps rang through the basement walls, letting me know they're coming. My heart was rumbling in my chest like a little engine.

The footsteps were coming closer, getting louder. Next thing I knew, two men stopped in front of my cell.

One opened the door with an old-looking key while the other man looked at him with a bored expression.

The door opened and I stood up.

One of them entered my cell and grabbed my arm without a word, like I was a product, not a human being.

I didn't resist. I followed meekly, waiting for what's to come.

They had me in a painful iron grip that felt like someone wrapped the iron bars of my cell door around my arms.

They urged me up the stairs.

Walking up the steps felt like going up a hill. I expected bright sunlight to daze me, but there was none. It was nighttime.

Thick black curtains on the windows were drawn. There was a suit of rooms up ahead, I passed one of them on my way here.

The exit was so close, yet so terribly far.

They turned left and led me to a set of large doors. I could see light seeping from beneath them. One of them unhanded me, opened the door and pushed me in, like he was throwing a lamb into the lion's den.

I snapped my eyes shut, but it didn't help. The light was bright enough to make my eyes water. I wanted to run back to my cell to never have to look at it again.

I heard the door closing. I tried to open my eyes slowly, but it hurt too much. Was light the first torture?

I managed to keep my eyes open after a while. My vision was blurry. I could only see his outline, so I tried blinking rapidly, staring down at my feet.

Once my vision went back to normal, I looked up and saw the reaper standing just a few feet away, watching me silently. The shock made my breath hitch as I took a few steps back.

He was dressed in all black: black shoes, black pants, black shirt. Everything looked neat and smooth. Not a wrinkle or spot in sight. He

looked flawless, like he just stepped off of a boutique display window.

His raven black hair was combed back neatly, falling in a dark wave of locks. He had a somewhat tanned complexion. As for his eyes, they looked just as grim and cold as before.

The color of his eyes practically blended with the ebony color of his pupils even in the bright light of the lamps.

He slowly raised his arms and folded them over his chest. His shirt stretched and hugged his body like second skin. Nature clearly was playing a cruel joke on us. I wanted to look at him. Watch him closely. It wasn't every day that I met a man of such toxic magnetism.

He kept staring me down silently.

For a moment I thought he wasn't real. That he was a mannequin.

His eyes weren't looking me over like they would, had he been human. He wasn't observing me. His eyes stared intently into mine. His gaze pulled me in like a black hole, and I did my best to avoid it.

I noticed a double door at the other end of the room. I tilted my head to the side and saw a similar door to my right.

This was the door they took me here through. I knew where the exit was. It's in the next room over.

Were his goons still standing outside the door, were they gone? If they were, I might have some time to run out and dash to the forest, right? They might shoot me down. What if they're standing outside? Then they would just drag me back. But what if there's a punishment? Did he want me alive?

He's searching. Looking for a special girl. Who was he looking for? Whom did he want? What if he wasn't really looking for anyone? If this was all just a game, I was as good as dead.

Adrenaline was pumping through my veins, reminding me I was still alive and kicking.

My right thumb began fiddling with the ring.

I slowly turned my head to face him. He was still in the same spot, his gaze as eerie as before, piercing right through me.

Was he armed?

Silence was his weapon.

He's watching me. Waiting. Was this a test?

The corner of his lips twitched a bit. Just a miniscule disturbance in his form, yet it couldn't go unnoticed.

"Looking for a way out?"

“Yes,” I sighed.

“Why aren’t you running then?”

I sneered, looking down. I had no reason to smile, but my anxiety got the best of me.

“What do I have to do for a chance to escape?”

I looked up, meeting his gaze.

Now was his turn to smirk.

“You still think you can escape, don’t you?”

Dread bound my body with invisible threads.

The air in the room was heavy with tension. I could feel my pulse, my ears were ringing.

“You don’t get to choose. There’s only one option. And believe me, you’ll want it. It’d seem like paradise to you.”

“If this is paradise, what will hell look like?”

I immediately regretted saying it out loud. A wide grin appeared on his face.

I tried to swallow the lump in my throat, but it was pointless.

He turned his back to me and went to his desk. On it was a glass decanter with a tumbler, as well as a large blue box.

My heartbeat quickened with renewed vigor. The crimson liquid inside the decanter looked like blood. He calmly poured himself half a glass, drank it and turned back to me.

“Do you want to know what I have in store for you, Zoe?”

“No.”

I whispered this under my breath, looking at the floor.

He slammed the glass on the table and I jumped.

“Do you like animals?”

“Yes.”

“What about dogs?”

Was he going to kill a dog before me? Or did he want me to kill one?

“What is the most important trait of a dog?”

“Loyalty.”

“Louder.”

“Loyalty,” I spoke up.

“I want you to become a dog.”

“What?”

“I want your loyalty, diligence and selflessness. I need you to be as loyal as a dog to me. You will follow my orders without question. If I tell you to steal, you steal. If I tell you to kill, you kill. If I tell you to die, you drop dead.”

I should've tried to run while I still had the chance.

There's no paradise, only hell.

“If I refuse, are you going to kill me?”

“I knew curiosity will get the best of you.”

His smile was alluringly ominous.

He took a phone out of his pocket, made a few clicks and put it on speakerphone.

I heard the dial tone.

“Hello.”

The voice on the other end sounded raspy and tired.

My jaw dropped, eyes opening wide in shock. I felt like a dirty boot pressed on my throat, cutting off all oxygen.

I could tell this voice from thousands of others.

This was my dad's voice.

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CHAPTER 15

~~The authorities have always been on my side. They gave me strength and protected me. We walked hand in hand. I could do anything. I felt invincible.~~

“Zoe, is that you?”

“Yes, daddy.”

Warm tears rolled down my cheeks.

“Zoe, I called you so many times, you didn’t pick up the phone. Is everything alright?”

I felt a faint touch of relief behind the thick fog of terror.

I raised my teary eyes to look at the reaper. He had a blank expression on his face, like there was no soul behind those eyes whatsoever.

“Yes. It’s fine.”

“Sweetheart, please, don’t worry, okay?”

Anxiety washed over me like a wave of icy-cold water.

“I’m in a hospital right now and...”

“Are you hurt?”

“No. I’m okay.”

He signed heavily and stayed silent.

His voice was shaking when he spoke again.

“Zoe, mom’s been in an accident. A truck T-boned her car. The driver lost control of it. She’s in a coma.”

I could no longer feel my body. The urge to lean on something was not just a need, but a vital necessity.

I was panting. My eyes darted to the floor, looking for something I wasn’t even aware of myself.

My right hand clutched my shirt, stretching it.

I thought I was going to fall and shatter into a thousand tiny shards, like the glass figurine I felt I was.

“Dad?”

“Yes, sweetheart.”

“I love you both so much.”

He let out a heavy sigh. That sigh held so much pain and suffering he’d never tell me about.

I could feel my anger waking up from its slumber.

“We love you, too. I’ll call this number when I get any news.”

“Okay.”

This could be our last conversation. I didn’t think the reaper would allow me to speak to him again.

My chest felt heavy, like there was a concrete slab crushing it.

I didn’t know what else to tell him. I didn’t want to say goodbye. I felt like I was chopping away at a vital part of myself, about to lose it forever.

“Kiss mom for me.”

“Okay, honey. Take...”

The reaper ended the call, leaving me no time to say goodbye.

He slipped the phone in his pocket nonchalantly.

What if I’d said “yes” straight away? What would’ve happened, had I agreed to his terms? She was in the hospital before I made any decision. Why didn’t he let me choose? He made the choice for me. Why? Had I not asked, I would’ve never learned she was in a hospital in the first place. He’d have denied me a chance to say goodbye to her.

I balled my hands into fists hard enough to make the nails dig into my palms.

Anger was turning into rage. It was seething, spilling over from my chest and flowing through my body.

My gaze fell on the blue box he’d just opened. A dagger with a silver handle lay inside.

Would I be able to kill him? He’s standing too close to the box. I would never make it.

What about running away? There’s no way back. He knew where they were. I was trapped.

I wiped away the tears with a sleeve of my white shirt, now stained with dried blood.

My eyes were filled with venom. My heart brimmed with hatred looking to burst out. It overwhelmed my mind, wishing to break free.

I was going to take a step forward when he ordered:

“Take your clothes off.”

“What?”

I spat it out like an insult.

“I can call somebody to undress you.”

He took his phone out.

“I’ll take it off!”

My angry voice echoed across the room.

I took off my filthy shirt, balled it up and threw it in front of me defiantly. I removed my sneakers and socks, pulled my pants off. I was standing in my lime-green lingerie with a tiny yellow bow on the panties.

“Is that all?”

“No. The underwear has to go as well.”

My face twisted in anger.

I smiled uncomfortably, staring at the floor. I quickly unclasped my bra. It fell at my feet with a dull sound. Then I took off the panties.

He frowned a little, a tiny wrinkle showing between his eyebrows. His glance slowly slid from my neck to my breast, stomach, groin and legs.

He stared at me like he was trying to remember something, or maybe memorize what I looked like.

“Turn around.”

I turned around, like a dog obeying a command.

I looked at the striped wallpaper on the wall. The clicking of his shoes echoed off the marble floor as he came closer. My eyes darted from side to side all this time in confusion.

What was he going to do? Why was he coming closer?

What if he’s got the knife?

That thought made me turn around. My feet caught on the sneakers. My left hand gripped his black shirt, crumpling the fabric in my fist. He gripped my wrist tightly, holding me in place.

Panting, I looked at my hand, still gripping a handful of his shirt. We were so close, I could feel the heat radiating from his body. Wasn’t he supposed to be cold, like the grim reaper?

He tilted his head down and I saw his irises. They were different from the color of his pupils and looked umber brown.

He smelled of wine, amber, musk and spices. The smell was too strong. It was suffocating me.

I let go of his shirt and took two steps back. I felt like I could get tainted by his ugly nature and turn into someone just like him.

His shirt was no longer perfect. It suited him better now. Evil shouldn't hide behind a perfect facade.

He kept staring at me in silence and it annoyed me.

I could see his jaw muscles moving. Then he turned around and walked to the table.

"Get dressed."

I turned my back to him and crouched down to pick my underwear up.

I got dressed hastily and turned back to him, meeting his gaze once more.

I still felt naked before him.

"How long do I have to take your orders for?"

He chuckled.

"You're asking the wrong questions, Zoe. It should be, *What else can I do for you?*"

How could I follow his orders, if the only things I felt for him were anger and repulsion?

I didn't say anything.

"Now, let's move on to the fun part."

He took the dagger and began turning it in his hand. He came closer and handed it to me carefully.

His black gaze stared deep into me.

"Prove your loyalty to me."

I frowned.

"Choose a non-vital part of your body and drive it deep into it. If the blade doesn't go in deep enough, you'll have to repeat it over and over until you do it the way I told you to."

My eyes fell on the dagger. I could take the dagger and slit his throat. Could I really do it? I didn't have a choice, I had to.

What if he ordered for my family to be killed if I were to stab him? The stakes were too high. I could not risk it.

"If you changed your mind, then..."

I quickly snatched the dagger.

I couldn't believe I was actually doing it. Couldn't believe I was capable of it.

Where should I aim it? An arm? A leg?

I raised my eyes to look at him.

Temptation was whispering in my ear. Maybe it was worth a try? He was standing just a few steps away from me. Close enough for a strike.

No.

This was an illusion. He's taller, bigger, and definitely stronger than me. He isn't stepping away for a reason. He's toying with me, testing me. He definitely had a plan in case I tried to stab him. It would be too easy, and he's not easy to deal with.

He's not just some psycho killing for fun. He's a cold-blooded strategist. Every step he takes was calculated. He's too smart. He's evil, he would suck everything he needs out of you. And once you become useless, he'd get rid of you without a second thought. He didn't live in the shadows, he was darkness himself.

I couldn't risk my parents. If I did as he said, I'd be able to help them even from here.

Maybe I'd even find a way to escape.

I looked down at the dagger and gripped the handle tight with my right hand. I took two deep breaths and slammed the dagger into my shoulder with one quick move.

I screamed loud enough for the echo to ring in my ears, stunning me. Too weak to stand, I bent over, dropping to my knees. The pain was so bad I thought I wouldn't make it. It was searing hot. My shoulder was getting numb.

I turned to look at my shoulder and saw the dagger stuck deep in my flesh.

I felt like someone threw water in my eyes and it was flowing down my face now.

I saw the reaper crouching down next to me. I crawled to him, clawing at his knees.

"Help me, please."

My voice was shaking from the pain and helplessness.

He smiled and ran his hand through my hair.

"Take it out, Zoe. I want to see you do it."

Sobs escaped my throat.

My hand was shaking, which only made it worse. I pulled the dagger out in one fell swoop. My hand slipped and the pain grew worse, like I got stabbed once again.

I screamed at the top of my lungs, falling on my left side and doubling over. I was writhing in pain on the floor, my mouth opening and closing like a fish out of water.

I caught my breath and pulled at the dagger again, jerking the blade out of my shoulder and letting it land on the marble floor with a clink. My whole body was in agony. I was wailing and moaning as my body trembled. Then all my feelings grew dull.

I could no longer feel anything, and the room went dark.

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CHAPTER 16

~~When the prey gets stuck to the web, the spider takes its time with it. He waits patiently until it's thoroughly trapped. The spider watches it struggle closely. A new day will come, and it will weave a new web, waiting for its next victim.~~

I opened my eyes to see maroon ceiling. I slowly moved my eyes until I realized it wasn't the ceiling I was looking at, but a velvet baldachin.

I leaned on my elbows, trying to figure out where I was. The pain in my shoulder wasn't as bad anymore.

I glanced down at it and saw the wound had been dressed.

I sat back, looking ahead. My throat felt raw. I didn't have a drop of water to drink for two days.

Memories of last night were firing away in my head like arrows raining down on my mind. My pulse sped up, even though I was in no danger at the time.

There was a small bottle of water on the nightstand. I reached for the bottle, gulping it down to the very last drop. Once I emptied it, I knew it was nowhere near enough.

Were they too stingy to leave some more damn water around here?

I left the empty bottle on the nightstand and looked around the room. It was large. Much larger than the room Bell and I shared. The roomy bed with champagne-colored sheets was adorned with a burgundy red baldachin. The edges of the baldachin were decorated with tiny hazelnut beige tassels. The baldachin was tied to the four vertical bed posts. There were small neat nightstands with reading lamps on either side of the bed.

There was also a large wardrobe, a vanity table with a mirror, a couple of couches and a coffee table. All of it reminded me of museum exhibits you'd visit to see how well-off folks of the past used to live ages ago.

The curtains matched the baldachin. They adorned the tall French windows. The daylight illuminated the whole room despite the gray clouds outside.

I walked to the window and looked outside. What I saw out there made me run downstairs right away. Adrenaline numbed the sharp pain in my shoulder.

I ran out of the room, darting down the cold stairs barefoot until I reached the main door.

The doors to the front yard were wide open. A man of around 35 I'd never met before stood by, smoking nonchalantly.

"What's that?"

He gave me a bored look and calmly blew the smoke out.

I ran up to the black bag and unzipped it.

Inside was Cass.

She was dead.

Anger, fear and sense of injustice melted together, clouding my judgement.

I darted to the other bags, but a strong hand wrapped around my wrist stopped me.

I had never seen the man before. He looked peeved.

"Levi, let her go,"

The man with a cigarette said carelessly, holding it between the teeth.

Without a word, Levi let me go and I unzipped each bag. There were four of them in total. Inside were the girls from the basement. Every one of them had been shot in the head.

I was on the verge of tears when anger overwhelmed me.

"Where is he?"

I turned to look at the man with a cigarette.

He carelessly ashed his cigarette without looking at me.

"Second floor, first door on the right."

I quickly headed to his office, skipping over every other step on the stairs. My left foot slipped and I fell on one knee, breaking the stitches.

I kicked the door hard enough to make it bounce from the wall and fly back at me. My hand caught it midway.

"What the fuck?"

I was nearly shouting.

He raised his head as he sat in a brown armchair at a large table. He frowned, his eyes glaring daggers at me.

“I asked you a question.”

I expected my voice to sound just as confident as it did when I asked the question, but it sounded hesitant.

He got up from the table and headed towards me.

My determination wavered with each step he took. His mere presence was terrifying. It evoked fear for my life, fear of the ominous uncertainty he brought about.

I wanted to run, but he caught up and grabbed me by the hair so hard my neck arched back, forcing me to meet his gaze.

“You are not to talk to me like that.”

His deep voice, ink-black eyes, darker than the plumes of midnight storm, and his cold expression made my stomach turn.

I tried to swallow my fear, but it didn’t work.

“The black bags. In the yard. Why?”

My voice sounded like it was about to break and fade away.

His gaze fell on my shoulder and he frowned slightly.

Gripping me harder for only a moment, he finally let me go.

“The stitches broke.”

He turned around and went back to the table.

“Why?”

“Sana’s coming today. She’s a doctor. She’ll come here every day to dress the wound until it’s healed. I know you haven’t eaten yet. Marta will bring your breakfast soon. She’s the housekeeper around here.”

“Where’s his body?”

He stopped.

“That guy.”

I could hear the tears coming in my voice.

Tears welled up in my eyes, but I wasn’t going to cry.

Not in front of him.

“I want to bury him. He...”

“All the bodies from the woods were collected and taken away yesterday.”

He pulled a white silk handkerchief from his jacket pocket.

“Where to?”

He turned around and began walking towards me.

I looked him in the eye, waiting for answers.

“It was you, wasn’t it?” I whispered.

A lonely tear rolled down my cheek.

He slowly slid the handkerchief up from the back of my hand, stopping at the wound and gently pressing down.

I looked down and saw blood running down my arm. The drops stained the cream carpet.

My shoulder stung. And the pain was growing.

“Does it hurt?”

“No.”

I flicked the tear away like a pesky fly.

I won’t give him the pleasure of watching me suffer. I wasn’t going to let him break me. I knew I would escape. I’d get rid of my invisible leash and then the whole world would know who he was.

I pushed his hand with the handkerchief soaked in my blood away.

Why was he doing this? Could he have let them leave? Could they have survived? Why did he have to kill them? And the bodies? Would their families even know they were dead?

“Will their families ever learn they’re dead?”

He went back to his armchair, rested his right hand on the desk, drumming his fingertips on the wooden surface.

“That is not something you should worry about. Think about your recovery. Because my business is stalling, and it makes me nervous. And when I get nervous, I get rid of useless people.”

His words sent shivers down my spine, like a gust of icy wind.

Looking down at his papers, he said indifferently,

“You can leave now.”

I slammed the door to my room and went to the bathroom.

Monsters don’t hide under the bed, they don’t live in dark woods, waiting for you. Real monsters have unlimited power, menacing amount of money on their banking accounts, formidable connections and a long list of missing people behind them. They don’t care for humanity, values or ideals. A human life is a problem they solve one bullet at a time. You have only two options: submit or die, because they are the ones picking the next song.

I took a white fluffy towel and pressed it against the wound.

I sat down on the toilet and wept.

What did I do? What did I do to deserve this? Why me? What did I do wrong? Was I such a bad person? Why did it have to be me?

A sudden knock on the door pulled me from this ritualistic torment.

I froze and didn't react at first. I heard more tapping and wiped the tears away quickly, heading to the door.

I opened it to see an older lady. Wrinkles covered her face like loving touches of years long passed. Her hair was as white as snowbanks in winter. Her gray eyes reminded me of the fall skies hiding the sun until spring comes.

"My name's Marta. I brought you breakfast."

I nodded and stepped aside. She placed the breakfast tray on the coffee table. Her eyes stopped at the bloody towel in my hand.

"You're bleeding, aren't you? Shall I call the master?"

"No... no. No need. Thanks."

My first "no" was too loud and crass.

I didn't need him or his help. He should go back to hell he'd crawled out of.

I could hear concern in her voice, but she simply nodded and left, closing the door behind her.

Marta was old enough to be my grandmother, but her lively movements made her seem younger.

I saw the food tray, knelt next to it and began stuffing my face with some scrambled eggs and bread, washing it all down with lukewarm tea.

The wound was aching, pain shooting down the arm. The bleeding showed no sign of stopping. It kept running down, tickling my wrist.

I heard the doors slam outside. I jumped to my feet, still holding a slice of bread in my hand and chewing the food.

There was a gray minivan and a dark-blue car parked next to the house. The car looked brand new, clean, shiny and expensive.

Someone opened the door for the reaper, but he stopped and turned around, looking right at my window. It's like he could feel me staring.

I wanted to step away from the window and hide. It wasn't a good idea to draw attention to myself, provoke or stand out. I was supposed to hide, act scared and nod my head like the dog he wanted me to be.

But my uncontrollable desire to rebel got the better of me. I bit from the bread slice defiantly, still staring him down. Levi stood next to him. He said

something, but the reaper wasn't even looking at him. He kept staring at me.

His sinister glare slowly bored into me like a knife, showing me visions of my own death.

Holding the bread in my mouth, I closed the curtains in one fell swoop.

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CHAPTER 17

~~I learned the art of lies when I was still a little girl. I could see no one wanted the truth. I knew I had to learn how to lie to succeed. And not just to lie, but to actually believe the things I said. After all, if I can convince myself, I'd easily convince everyone else.~~

“Take the pills if the pain comes back. No need to bear it.”

Sana drew the catheter out of my left arm. A small drop of blood beaded on my skin until a band-aid covered it.

Sana had short hair, but it didn't take away from her feminine look. Her haircut highlighted her gentle features, making her look younger.

I watched her gather her things calmly. I began to roll the ring with my left thumb mindlessly.

I was dragging my feet about it, but I had to try and find out, whose side she was on. Did she have a gun at her head like me?

“Have you been working here long?”

“No,” she replied without looking.

“Do you know, how I got this wound?”

She raised her tired eyes to look at me. They matched the color of her hair.

“You stabbed yourself with a knife,” she said flatly.

“He made me.”

She kept packing her stuff, like she never heard it.

“Can you help me?”

“I already have.”

“Can I use your phone?”

She stood up straight in her ivory coat, bag in hand.

“Have a nice day.”

She turned around and left the room.

I sighed dejectedly, sliding my head down on the pillow.

No surprise there. He clearly told her not to talk to me but that didn't mean she couldn't take my side. I just needed to find out what he's using against her. I could try to help her. We could team up and fight him together.

I would never make it out on my own. I needed allies. I needed someone to betray him. I did not believe everyone was here willingly.

I heard two knocks on the door.

"Come in."

Marta entered the room.

She walked to the table quietly to take the tray with the dirty dishes away.

In the morning, she brought me breakfast, and then Sana paid me a visit to put me on a drip. That was my new daily routine for the first week of living in a cage.

"Master wants you to know he will be home for lunch today."

Are we supposed to dine together? Why?

I'd rather not see him while I ate, at least. I was sure his aura would turn any food toxic.

I nodded silently. I still couldn't figure out how to talk to Marta. I felt really awkward being catered to like a princess. My sense of importance was mixed in with a nauseating feeling of being stripped of my personality around him. Because neither my wishes, nor my life were worth a damn to him.

"Take your clothes off. I'll wash them."

"When will you bring them back? I don't have any other clothes. I have nothing to wear."

"You will find all your clothes in the wardrobe."

"But I need these clothes specifically."

"Alright. I'll bring them back tonight."

"Thanks."

I got up and went to the bathroom to get undressed. I wrapped myself up in a fluffy white robe. I'd been sleeping in my own clothes all this time. I'd been ready to get up and leave at any moment.

But I couldn't escape.

Marta took my things and left, and I walked up to the cream-colored wardrobe. The wardrobe was full of dresses, blouses, skirts and shoes. Everything was new.

I wondered if there were any girls here before me. How many were there? Did anyone make it out?

As I looked through the clothes, I realized there were no pants, shorts or flat shoes. I pulled the bottom drawer out and saw sheer lacy lingerie. No casual underwear.

All the clothes were conventionally feminine. It made me mad, and I pushed the drawer back angrily, slamming it closed.

I walked up to the window and sat down, looking out at the gray fog over dense, dark woods.

I had to do something before the blood sea he inhabited drowned me.

Recovery gave me a head start, but for how much more?

I needed a phone. Everyone in this damn manor had one. I just needed to steal one. I could call dad and tell him everything. He'd take mom and skip town, moving as far away as possible.

I wasn't sure they could transport mom while she's in a coma, but they had to get out of that hospital. If they did it, if they moved to a safe place, I'd be free to run away.

I was going to get away from here, God damn it. I would escape and forget all about this god-forsaken place. About the reaper and his manor.

Did the police come to the university? Where was Bell? Was she alive? I needed the news. My room had no TV.

The scenery changed, but I was still locked up. I was cut off from the world.

Who was behind the university attack? The reaper? He killed one of them back in the grove, so did his bodyguard.

What about the girls? He took them from the university the night before the attack. Did this mean he wasn't working with them? I couldn't be one hundred percent sure. But what's the point in this? What's the point in killing everyone in sight without thinking? To what end?

Endless flow of questions with no answers weighed down on me, driving me mad.

I hopped up, heading to the wardrobe.

I was going to act like I accepted the rules of his game to play on my terms instead.

I put on a silk dress with long sleeves and golden buttons, as well as a pair of kitten heels.

Putting on makeup felt awkward, but my pale face looked utterly pitiful. I put some mascara on, added a bit of blush and headed to his office.

With every step, my bravado was slipping away like a naughty kitten trying to hide from the mess it made.

I knocked and pulled the handle, but he wasn't there. So I quietly closed the door from the inside.

I ran up to the desk and began pulling the drawers.

I sat into his large, cold armchair, and it sent a wave of fear through me. As if he was standing behind my back, watching me.

What was I doing? It was clear as day he wouldn't leave his phone in the open, knowing I was after it. And he definitely told everyone not to give me a phone. I was just wasting my time. I'm everyone's enemy now, and I had to become their friend.

My heels clicked on the steps monotonously when my gaze fell on a man with a cigarette sitting on the porch by the wide-open doors.

"Hello."

The man was scrolling on his phone, smoking lazily like he was doing it more out of boredom than anything else.

"What are you doing?"

Still no answer.

"He's not in his office. Where is he?"

"He left."

"Can I go outside?"

"No."

I went down a few steps and stood in front of him.

"Can you take me to the university?"

He smirked, putting his cigarette out on a moss-covered concrete step.

"Maybe I should just give you my car keys so you could make a run for it, and my phone to call the cops?" he replied, looking back at me.

That wouldn't have been half bad.

"What's your name?"

"Norman," he answered, still staring at his phone.

"I'm Zoe."

"I know."

His people reminded me of him.

Every door has a key, and every man can be won over.

"What else do you know about me?"

“Everything I need to know.”

“How long have you been smoking?”

“For a while.”

“I’m gonna stay here for a while, too, and I’d love for my life to get more comfortable. Do you get me? I want to make myself at home, to carry out my duties better. And to make myself comfortable, I’m gonna need my stuff. And it isn’t much. The dorm isn’t even far from here. About a five-minute drive, if that. I want to get my stuff back. My favorite skirt, blouse, things like that. It won’t be long. And there shouldn’t really be anyone at the university. The classes have obviously been cancelled, so I won’t get in anyone’s way. What do you say?”

“Do I look like an idiot to you?”

He placed the phone on his knees and gave me an annoyed look.

“No. Of course not. But maybe...”

“What?”

“Maybe this could stay between you and me? It won’t be any trouble, I’m not gonna run away. It’s not like I can, really. I’ve got stitches on my shoulder, and they hurt. I just want to get my stuff. That’s it.”

“No.”

“It’s not far.”

“No.”

I swallowed hard.

“I can do anything you want, and it’ll stay between us. What do you say?”

He lifted his gaze and let it dwell on me, lost in his own thoughts.

“You don’t have anything I want.”

A total failure.

There was no winning him over. He’s like a brick wall.

I needed more time to gain his trust, but I didn’t have any.

I got another idea, just as desperate as my attempts to escape.

“Call your boss.”

My voice sounded like an order. It was so cold I got a nasty feeling of doing something inherently wrong deep down.

When in Rome do as the Romans do.

I saw his body tense up. He wasn’t sprawled about anymore. He sat up straight. His whole body got tight like a string.

He tapped the screen twice and gave me the phone.

My heart was racing like crazy. I could feel the fear rising from the deepest pit of my stomach. My thoughts screamed for me not to do it. That it was a terrible idea and I needed to drop it before it's too late.

But I wasn't going to back down. I could only hope he wasn't a vengeful type, since our last conversation didn't go too well.

He picked up the phone after two dial tones.

"Speak," he said in a low voice.

I didn't know, if I should say hi or just get to the point. I was trying to get over my terrible awkwardness and anxiety.

"This is Zoe."

I thought he hung up and had to look at the phone screen to see he was still listening.

"I know I was rude to you last week. I'm sorry."

I was so nervous, all my thoughts got jumbled up and I didn't even know where to begin asking him about it anymore. What leading questions should I ask him? What was it that I even wanted to ask?

"I'm sorry I yelled at you in your office."

I wasn't sorry.

"And for almost knocking down my office door?"

"That, too."

"And for raising your voice at me?"

He really was vengeful.

"I'm sorry for that, too."

"Now tell me what you're grateful to me for."

"Grateful?"

I could barely hold my sarcasm.

"Have you thanked me for calling Sana when you deliberately tore the stitches? I could've let you bleed to death, but I hadn't. Or for Marta feeding you instead of letting you starve? For the clothes in your wardrobe? For your room? Don't you want to thank me for that?"

I was gripping the phone, ready to chuck it deep into the woods, yelling out every swear word I knew.

"I'm thankful to you for everything," I replied through gritted teeth.

"When you say everything, you mean nothing. Be specific," he ordered coldly.

I closed my eyes and took a deep breath.

“I’m thankful to you for calling Sana in to fix my stitches. I’m grateful for Marta, who feeds me great food. Thank you for the things in my wardrobe. Thank you for the private room I got.”

“You’re most welcome, Zoe. I’m glad you appreciate my generosity.”

It took everything I had in me to keep my smart mouth shut.

“Now, get to the point.”

I felt like someone shook me and dropped me back down.

I opened my mouth but couldn’t remember what I wanted to ask about.

“Zoe, if that’s all you wanted to say, I’m hanging up.”

“No.”

I sighed.

“Sana’s put me on a drip. And she told me I should spend more time outside. This will help lessen stress and ramp up my recovery. Can I go for walks around the manor?”

Before he had a chance to reply, I quickly added,

“Norman will be with me. He’ll accompany me on my walks.”

Norman glared at me, not even trying to hide his frustration at the fact he’s going to be the one baby-sitting me.

He didn’t reply right away.

“Alright.”

“Norman is a reliable man, right?”

“Most reliable.”

A long pause followed.

“Hurry up, Zoe.”

“The university’s closed today. There’ll be no one around. I’m sure the survivors went back home. And…”

I spoke so fast I was out of breath.

“Maybe you could let Norman and I go back to the dorms to pick up a few of my books and stuff?”

Norman clicked his tongue, looking annoyed.

There was a pause.

A long one.

I didn’t notice I’d been holding my breath waiting for his response.

“Pass the phone to Norman.”

My heart dropped.

I screwed up.

I slowly handed the phone back to Norman. He nodded his head to everything the reaper told him, then hung up the phone.

I rolled the ring anxiously.

What did he say? Well?

Norman lifted his head to look at me, narrowing his eyes.

“The fox has won.”

I bit down on my lower lip to hide a smile.

A small victory is still a triumph.

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CHAPTER 18

~~No one knew me better than I knew myself. I knew what I liked to eat, wear or entertain myself with. I knew pretty much everything there's to know about me, but I could never fathom, why one part of me always wanted to go against me.~~

Drizzling rain covered the windshield like milky haze.

I reached for the radio to listen to the news and see, if there was anything about the attack.

“What are you doing?”

“Turning the music on.”

“You’re pressing the wrong buttons.”

“Then press the right ones.”

Norman let out a pained sigh and pressed a button. Music was playing.

I let the song play for a few seconds and began switching the stations.

“Quit surfing the stations. The noise gives me a headache.”

I stopped when I heard the news.

Norman gave me a sulky look.

“I changed my mind about the music.”

“Yeah.”

I never liked the news, but that day I needed it like wet soil needs the sun after long months of rain. I was hoping to hear that everyone already knew about the university. That people were screaming about it from the rooftops. I needed the names of the dead and the missing. I wanted to hear something.

I kept listening. Waiting. There was nothing about the attack or our town on the radio. Nothing.

It’s like we never existed.

An upbeat song followed the news. It didn’t resonate with my feelings of disappointment and devastation.

What if they were still there? What if they were still holding everyone hostage? What if they're torturing people? What if there's an ambush back there?

"Do you have a gun?"

Norman frowned.

"Yeah, but you're not getting it."

"And I'm not asking you for it," I replied, parroting his tone.

We got pretty far away from the manor. I could run and ask for help. There might be people at the university. They could call for help or help me themselves. There were security cams, too. Someone would check the footage and see I was still alive. Then they could start searching.

Wouldn't it be better for the reaper, if everyone thought I was dead? For no one to know I was still out there?

Kidnappers never let their victims go. They keep them on a short leash or in a cage, like animals.

Why wasn't he worried about me trying to call the police on him? Why was he so sure about me? Why was he giving me freedom he'd robbed me of not too long ago?

We turned onto the road to the university. My heartbeat rose as the car rolled on. I was watching the outskirts closely. I was expecting them. Waiting for them to jump out to ambush us.

Norman turned to the parking lot.

Why did I come here?

The parking lot was just as desolate as the rest of the campus. On our way there I realized we didn't see a single car or any people around whatsoever.

Ilion was dead.

I didn't want to leave the car. I wanted to tell Norman I changed my mind. That I wanted him to take me back.

I quickly got out of the car, unwilling to keep kicking these thoughts around in my head.

The silence on our way to the dorms was nothing short of deafening. There was no wind, no rain, no people.

I expected to see reporters, forensic specialists, the police, survivors, casualties, anyone, really. But all I saw was blood on the lawn, the only trace of their crimes.

Memories dazed me in a flurry of blinding flashes as I pulled the door to enter my dorms once again.

Fear. The screams. The murders. The blood. So much blood.

My hand was shaking and I couldn't pull the door.

Norman moved my hand out of the way and opened the door.

"Where to?"

"Second floor. Right down the hall. Room 16."

Heart was pounding in my chest, ready to burst in sheer terror. Thoughts of stumbling upon her dead body drove knives into my heart.

What if she died?

Norman opened the door, and I let out a relieved sigh.

She wasn't there.

"Make it quick."

I took my suitcase and a backpack from the cabinet.

Norman hovered over me like a jail warden, watching closely as I gathered my things.

"Curious about my underwear?"

"Couldn't care less about it. But I can't say the same about your phone and laptop."

No surprise there.

"As you can see, the laptop's on the desk."

I pointed my hand at it.

I wasn't looking at the things I was taking. I ripped everything I saw off the hangers, throwing it in the suitcase.

I remembered my phone was on my nightstand, under a textbook on existentialism.

Once I was done packing the suitcase, I tried closing it, but it wouldn't budge.

I was huffing and puffing, acting like I was struggling. I was trying to make it look like the suitcase wouldn't close under my weight.

"It won't close."

I gave him the puppy-dog eyes.

"Step aside."

Once Norman's full attention was on the suitcase, I turned my back to the nightstand and swept everything on it into my backpack.

"Why do you need so many clothes? He got you a full wardrobe of stuff."

“I don’t want his things. Besides, someone’s already worn them already.”

“No one’s worn them before.”

“Haven’t other girls worn the clothes?”

“Other girls?”

He looked at me like I was speaking gibberish.

He zipped up the suitcase and lifted it.

“There were no others.”

I frowned.

Why? Why me then?

I sat on the bed, holding the backpack on my knees. I reached for the maxi pads on the bottom shelf.

My left hand gripped the phone in the backpack while the right one was packing the pads. I made it look like I was struggling to push the pads deeper into the backpack as I was hiding my phone.

I zipped the backpack up, left it on the floor and headed to the desk.

I quickly scribbled a note for Bell, “I’m alive.”

“What’s that?”

“Nothing.”

“Nothing?”

“I didn’t see anything. And neither did you.”

“I’m not risking my neck for *nothing*.”

He was about to come to the desk, but I got in his way.

“Two words can’t harm anybody.”

He narrowed his eyes.

“Please. Let’s go,” I said under my breath.

He stalled, then swore and turned to leave.

I smiled at his back.

Norman took the suitcase and, of course, the backpack.

We got to the hall and I said nervously:

“Oh, shit.”

“What now?” he whined.

“I think, I’m...”

“What?”

He looked annoyed.

“I’m leaking. Crap. I need to go to the bathroom before I get blood on the dress.”

I headed to the bathroom hastily before turning around and walking back to him.

“I need pads, and I really need to change my panties, or I’ll...”

“Holy shit, I didn’t ask you to tell me about it. Just take the backpack and go already.”

I took my heavy backpack and ran to the bathroom.

I walked in and locked myself in one of the stalls.

I tried turning the phone on, but saw a red battery flash on the screen.

I couldn’t go back for the charger. I’d have to look for one at the manor.

Where should I put the phone? This damned dress had no pockets. I couldn’t put it in my bra, it would show. There wasn’t enough room in my shoes. I was wearing heels. I should have planned it better. I shouldn’t have given them my sneakers. There was only one option left.

I left the toilet stall and froze.

“Revenge” was written on the mirror in large letters in now-dried blood.

I felt a lump in my throat.

I ran out of the bathroom, nearly knocking Norman down.

“Fucking ’ell. What is it?”

I gave him the backpack and quickly walked towards the exit.

I needed air. It felt like I was inhaling blood. The whole place was soaked in it.

We got to the car without a word. I felt relief once I got back in the car. I shouldn’t feel that way, I was still in danger. But I allowed myself to wallow in it, at least until we reach the manor again.

That’s when the realization hit me like a brick.

He wanted me to feel I had no freedom. Wanted me to have an illusion of freedom. I took a deep breath and realized I no longer had any. All I had now were vivid memories and a fresh taste of it in my body. And my life was never going to be the same. He held it in his hands now. As well as the lives of my family. He’s a puppeteer, and I was a puppet.

CHAPTER 19

~~If I believe I'm strong, then it's true. If I believe I can do it, nothing can stop me. If I believe I'm going to die, I will walk myself to my deathbed.~~

I tried looking for the news, but there was only music. Norman began nagging like an old man and I stopped tinkering with the radio.

We were close to the manor now. It looked massive, clearly Victorian with gothic details. Time wasn't too kind to it. It gave the building both a grim and solemn look. Towers with tall spires, arched windows and gray-beige stone that clearly got tarnished over the years and looked almost black now intensified the overall impression.

Stained statues with washed out faces and cracked bodies, moss-covered attic and walk-out balconies with banisters only sharpened the impression. The entire facade of the house was aged and reminded me of an old man.

The front part of the house had three floors, while the back half had four, maybe even five. The house was drowning in weeds and overgrowth, making it look abandoned.

I got out of the car and watched Norman take my things out.

We headed to the house and he smirked, his smile reaching only the left corner of his lips.

"Five minutes, huh?"

"Math was never my strong side. I'm a philosopher."

Smiling back to Norman, I turned my head and saw him.

My body froze and tensed up, feeling the danger radiating from him. His eerie look seemed to suck out my smile and any joy I felt, filling me with fear and tension instead.

The reaper's hands were in his pockets. At that moment his face showed clear signs of irritation, growing malice and glimpses of disgust.

"You're late."

I opened my mouth to reply, but he beat me to it.

“Dinner’s ready.”

He turned around and headed to the dining hall, his shoes clicking on the marble floor.

I followed him meekly, trying to hide how nervous I was.

The dining hall was large. One could easily throw a party for two hundred guests in a hall like this.

My gaze fell on a small table covered with a tablecloth in the middle of the room. It was more suited for one, rather than two people. There were napkins and silverware on it.

The room was dead silent. The clicking of our shoes were the only sounds breaking it.

He pulled my chair back to help me take a seat. Then took a seat across from me.

I crossed my right leg over the left and began to swing it.

We were sitting too close to each other. Close enough for me to see his face clearly and feel his heavy scent.

He stared at me without a word.

I looked away, taking in my surroundings. I was so nervous, I couldn’t concentrate on the interior.

Should we be talking? Was I supposed to say something? Or could we just dine together in silence and leave?

I turned back towards him. His eyes were no longer burning holes through me. He slowly looked me over. His gaze stopped at my neck, right where the wound on my shoulder was. Then his raven black eyes met mine.

His gaze and appearance both frightened and tantalized me. I wanted to look back at him just as boldly and daringly. I wanted to let my gaze slide all over him just as blatantly, studying his appearance. Sure, he scared me, but I was also terribly curious about the details of his character. Obsidian eyes, coal black eyebrows, raven black hair, the harmony of black shades drew my attention, letting me know I’d never met a man like him before.

I couldn’t bear looking him in the eye because of how intense his gaze was. His eyes could see into me deeper than I dared to look myself. The void of his gaze could drag my soul out and tear it to shreds.

I felt the tension and pressing silence in the air. They made my anxiety worse.

Suddenly, the door opened and my knee kicked the table.

The silverware clinked, making him frown.

I wanted nothing more than for this dinner to end.

Marta slowly rolled in our meal plates and a bottle of semi-sweet wine on a squeaky trolley.

She placed them on the table silently. She opened the bottle and poured the wine.

The soft sound of wine filling the glasses broke the silence.

I gave her a small smile.

“Thanks.”

She nodded and left.

The reaper was watching me closely, like I was some kind of a zoo animal.

Scraping the knife on the plate, I cut a piece of meat and shoved it in my mouth.

I had no appetite.

I was full on my anxiety.

“Did you get everything you wanted?”

I struggled to swallow the meat I’d nearly choked on when he spoke.

“Yes.”

I avoided his gaze.

Picking up my glass of wine, I took a big gulp.

“Is there anything you’d like to tell me?”

My heart was thumping violently, hurting me.

What did I have to tell him? That I was rummaging through his desk today? That I took all my old stuff because I refuse to wear the clothes he bought me? That we spent more time in the dorms than we should have? That I left a note for Bell? Or that my phone was in my underwear right now?

I stared at the meat on my fork.

“I don’t have anything to say,” I uttered under my breath.

I raised the fork and pushed another piece in my mouth.

I didn’t want to talk. I wanted to eat and go back to my room. I had to hide the phone and find a charger.

The food was delicious, but I was too nervous to enjoy and savor the vivid taste of the warm meal.

He ate like we were dining with the Queen. Slowly cutting each piece and bringing it to his mouth with utmost care. I could see his teeth press on

the fork, his lips sliding on the metal. He picked his glass up gracefully and took a sip of the red liquid.

My right leg went numb. I moved it down and accidentally brushed against his ankle.

He looked up at me. For a few seconds it seemed like his eyes got darker than usual.

I took the glass and turned my head to the door.

When would Marta return? This was my last sip, and I needed more.

I emptied my glass, placed it back on the table and remembered there actually was something I wanted to ask him.

“I’m your first.”

He laughed and I could see his genuine smile for the first time. It wasn’t just beautiful, it was intoxicating, thrilling. It made me want to forget who he was and what he’d done. I bet this smile helped him win over some important people and got most girls to give him whatever he wanted.

It softened his grim features and made him look a lot more humane. He looked so fine, I wanted to touch his beauty like a rare painting hanging on a wall. And his deep laugh was so charming, it made me crave hearing him speak.

I felt gross. The man before me was a murderer, and this was what I was thinking of?

I swallowed to fix the dryness in my throat and said,

“There were no girls here before me. I’m the first.”

His face returned to its usual expression, and I thought I imagined everything I heard and saw only a moment ago.

“You are the first.”

“There has to be a reason. Why was I...”

“There’s no reason.”

That’s right. Anyone could’ve taken my place.

The girls in the basement were captured before me. So, this wasn’t about me at all. The truth was, one crazy morning he woke up and decided he could do this.

“Why a woman? Why not a man?”

I watched his long fingers run up and down the stem of his glass.

“Which do you think is best, to die or go missing?”

Marta entered the room at that moment. The wheels on her trolley weren’t running smoothly, making obnoxious squeaking noise as it rolled

instead.

She took the plates, poured us some more wine and left the bottle.

How I longed to snatch it and drink it down to the last drop, pass out and wake up back in the dorms, thinking all this was just a bad dream.

Marta left, closing the door behind her.

“Neither,” I half-whispered.

“Neither?” he asked loudly,

“Zoe, your naivete is astounding. Unfortunately, the world will make you choose. And if you don’t make one, the choice will be made for you.”

“You didn’t answer my question.”

“And you didn’t answer mine.”

“I don’t want to play your games.”

He grinned, baring his straight white teeth.

“Dear Zoe, you already are.”

I grabbed the bottle, so did he. I tried pulling it towards me, but his grip was vice-like.

“You already know the answer. You made the choice for me.”

I pulled the bottle.

“I’m gonna have to work on the stubbornness.”

“You do that.”

I could see a shadow of irritation on his face, and yet his eyes twinkled with amusement.

Was he driving me crazy on purpose?

“Are you gonna let me have a drink?”

“Are you gonna drink from the bottle?”

“No.”

“Then let it go and let me pour you more wine.”

“I can pour myself wine just fine.”

“You’re in my home. Sitting on my chair. At my table. You’re eating my food and drinking my wine. You’re wearing the clothes I bought you. I saved your life. And now your life belongs to me. Your existence depends on me. On my mood. So, maybe you shouldn’t make me angry?”

I was seething, my anger ready to burst.

His eyes mirrored mine. They were brimming with anger.

I let go of the bottle and rested my hands on my knees, gripping a napkin.

A smug smile tugged at his lips.

He was pleased to see I caved in.

He poured me more wine and was about to clink glasses, but I drank mine in one swig.

“Saved me, you say? You’re my savior now? This doesn’t look like my house, and you don’t exactly remind me of my family.”

“This is your home now, and I am the only one you’re gonna run to whenever you need a shoulder to cry on.”

“I’d rather drown myself in my own tears than cry on your shoulder,” I spat.

He kept smiling.

He was no longer hiding how much he enjoyed this.

“Zoe, are you sad you didn’t get to die back at the university now? Or that you escaped from the line of your classmates as they got slaughtered? Or that you couldn’t save that poor girl that got her head chopped off? Or maybe that, because of you, your mother is now in a coma?”

My eyes went wide, I grabbed his glass and threw the wine in his face.

I grabbed a knife and was about to stab it deep into his rotten heart. He got behind me in a blink of an eye. He grabbed me by the hair, knocked my chair out of the way and pushed my face into the table, making me gasp.

The plates clanked. Some of them got knocked on the floor, shattering into pieces.

He twisted my arms behind my back so hard I thought they’d break. I let go of the knife right then.

The side of my face and my chest were pressed into the table, while my butt was pushed up, bumping into his groin. He had my hair in an iron grip with one hand, the other holding my arms behind my back.

I could feel the spilled wine soaking my silk dress. My anger was now mixed in with fear.

“I have been kind enough, haven’t I? I let you pick up your things. Allowed you to have another taste of the freedom you were used to. I even let you leave that silly little note in vain hopes of getting rescued. If this is how you thank me for it, I’m gonna have to teach you the right way to do it.”

Fear ran through my body like a lightning bolt. My throat felt dry.

Fucking Norman.

“Go to hell.”

I tried to wiggle my way out, but his grip was firm. He gripped my hair tighter and I screamed.

His warm body covered mine, his lips coming too close to my ear as his breath blew hot air at it.

“Did your fear disappear so fast because you forgot I could hold you like this every day? You’re gonna stay like this day in, day out until I feel like taking your life. It could be today or in a week. I will do everything possible to make you beg me to do it sooner.”

The venom in his voice chilled me to the bone.

I wasn’t struggling anymore. I was afraid.

“I’m gonna have to teach you quite a few things. You still live in hope. In hope of escaping, of meeting your family, friends, going back to your studies, and you never will. It’s time you faced the reality. One important thing I’m gonna teach you is to answer my fucking questions. I’m going to ask you a question one last time. Do you want to be missing or dead?”

“Missing.”

“Do you like knowing I could do anything I want to you? That your entire worthless life belongs to me from now on? That no one’s coming to save you? And that, once I’m fed up with you, I’ll get rid of you with one lazy wave of my hand? And once I get rid of you, your body will never be found. That I could wipe you out of existence?”

Fear overcame me. My whole body was trembling. I could barely breathe.

“No.”

My voice was shaking.

All my hatred melted away like fog.

“You don’t get to have a choice anymore. My desires are your choices. My future is your choice. The choice is your faith. And I am your religion.”

A strand of hair fell on my face, covering my eyes. He let go of my hair and gently tucked the loose strand behind my ear.

I could feel my back break into a cold sweat.

“I’m sorry.”

My voice was shaking and the apology sounded garbled.

“Louder.”

“I’m sorry.”

I yelled out for the whole room to hear.

“I like it when you behave, Zoe.”

He stroked my hair and let go of my hands.
I didn't get up right away. Fear paralyzed me.
I slowly got to my feet, staggering to stand in heels.
I looked down and was about to walk out when he grabbed my wrist
roughly.
Our eyes met.
“Where do you think you're going? We aren't done yet.”

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CHAPTER 20

~~I often ask myself, "What if...?" What if things had turned out differently? Would I've been the same person? Would I have knowingly chosen this path? Or was it all meant to be regardless of the choices I made? What if?~~

I felt blood drain from my face as fear gripped my body.

"Clean up after yourself," he barked rudely.

I turned back to the table meekly and wanted to crouch down, but my dress wouldn't let me.

I hiked it up, getting down on my knees.

My hands were shaking as I collected the shards into a napkin, putting the broken plate together like a puzzle.

He stood there, arms crossed. The bottomless void of his pitch black eyes looked down on me like I was not only unworthy of being here, but had no right to exist at all.

He liked the power. He loved inflicting pain and destruction.

Once I was done, I felt my feet go numb. I swayed as I got back up and he quickly caught me by the arm.

I jerked my arm away like it was on fire.

"I'm done."

"No."

My heart began thumping harder again.

Did I miss something?

"Take a napkin and wipe me down."

His face remained expressionless. It looked colder than a slab of ice. But I could feel him crushing me, trampling me underfoot and enjoying the view.

His lips parted to say something and I quickly reached for a tissue napkin. The napkin was filthy and I didn't know how to wipe him down.

I pulled the sleeve over my hand and wiped him off with careful motions of my shaky hands, moving from the neck to his chin.

I felt like a gazelle standing before a lion. One wrong move and I was dead.

Once my sleeve got dirty, I turned the fabric over and began wiping his face.

He was much taller than me. Even in heels I stood at his neck height as his heavy scent suffocated me.

I would not lift my eyes to look at him. I was scared.

“Enough,” he said coldly.

The sleeve slipped out of my grasp and my fingers touched the warm skin of his face.

The corner of his lips twitched imperceptibly and I pulled my hand away.

“Can I leave?”

“Yes.”

Holding back a sigh of relief, I quickly headed to the door.

I met Norman as soon as I left the room.

“Dinner was a blast, wasn’t it?” he asked, smirking.

I glared daggers at him and his smirk slowly faded.

I hastily passed two large rooms until I reached the hall. I took the shoes off and ran to my room.

My dress, makeup, lingerie, my hair, all of it felt weird, like it was sucking the life out of me. I wanted to get rid of it all.

I burst into my room and unbuttoned the dress feverishly. Stopping midway, I pulled it over my head.

I turned the warm shower on and got in.

Memories of the last week tormented me. They were so oppressively persistent I could barely get through the brain fog they brought me. I felt the growing dread slowly taking over my body.

I couldn’t stop shivering, so I turned the cold water on.

I closed my eyes and took deep breaths.

I could hear Justin’s voice, felt his touch, inhaled his scent.

Icy water washed away my warm tears.

Once I noticed I was no longer trembling with fear, I turned the warm water back on.

It warmed me up, comforting and making my body relax. I could feel my thoughts melt, my emotions calming down.

The bathroom made me feel safe. I wished I could hide there forever.
Wished he could never find me. Wished no one could.

I wiped the vapor off the mirror.

I looked myself in the eyes.

I promised myself I'd make it out and run away. I would escape. I would never let them devour me. I would not let the evil win.

I must keep fighting. No matter what. I would not give up. I would fight.

I wrapped my phone in toilet paper and hid it on the bottom shelf behind the toilet paper.

I had to get my hands on a charger. The phone was my only way out now.

Lost in thought, I sat down on a small plush rug and leaned against the sink cabinet. Before I knew it, sleep took me over.

I was startled awake by the sound of the door handle rattling violently.

I tried to jump to my feet, but the sharp pain in my shoulder nearly knocked me back down. Slipping on the carpet, I grabbed the sink at the last second to steady myself.

"Why the fuck is the bathroom locked?"

I unlocked the door right away and threw it open.

Norman was standing there, scowling.

"What?"

"Why was the door locked?"

"I locked the bathroom because I was using it. Look at me, I'm wearing a bathrobe."

He swore under his breath.

"Boss says you need to be ready by six."

"What's at six?"

"He'll tell you himself."

"What time is it?"

"Time to get ready."

Norman left and I felt the consequences of napping on the floor.

My neck and left side were killing me. The rest of my body didn't feel much better.

There was a knock on the door before Sana entered the room.

She greeted me and got to work straight away.

I bared my shoulder and saw her shake her head disapprovingly.

"A couple stitches came apart. I'm gonna have to put them back."

Emotions overwhelmed me yesterday and I didn't see that happen.

Sana gave me a shot and took out a needle.

I felt nothing as it pierced my skin.

I thought about how great it'd be to have some sort of a shot for emotions. An injection to make you forget about pain, fear or any other emotions you don't want. Life would've been so much easier.

Granted, I wouldn't have been able to feel joy, but what would I need it for, if all I could feel was pain? Why would I need it if the pain leaves a wound so deep you feel like this time you're not gonna make it?

And the happiness? What does happiness leave behind? Just a sweet aftertaste. You can't capture it and stuff it in a box. You can't feel it all the time. Now you have it, the next moment you don't.

It's a mirage. Sometimes you miss it so bad you begin to desperately seek it out yourself. And you'd do anything to feel its fleeting relief. So let it burn with the pain.

"Do you have kids?"

"Yes."

"How old are they?"

"He's 22."

"So am I."

Without a word, she cut the thread and placed a band-aid over the wound.

"I lost my phone charger. Do you have one on you?"

"No."

She pierced my vein and inserted the needle.

"Try not to break any more stitches. Reapplying stitches would leave a rough scar."

"Okay," I whispered, looking at my ring.

The silence made me ask her outright.

"Do you work for him because you want to, or because he's forcing you to?"

Sana lifted her head to look at me.

"Because I want to."

Somehow, I wasn't surprised.

We didn't talk after that. Once the drip was done with, she quickly finished her work and disappeared.

Norman never brought my things back. The reaper obviously told him to throw them away.

I sat at the vanity table, looking at the pile of makeup before me, not knowing what to use.

Makeup had always been an outlet for me. It was my meditation, something that always put a smile on my face. I could use it to express myself, show the world who I thought I was. But what was I like now?

I slowly brushed my hair, twisted and pinned it up with a claw clip.

I didn't want to use the eyeshadow shades I was used to, much less my favorite ones. I wanted to keep the things I liked to myself only. I wanted to hide them, keep them a secret, something that evoked good memories and reminded me of who I used to be.

I finished my evening makeup that night and felt absolutely nothing for the first time.

My hair was fluffy and curled up and the ends. I never liked straightening them. But today I knew I wanted to hide. I did not want to show the real me.

I rummaged through the entire underwear drawer but found no comfortable lingerie. So I chose something white.

I walked up to the mirror and didn't recognize myself.

I looked like an older version of myself, like I was 28, and not 22.

Would I live to see my 28th birthday?

Suddenly, the feeling of anger swept over me like an icy rain.

Blamed the gorillas attacking the university. Blamed Lea for not letting us take the fire-escape. Blamed people at the library for not fighting back. Blamed the reaper for what he did to my mom. Blamed mom for not staying home that day. Blamed dad for letting her leave. Blamed parents for not letting me drop out of the university. Blamed Bell for not taking my side. Blamed Justin for making me forget about wanting to drop out. Blamed him for leaving and never coming back. Blamed myself for not being brave enough to do it. Blamed myself for not running away from the reaper when I still could.

The door opened, distracting me from the flow of my grim thoughts.

CHAPTER 21

~~Our surroundings define us. We make this choice subconsciously and don't always know why we choose these people. But once our actions become conscious and deliberate, stepping away from our usual patterns gets tricky. A cell torn out from a body won't survive on its own.~~

I froze, looking into his eyes in the mirror. His dark gaze slid from my eyes to my cheeks, lips and hair. I felt unnatural and awkward.

I got used to disgust, anger and indifference, but I wasn't prepared to see curiosity in his eyes. Hadn't I known his opinion of me, I'd have thought he actually liked me.

My pulse sped up as his gaze slowly slid down my body like a cold snake.

I wanted to turn away and cover myself, but it was too late.

I hated the way his presence made my body stiffen up. I knew he could see me freeze every time I saw him. He liked it, I just knew it.

He was dressed in a black tuxedo with a black rosebuds pattern. His hair was neatly styled back in rich waves. His scent filled the room. The scent of amber, musk and spices.

"There's a white dress in the black garment bag."

Our eyes met again.

I turned around and walked up to the wardrobe.

I could feel his eyes on me. It made my movements look strained.

I put on the dress and was about to zip it up when I heard his footsteps. He gently brushed my hair to the side. He zipped it up in one steady move.

I bent over and picked a pair of blood red pumps from the bottom shelf of the wardrobe. I expected him to object, but he said nothing.

I sat down on the bed and put the shoes on the carpet.

He came up to me and got on one knee. His scent embraced and marked me.

He rested his warm hand on my ankle, sending a wave of goosebumps through my body. With a gentle motion of his right hand he slid the right shoe on, then did the same with the left one.

He took my hand, helping me up.

I walked to the mirror and saw a statue of a Greek goddess come to life. The delicate details on the sleeves and folds of fabric along the dress added lightness to my look. Part of the fabric was wrapped around my waist, showing off my figure. The dress was floor length, adding sophistication to the overall image.

It covered the shoes. That brought me down a bit.

“You’re perfect.”

I looked up at him.

His compliment caught me by surprise. But I was even more baffled that, despite seeing me naked before, he only saw a woman in me now, as I stood before him in this dress.

“Thank you,”

I whispered, looking down at my heels, trying to hide my awkwardness.

“Look at me.”

The icy note in his voice was back.

I lifted my gaze and our eyes met again.

“At the reception, I want you not to talk to anybody. Stay by my side or anywhere I can see you. Everyone has to think we’re a couple. Got it?”

“Yes.”

He frowned slightly when his eyes fell on my hair.

“Do you always straighten your hair?”

“Sometimes.”

He caught a lock of my hair between his fingers.

“Could you...”

His dark eyes left my hair and found my eyes.

The strand slipped through his fingers like a feather and fell on my back.

“Sana scolded me today for breaking a few stitches again. If you’re gonna hit me, can you hit somewhere below the stitches to let them heal?”

He frowned.

He looked confused and slightly disgusted.

“What makes you think I was going to hit you?”

He didn’t hit me yesterday, he just took the knife. But it all seemed like a matter of time to me.

“I’m not gonna hit you, Zoe. I don’t hit girls. Definitely not the way you expect, at least.”

I opened my mouth to ask what he meant. The realization stunned me like a bright flash of a light bulb in a dark closet.

“Let’s go.”

He took my hand and led me downstairs.

No one spoke a word for the first hour on the road.

It was the middle of the night. I tried to make out anything outside, but it was too dark.

I turned to look at him. He was looking out the window. His elbow rested on the door panel. His knuckles were pressed to his lips.

His cheekbones boasted clean-cut, even lines, as did his nose. Black hair matched his slightly tanned complexion perfectly. His soft berry lips looked well-defined.

“Do you want to ask me something?” he asked, not turning his head.

“No.”

I turned to the window.

My right hand was playing with the ring.

“Yes.”

He turned his head to look at me, ready to give me his full attention.

Our eyes met and my breath quickened as I took in the air laden with the rich scent of leather seats.

I had many questions. All of them floundered in the sea of my thoughts, drowning in his stormy, turbulent obsidian eyes.

I knew he wouldn’t want to answer all of them. I was willing to try and be left in the dark.

I looked down at my hands and asked,

“How do you earn your living?”

“Drugs.”

It came out so casually, as if he said something like, “I sell cars.”

“Do you like it?”

“It has its ups and downs. Just like any other job.”

“This isn’t ‘any other job’. You’re ruining people’s lives,” I said under my breath.

“I’m not responsible for people’s lives. Just like I don’t make a choice for them.”

“Addicts don’t have a choice. Their choice is made by drugs and people like you.”

My courage was coming back, dragging my anger with it.

His smile grew wider, baring his teeth and leaving dimples in his cheeks.

He was laughing.

What was so funny?

He got quiet abruptly. His black eyes, darker than a moonless night, stared into mine. His right eyebrow was raised.

“Are you judging me?”

“Yes. With the money you have, you could’ve done something meaningful for the world without actually harming anyone.”

“Like what?”

“Like building a car factory. Hire people. Give them jobs. Do something worthwhile, something useful. You could’ve changed the world. Or at least tried to make it better.”

“Factories emit huge amounts of harmful gases into the atmosphere, destroying and polluting the planet. They increase the incidence of many diseases in people, including the terminal ones. Cars also cause a ton of harm to the environment and people.”

“Then open a private clinic. Hire skilled professionals. Let them save lives while you manage the business, look for investors, take part...”

“I don’t care about that,” he cut me off, “I’m no Messiah and don’t wanna be one.”

“You’re not even close to being one. Messiah doesn’t destroy anything, he creates things.”

I bit down on my lower lip, trying to hold back my anger and reminding myself he was the one in control here.

He saw it and I noticed one corner of his lips perk up.

“What if I don’t want to?”

“What?”

“What if I don’t want to change the world and serve people? What if I want to live this life my way?”

“Then live without hurting others. Villains are miserable because everything they do reaps nothing but evil and devastation. They’d never be surrounded by good people. They’re lonely. So stay alone and live with your demons, away from people.”

He chuckled.

“I used to read different fairy-tales as a kid. The ones where the princess went to the bad guy herself, because her world wasn’t black and white, and there was no justice in it. That’s why the bad guy comes and takes what he wants.”

“This princess is just as evil as he is.”

“Maybe.”

His slender fingers rubbed his chin.

“What would you do if you woke up just like me tomorrow?”

“I’d kill myself.”

I didn’t hesitate to answer.

I had no problem telling the good from the evil.

I’m good.

He’s bad.

He smiled. The lights of a passing car made his smile look even more insidious.

“What makes me a bad guy, Zoe?”

“You’re well aware. Your actions, of course.”

“If I were to wake up tomorrow and decide to stop dealing drugs. If I used most of my money to fund rehab centers. Would that make me a good person?”

“Nothing could wipe out what you’ve done. You killed four innocent people, and that’s the ones I know about. How many lives have you ruined?”

I wanted to say five, but my mom’s still alive.

“So a bad guy can’t change and become good? Does that mean bad people don’t deserve forgiveness?”

“You don’t. There’s a limit.”

“And who’s to decide where this limit lies?”

“Common sense. Sound judgement. Universal moral principles.”

“Zoe, have you ever hated someone so much, you didn’t just want to just kill them, because their death would bring you satisfaction? You wanted to keep and torture them, wallowing in their suffering.”

“No.”

I swallowed hard.

“I’m not that...”

“You’re not that kind of person? Was that what you were going to say there? And If I were to make a call ordering for your parents to be killed?

And not only them, but all your friends and family. Everyone you've ever talked to or made eye contact with. And then took a gun out and asked you to choose. My life or yours?"

"The choice is obvious. Yours."

"I knew you'd rather pick mine," he grinned, "but are you going to kill yourself once you've shot me?"

My heart was thumping in my chest like he'd already pulled the phone out, ready to make the call.

"Yes."

"According to the *universal moral principles*, you can't kill either of us. Would you be able to live with yourself, knowing I was going to rot in prison for the rest of my life?"

"What're you trying to say?"

"That you're a hypocrite, Zoe. You're not as nice as you think. Life hasn't come down on you hard enough to make you squirm, trying to save everything you love no matter the price. You claim to live as per your morals and principles. But why do they fall like a house of cards the moment I touch it?"

I tried to swallow, but my throat was dry.

"That's different."

"Different?"

He smirked.

"By that logic, I'm not a bad guy? Then who's the bad guy, Zoe?"

"I don't know."

"You can be the bad guy, if you want. Or do you prefer playing nice? Because I don't mind being myself. But it really flatters me when you call me a bad guy. It's like you want me to be one. So you won't have to."

His words stirred internal struggle in me.

"You don't follow moral principles. You pick and choose them however it suits you."

He wasn't just manipulative. He cracked your skull open and went elbow deep in your mind, picking out the tools he could use as weapons against you.

His eyes, like two black holes, glistened in the night. His smile never left his lips.

"I like your innocence and that open-hearted altruism. It's cute."

I huffed.

I turned to the window, folding my arms.

That's how the evil is, it never sees the full picture. And it doesn't need to, since it exists only to destroy.

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CHAPTER 22

~~Knowledge gives me confidence. My beliefs shape me. My principles support me. I want to stand on sure ground no matter what. I wanted to watch myself grow, not fall to decay.~~

It's only been a few minutes since our last conversation when he broke the silence,

"You know what's funny?"

I turned to look at him.

"We've been on the road for over an hour. This is the third and longest conversation we've had so far. You ask me questions about anything except my name. Am I that uninteresting to you?"

He tilted his head to the side. His dark eyes stared deep into mine.

My eyebrows knitted together as my lips parted.

"Eric. My name's Eric."

"Huh."

"What?"

"It doesn't suit you."

One corner of his lips twitched a little.

"And what does?"

The reaper, obviously. But I wasn't going to tell him that.

I realized it was no use arguing with him. If someone believes the sun's black, you won't change their mind. Because it really is black to them.

So I told myself there really was no point in appealing to his sense of justice or guilt. Because he had neither. Just like he lacked any convictions, principles or values. It's no good trying to persuade, outsmart or fool him.

I was wasting my time and energy. I needed some outside help.

"You don't look Scandinavian. Italian, more like. Salvatore would've suited you better."

"Salvatore."

He said it and got lost in thought.

“How old are you?”

“30. Old enough?”

He was smiling.

“Yes.”

The corner of my lips perked up in a small smile and I immediately scolded myself for it.

“Do you...”

I looked at him curiously.

“Do you like art?”

“Art? Like, paintings? No. I don’t have an eye for them whatsoever.”

“What about horseback riding?”

“No. I’ve never gone horse riding in my life.”

“Why Philosophy?”

“I wanted to understand the world better, find my own meanings of things.”

“Did Philosophy make you draw a clear line between the good and the evil?”

“I’ve always been like that. Philosophy has nothing to do with that.”

I looked down at my hands resting on my knees.

Why was he asking me things he knew anyway?

The fact that he knew a lot about me while I knew next to nothing about him didn’t sit well with me. I didn’t like this power imbalance.

“Do you like reading?”

“Yes.”

“Do you have a favorite author?”

“No. I didn’t like choosing just one.”

“Do you know who hired people to raid our university?”

He immediately got serious, slipping his mask back on.

“Yes.”

His answer was curt, letting me know he wasn’t going to go into any details.

I was impatient, I knew that. I was rushing things.

The thought that he knew the truth but refused to tell me for some reason was eating at me.

“Who gave you that silver ring?”

I wanted to tell him it's none of his business and that he could go to hell. But maybe our interactions could bring us closer. And this would allow me to get more answers. I really needed to know who killed him, the reaper or those men?

I could feel it was him with every fiber of my being.

"My boyfriend."

"Why did he give you a men's ring?"

"He didn't. It's his ring. He left it with me temporarily. As a promise he'd come back to me," I whispered the last sentence.

His elbow was braced against the bottom of the glass window while his head rested on his knuckles. His eyes never left mine.

"Do you have a girlfriend?"

His lips slowly broke into a smile.

"Is there a candidate?"

My gaze fell back to my ring.

"I don't see you as a boyfriend."

"Neither do I. I could see myself as a husband."

I frowned. A strand of hair covered my face.

"A husband? Are you actually into relationships?"

"Why wouldn't I be? I like women."

He tucked a strand of hair behind my ear with a gentle movement of his fingers.

"Do you want a family?"

"I do."

I wasn't hiding my surprise.

"I thought you've been dreaming of taking over the world and raising havoc or something like that."

He picked a lock of my hair and began twisting it round his fingers.

"Having a woman I love by my side won't get in the way of me conquering the world or building a family with her."

I thought he was tricking me, that he was going to laugh in my face mockingly the next moment, but he didn't.

"Why are you so surprised? Because I like women? Or because I want to be a husband? Or maybe because I want to start a family?"

"All of the above."

"Do you want to get married?"

"Yes."

I was rolling the ring with my right hand finger.

“Have a family?”

“Yes.”

I looked up to see him smiling.

His smile was so genuine, so beautiful and truly happy that I forgot about his true nature for a moment.

“You have a nice smile.”

I didn’t notice I was smiling back.

Immediately wiping the smile off my face, I looked away. This made his smile grow wider.

I was fidgeting in my seat. The car seemed too small.

“What’re your hobbies?”

Other than killing people, I wanted to add but held it in.

“Weapons. Books. And... paintings.”

“Quite unusual.”

“What hobbies did you expect?”

Torture and murder.

“I don’t know. Cars, women and money.”

One corner of his lips perked up.

“I’d call those my passions, rather than hobbies.”

“I can’t imagine you dating a woman. Building a long-term relationship.”

“That’s because you don’t know me well enough. I’m full of surprises.”

That was true. He wasn’t just bewildering, he could make you forget how to speak.

“How do you see me?”

“You seem like a guy who gives no promises. The type to bluntly state they’re here to use you and leave right after, not staying the night. Maybe I’m wrong, it’s just based on your looks.”

“What about my looks?”

“You’re too handsome to be faithful.”

He laughed, touching his lower lip with the tips of his fingers.

“You’ve painted a portrait of a coward, someone afraid of intimacy.”

“Aren’t you afraid? Do you even care about stuff like that?”

“Few things scare me, and this is definitely not one of them. I appreciate intimacy. Emotional. Physical.”

“You’re not as you seem.”

“Neither are you, Zoe.”

I kept rolling the ring on my finger.

“Did you notice how easy it was?”

“What was?”

“For me to make you relax around me.”

Tension swept over my body. I swallowed my growing anxiety and sat up straight.

“I wasn’t relaxed.”

“Didn’t your mom tell you that lying is bad, Zoe?”

My anger flared up like a lit match falling into spilled kerosene.

“And didn’t your mother teach you...”

His left hand gripped my throat. He squeezed my throat, cutting off my oxygen. My hands clawed at his arm.

“What, Zoe? Tell me, what did she not teach me?”

His eyes were burning with hatred and true evil. This was the real him. He was no longer hiding behind sweet talk and a cute smile.

He looked down at my lips, then his gaze met mine again.

“You should watch your mouth, little liar.”

He let me go and I began to cough, gasping for air.

I sat up and kept rubbing my sore neck.

“You think I’m evil. You haven’t met the real evil yet.”

Why did that sound like a promise?

We turned off the highway and onto a gravel road, driving deep into the dark woods.

We were going in pitch darkness. No lamps illuminated the road anymore.

I was rolling the ring faster. I could feel his eyes on me.

I hesitantly turned my head to look at him and caught him watching my hands closely. I stopped touching the ring.

My heart was racing, my thoughts scampering about like ants.

Where were we going? Why was it taking so long? What were we going to do? What was I going to do? Was I going to get killed?

I returned to rolling the ring mindlessly.

His palm covered my hands.

“Don’t be so nervous.”

“Where’re we going?” I blurted out nervously.

“The auction.”

“What kind of auction?”

“Art auction.”

“You want to buy a painting?” I asked suspiciously.

“Yes.”

My anxiety slowly faded, but never went away fully.

He didn’t move his hand. It stayed on my left hand, lightly stroking it with his index finger. I wanted to shake his hand off, but decided to sit still instead to avoid provoking him any further.

The car drove up to the wrought gates of an estate.

Gravel rattled under the wheels of the car. The area was illuminated by dim lights stuck into the ground. An old mansion came into view. Yellow light seeping through the French windows lit up the lawn. Cars were parked next to it.

Well-dressed men and women walked the green carpet on their way to the entrance.

Anxiety rang in my head like a tiny annoying bell. It made me ask the question that was tormenting me, begging to be let out.

“Am I going to die tonight?”

He was looking out the window.

“Do you want to die?”

“No,” I exhaled.

“Just stay close.”

Why didn’t he answer the question?

I didn’t notice I’d been gripping his hand and he held mine all that time. I let it go and he immediately pulled away.

The car doors opened and we got out in sync.

He walked up to me and interlocked our fingers. That felt too intimate.

Justin and I never held hands like that when we were together.

“Do we have to hold hands?”

“We do.”

“Maybe I could take you by the arm?”

He leaned in and whispered in my ear,

“They need to know I’m fucking you, not keeping you company.”

I opened my mouth and immediately closed it.

The feelings of shame, awkwardness and anxiety made my breath hitch. I stared straight ahead.

I wasn’t going to die tonight, was I?

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CHAPTER 23

~~I used to dream about my future as a kid. I imagined a beautiful, happy and carefree life. I was reverently looking forward to growing up. And once I got older, I realized I no longer wanted to know anything about the future. I was too scared to wake up. Too scared to live. Scared to think.~~

The reaper led me from one room to another, as if he wanted everyone to know we were there. Dressed-up men and women cast appraising looks our way and whispered among themselves.

Some guests' eyes followed us like we were some sort of celebrities.

Others weren't as happy. They stared us down like ravenous hyenas, seemingly ready to tear me apart the first chance they get.

Anxiety made me grip his hand tightly, but I forced myself to release my grip almost immediately.

I looked up at the reaper. He didn't care for my hand or the attention of everyone around us. His gait exuded steadiness and confidence. He looked over everyone's heads.

When we reached the next room, I saw two men smile the moment they noticed him.

We came closer and he shook hands with them.

He didn't introduce me. He just let go of my hand and wrapped his arm around my waist, pulling me closer.

No one asked my name or who I was during the entire conversation. No one even glanced my way. It's like I wasn't there.

I felt incredibly awkward about it, mostly because of his hand resting possessively on my waist.

I should have been mad, grossed out, or at least scared. But all these emotions were muffled by the feeling of security.

I finally realized what the saying "better the devil you know than the devil you don't" that I'd heard back in school really meant.

More people approached him. Once some left, the others took their place. Everyone still ignored me. And I didn't mind that, to be honest. After all, I didn't know what to talk to them about or what I could say, really.

A woman several decades older than him that I'd never seen before gave him a sweet smile. On her way out, her gaze quickly slid towards me, and I noticed a hint of disgust in it.

What did I do wrong? I still stood there quietly, staring into space. Wasn't this what the reaper wanted?

I wasn't dressed provocatively. Almost my entire body was covered by the fabric of my dress. I'd never met her before, and she'd never seen me. How did I offend her?

The reaper grabbed my hand, breaking my train of thought, and pulled me into the next room.

It was filled with the same buzz of chatter as the other ones. Everyone was drinking, chatting and laughing. Suddenly, a live band started playing a slow melody.

He stopped and pulled me close all of a sudden. He gently put his right arm around my waist, reducing the distance between us. He held my right hand in his.

"Relax."

He said this as he led me in a dance.

I couldn't deny his wish, or his order, to be precise.

My heart throbbed painfully in my chest because of all the prying eyes, the dance, his hands, the unfamiliar atmosphere and the tension that permeated every corner of the room.

I tried to concentrate on the dance and ignore my thoughts. But when I realized it was just the two of us dancing while everyone else stood around, watching us, a fresh wave of anxiety washed over me.

My eyes kept wandering the darkness of my mind while his gaze remained fixed on me. Dark, intense and cold, they seemed otherworldly.

We were so close I felt the dark void of his eyes could devour me. And I wanted that.

I didn't want to be here. I wanted to disappear. I wanted them to take me somewhere quiet, away from people. Somewhere I wouldn't have to feel anything.

The melody faded away and we heard a startling storm of applause.

He turned and gave me a wide, joyous grin as I kept looking at him, utterly mesmerized.

The applause died down and upbeat music started playing. People began to fill the dance-floor.

My eyes wandered the crowd, looking at the gowns other women were wearing. They were dressed in short loose-fitting dresses. The dresses were bedazzled with glass beads, sequins and glitter. Many had long strings of pearls or diamond necklaces around their necks.

That's when it dawned on me.

My dress wasn't on theme.

The theme here was obviously the "roaring twenties". And neither of us matched the theme.

Did he do it on purpose? Did he not know?

As I looked at the men's suits, I met the gaze of a man in the far corner.

He was overweight, but his legs were skinny. He combed his thin gray hair back to hide a bald spot.

He pulled an inhaler and took a couple hits from it, his lifeless gaze never leaving mine as he listened to the man next to him talk.

His gaze made my stomach turn, crushing my chest. I felt an inexplicable wave of anxiety.

I turned away and looked up at the reaper. He'd been staring at me all this time. One corner of his lips twitched and he slowly tucked a loose strand of hair behind my ear.

The room was thick with the smells of fresh food, alcohol and women's perfume. And yet, his scent... His scent dominated the place. I couldn't fully take in all the new scents because of how close he was.

I began to think his scent was mine now, too.

His eyes went to my lips and then shot back to my eyes.

I could see the clear intent in his gaze.

I frowned, ready to step away.

He leaned closer to my ear.

His warm breath tickled my ear lobe. His voice sounded deep and sultry.

"Act like you enjoy it. Just like I acted like I didn't notice you hiding a phone in your panties at dinner."

I opened my mouth to protest but his soft lips covered mine.

His right hand slipped into my hair, pulling me closer as his tongue penetrated deep into my mouth, making us intertwine.

His tongue caressed mine, driving me insane. I was no longer thinking. My breath hitched. I could only feel.

He was sucking. Fondling. Dominating me.

He savored the kiss. The way secret lovers savor a fleeting shared moment in a blooming garden under the veil of night.

His warm tongue licked along my lower lip, his teeth biting it slightly to remind me he was in the lead.

When he pulled away, I was overwhelmed by shame and fear because I submitted to him instead of fighting it. But the worst were my feelings of guilt and disgust because that kiss changed something deep inside of me.

I opened my eyes and saw desire in his gaze. Desire fading into slight distaste. His emotions switched so fast I wouldn't have noticed it had we not been standing so close to one another.

"Eric!"

A raspy voice made him drag his gaze away from me.

I didn't turn to look at the man calling him right away. It took me a moment to throw my thoughts and feelings away and pull myself together.

Finally turning to look at the stranger, I realized it was the man with the inhaler.

"Why don't you introduce your fair lady to me? She's shining like a diamond among us tonight."

I was surprised he not only noticed me but wanted to know who I was.

"Roosevelt, this is Zoe. Zoe, this is Roosevelt."

"So stunning."

His clammy hand grabbed mine and he brought it to his shriveled lips.

I wanted to jerk it back, but that would've been really rude of me. Once he let my hand go, I hid it behind my back and wiped it on the dress.

Something about him felt wrong. My whole being screamed danger to me.

There was something I didn't understand about his gaze, but I knew it wasn't supposed to be there.

Roosevelt began to cough, turning away but not bothering to cover his mouth. It looked like he was about to die, but unfortunately, he was still with us.

"We haven't seen you around for a while."

"I've been busy."

“Oh. I can see how busy you’ve been. If I had important business like this, I’d shut it away so no one else can catch a glimpse of it. I’d have this diamond shine only to me.”

His words made me wrestle against disgust and repulsion.

His dull eyes ogled me, from my head to the red heels peeking out from underneath the white dress. I wanted to turn invisible again.

I put my hand around Eric, trying to stand closer in an attempt to get the shameful protection only he could give me.

He didn’t push me away, just rested his hand on my back, stroking it gently.

“The auction’s about to start. I want to buy a painting. Any advice?”

“The Dark Cloud will be a good choice.”

“The Dark Cloud. Why that one?”

“I can’t reveal all of its strong points. But it’s more valuable than it looks.”

The old man cackled breathlessly.

“Will you allow me a dance with your diamond?”

I gripped reaper’s jacket.

His hand kept caressing my back calmly.

“I’m gonna have to decline, or we might miss the auction.”

“Of course. Maybe afterwards?”

“By all means.”

Roosevelt gave me his creepy smile and left, blending in with the crowd on his way to the next room.

“Eric, please.”

I took his hand.

He looked down at my hand, frowning slightly.

“What?”

His voice was cold.

“I don’t want to dance with him.”

“What are you willing to do for it?”

“Anything.”

He grabbed my chin, lifting it to make me look into his eyes.

He was angry.

“Take the knife from that table and kill him.”

“What?”

“Zoe, I know you don’t have trouble hearing.”

“I... I...”

“You told me you’d do anything. Then prove it.”

He’s asking the impossible. He knew I couldn’t kill a man.

All the rooms were overcrowded. How was I supposed to do it? How was I going to do it without being noticed?

Doesn’t matter. And even if I found a way, I wouldn’t take a life.

I turned to look at the knife sticking out of a large chunk of meat on the table.

“I can’t,” I whispered.

“Then don’t tell me you’d do anything I say. I hate empty promises more than anything.”

He tightened his grip on my hand and dragged me to the auction.

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CHAPTER 24

~~The naive part of me always thinks and hopes for the best when I should be preparing for the worst. After all, the quiet always comes before the storm. It can just brush against you or carry you so far you'll spend a long time looking for your way back, perhaps never even finding it.~~

"Five thousand!"

"Five and a half!"

"Six thousand!"

"Six thousand, one! Six thousand, two! Six thousand, three! The Nightfall is sold to number forty-five for six thousand dollars!"

People applauded. The reaper and I didn't applaud, we just watched the auction indifferently.

Many participants didn't get a seat, so they filled the spot behind the last rows. We were sitting in row six out of thirty. The second hour of the auction was underway.

All of his anger completely disappeared. His sudden fits of impulsive violence scared me. I could never tell what he'd say or do the next moment. He's like a labyrinth, you keep searching for the clues to find the exit, but you only end up more confused and lost until you hit a dead end.

"How many paintings do you want to buy?"

"One."

"When are they going to bring it out?"

"Now."

I turned my head to look at the stage. The painting was carefully placed on the wooden easel.

"The Dark Cloud?"

"Yes."

Why did he tell Roosevelt to buy the painting if he wanted it for himself?

The canvas was large. It was an oil painting. Various shades of blue dominated the composition. The painting depicted an overcast, stormy sky that took up almost the entire canvas. The sun could be seen behind the clouds. Its pale-blue rays poked through the dark clouds. A broken flock of birds could be seen flying on the left side of the painting. Below was a green field with a dark outline of forest in the distance.

Just a regular painting. Nothing about it was noteworthy or memorable. The ones before it were a lot more beautiful and interesting to look at.

If I had as much money as them, I'd never blow it on a painting that bland.

"What do you think about when you look at this painting?"

"It's boring. Nothing special. I wouldn't have taken it even if they'd paid me to."

Eric laughed so loudly the people in the front rows turned back to give him annoyed glares.

When he stopped laughing, he gave me a curious look, a smile still lingering on his face.

I frowned and looked away, turning back to look at the painting.

"What do you see when you look at it?"

"Hope."

"Hope?"

"Why are you surprised?"

"Because you don't need hope."

"You're right, I don't. But it serves as a reminder of a lost friend who needed it so much."

Did he actually care about other people? I'd never have guessed he was a sentimental type.

"Where are you going to put it?"

"Next to my bed. I want to look at it as I fall asleep and wake up."

He rarely stayed the night in his room. He'd usually leave in the evening and come back in the morning. What was the meaning of this painting?

"Painting titled The Dark Cloud, artist unknown. The starting bid is fifty thousand dollars!"

How much?

My eyes nearly popped out when I heard the price.

Why was it so expensive?

"One hundred thousand!"

I turned to look at Eric to see if he was in his right mind, because the price he was offering clearly said otherwise.

The painting wasn't worth fifty grand, one thousand would've been too generous for it.

"One hundred and fifty thousand!"

Roosevelt sat in the front row.

He turned to Eric, giving his crooked smile.

Eric didn't smile back.

"Three hundred thousand!"

"Eight hundred thousand!"

"One million!"

I didn't understand what game they were playing, but it looked utterly insane.

"Three million!"

"Ten million!"

"Ten million, one! Ten million, two!"

"Sixteen million!"

"Sixteen million, one! Sixteen million, two! Sixteen million, three! And the item is sold to number two!"

The room burst into applause.

Eric looked content, and I couldn't understand, why. He told me how important this painting was to him mere moments ago, and now he sat there like this was exactly the plan.

The auction came to an end and everyone headed to the main hall.

The waiters carried around trays with glasses of champagne, offering drinks to everyone.

Eric led me to the refreshment table, took a glass of champagne and disappeared into the crowd without saying a word to me.

Looking at the abundance of snacks I realized that I wasn't very hungry, and that I really needed a drink.

The moment I thought about it, a man with a short haircut and light stubble appeared next to me. He had light-blue eyes. Smiling, he passed me a glass of champagne.

I gave him a small smile and thanked the man.

We stood there silently, facing the dance-floor with our backs to the table.

"Are you enjoying yourself?"

I broke into a laugh that quickly died down.

The reaper forbade me to talk to anyone. But how was it possible? I wasn't going to stand there silently like I was mute.

He looked at me quizzically.

"I don't want to be here."

"I understand.

August."

He offered me his hand and I shook it.

"Zoe."

"I've never seen you around here before."

"And I have never been around before."

Silence fell between us.

"How often do they hold these events?"

"Usually once every three month."

"Did you come here with your girlfriend, too?"

"No, I don't have a girlfriend."

He smirked as his gaze wandered wistfully.

He looked so calm and normal, the complete opposite of Eric.

"Why did your boyfriend leave you here?"

"I don't know."

"Had it been me, I'd never have left my girlfriend to stay here all alone."

I got flustered and took a big sip of champagne.

"Did you take part in the auction?"

"Oh. No. I'm not a fan of art."

"How do you prefer to spend your money?"

It took me a moment to realize how that sounded.

"I'm sorry. That was rude of me."

He was smiling.

"Not at all. I like collecting rare things."

My eyes were glued to Eric the second I saw him dancing with a tall brunette with long, flowing wavy hair. Her black satin low-cut dress hugged her body flawlessly. She was almost as tall as he was in her heels.

Who was she?

The way they looked at one another made me think they weren't strangers. They looked so laid-back and carefree next to each other. Smiles never left their faces as they were chatting away merrily. They looked like a couple.

“You aren’t jealous, are you? He’s just asked her to dance.”

“No. He can dance with whomever he wants, we aren’t... we don’t get jealous.”

“Are you sure?”

August got closer and tilted his head to me.

“Because he’s looking at you right now, not her. And he definitely is jealous.”

I looked up from my glass and met Eric’s cold gaze glaring daggers at me.

My heart picked up the pace. He looked angry.

Did he see me talking to August?

I knocked back the glass, finishing the rest of my drink.

“I could make him get back here in a flash.”

I stepped away from him.

“No need.”

“I thought you wanted that.”

“No. I like your company.”

“The refreshments here are trash. The only redeeming thing about this party is loads of booze. And a good chat.”

I burst out laughing at his sudden confession.

“Do you want to dance?”

“No.”

Eric’s gruff and angry voice rang next to us.

The brunette was nowhere to be found. It’s like she disappeared into thin air.

“Glad to see you, Eric.”

“Can’t say the same.”

He roughly gripped my wrist and quickly dragged me outside.

“Goodbye, Zoe.”

He lifted his glass and drank it.

I could only nod my head goodbye.

CHAPTER 25

~~Broken promises ruined something within me. They take away your faith and hope, turning you into a cornered kitten, scared and hiding from people. Your faith becomes shaky, and trust is nearly impossible to come by.~~

“Don’t look at him.”

I turned away.

“Where are we going?”

“Don’t ask any questions.”

We got outside and Eric roughly turned me to look at him like I was his possession, and not a human being.

He was enraged.

His eyes seemed even more terrifying in the night. He looked like a bloodthirsty predator, ready to rip me apart.

I was rocking on the waves of anxiety.

“How long have you been talking to him?”

“Not that long.”

“How. Long?”

“He came up to me and started a conversation first. Am I supposed to stay quiet when someone asks me a question? You taught me to answer questions when...”

“I taught you to answer my questions, not that bastard’s. Can’t you see the difference, Zoe?”

“Yes.”

I looked down.

“What did you talk about?”

“Nothing, really. He asked if I liked it there. Asked me if I was jealous about you and that girl. Asked...”

“And what did you tell him?”

“That I wasn’t jealous. That we were an item and I wasn’t jealous.”

I decided to omit the part where I asked August questions.

He ran a hand through his hair and smiled, looking at the ground.

“Nothing bad happened. I’m sure everyone thought we were a couple.”

“That’s not the point.”

“I get it, I disobeyed you. But I didn’t do it on purpose. I...”

“What?”

I could feel his anger infecting me.

“Why are you angry? What made you so mad? He was sweet to me.”

His eyebrows shot up.

“Sweet?”

He said it like an insult.

Smirking, he took a step back with a distant look on his face.

Cool night breeze got to me. It played with my hair, tangling it and sending shivers down my spine.

My heart was beating rhythmically, waiting for what he was going to do next.

I could see he was contemplating something. I had a weird feeling he was worried about something. But people like him were never bothered with anything. He had no problems. I was only seeing what I wanted to see. Something that wasn’t there.

We stood by a tall and still lush green oak tree. The yellow light from the large windows of the mansion lit up our small clearing.

Eric looked up and I felt a wave of adrenaline wash over me.

He spoke quickly and I couldn’t understand him at first.

“A black car will arrive in about five minutes. You will get in and go wherever it takes you. You are not to resist or run away. You will do everything they ask you to do.”

“What?”

“I’m only gonna say it once, so listen closely. Find a safe in his office. The office is through the door from the bedroom. There’s a silver necklace in that safe. Open the safe and put it on. Leave his house after that. Levi will be waiting at the corner of the house.”

“You...”

I wanted to tell him exactly how I felt about him. Let him know everything I’ve kept deep down from the moment we met.

I knew he didn’t bring me here to have a good time, I wasn’t on a vacation, he owned me.

But to give me away like I'm some kind of commodity? It's like I wasn't even human and my life was worthless. I couldn't comprehend that.

"The car's here," he said in a calm tone.

I could feel panic taking over me bit by bit.

At that moment I realized I had to let go of my pride and do anything to avoid getting into that car.

"Please, Eric, anything but that. I beg you. Please. Don't make me go with him."

I grabbed his arm with both my hands.

"I'll do anything you want. Ask for anything. I'll do it. But, please, don't make me go."

Tears rolled down my face, tickling my cheeks.

A clicking sound interrupted my pathetic sobs. My gaze fell on the silver gun in his hand.

"Please, forgive me. I know I shouldn't have talked to him. I'm sorry. I will never defy you again."

He raised the gun and began sliding it over my chest slowly.

"Your pleas are so sweet," he said mockingly, "and your offer sounds very intriguing. You're tempting me, Zoe. I'll definitely take you up on the offer. But not today."

He pressed the cold barrel of the gun to my heart.

I could feel it beating against the cold metal in a futile attempt to save itself.

"You're so beautiful. Don't cry. It'll ruin your makeup."

I clenched my teeth hard enough to make my face hurt.

Hatred was raging within me like a wildfire. I was ready to pounce at him, ignoring the barrel of the gun aimed at my heart.

I was on the verge of sacrificing myself, risking my life for a chance to hurt him.

I never knew I could feel such overwhelming, all-consuming emotions. I wanted to let them take me over, for them to take control of my arms and legs. I wanted to embody them.

I knew what anger was. But this was my first time feeling hatred.

He looked me in the eye, smiling. This was just a joke to him. A game.

"Shoot me," I hissed through gritted teeth.

He tilted his head to the side slightly, raising one eyebrow.

The smile still adorned his face.

“I like watching you squirm. Like breaking you down to see what’s coming next. I’m having so much fun. You think I’m gonna kill you? Here? No. First, I’m gonna kill your dear mom and dad. One after another. Death will be long. Torturous. And you’ll be sat right next to them, watching it happen, powerless to change anything. By that time, you’ll change your mind, as you do, but I won’t. I will finish what I started.”

He looked away theatrically, acting like he was trying to remember something.

“But someone’s definitely missing from this line-up. Don’t you agree, Zoe? Who did I leave out? Why, of course. Isabella.”

Anger snapped within me. I could feel my stomach turn.

She was safe. He wasn’t supposed to know her name. I knew this would happen.

I messed up.

“Maybe I should take her in once I’m done with you?”

“Don’t even think about it,” I spat it like an insult.

He caressed my cheek with the back of his hand.

“Then be a good girl, Zoe,” he kept stroking my face with a smile, “and get your ass into that fucking car.”

His hand left my face and his smile disappeared.

The gun was still pressed to my chest, ready to shoot and injure me for disobeying him, but not to kill me, unfortunately.

I slowly turned and headed to the black car.

My motions were wooden, I felt stiff all over. My body barely moved.

I forced myself not to think or feel anything.

The pulse was ringing in my ears, loud enough to stun me.

The driver opened the car door for me, but I didn’t get in right away. I lifted my head to take one last rage-filled look at the reaper. He stared back at me with a blank expression.

You would pay for this. The day would come, and you would pay for everything.

Once I got in the car, I heard a voice that sent a wave of primal terror through my body.

“Finally, the diamond blessed me with her radiance.”

I was met by Roosevelt’s raspy voice and creepy smile.

I wanted to scream bloody murder. Wanted to open the door and run until my feet start bleeding.

I wanted to kill Eric.

“Drive.”

He barked the order to the driver and the car rolled on.

My hands were shaking and I tried to hide them in the long sleeves of my dress.

“Did you enjoy the evening?”

“Yes.”

I replied without thinking, trying not to look at him. My voice didn't sound familiar to me. It's like I could hear someone else talking through me. Like I lost my voice the moment I got in this car.

“I'm one of the sponsors of these events.”

His voice grew hoarse at the last word. A coughing fit overcame him. He coughed so loud it sounded like he was going to die.

I probably should've had pity for the frail old man. But I felt none.

We were going to his home, where he was going to destroy my body and soul. What pity could I have for him? Pity for what?

Eric told me I hadn't met the real evil yet, but he couldn't be more wrong.

Roosevelt wasn't the true evil.

True evil dwelt in an old manor with a basement prison. He hid his corrupt mind behind expensive garments. His talk was sweet, yet his actions were ugly. His black eyes mirrored the endless void of his empty soul. His heart was long dead, hanging in his chest like a rotten apple on a branch. His looks were deceptive, just a trap to lure you in and tear you apart in the blink of an eye.

People like him came from hell itself to torment and destroy others, leaving nothing but searing pain and bottomless void behind.

CHAPTER 26

~~Evil has no limit. It's merciless, ghastly and grotesque. If you're lucky, it will never find you. But if you run out of luck and evil finds its way to you, know that no pleas would save you. Now you're all alone. So put your armor on and take a sword in your hands, you're on the battlefield.~~

The road to his place felt like an endless path to the very heart of the purgatory.

It was cool in the car, but I could barely breathe.

"Can I roll down the window?"

"Of course, doll."

I rolled it down and felt the cold night air slap my face.

"How long more is the road going to take?"

"Eager, aren't you?"

He looked at me with that crooked smile, like he'd suffered a stroke. He licked his dry lips.

Fear left a lump in my throat and I struggled to swallow it.

"I need to use the bathroom."

I had to escape.

He wasn't armed, which couldn't be said about his driver.

It's dark. If his house wasn't far from a forest, I'd have a chance to escape. The car would stop by the gates and I'd have a few seconds to open the door and run for my life. And with any luck, I'd be able to get away before they put a bullet in my head.

But where would I run? What next?

If I chose that path, all my loved ones would die.

I'd lose my home before I even got the chance to return.

What's the point in escaping? To save myself? This wasn't my big escape, this was the real death.

I could never live with myself knowing I threw them to the wolves to save my own skin. They still had a choice. They could still lead normal lives. They could live without me. They'd get used to it.

Not me, though.

I was in hell already. Holding evil by the hand and looking into its eyes. So why trade temporary suffering of my body and soul for eternal damnation?

Eric holds me by the throat even when he's not around. His phantom hand was always ready to snap my neck. All I could do was roll with the punches at that point. There were no other options.

Sadness and despair gently enveloped me, leaving sharp pain within.

"Are you listening to me?"

I turned my head to the old man.

"I'm sorry."

"Relax."

He rested his wrinkled hand on my knee.

I could feel how clammy his hand was through the thin fabric of my dress.

I felt sick with fear and repulsion.

"We're almost there. I have wine from 1934. I think you'll like it."

I don't think I could enjoy wine from your year of birth.

He wouldn't move his palm from my knee until his house came into view, and I couldn't bring myself to throw it off.

I felt like I was sitting on hot coals when I saw the car arrive at his mansion.

The car stopped at the locked iron gates. Two men with machine-guns stood nearby.

My hand reached for the door handle involuntarily and I pulled it quietly. The door was locked.

I lost whatever hope I still had at that point.

I knew there was nothing I could've done, no matter what decision I'd taken.

The car drove into the court yard, and I saw a modern-looking mansion. Its grandiosity felt obnoxious and tacky.

When I got out of the car I noticed how tall the steel fence around the mansion actually was. Cameras and security guards with machine-guns were at every corner.

Eric was part of the criminal world himself, but even he wasn't this paranoid. Who was this Roosevelt?

We made a bunch of stops on the way to his bedroom. He was showing and telling me about things I couldn't care less about. I pretended to be impressed, but deep inside I could only beg for all of it to be over soon.

"Make yourself at home, doll. I'm going to bring the bottle from my office."

I was sitting on a hard couch that made my butt hurt.

I turned to look at the large bed and felt the sticky feeling of panic creep up on me.

"I'm back. Did you miss me?"

He put out two glasses and poured us some wine.

I was going to drink it, but he stopped me.

"Not so fast. Smell it. What can you feel?"

Fear. Confinement. Death.

"Smells rich. But I'm not big on wine tastings."

"Ah. Yes. Eric told me about you."

"What did he say?"

"My, you really perked up when I mentioned him, didn't you? Is he your favorite?"

My favorite? What was he on about?

"No need to hide it anymore. No one will ever know you came here. I've already paid Eric for our night."

"What do you mean by hiding?"

"That you're his escort girl. He sleeps with you and allows those who can afford it to have a taste as well. You must be unforgettable with a price like that."

My whole body went numb.

A whore?

By working for him, he meant being a whore?

I smiled mindlessly and drank the whole glass of wine.

"Nice wine."

Roosevelt cackled and began coughing again.

He took a few hits of his inhaler and spoke,

"I knew you'd appreciate it. I hope you'll remember me. Come, sit closer to me. You're too far away."

He wrapped his hand around my waist and pulled me closer.

I could feel the stench of alcohol and his shriveled fingers holding me in a grip of dread.

I got a knot in my stomach, my gag reflex flaring up.

“Can I have more wine?”

“Of course.”

We clinked glasses. I put the glass to my lips, and a few drops spilled on my chest and knees as I drank.

“Shit,” I blurted out under my breath.

“Damn, you’re so hot.”

He pressed his body to mine, trying to kiss me.

“I’m sorry, but you need to take a shower to give me time to get ready.”

Roosevelt laughed and began groping me.

“Only if you join me.”

“I’ve got stitches on my shoulder. I can’t get them wet.”

“You’re missing out, hottie.”

He leaned towards me and licked my cheek, leaving a wet strip of saliva on my skin.

“I’m gonna be back soon. Get ready for me.”

The door to the bathroom closed behind him and I wiped his drool off my face with a sleeve.

I got up, ready to leave.

I could leave now. This was my last chance. Now or never.

The necklace. Fucking necklace. I had to find it.

I jumped up and headed to his office.

Eric didn’t lie. The door was close-by. But where was the safe?

There was nothing behind the paintings. Nothing behind the curtains, either.

Maybe it’s in the desk? Sure enough, it was.

Did the stupid reaper expect me to crack a safe?

Maybe the numbers were rubbed off on the buttons he pressed regularly? No. All numbers looked brand new and untouched.

Maybe there’s a key? I opened each drawer, but couldn’t find anything.

Maybe he kept his password in the open somewhere? No. There was nothing that looked like a password.

I ran around the room, looking for some sort of a hint.

I froze in place next to a glass shelf stand.

A safe, huh? Damn you, Eric.

The necklace was behind the glass, lying on a red pillow, glistening beautifully in the white light of tiny lamps.

The key was in the lock. I turned the key and opened it.

I put the necklace around my neck, hastily hiding it under the dress. It was cold and heavy.

“Zoe. Zoe. My diamond Zoe.”

Fear pierced through me.

I immediately left the office.

He was standing there naked and my gaze shot up to stare at his wrinkly forehead.

“I was looking for a restroom, but with no luck.”

He looked over my shoulder. I could see he was going to check the office.

I walked up to him and began sliding my hands along his body.

“You look so fine.”

He laughed, hugging me, trying to lean in for a kiss.

I put a hand between us.

“I still need that restroom. Make yourself comfy on the bed and wait for me.”

I turned to leave, but he grabbed my arm and pulled me closer.

“I’m tired of waiting. Let me fuck you right now. Take your clothes off.”

“I’ve had way too much alcohol tonight and haven’t used the bathroom in a while. It won’t take long. I’ll be back before you know it.”

He was watching me closely. He let go of my arm and slapped my ass.

“Make it quick.”

“Of course,” I smiled.

The second he turned his back to me, I grabbed a glass of wine and quickly headed to the bathroom, closing the door behind me.

Please, let it be my lucky chance. Please, let it be my lucky chance. God, please.

I opened the cabinet under the sink and saw a plethora of pill bottles.

What should I choose? Not a single name sounded familiar to me.

I quickly snatched the pill bottle in the middle.

What could I use to crush them?

Even if I were to find something, he’d hear me doing it.

I flushed the toilet and shoved a heaping handful of pills in my mouth. I chewed them carefully, trying not to swallow any saliva.

I turned the tap on and began spitting the soggy mass into the glass, mixing it with my finger.

I rinsed my mouth and my hand accidentally knocked over one of the vials. It fell down with a clink, spilling the pills all over the bathroom floor.

“What was that noise?”

“My bracelet broke. I’m coming.”

I quickly picked up the pills and flushed them.

Even if I left some behind, it wouldn’t matter. He clearly took these every day. There’d be nothing weird about it.

“I’ll come out if you close your eyes and open them once I sit down next to you.”

“What’s with the games, doll? Come out already. I’m getting tired of it.”

“Roosie, please,”

I cooed in a sweet voice, catching a wave of nausea.

“Alright.”

I heard him sigh. He was frustrated he couldn’t get what he wanted.

And he wouldn’t.

With quick, tentative steps I walked to the table, not taking my eyes off him and hiding the glass behind my back.

I took my glass and sat by his side on the bed.

He opened his eyes and I handed him the glass, smiling.

“Let us have our last glass of wine.”

CHAPTER 27

~~Manipulation is a weapon you carry with you at all times. People like to wield it to get what they want. You can spin the story in a way that would make someone believe they did something, even if they played no part in it. And they'd never know of the invisible weapon aimed right at their head. The weapon that made them confess.~~

I pretended to drink, watching Roosevelt closely to make sure he drank the whole glass.

“Come here.”

He dropped his glass and pushed me to lie on the bed.

My glass spilled wine on my dress, falling on the beige carpet.

His bloated body got on top of me. The towel he wore came undone.

I wasn't trembling anymore. It's like my fear just faded away.

I was lying there like a dead fish, watching things unravel.

He was licking my left cheek and my lips, moving down to my neck. His foul tongue was drooling on me as I stayed still like a toy.

I should have run when he was in the shower.

I should have run while he was sitting on the bed.

He began groping my shoulders, breasts and stomach. He ground on me like a horny dog.

He grabbed the collar of my dress and tried to rip it open. The thin fabric gave way and the sound of cloth tearing filled the room.

“What the fuck?”

The necklace.

I tried getting out from underneath him, but it was impossible.

“You, bitch!”

A sharp slap to the cheek shocked me. I wanted to scream the pain out, but my vision went blurry.

“Tried to rob me, you, skank?”

He grabbed me by the hair and dragged me to the floor.

I screamed, gripping my hair with both hands. I felt like I was being scalped.

He grabbed my arm and threw me to the floor full-force.

The bed was tall and I broke the fall by landing on my arm. I tried to get up, but he came up and kicked me in the stomach.

He kicked me in the ribs twice after that.

He was beating me furiously, mercilessly.

I tried to cover myself with my hands as I lay there. One of his kicks hit my fingers. Sobbing escaped my lips.

“Whore!”

He sat on top of me and grabbed my neck with both hands.

He squeezed for all he was worth.

I tried to claw at his face, and he pulled one of his hands away to land a hard blow in my eye. Whatever air I still had in my lungs got pushed out violently.

His other hand began to fumble about the layers of my dress.

I was kicking and trying to move away from his hand when he raised it to punch me in the nose.

Agony made me see black spots and the taste of blood in my mouth screamed for me to keep fighting.

He hiked up the skirt of my dress and tried ripping my panties off when his face began to flush red and his eyes got a glazed-over look.

His hand flew back to my throat and he resumed strangling me savagely.

Tears began streaming from my eyes like midwood brooks.

I stared into the furious eyes of death itself. Death reeked of alcohol and shower gel. That’s when I realized I wasn’t going to make it.

I was going to die.

Black spots filled my vision and I felt like I was about to pass out.

He was looking more and more flushed, like he was strangling himself instead of me.

His grip was getting weaker, but not weak enough for me to take a big gulp of air.

I raised my arm and slapped him in the face. Gasping for air, he moved his hand to his throat, hitting me on the chin.

The blow wasn’t hard, but I could taste fresh blood in my mouth.

I’d bit my cheek.

He got off of me, and I coughed violently, gasping for the air I still couldn't get enough of.

He staggered to get to the table, tumbling down right next to it. His hand was fumbling for the inhaler on the table.

It brought me great pleasure to watch it slip out of his hands.

When he finally got it, he took two hits but it did nothing. He was still suffocating.

His face turned red like a ripe tomato ready to burst. His eyes went wide, saliva began dripping from his mouth.

I watched him from the floor all this time, trying not to pass out.

"Call for help," he croaked.

"No," I whispered.

Now was my turn to see terror in his eyes. He realized he lost.

His body went limp. He fell on the side, staring at me.

I watched him take a couple more breaths right before life left his body for good.

His glassy, lifeless eyes stared back at me.

I tried to get back up, but my whole body was now a huge open wound. I leaned on my elbow, but my arm was too weak and I fell on the side, moaning in pain.

I tried to get up again and this time turned out better.

Leaning against the wall, I stood there, watching his dead body.

I had to run.

A wave of adrenaline hit me.

I ran out of the room, holding the collar of my dress with my left hand to hide the necklace, my shoes dangling from my right hand.

I hurt to run, my left eye wouldn't open, but I kept running.

I ran into the hall and came upon a middle-aged woman.

"He's..."

Fear left me speechless. I didn't know, what to do. I had no idea, what to say.

The woman looked at me with furrowed brows. She looked me over intently, like she was trying to decide what to do with me.

She rushed into his room, leaving me standing there with my ugly thoughts.

She would know I killed him. She'd call the police. I had to run.

She came back, and I froze.

“He’s dead.”

My mouth hung open as I blinked rapidly, waiting for her to make a decision.

“You need to leave.”

I quickly nodded.

She led me to the front door and closed it behind me without another word.

I staggered as I walked to the main gates.

The guards didn’t ask any questions. They said nothing as they let me out.

I stumbled along the fence barefoot, unable to fathom how quickly I’d managed to find myself there.

Bright headlights blinded me. A dark-blue car pulled out from around the corner and stopped.

Levi got out of the car to open the passenger door for me.

I got in, threw my shoes on the floor and pulled legs closer to my body, hugging them tightly.

I was safe.

I was okay.

I was alive.

It’s fine. It’s fine. It’s fine.

Memories of what’d just happened flashed through my mind.

Emotions washed over me like an icy wave as tears streamed down my face. The sobs turned into wails that filled the car.

Levi didn’t try to calm me down, ask me questions, or do anything that would’ve made me cry even harder. He drove the car silently, like he wasn’t even there.

I cried, drowning in my tears and choking on sobs. I couldn’t get enough of them. I didn’t know if I could ever stop or when I’d have enough.

The car stopped and I raised my tear-stained eyes to look out the window.

We returned to my prison.

I unclenched my hands so I could sit up straight and put my shoes back on.

My face was throbbing and burning. It was hard to swallow.

I didn’t want to move. I didn’t want to be in my own body. It no longer brought me any comfort.

I put my shoes on, got out of the car and headed to the reaper's office.

When I walked in, Eric was leaning against the table, staring at the wall in silence.

He stood up straight when he saw me. His whole body tensed up like a spring. His eyes looked me over, taking in the consequences of his actions. He kept balling and relaxing his right fist.

"Does it hurt?"

His voice sounded like he couldn't believe his own eyes and wanted to make sure what he was looking at was real.

I tried to take the necklace off, but it got tangled in the scraps of my dress.

I pulled at the dress, and it gave in with a sound of fabric tearing.

I wanted to rid myself of the dress, too.

Burn it.

Forget it ever existed.

I could still feel the filth and depravity of that night. It's like the dress had absorbed all those disgusting events and now carried their imprint within itself.

Crazy fatigue crushed me. I wanted to wash away all my thoughts, this whole day as soon as I could, and plunge into a deep sleep, finally letting myself drift away someplace all of this filth can't reach.

Eric came closer.

His eyes never leaving mine for even a second.

I took a step towards him once I took off the necklace and held it out in my hand.

"You didn't worry about it when you gave me to him. Why start now?"

I could see a tinge of anger and regret in his eyes.

Regret?

No. I was just seeing things.

Psychopaths can't feel those kinds of emotions. And even if he could, fuck his regrets and fuck him, too.

"I asked you a question."

His voice was cold.

I let my hand fall and the necklace dropped to the floor like a cast-off trinket.

"What exactly would you like to know, Eric? Whether he raped me or not? Did he strangle me? Be more specific about the parts of the story

you're curious about. Because he called me a whore and was going to treat me accordingly. All because you told him I was one."

"Answer the damn question, Zoe."

He replied through gritted teeth.

I could feel all the emotions I'd left in the car come down on me like a giant wave.

"Yes. It hurts. It hurts like hell to realize a human being can do stuff like this to someone they've never met before. Someone who did nothing wrong. It hurts to know that men like you and Roosevelt walk the Earth, raising hell wherever you are. It hurts to know I'm all alone. That no one's coming to save me. I live in a cage, and I have no idea how long I've left to live. I have no future. All I've left is my past, beautiful memories I burn to see any light in my life at this point. Because my life as it is now is hell. And you are the reaper, sucking the life out of me little by little, watching me die slowly."

I walked around him to the table and grabbed the scissors from it.

His body tensed up.

I could see him clenching his jaw hard.

"You want me to kill myself, don't you? Is that what you want?"

Tears were flowing down my face with renewed vigor, my voice breaking.

"Would it be easier for you if I killed myself right now? Would you be happy then? I know, I would. I'd be happy to finally save myself from you."

I rammed the scissors into my chest and felt them colliding with flesh, but there was no pain.

I looked up and saw Eric standing much closer now. His face looked slightly twisted.

I glanced down and saw a red stream of blood flowing from his hand.

The scissors stabbed his hand, but didn't go fully through.

Terror showed in my face.

He jerked them out in one fell swoop and threw them on the floor.

I was shaking.

"I... I..."

He took my tear-stained cheeks in his hands and lifted my face, making our eyes meet.

"It won't make me feel any better."

I looked at him, trying to comprehend what I'd done and what he said.

I began to step back and his hands slipped away from my face.

Blood was dripping from his hand. It soaked into the carpet, wishing to stay there forever.

My gaze darted from him to his hand, the scissors, the carpet and the necklace. And I ran out of the room.

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CHAPTER 28

~~I regret many things, my actions, words and hesitation. I'm drowning in darkness with no hope for forgiveness. After all, how can you ask for forgiveness if you can't forgive yourself?~~

My thoughts were no longer clear. They got hazy and seemed more like a dream.

I sat down on the toilet lid, leaning to the side and resting my left cheek on the cold tiles.

Pleasant sensations spread throughout my body.

Out of the corner of my eye, I saw him enter the room.

It seemed like I felt him long before I saw him. It's like my body always knew when he's near as it cowered in fear, ready to flee.

Staring ahead blankly, I asked,

"Am I just like you now?"

He crouched down in front of me, took one of my feet and pulled the red shoe off.

"No."

He took off the other shoe and placed my foot on the cold tiles.

"You'll never end up like me."

I didn't believe him. I knew he was lying.

His hand was still bleeding, but he didn't care.

I tore off a chunk of my dress that had already been hanging by a thread anyway and took his hand.

I placed his hand in my lap and bound it up silently.

I got up to walk to the mirror.

What I saw there shocked me to the core.

Half my face was red and swollen, like I had some kind of horrifying hives. My left eye was swollen shut and I still couldn't open it.

Was my eyeball still intact in there?

My lower lip was split, a dried-up red streak went from my nose to my chin.

Makeup was smeared across my face.

My face looked like I stood a few rounds in an UFC fight. And only the blue fingerprint bruises all over my neck told the real story.

The dress lost all its allure. It was no longer as delicate and flowy as I remembered.

It turned into a rug. The top was torn up, a piece of it now tied around Eric's hand. The rest of the dress was stained with wine and looked blood-covered.

I shuddered.

Eric stood right behind me all this time, watching my reaction.

Our eyes met and he calmly unzipped it, letting the dress slide to the floor.

I took a deep breath. The dress stopped feeling light a long while ago. It was more like a chain mail now.

My gaze fell on my body.

Large red blood vessels showed me a morbid map of all the bruises I had yet to see. A few spots were already showing blue.

My look reminded me of a defaced painting.

I reached for the band-aid on my shoulder and ripped it off. I stifled moan left my lungs.

I smirked.

"The stitches didn't come apart."

I didn't know why I was so happy about it.

My gaze rose to the reaper as he undid the last button on his shirt and threw it aside.

My heart skipped a beat and began picking up the pace.

My eyes explored his body, looking at his scars.

I turned to face him, not even hiding my curiosity anymore.

The scars were both big and small. Some looked like gunshot scars, others were probably there from various knife wounds or stabbings with some other sharp objects.

For a moment I felt like I wasn't alone in this.

Reaching behind my back, he unclasped my bra with one sweep of his hand and it fell down loosely.

My heart beat rapidly in my chest as I stared into his bottomless eyes.

He leaned in to take my underwear off. His eyes never left mine.
He took my hand and led me to the shower.
Every little movement reverberated through my body with sharp pain.
He checked the water and pulled me under the warm streams of water.
The water felt nice, but there's no way I could relax with him around.
Taking a washcloth and shower gel, he began to lather me up.
"Your hand's gonna get wet."

My voice was hoarse and my throat felt sore from all the screaming I'd done that night.

He stayed quiet, coating my collarbones with soap.

"I can wash myself."

"I didn't say you can't."

I had no strength left to fight him, and I gave up without a fight.

"Raise your right hand."

He slid the washcloth along one of my arms. Then did the same to the other one.

There was nothing sexual about his touch. His movements were earnest and caring.

I watched his deeply focused face.

I allowed myself to let go of everything brewing inside of me. I allowed my eyes to wander his body to get away from my stifling thoughts.

His eyes were fixed on my stomach as he gently lathered it up.

I wanted to see him smile. A smile would've made him look less tense than he did.

His hair got wet and began to curl up. He brushed it back.

The splashes looked almost cinematic. I watched in awe as they flew every which way.

Tiny drops went on to languish on his eyebrows, cheeks and lips, ready to run down.

He swallowed and I saw his Adam's apple bob up and down.

His arms were buff, his torso looked chiseled.

I watched as the drops trickled down, getting lost under his belt.

I shamelessly stared at his scars and was about to bring my fingers to touch them when I hastily pulled my hand back.

Feeling his gaze, I looked up and met his eyes.

Did he notice me ogling him?

I quickly looked away.

“You don’t have to worry about it. Look as much as you want.”

I saw a shadow of a smile on his face.

I didn’t notice I began fiddling with my fingers the way I always did.

“I got hit on the head. It has some unfortunate consequences, as you can see.”

His smile grew wider.

“If you say so. Turn your back to me.”

I swallowed and did as he said.

“You’re too good at this, which means you must be doing it all the time. So...”

“You’re the first.”

I turned back to him with a smile.

“Why are you lying?”

“Why are you jealous?”

I looked away.

He crouched down.

“Put your left foot on my leg.”

“Why?”

“I want to wash all of you.”

“He didn’t do that.”

I didn’t know why I told him that. I felt uneasy. Both my body and my head were buzzing. My emotions got garbled up and I couldn’t tell them apart. I didn’t understand what was happening.

He raised his eyes to look at me.

“Doesn’t matter. I want to wash you. May I?”

I nodded my head slightly and did as he said without another word.

I lost my balance for a moment and grabbed his broad shoulders to steady myself.

He didn’t react and I quickly pulled my hands away.

“It was an accident.”

“Sure it was.”

He poured shampoo into his hands and began to lather my hair up, massaging my scalp.

All of it seemed wrong, way too intimate.

His movements felt relaxing and I closed my eyes.

He stood too close as he rinsed the shampoo off of my hair.

He stared into my eyes intently.

“Don’t look at me.”

“I like looking into your eyes.”

“Why?”

“They tell me a lot.”

“Tell you what?”

“What you’re feeling.”

He took a step closer to turn the shower off behind me.

He got close enough for his torso to brush against my nipples.

A jolt of electricity ran through me, making them hard.

He picked up a white fluffy towel and began to dry me carefully.

“Why are you doing this?”

He kept drying me, ignoring the question.

After a while, he replied,

“I don’t know how to apologize.”

Why would he want to apologize? Was he sorry? Then why did he choose to do something he’d feel sorry for?

Anger was coming back to me, sobering me up and giving me strength.

I snatched the towel from his hands, wrapped it around myself and stormed back into the bedroom.

I sat on the bed silently, struggling with the storm of emotions rising from the depths of my mind.

I heard him leave the bathroom and turn off the light.

“I want you to leave.”

I refused to look at him, staring at the white carpet instead.

He stood there, and I made myself meet his gaze.

He let his gaze dwell on me. He looked like he was about to say something, but he just turned and left the room instead.

CHAPTER 29

~~How do you know for sure you've chosen the right path? How do you know you haven't lost yourself? And if you have, how do you get yourself back? How do you avoid turning into a wild beast when living with ravenous wolves? How do you trust yourself? How do you discover yourself? How do you stay loyal to yourself? How do you stay yourself? How do I know who I really am?~~

Voices outside of my door made me open my eyes.

My right eye opened just fine, but the left one responded with a gnawing pain, chipping at my sanity like a vulture picking at a dying animal.

I went to touch it but even a light graze made me wince.

I pursed my lips and tried to sit up, leaning against the headboard. I wanted to whine and cry, but I clenched my teeth instead.

Leaning back, I began to take deep breaths, trying not to focus on the pain.

It'd pass. It's not forever.

Sana opened the door and our eyes met.

For the first time ever I could see emotions clearly on her face. The shock, confusion, bewilderment and, most likely, fear.

She quickly wiped off all emotions from her face and began setting up her things the way she always did.

"My whole body hurts," I croaked.

She looked up at me and wheeled in the IV stand without another word.

I could sense her nervousness.

Gloves, caps and syringes, everything that was usually under her full control, was now slipping from her grasp.

Wonder why she got so scared. Was she afraid of becoming an accomplice in his shady dealings? Or maybe she thought the same fate awaited her, too?

“He did this.”

Her hand paused for only a couple of seconds before piercing my skin with the needle.

“He wasn’t the one beating me, specifically. But he did everything to make sure it happened. He wanted me dead.”

I whispered the last sentence and shuddered.

Did he really want to kill me?

I didn’t know.

Maybe he just needed the necklace.

Then why did he let it fall to the floor like a useless trinket? A trinket that nearly cost me my life.

I remembered regret in his eyes when he saw me. That expression would be hard to forget since he rarely showed any emotion other than anger.

“Aren’t you afraid he’d do the same to you?”

She said nothing.

“He doesn’t care about people. They’re nothing but tools for him. I’d be afraid of working for a man like that. A monster. Because you can never be safe around him.”

She kept filling the syringe.

“He’s evil. How can you work for him?”

She examined my body, ignoring my words like she couldn’t hear me.

“I don’t know, how long I’ve left until he decides my life’s of no use to him anymore.”

I grabbed her hand.

“Sana, please, help me. All I need is...”

“I can’t help you.”

The pain in my chest felt like her words slashed my heart with a scalpel.

“But why?”

“I work for him because he pays for my son’s treatment. My son has been in a coma for almost 8 years.”

She raised her hazel eyes to look at me.

“They were best friends at the university. Eric decided to pay for his treatment himself, asking for nothing in return. But I’m not that kind of person. I wanted to repay him. He didn’t want to hear it, but I kept coming here every day, begging him to hire me. I couldn’t sit around and wait. I wanted to help my son somehow.”

My throat felt dry and I swallowed my saliva, wincing in pain.

“I always knew what his family did. I simply didn’t care. Because when your son is lying there like a vegetable, the only thing you can do, other than give in to the endless pity party and suicide ideations, is to start working to try and restore faith in at least something in this world.”

I didn’t take my eyes off her.

“I’ll stay by his side for the rest of my days, no matter what. I know I could never pay him off. I’ll be in debt to him even in my next life. He might be true evil to you, but to me he’s a savior, the kindest man the world has to offer.”

She looked away and began collecting her things while I watched her.

I felt my steely conviction shaken by a whirlwind of new information. I began to doubt not only who Eric was, but everything I so eagerly believed in.

I could never imagine that someone who’s willing to kill without mercy would care about someone else’s life. That he actually gave a damn. That he had some kind of values. Maybe even morals?

He’s the villain in my story, but is he really that bad?

He told me I didn’t know him well. Now a faint desire to get to know him better awoke in me. I wanted to see all sides of him. Wanted to know who I was fighting against.

When Sana left, Marta knocked on the door. She brought me a tray of food. With a gasp, she dropped it to the floor.

I saw fear and shock distort her face as she left the room, her quick steps ringing in the hall.

Her reaction was hardly a surprise, since the entire left side of my face looked like a bloated slab of purple meat, and my bloodshot eye wouldn’t even open.

My neck showed a purple collar from the hands that tried strangling me. My nose was swollen. And I didn’t even want to talk about the rest of my body. I was barely recognizable, surely.

I spent the whole week in bed, struggling to get to the bathroom and back.

It hurt to breathe. Hurt to swallow. Hurt to lie down. Hurt to move. Things I was used to became a luxury.

I envied my past self, remembering how easily I did my routine tasks without paying them any mind.

I woke up every morning, thinking, “Is it over yet?”

The pain would get worse at dawn, as if the sun was bringing it with its rays, punishing me for the sins of the past long forgotten.

I was supposed to feel better, but the relief never came.

Nightmares haunted me, tormenting me every night.

Every night I would find myself in that room. His hands would strangle me every night. Those red eyes would stare at me night after night. And every night I would die.

Sana offered me sleeping pills, but I was afraid I'd not be able to wake up from the nightmares and would actually die.

I believed it was a real possibility.

Nightmares ate away at me, robbing me of sleep. At night I would wake up screaming, covered in sweat.

Marta brought me food like clockwork. She looked at me with the kind of sympathy I'd not seen in a long while.

One night, she took a seat next to me, closed her eyes and read a prayer.

I was moved by the gesture, even though I wasn't religious myself. I didn't know what I believed in, or whether I had any faith left at all. But I was glad to see someone actually cared for me in this cold prison.

I'd finished my dinner and put the tray aside when I heard a knock on the door.

It wasn't Marta. I told her she didn't have to knock anymore.

The door opened and Norman walked in.

He stood in the door, watching me silently.

I wasn't happy to see him.

He cleared his throat.

"You can take a sit, if you want."

He looked at the armchair and nodded.

He sat down, still not saying a word. This was beginning to piss me off.

"Did you come to sit around in silence?"

"No. I wanted to ask. Do you need anything?"

"No."

"How are you feeling?"

"Like shit."

He sat there, nodding his head, looking at the floor.

What difference did my state make to him?

I was still mad at him for telling the reaper about the note. But I was also mad at myself for being so naive. It was my fault he found out about it.

“Why are you here?”

“I came to see how you’re feeling.”

“Now you know. Anything else?”

“How’s your face?”

I raised an eyebrow, despite the pain.

“You can see that yourself.”

“I heard you have nightmares.”

“Did Marta tell you?”

He nodded.

“Yes. I do.”

“About what?”

I frowned.

“What’s in it to you? Why did you come here asking me about it?”

“I wanted to see how you’re doing. Can’t I?”

“Not after you told the reaper of the note I left for Bell. Now he knows about her, thanks to you. So no, Norman. You can’t ask how I’m doing.”

He kept nodding his head.

I was fighting the urge to tell him to get lost.

“Fair enough.”

I sighed audibly.

“Norman.”

“Yes.”

His eyes looked at me expectantly.

“Close the door behind you.”

He nodded a few times, still deep in thought. Finally, he got up and left.

I fixed my blanket angrily.

He doesn’t give a crap about me, just like everyone else in this house. Why did he come? What’s with the sudden curiosity? What was he going to do with this information?

My hands froze.

Norman wasn’t asking for himself. He’s asking for Eric.

But why didn’t he come to see me himself? Was he so busy, he sent one of his henchmen to do the job for him? Maybe he wanted to see if I was well enough to be sent to my next tormentor?

Or he’s just a coward. He was afraid of seeing me himself because I evoked the emotions he clearly wasn’t used to feeling.

Maybe he didn't want to see me because he was repulsed by me. Looking at me now was not for the faint of heart, after all.

I didn't know what kind of a man he was.

I saw the regret in his eyes. He didn't get mad when I stabbed him with the scissors.

He shielded me. Didn't let me harm myself.

He said, he didn't want me to die. He washed me with such care. He really did regret this.

Last time I saw him, I told him to leave my room.

Did this mean he didn't want to hurt me? He wanted to know how I was, but didn't want to upset me? Was this his way of looking after me? Did he care about me?

This was insane.

I closed my good eye, trying to fall asleep, but when I felt myself dozing off, my eye shot open once again.

Maybe he's looking for forgiveness? But what would he need my forgiveness for? He didn't need it. What did he want then?

I turned my head to look at the clock.

It was one in the morning.

I got out of bed and decided to go downstairs to the kitchen to have some water.

Thoughts about Eric were swirling around in my head on my way there.

I froze when I got to the door.

In the moonlight, I saw Eric pouring himself a glass of water from a clear decanter.

He was clad only in dark blue pajama pants with a black checkered pattern.

I could see every muscle moving on his back despite his slight movements.

I was about to turn around and leave quietly when I saw him freeze.

He slowly turned to face me and our eyes met again for the first time after all those weeks.

His obsidian eyes looked dark as night.

They didn't look as dark as I remembered them.

They no longer scared me.

His gaze was intense. I wanted to look away, but then I realized it was just a habit of mine. I didn't really want to.

I felt my whole body tense up as my emotions turned into a knot of incomprehensible feelings.

The air felt saturated with something here. It was as if it'd transformed under his pressure. Like it was on his side.

His eyes slid lower. He looked me over languidly, moving from my face down to my body and legs.

I was wearing a grey cotton T-shirt and short shorts. The pajamas were clinging to my body.

I felt the growing tension, but there was no fear behind it this time.

I let my gaze slide over his body just as brazenly.

His raven black hair was tousled.

He saw me looking at him and he began to drink slowly, never taking his eyes off mine.

I watched his throat bob up and down. Watched as the water spilled and ran down his chin, neck, chest and abs.

I swallowed hard.

Finishing his glass, he filled it again and walked up to me.

"Open your mouth."

His gruff whisper made my heart race.

I opened my mouth.

He placed his thumb on my chin, tilting my head back slightly.

He began slowly pouring water into my throat. I grabbed his bicep to let him know I needed a break.

I saw his jaw clench and relax.

His eyes looked restless.

I couldn't read the feelings behind them.

"I can drink on my own."

"I know," he said under his breath.

I opened my mouth and tilted my head back.

The smile on his face grew wider. It sent a pleasant sensation through me.

He kept pouring the water into my mouth until it was gone.

A tiny trickle of water leaked from the corner of my lips and ran down my chin and neck.

Two of his fingers brushed my collarbone and I flinched.

They went from my neck to my chin.

He slid them up until they touched my lips. His fingers slowly stroked my lower lip, as if smearing the water over it.

My breathing was heavy and I couldn't understand what was happening.

Pulling his hand away, he began to leave careful, feather touches on the left side of my face with the pads of his fingers.

His eyes took in every detail of my face, and I remembered how ugly it was now.

I put my chin down.

He gently lifted my chin with his thumb and index finger.

"Stop hiding from me."

"I'm ugly."

"Ugly and you will never mean the same thing. You're the most beautiful girl the world has ever seen. That I've ever seen."

My heart skipped a beat.

I placed my hand on his chest.

I wanted to make sure he still had the heart Sana told me about.

It was beating. Thumping almost as hard as my own was.

I licked my lower lip.

My hand grazed his abs, moving down to his groin.

I was about to go lower, but he grabbed my hand. I felt like someone threw a bucket of cold water at me. Only now did I realize what I'd done.

Shame showed on my flushed cheeks as anxiety took me over.

Avoiding his gaze, I pulled my hand out of his grip and ran out of the kitchen.

I ran into my room like my feelings and thoughts were chasing me.

Why did I do that? I shouldn't have touched him. This was Eric. The reaper. My face's disfigured, mom's in a coma, four girls were dead and Bell was in danger because of him.

He wasn't a good man, and never would be. He was a murderer and a criminal. And people like him might have had days when they did some good things, but did that make them good? Never.

He was the evil trying to break and change me.

Flowers wither as he passes. His hands are elbow deep in blood. His soul belongs to darkness.

I had to run from him, not towards him. I had to fight, not let him touch me.

It didn't matter, how handsome he was on the outside. Because inside of him was a dark world, filled with pain, devastation and suffering.

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CHAPTER 30

~~Disturbing things find a home in my head. Sometimes they scare me so much, it feels like they've happened already. Like I had to do something, hurry somewhere or decide something because of them. Sometimes I feel like it's already too late. How much do I believe the things in my head?~~

My hands were shaking as I sat there, waiting for my phone to charge. Just a little more, and I'd hear dad's voice. I'd tell him everything. They'd have a chance to escape.

Once they'd be safe again, dad would call me and I'd run away from here.

I'd wake up early and take the first bus. There'd be stops on the route, I'd buy a ticket to another bus, so Eric wouldn't track me down.

I'd leave the reaper, his purgatory, the nightmares and all my past behind.

I'd bury the memories and never go back to them.

I would find peace and tranquility. I would learn to live again.

We'd move to another city, maybe even another country. We'd hide for a while and start our life anew. I'd find a job. I'd try everything that sparks even the slightest interest in me. I'd stop wasting time and whining. I'd start doing more and appreciating what I did. I'd find myself. I could fill that empty, lonely part of me that aches like an open wound. I would be happy. I was sure I would.

And if I suddenly decided that my life was terrible, I'd come to the place I'd buried the memories at and stand there for a while. And then I'd return to my life again, ready to appreciate every moment, every breath, every smile, every kind word. I'd learn to appreciate life.

While everyone was asleep and Norman was doing his night patrol, I snuck into his room and took his charger. He might notice it gone and barge

in looking for it any minute. Or he might go to sleep and realize it's gone only in the morning.

I tried not to think about it, although I sat quietly and tried to listen for any noise outside the door.

I felt anxiety trying to get the better of me. It's like a spasm that cramps you up and then releases, slowly driving you crazy.

The phone screen lit up and I dialed the number.

I heard the dial tone.

"Hi, sweetie."

"Hi, dad."

My eyes were filled with tears.

"I called the number we last spoke on, but it was unavailable."

"Dad?"

"Yes?"

"Are there any good news?"

A heavy sigh was heard on the other end.

"I sold my car and our wedding bands this week."

He stopped, waiting for any questions, but I kept listening.

"I won't go into medical terms. I'm fed up with them myself. The thing is, your mother needs a year-long injection treatment. I scraped together enough money for the first two shots. I borrowed some money from my colleagues at work. I've reached out to a relief fund but things aren't going as well as I'd like. I wanted to take out a loan, but things have been going badly at work for the last six months, so it was denied. We need ten more injections. Each injection costs around six thousand dollars."

I looked at the wall. My head was empty, and my ears were ringing like I'd just been hit. Tears were streaming down my face.

Was this the end?

She couldn't just die.

No way.

She would never leave us.

She would never leave me.

"Dad?"

"Yes, sweetheart."

"I'm scared. I'm so scared."

"I know. So am I. But we aren't giving up yet. And don't even think of coming back to us now. She's always dreamed of you graduating from the

university. So focus on your studies and I'll do my best to help her."

"Okay," I whispered.

My words felt bitter.

It was my first lie.

I won't be able to do the bare minimum my mom expects of me.

"Now then, how have you been? How are your studies?"

"It's alright."

I tried to swallow the lump in my throat, but it got stuck.

"Not much to tell there. Going to classes, doing homework. Just a Groundhog Day."

Another lie.

I could feel it crush my heart.

"And your friends? Do you see them often? How's Bell doing?"

My jaw began shaking. I was holding back tears.

"Bell's okay."

The third lie.

Just as disgusting, sticky and tar black as the mire I was now drowning in.

"Stay safe, Zoe. Don't strain yourself and call me some time."

"I will," I replied pensively.

I covered my mouth with my hand, feeling like I couldn't control my breakdown.

"Dad, kiss mom for me."

"I will, honey. Take care. And call me. I miss you."

"I'll call... and I miss you, too... so much."

The call ended and I fell face down into the pillow to muffle my screams.

I screamed until my vocal cords hurt.

I continued to sob until my sobs turned into weeps, and my weeps turned into a ringing silence.

I woke up at lunchtime and went to the bathroom. My eyes were red and I could see two large dark circles underneath.

I began looking my body over.

The bruises changed color from blue to greenish yellow. They were no longer aching, though they kept my body looking ugly.

If I couldn't be saved, at least my family should be. I'd get the money. I'd do anything to get it. She would not die. She would live.

Yesterday's pity left with the dawn, anger taking its place.

I liked the anger. It was productive. It made me stronger. Made me hate. It pushed me to the edge, whispering, "Do it."

It's lunchtime. The reaper was supposed to be in the dining hall. But I didn't find him downstairs. I looked out of the window. The car was gone.

"Marta, where's the reaper... Eric gone?"

She kept kneading the dough, not looking at me.

"I'm only a housekeeper, not his secretary. How would I know where he went. Not like he reports to me."

Marta wasn't in the mood, so I tried again:

"Do you think he'd be back today? Can you call him?"

She took her eyes off the dough and gave me an annoyed look.

"Don't even think of running away. Your face's barely begun healing up. Don't make him angry."

"I'm not going to run."

She narrowed her eyes at me and turned away.

"Whatever you're up to, better quit it right now."

"How long have you been working for him?"

"From his bottle up."

"Where're his parents? Are they still around?"

"They're dead."

My thoughts went to my parents, but I pushed them aside.

She plopped the dough in a bowl, covered it with plastic wrap and stuck it in the freezer.

"What did they do?"

"Same thing he does."

She put vegetables in a large bowl and set about washing them.

"Did they get along?"

"Sometimes."

Her monosyllabic answers didn't help much.

"Has Eric always been like that?"

She glanced at me and then looked down at the vegetables on the cutting board.

"No."

"Do you think he's a good or a bad man?"

I knew the answer, but I wanted to hear it from her.

Marta huffed.

"He's neither good, nor bad. He's just a man."

Just a man.

I repeated this to myself, trying to figure out if he really was just a man, and not the evil I'd made him out to be.

"He leaves so often. Is he visiting his girlfriend?"

"No idea, but he's never brought anyone home."

"What does he..."

"Enough with the interrogation. Ask him yourself when he comes back. Now, go away from the kitchen. I can't get anything done with you."

Talking to Marta helped me learn one thing: he was away.

I walked up the stairs and turned towards his office when I heard the sound of the front door opening.

I darted towards my room and stood just around the corner, listening in on the conversation.

"How's she?"

"Came out for a chat."

"What did she ask you about?"

"You. She asked me to call you, but I told her she could talk to you herself when you come back."

"Alright."

Hearing his footsteps, I quietly opened and closed the door of my room.

I quickly climbed under the blanket and lay down with my back to the door.

He's coming. I knew it.

No. I could feel it.

All my morning anger was replaced by a thrill of excitement, and my thoughts got tangled up.

I didn't understand why the fluster I felt was so pleasant and not tormenting. I still hated him. He took my life away. Twice. And last night was the second time.

I had to talk to him when he got here. I needed money, and he had plenty.

There was a barely audible knock on the door.

I froze.

My heart was pounding in my chest, ready to burst and fall out onto the bed.

The door opened and I realized I wasn't ready.

I wasn't going to talk to him, not after he washed me, and not after I got handsy with him in the kitchen last night.

My cheeks began to burn from the memories and the overwhelming shame.

I was disgusting.

His steps pulled me out of my thoughts.

I heard him stop. I could feel his smell. It no longer felt heavy. I was beginning to like it.

The mattress sagged. His fingers gently tucked a strand of my hair behind my ear.

His fingertips brushed against my cheek, which no longer hurt, but still didn't look great.

I thought he was going to leave, but he didn't. He stayed there, sitting silently next to me.

My heart ached from how hard it was beating.

Why wasn't he leaving? Why was he still sitting there? Did he notice I wasn't asleep?

He would've spoken if he had.

I felt the mattress return to its original form.

The door closed and I turned onto my back, taking deep breath and trying to figure him out.

Why did he care?

Anger was coming back to me.

It wasn't just that he had physical power over my life that made me angry, but that he was starting to get too deep under my skin. Somewhere he had no business being at.

The next morning I got up before dawn. I wanted to go to his office and find the safe.

Leaving the room, I looked around, listening for any sounds.

I opened the door, walking in backwards and watching his bedroom door.

"Why are you sneaking in here?"

I gasped, not expecting to see him back so soon.

"I didn't want to make a fuss."

"In my office while I was away?"

Damn it.

"No."

He raised an eyebrow.

"I want to talk."

Only the warm light from a lamp on the desk illuminated the room.

He looked scary, like he'd just crept out of a crypt.

His eyes watched me intently.

"Take a seat."

Sitting down on the cold leather sofa, I realized I was wearing the same pajamas I had on the night we met in the kitchen.

I began rolling the ring.

He took his coffee, stood up and calmly walked over to the reddish-brown leather chair, sitting down opposite me.

The setting felt like a deal with the devil. And it was, really.

He sat down and took a sip of his coffee. I shifted on the couch under his gaze, flustered by the memories and what I was about to offer him.

"What do you want to talk about?"

I looked up at him and opened my mouth to speak, only to close it almost immediately.

I should've written my speech down on a piece of paper, because right now my thoughts were in utter chaos.

I looked down at the ring on my left hand.

Fear and anxiety made my stomach turn.

His gaze fell on my hands.

"I want you to pay me," I blurted out in a single burst.

He smiled, placing the cup back on the table.

"Pay for what?"

His dark gaze made me feel naked and helpless before him.

"For completing your tasks. I brought you the necklace, like you told me to. I know there'll be other tasks, and I want to get paid for them."

Something flashed through his eyes when I said that.

It was so fast I didn't get to see how he felt about it.

"I want to get at least something for completing them."

"You do."

"What do I get then?"

"You have a new room with a soft bed, your own bathroom and a wardrobe filled with new things. Marta as a personal chef. Sana as your doctor. Norman and Levi as personal drivers. You can go outside and take walks around the manor. But I could chain you up in the basement, feed you leftovers and we'd see how well you hold up."

I swallowed audibly.

I looked down at the ring on my hand.

“So that’s a no?”

“No.”

“No?”

He raised his eyebrow questioningly.

All was quiet once more.

“What do you need the money for, Zoe?”

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CHAPTER 31

~~Regretting the past has become my daily routine. I like to think about how I could've acted, what I could've said. I like to imagine what people would say to me, how they'd react. I like the power I have over them.~~

I didn't want to tell him the truth. I was ready to come up with anything just to avoid talking about the shitty situation my family and I found ourselves in.

I didn't want him to have control over my despair. I didn't want to give up the tiny piece of hope and freedom I lost after talking to dad. I stubbornly wanted to keep it to myself, hide it and never let anyone know it.

But the more I thought about it, the more I realized that I was holding on to an illusion. It was just wishful thinking. It gave me a place to hide.

Because I was too afraid of coming to light. I was scared to admit I was stuck here for good. Scared of my life never being the same again. Of being broken day after day as I silently pick myself up and keep going. But for how long would I have the strength to get up? How long could I go on? And was there a point in this? Maybe it's easier to end it all?

I felt a lump of tension and didn't try to swallow it.

"I know I won't get away from you or return to my old life and my family."

"Glad you're acknowledging it."

I squeezed my finger until it hurt.

"So the money I want aren't for an escape."

"Glad to hear that."

I raised my head and met his eyes.

"I need money to graduate. My father's probably got my upcoming expulsion letter already. This means he's not gonna pay for the next semester, and I'd like to keep attending classes. If you allow me, of course."

That was a lie.

To a degree.

Dad had paid for the university long ago, but he was going to get the letter soon, anyway.

Why hadn't anyone called him yet?

"I'll think about it."

"Really?"

Hope rekindled within me.

"No."

And it's gone.

"Why?"

"Don't feel like it."

"But you can trust me. I promise I won't hang out with anyone. I'd study remotely, attend classes online and do homework."

He stayed silent.

I could argue that I was bored of living in the manor, but I had a hunch he'd make sure I could only dream of quiet times around here then.

"You have tons of money. It won't make you any poorer."

He frowned and took a sip of his coffee.

"It's not about the money, Zoe."

"What is it then?"

"The problem is that I still haven't heard your real motive to get my money."

I lowered my gaze to the ring and pursed my lips.

I began spinning it quickly, trying to think about what I was going to say. Doubts were eating me alive. My thoughts were pushing me from one extreme to another.

Everything inside me rejected the idea, but I knew I had to do it.

I promised myself I'd save her. I'd do anything I can and then some. But at that moment I was ready to swallow my own tongue.

I kept quiet and gathered my courage, because the next thing I'd say was going to taint my soul forever. There'd be no going back.

This was the starting point, the moment that'd send me into the hellfire to burn for eternity. This was something I could call a deal with the devil.

"I need sixty thousand dollars. And I only have one thing to offer to you. I want to exchange it for the money."

"What do you need the money for, Zoe?"

He was getting angry.

“My mom’s treatment.”

“And what can you entice me with?”

“Myself.”

His eyebrows shot up and he burst into laughter.

I kept rolling the ring nervously, ignoring the pain.

I felt like I was being publicly shamed for doing something dumb.

Once he was done, he rested his elbow on the armrest and propped his chin on his knuckle.

“I’m not attracted to you, Zoe. You aren’t my type.”

I opened my mouth and frowned slightly.

Really?

Perhaps I misunderstood his touches and compliments. That means, they were nothing to him. Now I knew why he took my hand away that night.

It’s good that he didn’t feel anything for me, because it’s mutual. This meant we could easily make a commodity-money exchange and go our separate ways without consequences.

He kept watching me intently.

I saw daylight fill the room bit by bit, taking with it the ominous atmosphere.

“But I’ll give your offer a thought.”

I looked up at him.

“Someday.”

That means never.

Disappointment was slowly creeping in.

The phone rang and he picked up.

I thought it was the perfect time to get out of his humiliation room.

The conversation took too much of my energy, leaving me feeling empty.

Before I knew it, a week had passed.

The weather was abnormally warm for Fall that day. The sun decided to bless us with its rays after months of murky weather.

I spent the whole day lying in bed, letting my thoughts gnaw at my psyche. I was thinking about how stupid and pathetic I sounded a week ago. Why couldn’t I get to his safe first, and then ask for money? Now he wouldn’t leave the safe unattended.

Not the safe, not the money or jewelry, nothing at all.

I’d shown him my weakness, and now all I could do was wait for him to take advantage of it.

The sun blurred my vision. I sighed heavily and set out to get dressed.
I went downstairs and was about to open the door when Marta ran out from her room.

“Where do you think you’re going?”

“For a walk.”

She gave me a suspicious look.

“Don’t wander off too far. The dinner’s about to be ready.”

I gave her a nod and stepped outside.

Soft, warm breeze, the kind you can only get in spring, greeted me.
Toasty rays embraced my face and clothes, sharing their warmth with me.

I walked towards the woods, feeling their call. It’s like they wanted me to go deeper, to escape and find freedom.

As I was walking, I imagined how I’d run away from here, where I’d run, what I would do.

These thoughts made my pulse race, but the invisible shackles were too heavy for me to give in to my feelings.

I walked for so long I didn’t notice how I got to the rotten fence.

The place where my life changed forever.

I was about to climb over the fence and had already thrown one leg over when a large raindrop fell on my forehead.

I looked up at the sky and noticed the clouds had thickened, the sunlight merely a memory now.

I pulled my leg away and headed back to the manor.

I could hear the rumble of distant thunder. Day looked more like night.

Leaving the grove, I saw Eric’s car.

My heart began beating faster before returning to its usual rhythm.

A sudden heavy rain began to fall, like a wall of water crushing down on the ground.

The cold drops soaked my clothes up, chilling me and sending pleasant goosebumps all over my body. I wanted to stay and enjoy it.

Everyone’s afraid of the rain. That meant I was here alone. I was free.

I looked up to the sky, closed my eyes and enjoyed the drops falling on my face.

I wanted it to wash away all the memories. I wanted to forget everything, be reborn and turn into a nobody.

I stood there, savoring the moment of freedom this Fall rain gave me.

I forgot how amazing it was to be free.

For just a few seconds, only a few moments, I allowed myself to imagine what my life would have been like, had I not met Eric. Had my mom been okay. Had no one raided my university. Had Justin still been alive.

I took the damp, earthy air deep into my lungs, as if my impossible dreams could come true.

I smiled at them and this magical rain.

I began shivering as I opened my eyes. All my clothes clung to my body like a second skin.

It got cold, and I ran back to the manor.

Marta hadn't turned the lights on yet, which means she wouldn't scold me for the wet marks on the floor.

I entered my room and headed to the bathroom, only turning the light on in there.

My hair stuck to my face and neck. Water was dripping off it.

The long sleeve was wet and the fabric over my chest became transparent. My pants felt so gross I wanted to take them off right away.

I unbuttoned and dragged them off of me.

A chill ran down my spine. I felt like someone was watching me. I could sense it.

I looked up at the mirror, peering into the darkness of the bedroom behind me, and saw him.

Eric sat in the chair, staring back like the darkness was quietly creeping up on me.

My heart picked up the pace.

Had he thought my offer over? Was it going to happen?

Right now?

His eyes slowly looked me over. It's like he was seeing me for the first time.

I pulled off my long sleeve and dropped it on the floor, not looking away even for a moment.

Water was dripping from my hair, leaving wet trails on my skin.

I slowly turned and walked towards him.

I stopped by his knees, leaving a small distance between us.

I saw his jaw clench. His whole body tensed up.

His eyes followed the drop as it ran down my neck and collarbone, stopping on my nipple.

He jumped to his feet and I took a step back.

My heart was pounding, waiting for him to take the first step.

The tension in my abdomen twisted like a ball of snakes, making my breathing get shallow.

He placed his warm index finger on my neck. Goosebumps swept me over like a sea wave, running from my neck to my feet. I could feel my quick pulse thumping against his fingertip. He slid it down my neck. His touch made my nipples hard and sore.

I closed my eyes, breathing heavily.

He kept running his finger along my collarbone, moving to my chest. He pulled away before it reached the nipple.

A shadow of regret lurked inside of me, but I cut the loathsome feeling off immediately.

I opened my eyes and saw a smug grin on his face.

Confusion and shame became intertwined within me.

“You aren’t gonna sleep with me?” I whispered.

He shook his head slowly.

“Am I that disgusting to you?”

His face twisted in pain, as if my words had brought it upon him.

“Do you want me to beg you?”

His expression was unreadable.

With a nervous sigh, I got on my knees. Fear coursed through my veins.

I reached for his belt, trying to hide my shaking hands.

“Get up.”

I hesitated, but got up.

I looked at the floor, too afraid to meet his gaze.

He went to the bathroom, came back with a towel and wrapped it around me.

“Don’t pity me.”

“I don’t pity you.”

“Why did you bring the towel then?”

“You’re shivering.”

Silence hung in the air and I dared to break it.

“If you didn’t come here to sleep with me, why are you here?”

My gaze met his.

He frowned, looking at my shoulder.

When his eyes met mine, he gave me a distant, cold look, as if I was the most annoying person he’d ever met.

“This was a mistake.”

With that, he left the room, closing the door behind him.

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Part II

Tenebrae cordis

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CHAPTER 32

~~Hidden desires are calling for me, but all I can hear is an echo. I'm not prepared to face them in the daylight. I welcome them under the veil of night. I'll drown in my dreams, and two shall be one.~~

I was looking at my reflection in the mirror intently. Bruises no longer covered my neck like weeds in a garden. It no longer hurt to eat, walk, get dressed or lie on a pillow.

The bruises healed, but the smothering memories were fresh as ever.

My nightmares didn't back out. Now I wasn't the only one being tormented. My family, Bell, everyone I know would get tortured in my nightmares.

The deep wound on my shoulder skinned over, leaving an ugly scar behind. A scar reminding me that I was robbed blind.

My life, my family and my future were stolen from me.

I wanted the unseen wounds to heal, too.

My hand slid from my neck to my chest. Memories of last night ran through me like a bullet sinking into my heart.

I saw blood rushing to my face. A gentle blush was showing.

Shame and anger consumed me.

For a second I thought of breaking the mirror to get away from the vision of this backstabbing expression.

I couldn't risk getting any new scars, so I sighed heavily and crawled back into the warm bathtub.

Why did he refuse to sleep with me? Why did he tell me it was a mistake? What was his problem? Did he think I was beneath him?

Maybe he simply enjoyed degrading me. He got off on the power he had over me.

He wanted to show he could refuse what was offered to him. He'd take something when he wanted it.

He's in charge. He got to decide what happened next. He'd never share his power, be it something major or the most minute matter in the world. He didn't like anyone else gaslighting or controlling him. He reserved that role for himself.

We haven't seen each other for almost two weeks. The man could kill my mood even when he was nowhere near me.

Suddenly I no longer felt like taking a bath. I did want to find the safe in his office, though.

I dried myself off and put on a clean shirt and panties.

I looked out the window and didn't see his car.

I have some time to check every corner of his office.

I didn't waste time drying my hair. This was going to be my cop-out. If he came back and caught me sneaking about, I'd tell him the hot water's out and I wanted to warn him about it.

Draping the towel around my neck, I headed to his office.

As I laid my hand on the door handle, my gaze fell on the door to his bedroom.

I gripped the handle, contemplating where I should go next, his office or the bedroom.

Whenever he came back, he usually went to his office. He rarely slept in his room. Maybe I could find something valuable in there.

I walked to the door to his room and put my ear against it.

Silence.

I pulled the handle and stepped in.

His tantalizing, heavy scent invaded my nostrils. The whole room smelled of him, like he was right there beside me. The thought sent a thrill of anticipation through me, his scent making me feel lightheaded.

His room was dark and spacious. Deep blue wallpaper on the walls. A gray carpet on the floor. The varnished bed frame was jet-black as well.

I wondered what his favorite color was. Was it green?

His tall bed with dark silver linens was carefully made.

The bedposts had no tester. Dark gray nightstands were placed on either side of the bed.

Everything looked minimalistic and oppressive at the same time. My vision craved for more color, more furniture. This was too barren and

gloomy for me.

No wonder he's so weird. Anyone'd go mad living in this purgatory of a room.

This bedroom suited him perfectly, though. There was an air of grim mystery to it.

I sat on the bed.

It was so tall, my legs were dangling from the side and couldn't even touch the floor.

I jumped when I saw myself in the mirror.

A large mirror extended from floor to ceiling.

All the air escaped my lungs when I saw the painting in the reflection. It was the one, The Dark Cloud. It was hanging over his bed.

I remembered how much he wanted it. I couldn't even imagine paintings costing that much. Roosevelt gave an arm and a leg to get it.

He sold...

All my thoughts vanished the second I heard the sound of the door handle rattling.

The handle turned down and he entered the room.

My heart was racing like crazy.

I knew it was him. My body knew when he was close-by.

I didn't look at him. I froze.

That was the perfect time for me to tell him, why I was sitting on his bed. But fear paralyzed both my body and my voice.

I could hear the rustling of his clothes as he came closer, now standing right in front of me.

It took everything I had in me to lift my eyes and look at him.

He was clad in a gray shirt with a few buttons undone at the top, and a black suit jacket with a white handkerchief peeking out from the breast pocket.

His eyes were no longer hidden behind an icy mask. They were burning with peculiar hatred, the likes of which I've never seen in him before.

I could see his chest rise and fall at a rapid pace.

My anxiety reached its peak but didn't turn into dread.

His muscles tensed, straining the freshly ironed shirt as he slowly got down, looking me in the eye.

He knelt before me and I leaned back mindlessly, resting on my trembling hands.

His wild eyes looked ready to hurt or kill me. They were as black as his soul.

His eyes entranced me, how else could I explain, why I didn't move an inch?

His hands gently caressed my hips. His touch felt raw and sent waves of burning excitement throughout my body.

He slowly pulled my lace panties off. He let it slide freely down my legs, hanging off my right foot.

I was breathing through my mouth. My face was flushed. My body was on fire.

My pulse skyrocketed as his face came closer to my wet, throbbing core.

I opened my mouth, trying to take in more air. My chest rose and fell rapidly, but I could barely breathe. It's like there was no more air. Only him. I was breathing him in.

With his eyes glued to mine, he ran his soft, wet tongue over my clit.

I threw my head back, letting out a hoarse, lewd moan I'd loathe myself for later. A wave of pleasure washed over my body, but didn't engulf me just yet.

He slid his hands under my buttocks, cupping them and pulling me to the edge of the bed, closer to him.

His wet tongue twirled, pressed and entered me harder, driving me insane and delirious with lust.

I couldn't think straight. Couldn't breathe.

Arousal overwhelmed me with increasing force every time he touched me. The waves grew stronger. His eyes bore into me with a fierce, animalistic intensity as he devoured me like an insatiable beast.

I looked up and saw our reflection in the mirror.

I stared into my own half-lidded eyes. I saw a soft blush on my cheeks, my damp hair clinging to my face.

His black suit jacket was pulled tight, the outline of the hard muscles on his back showing through the fabric. His powerful hands squeezed and released my butt.

I felt like I was about to become one with the waves, whether I liked it or not.

I was ready to drown. Fade away. Burn away.

He pulled his tongue out of me, running it from the bottom to the very tip of the clit, and I cried out as my mind plunged into the depth of thrilling

arousal and ecstasy.

I fell on my back, closing my eyes and pulling my knees up.

I sank deeper and deeper, going down fast. I felt like I was breaking down. New sensations ravaged my body, mind and soul. They set me free.

Before I had time to collect myself and grasp everything, I felt the touch of his hand. He moved it up and down, gently stroking my breasts and stomach through my cotton T-shirt.

I began to blink my eyes lazily when he suddenly grabbed me by the waist and pulled me towards him.

As soon as my feet touched the fluffy carpet, I felt how rubbery they got.

I stood there, disoriented, as he took my hands and placed them on the bedpost. He tied them up with a white silk scarf. I tried to move them, but they were tied fast.

Anxiety began to climb and drag me back to earth, reminding me that I was tied up and posed without my underwear.

He pressed his body against me and I could feel how hot he was.

His body heat seeped through his crisp shirt, passing on to me and sending a new surge of pleasure my way. Now I could clearly hear his heavy breathing.

His warm fingers caressed my cheek. He tucked a strand of hair behind my left ear and whispered,

“Your pussy is the sweetest thing I’ve ever tasted in my whole damn life.”

I felt my walls tighten at the sound of his deep, intoxicating voice. I wanted to moan, but I pressed my lips to the bedpost to keep it down.

“Do you want me to go gentle or hard on you?”

“Gentle,” I whined.

“I see. Hard it is then.”

Anxiety, desire, fear and arousal became intertwined, taking away all my ability to think.

He slapped my ass and I cried out.

The stinging sensation from the slap gently merged with excitement.

The sharp pain startled me, but I wanted him to do it again.

He grabbed me by the throat and pulled me towards him, letting his erection press against my ass. The silk scarf was tied tight around my wrists, holding me in place.

“If you want more, ask for it,” he growled through gritted teeth.

I was on the verge of asking him, but my pride wouldn't let me. I'd rather die of my feelings than of shame.

I pursed my lips.

"Zoe, your stubbornness makes me wanna drive you almost to the peak and leave you here alone, just to watch your pitiful attempts to help yourself. And to see your frustrated eyes afterwards, hungry, begging for my touch. I'm ready to drive you insane."

You've been doing the same to me.

"Please," I whispered breathlessly.

"Please, fucking what?" he asked impatiently.

I bit down my tongue to stop myself.

He took his hand away from my throat and pulled my hair.

Startled, I gasped.

"Zoe, you..."

"Spank me," I blurted out.

I heard him chuckle.

His hand slid to my right buttock as he began to stroke it slowly.

"Come again?"

"Spank me."

He slapped me harder and I felt like I almost came.

My hands tugged at the binds, giving me pain.

He pulled me back, my straight arms pushing at the bedpost, my lower back arched and my butt thrusting back.

He wrapped my hair around his fist and pulled so hard it sent a warm wave to my abdomen.

Excitement was bubbling over in me like boiling water. I felt the juices covering my sensitive parts, ready to drip down my thighs.

He pulled my hair and I cried out again.

"Hold tight. It's on now."

CHAPTER 33

~~Sweet memories are there to distract you and help you escape from reality. They give us faith in the sincerity of actions and make us trust the illusions. They are my sanctuary. They become my purpose.~~

My breathing was heavy and obscenely loud. I couldn't keep it down because new emotions, a whirlwind of sensations and curiosity about what he'd do next took me over, depriving me of oxygen and common sense.

The silk scarf cut the blood flow to my hands. I could feel them getting numb.

His right hand stroked my buttock, then slowly moved to my burning, wet core.

My whole body felt raw. Every touch of his aroused me, it seemed. The sheer intensity of his gaze would have made me cum, had I been facing him.

His fingers caressed my clit. I arched my back, pushing harder against his erection. The scarf strained, cutting into my hands painfully.

He was stroking it languidly, circling around. Then he moved lower, to my aching core.

"You're so wet, *vita mea*. Do you want me that bad?"

I shook my head because my tongue wasn't listening to me and my head was spacing out.

He lightly slapped my clit and I cried out, arching my back and rubbing even harder against his hard-on.

I could no longer feel my hands.

"If you keep being this stubborn, I would take your ass instead of your pussy."

I felt a surge of anxiety, replaced by a hot wave of arousal.

My nipples got so hard it hurt.

His lips brushed against my ear and I leaned closer.

“We’ve got to learn to crawl to start walking. Didn’t you say that yourself, *vita mea*?”

What?

He entered me with two fingers and I cried out from the sharp, unfamiliar sensation, immediately moaning as his thumb began to press on my clit.

I pursed my lips, trying to keep quiet. All thoughts escaped my mind, as if I’d never even had them.

My whole body craved his touch. It screamed for his hands to go over every little part, not missing an inch.

His fingers were driving me crazy, the heat of his body, his deep breath and his overwhelming scent pushing me to the limit, making me give in and start begging for him to enter me.

My heart was pounding in my chest as my body was flushed with heat.

My arousal was so intense, it made me writhe in tantalizing pain. The bubble of ecstasy ballooned, getting bigger and bigger.

My ass was pressed against his cock as his fingers kept penetrating me. It was getting harder to breathe. My sensitive folds got used to his fingers and I no longer felt pain. All I could feel was the tsunami rapidly drawing near.

His lips came close to my ear and he whispered through my hair, “You love my fingers fucking you so much. Such a hypocrite you are, *vita mea*.”

I wanted to retort, but his fingers suddenly pulled out of me, and I gasped loudly.

“Miss me already?”

His wet fingers stroked my lips.

“I will take you to my world, but first, get a taste of your own. Open your mouth.”

I didn’t flinch as his fingers entered my mouth.

“Suck,” he ordered in a cold tone.

I yielded and began to suck, licking his fingers with my tongue. I didn’t understand how it could be so humiliating and so arousing at the same time.

“I know it feels so hot it’s hard to breathe. Your stomach’s swelling up with lust like it’s going to burst. Your heart’s racing, ready to fall at my feet. Your nipples are burning, yearning for my touch. The throbbing between your legs feels raw. I want you to remember yourself like this. I want you to remember how your body groans and calls for me. How fucking bad it

wants me. It belongs to me now. I'm the only one it's gonna cry for, and I will be the only one to sate its hunger."

With every word he said, a wave of arousal was about to overwhelm me. I took quick breaths, fighting it along with my urge to moan.

He pulled his hands away and I heard the sound of his belt unbuckling. I was on the brink of ecstasy.

He was right. The excitement was so strong it made me suffer. I wanted to feel him. I wanted him to finally quench my thirst.

I felt his tip press against my slit. He began sliding it up and down, lathering my slick juices over the swollen folds and the sensitive flesh around them.

My pulse picked up sharply and I held myself back from groaning like a madwoman.

"Do you like it?"

I didn't answer. I wasn't going to speak to him anymore. Not here and not like this.

He let his cock grind on my clit, and a telltale groan escaped my throat. I bit on my lower lip right away to shut myself up already.

"You're so hungry. I'm glad to be the first to sate your hunger."

After these words, I felt him enter me slowly and I moaned, pressing my hand to my mouth to try and muffle the sound.

"Fuck, you're so tight. I can feel your walls gripping my cock," he croaked.

This sent a new wave of searing lust down my abdomen.

Pain and pleasure were in a tug of war as his hard cock pushed through my heat, filling me.

I tried to hold back my moans, but it was a losing battle that I no longer had the strength for, and I gave in.

My knuckles turned white from gripping the bedpost so tight.

I didn't have time to get adjusted to him when he entered me roughly, and I screamed. His right hand grabbed me by the hair.

"I like hearing your sweet screams."

He entered me with renewed vigor, pulling my hair, and I cried out again.

My screams soon turned into loud moans filling the room. I felt euphoric from the immense pleasure the pain brought me.

"Louder."

He pulled out abruptly and pushed back in.

My moans got louder.

"I said, louder."

He entered me again, his thrusts rough and hard.

His groin slapping against me, my moans and his breathing made the wave rise, taking my attention away from the pain between my thighs and his grip on my hair. The pain only added spice, turning addictive. I wanted to feel it again. The pain and arousal were a crazy mix. They were a perfect match. Like good and evil. Like me and... him.

I could barely breathe. I could feel my orgasm building up. There was no way to escape or get rid of it. It was too big. I could feel it.

His lips leaned closer to my ear.

"Wanna cum?"

I didn't reply.

"You don't, then."

He pulled out of me quickly and I let out a deep moan that sounded like a frustrated wail.

He slapped my ass hard and I screamed. The burning sensation from the slap to the ass merged with surging lust, bringing out a disturbing desire to feel them together again.

His absence felt like an irretrievable loss. I wanted him back in. Wanted him to touch me. Craved his touch. My whole body ached for him faithlessly.

I threw my thoughts aside along with my pride and rasped out,

"Yes."

His grip on my hair tightened.

"Louder."

"Yes," I nearly screamed.

His right hand caressed my neck.

"I love when you beg me. Who am I to deny you, *vita mea*."

After these words he entered me roughly, and my eyes went dark from the crazy wave of desire. When I heard his low groan, I felt my walls begin to clamp up around his cock.

"Fuck, Zoe."

He growled through clenched teeth.

Arousal became unbearable. I lost control over my body and gave in, drowning under the rogue wave of much-needed release.

I felt it washing over me, making me a part of it. It took my body, until there was nothing left. I merged with him. We became one.

I felt nothing but wild ecstasy flowing all through my body. It's like I left my body and Zoe no longer existed.

It seemed to last forever. It seemed to me that these feelings would never leave. How could it be a simple deal if I enjoyed it so much?

I'd never experienced anything close to that in my life. I knew there was no way back. I would never be the same again. This was going to change me once and for all.

I caught myself craving those feelings again. It was addictive, like the hardest drug.

After an indefinite amount of time, I opened my eyes and found myself lying in the bathtub.

Eric turned the water on and I saw his gaze fall from my eyes to my chest. My nipples got hard and began to ache.

His gaze was a blazing abyss.

Why wouldn't he touch me?

My brain woke up and began fighting my body. I wanted him to leave, but I didn't. I wanted him to touch me and I didn't. I couldn't decide which side to take.

I really wanted him to wash me. At least that way I could feel his touch again.

The image of him half-naked sent a new wave of excitement down my stomach.

His abs. Strong arms.

I wanted his big hands to squeeze my breasts until it hurt. For his lips to touch my neck, kissing and biting it hungrily. I wanted to lean against his naked flesh, not the cold bathtub.

I saw him freeze, watching me. He knew about my struggle. I could see it in his eyes.

With every breath I took, my pulse got steadier and my brain began to work better.

It took me some effort to look away from him and choke up my dark desires.

I knew I'd never forgive myself if I gave in to them.

"I want you to leave."

I watched the water fill the bathtub when I heard the door closing.

My body went limp, as did my brain. My eyelids were growing heavy and the water was getting too warm.

My eyes shot open and I found myself lying in bed. My body was dry, toasty and covered with a blanket.

I had to get back to my room.

I'd leave.

I was just going to wait for him to come back.

Wait for the money.

And then I'd go back to my room.

Yes.

That's the plan.

I wouldn't stay here.

I would not sleep in his bed.

I was just going to rest my eyes for a bit, until he came back.

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CHAPTER 34

~~Does the end always justify the means? It always mattered to me. I overcame all obstacles and moved on forward. I knew I'd make it. I believed in the idea. I worked towards it. But sometimes you can put all you have into it and end up with nothing. No one will support you. No one will lend you a shoulder.~~

I slowly opened my eyes and immediately closed them because of the light peeking through the gap in the poorly drawn curtains.

The sunlight was shining straight into my eyes and I squeezed them shut, turning my back to it.

I pulled the blanket over my head and couldn't understand why it smelled so good. The smell was familiar, but I couldn't quite place it.

I took a deep breath of the enticing aroma. I wanted it to fill my lungs. I wanted to take a bath with this scent.

Why did my bed smell so good?

The realization hit me like a thunderbolt.

My eyes shot open.

I looked at the blanket clutched in my hands and quickly flung it back.

It was his scent and I was still in his bed.

My pulse picked up.

I turned to the left and didn't see him there.

Did he sleep next to me?

No. The likes of him sleep under the entrails of the earth.

I got out of bed and was about to leave, but something stopped me in my tracks. I was naked.

I turned my head and saw my white T-shirt on a chair. I pulled it on and felt liquid running down my inner thighs. I ran my hand over it and realized it was blood mixed with his semen.

Memories of yesterday flashed through my mind like beacon lights. His dirty talk, his hands, the slaps, his deep voice. I stopped the intoxicating flow of memories dead and headed to my room.

While I was taking a shower, I tried to fight off the shame and self-loathing.

I blamed myself for enjoying it. I wasn't supposed to like it. It had to be almost mechanical. I should feel disgust towards him, but I could sense a different feeling. It changed.

Hundreds of questions ran through my head, but I was only truly curious about one.

Why did he want me to cum?

He knew it was just a regular deal. I was the product, he was Mr. Moneybags. He could have done anything to my body. Could have mutilated me. Could have raped me all night. But he didn't.

He made me cum and crave him even now. He made me savor the memories, dreaming of having another chance with him.

Yesterday I realized that there was no way back not only because of the tainting of my soul, but because of the addiction he plunged me into.

I knew those weren't my desires. It's what my body wanted, and body is mindless. He couldn't be trusted.

Once I was done with the shower, I got dressed and went downstairs, to the dining room.

With every step, memories developed like frames of a film. My hands were sweating and my heart was beating wildly in my chest.

I opened the door and walked in like a puppet. My eyes stared at my feet. I could feel his eyes on me. It was like he was calling me. Wanted me to see him.

Sitting down at the table, I cursed under my breath again at how small it was.

The freshness of his alluring scent hit me hard.

I looked at the food. I took the yogurt and added fresh berries to it. I mixed it slowly and brought the spoon to my mouth.

I kept staring at my plate as if nothing had happened while a war was raging within me. My thoughts fought like rabid dogs, ready to rip each other's throats out.

I fought for what's right while my mind screamed that I'd betrayed everyone I loved and cared for. I convinced myself it wasn't my fault and

that I did it for my mom, not because I wanted it. Another voice was screaming how I enjoyed every moment of it. I responded that I was glad I could enjoy it and that the experience didn't traumatize me. The voice said it'd have been better if it had left me traumatized, rather than turning me into a rat and a slut. It asked how I'd ever be able to look my parents, my mom in the eye after this. And I told it I was never going to see them again. The voice said it served me right that I wouldn't get to see them, because murderers didn't deserve to see their loved ones.

My throat felt tight and my stomach started to curdle.

The voice wouldn't stop.

It asked, what about Justin? He killed Justin. What's it like, to sleep with a murderer? What's it like to know pleasure at the hands that took the life of your true love? What would Justin have said about it?

The voice punched me in the gut. I felt the aftertaste of my ugly actions and feelings in my mouth.

I wanted to reply that I didn't know for a fact if he was the one who killed him. But I knew I was fooling myself.

If you choose to touch the darkness, don't forget you'll become a part of it. I was so nasty, I could be placed alongside the reaper himself.

My appetite was gone, but I kept stuffing the food in my mouth.

A hard feeling bore heavily on my chest. I couldn't change the past. And I truly was sorry.

"Did you sleep well?"

I glanced up and immediately lowered my gaze back to my yogurt.

"Yes. I did," I said under my breath.

We had to get back to our normal interactions.

I hated the stench of this gross awkwardness.

"What about you?"

"Usually I don't sleep much, but your naked body pressed to mine made me stay in bed a bit longer."

Shame crushed me from within.

"I'm sorry," I whispered.

"For what? For sleeping peacefully while your body was pressed to mine?"

"You should've woken me up and kicked me out."

"I will, next time."

Was there going to be the next time?

No.

I took a sip of my tea and burned my tongue right away.

“Eric. You owe me money.”

I stared him down confidently.

“Do I? Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

“I don’t think so, Zoe.”

He took a sip of his coffee.

“We had a deal, and we settled it yesterday.”

“The thing is, there was no deal yesterday.”

I was about to open my mouth, but he beat me to it,

“Did I tell you I took your deal? That I was going to pay you? Did we sign any papers?”

I rolled the ring anxiously.

“So you just used me?”

“And you liked that.”

A smile lingered on his lips, and I hid my hands between my thighs to keep from splashing boiling water in his face.

“But I need money. I really do. And you know it.”

I tried to keep my voice flat.

“I’m willing to pay and will gladly do so if you give me a good offer. Do you have anything I might want, Zoe?”

“Yes. And I’ve already given it to you. Sex was the deal. You got what you wanted. Now give me what I want.”

“So, you’re a whore?”

He clenched his jaw.

“Excuse me?”

“Only whores get money for sex. So tell me, are you a whore, Zoe?”

He said this with such ill-concealed anger, as if it wasn’t he who had just spat in my face, but I who had insulted him.

How could he be angry?

“I’m not a whore,” I replied through gritted teeth.

Anger was boiling within me.

“We made a verbal agreement. I gave you my terms and told you why I need the money.”

“Do you want me to treat you like a whore?”

“Aren’t you doing that already when you give me away to the likes of Roosevelt?”

“Sixty grand is a lot of money. I’m willing to give you one grand every time we fuck. Now, tell me, Zoe, are you going to be my whore?”

Anger was seething inside of me, trying to find a way out. I wanted to break a plate and drive a shard deep into his black heart.

“I will be a whore,” I hissed.

“Not just a whore, but my personal whore. One I’d fuck every day, whenever and wherever I want. I’ll do anything I want and you can’t tell me *no*. Now ask me. Nicely.”

I closed my eyes and took a deep breath.

“May I be a whore?”

“No.”

I frowned.

What the hell was wrong with him?

“You didn’t say *your*. Try again. I know that sweet voice and those pouty lips of yours can do much better.”

“May I be your whore?”

“Take your clothes off.”

“What?”

“I could change my mind.”

I stood up and took off my shirt, then pulled down my pants.

I was about to slip my hand out of the bra strap when he said,

“You can keep the underwear on.”

How noble. What a true gentleman.

Marta entered the room, and I quickly sat down at the table, covering my chest with the shirt.

He looked at me with a wide grin on his face.

He was having fun. Of course. Why else would he do this if not for fun? Money no longer brought him as much joy as holding power over people’s lives would.

Not looking up once, Marta poured us coffee, cleared the plates and left.

“Does it have to be here?” I whispered.

“Oh, I want it right here.”

He took his coffee cup and pushed the table to the side.

“I want to watch you touch yourself.”

I could not believe the words I heard.

I wanted to sink through the floor and never lay my eyes on him again. Noticing my hesitation, he took out his wallet, took a wad of bills and threw them on the table.

“Motivating enough?”

He raised an eyebrow.

I didn’t know where to begin with this. What was I supposed to do?

I did touch myself, but it’s been a long while. And I’d never touched myself in front of others before.

My eyes fell on the door. Was Marta going to come again? What if she saw me like that?

I stopped thinking and slid my hand into my panties.

With a trembling hand, I rubbed my clit through the lacy underwear.

He watched me, sipping his coffee, as if it was a regular morning of an ordinary day.

“Need a hand?”

I quickly looked up at him and grabbed the bottom of the chair with my left hand.

I wanted him to stop my torment, but I didn’t want him to join in.

I closed my eyes and tried to imagine he wasn’t there.

But who should I think of, if not him?

His steamy kiss at the gala, his gaze filled with wild lust, him kneeling in front of me, his naked ripped body, his strong hands, his groans, the dirty talk, the slapping of our bodies, his fingers circling my clit.

My mouth opened, I began breathing heavily. My pulse was racing. I could feel myself blush. My panties were getting wet. Everything down below swelled up and throbbed in anticipation.

Longing for him.

“Open your eyes, *vita mea*.”

I opened them, still touching myself.

He clenched his teeth, eyeing me with a hungry look. He got hard. I could see it through his pants.

This sent a new wave of pleasure down to my wet folds.

He pulled the chair closer so that our legs were touching each other.

“I want you to look at me every time you cum.”

He leaned closer and ran his hand over my cheek, neck and chest. His hand reached under my bra, caressing and feeling my breasts. He played with my nipple and I let out a loud moan.

His warm hand sent waves of heat throughout my body.

“You’re all flushed, and so damn gorgeous, Zoe. If you don’t cum right now, I’m gonna pop it in and fuck you right on the chair.”

My hand pressed even harder and circled over my slick panties. I wanted it to happen. My body was screaming for it. My wanton pleas were ready to fall from my lips, but I held them in.

He leaned in and said,

“Cum for me.”

His words made me let out a loud moan. It echoed off the walls of the room. I came for him.

Ecstasy was spreading through my body, but it wasn’t as intense as it was yesterday. It was soft, gentle.

I quickly pulled my right hand away from my underwear, not waiting for the afterglow.

He smiled as he looked at me, and I looked down at my knees sandwiched between his.

This was so shameful, so embarrassing.

I got up and got dressed quickly.

My gaze fell on the money. I grabbed it, squeezing the cash tightly in my hand, and headed for the exit.

This wasn’t anywhere near enough. How many times would I have to sleep with him to get the sixty thousand?

Sixty times.

I’d have to sleep with him sixty times.

Two months and a day. That’s how long it would take me to earn sixty grand, provided he slept with me every day, which didn’t sound feasible.

Damn.

I needed a new plan.

CHAPTER 35

~~What lies behind a deal with the devil? A depraved soul? The impossibility of turning back the time? Or a blind desire to believe that everything will work out in the end? That forbidden fruit will bring no misery? Putting faith in the evil for selfless reasons is the same as becoming evil. You think you can handle it, that you have the upper hand. But it's already too late. Your soul's already burning, you just haven't accepted it yet.~~

The dining room was going to be swarming with crime bosses that night. We're talking mob kingpins with big money, big mouths on them and an interest in making deals.

In my circumstances, I realized only stealing could help me.

The manor had no cameras. People would leave their bodyguards outside. Small losses mean nothing to blood-stained hands.

They might not notice or care about it since they had a lot of money and only got more with each passing month.

But cash wasn't my goal. I was aiming for jewelry. Only one piece of jewelry could cover that sum and help my mom.

I hated how quiet that week was. The deafeningly quiet times unnerved me.

I slept with the lights on, placing a chair to the door.

I didn't believe peace could come into my life.

I was waiting for him. I was waiting for life to throw me into the claws of terror again at any moment.

I didn't notice when the increased heart rate, near constant desire to defend myself and fight became parts of my everyday life. Danger was everywhere, and the calm served only as a harbinger of peril.

Sleepless nights allowed me to think over my plan and various workarounds. There was little time left, and mom had even less of it.

I was standing in a dress I couldn't zip up on my own.

It was a white satin maxi dress with no sleeves, draped, with a slit to the thigh. My hair was pulled back, a couple of loose strands framing my face. The makeup was done. The only thing that's left was the lipstick.

I looked like a sculpture one could see in a museum somewhere. I hated that. I didn't want to be beautiful. Beauty was a curse. Beauty attracted a lot of attention, and in this world attention went hand in hand with suffering.

You always had to be on your guard. You could never relax and just feel beautiful.

I attempted to zip up the dress myself again. I couldn't get the slider to move and gave up.

Sitting at the vanity table, I took a matte wine-colored lipstick and began to paint my lips slowly and carefully.

Would this lipstick get smudged tonight? Would my body be covered in bruises? Would this dress be soaked in blood?

Would I survive tonight?

The goal gave me strength and calmed my trembling hands and the racing thoughts flashing through my mind.

I heard a knock on the door.

Eric walked into the room and my heart picked up its pace. This happened every time against my will. I'd love to be able to control this, but it's impossible. It's like restraining yourself from breathing. Sure, you'd be able to hold your breath, but only for a minute.

He used to evoke paralyzing, mind-numbing fear in me. And now he made me want to reach out for him as I question my own sanity.

I tried to focus only on the fear, but fear and desire seemed to be intertwined. So all I could do was ignore them and hope they'd fade out as suddenly as they flared up.

His eyes looked intently at my lips in the reflection. I pursed them into a line and rubbed them together.

His fingers touched my neck, and my whole body began to sing the telltale song of desire.

He kept stroking it and I had to hold myself from snuggling up to him. His fingers slid down my bare back to the slider, sending pleasant, tingling sensations throughout my body and clouding my mind. He zipped the dress up carefully.

He stood behind me like an angel of death, ready to take me with him into the afterlife.

I stood up and brushed against his hand with my fingertips as I was walking past him. An electric charge ran up my arm, flying straight to my heart.

I opened the closet and took out a pair of black patent-leather high-heeled shoes with red soles. They looked tall and uncomfortable. Let them be a reminder that I should never let my guard down.

I sat down on the bed and was about to pick up the shoe from the floor when Eric beat me to it. He got on one knee.

“I want to cancel our arrangement.”

His hand froze for a couple of seconds, then he slid the shoes on my feet, first on my right foot, then on the left.

My heart was thumping treacherously, sending out pleasant sensations and craving his touch as my brain was getting carried away, waiting for his response.

“Do you really?”

He lifted his head, still standing on one knee.

I stared at my hands, avoiding his gaze.

“Yes. I realized this isn’t for me. I can’t...”

“Look me in the eyes.”

I anxiously swallowed a lump in my throat and looked into the bottomless void of his dark eyes.

“Now tell me you never want to sleep with me again.”

“I... I want to end our arrangement.”

His gaze sucked all air out of my lungs.

He put his hand on my knee. He began to stroke it gently, and I felt the heat spread and grow languidly.

He stroked my leg, moving closer to my already wet underwear.

“Do you still want it?”

I didn’t understand what he was asking about because my mind was trapped in a fog while my body called out to him.

He took his hand away and kissed my knee, whispering,

“Liar.”

My breath caught in my throat and my heart skipped a beat, racing even faster.

I stood up and was about to leave when he grabbed my hand and pulled me towards him in one fell swoop.

With my left hand I pressed against his chest, trying to put some distance between our bodies.

His right hand rested on the side of my face. His lips moved closer and I closed my eyes, waiting for a kiss.

“Do you really think you mean anything?”

I opened my eyes.

“Do you think your life’s worth something? Or maybe that you have a choice, any decisions to make or a life of your own? Or that your word means anything?”

I tried to break free from his grip, but it was viselike.

“You exist, eat, sleep, walk, breathe and blink only thanks to me. Your life is my life. It belongs to me completely and entirely. You don’t have freedom. No voice. No life. You’re my shadow. You will always be by my side. You’re gonna stay with me forever.”

A tear ran down my cheek.

“I’m the one to decide when to break our contract. When to take your life. When to make you choke on your tears. When to let your blood pool on the cold tile floor. When to make you cum on my cock. When to cause you enough suffering to make you feel your soul darkening, make you question if you even have a soul left in you.”

His smile slowly grew wider and it made me furious.

“I hate you,” I spat.

I put all the anger, repulsion, and hatred I’d accumulated over all this time into my words. Those weren’t just words. Those were my sincere feelings towards him.

“But do you hate me bad enough?”

His lips touched mine and his hand held my head firmly, giving me no chance of escaping the kiss. His grip tightened as he deepened the ravenous kiss.

I bit his lip and got a taste of blood. This lit an even greater fire in him, and he began kissing me with the fury of a wild beast, devouring me greedily.

He finally pulled away and I immediately turned around, running away, trying to hold in the typhoon of emotions I loathed.

I wanted to slap and kiss him. Curse him out and get on my knees. Yell at him and get on top of him.

He caught up, pushing me into the door.

I turned around and met his furious gaze. He was ready to tear me apart, but he just squeezed my hand tightly.

As I walked down and saw the crowd, I tried to let go of his hand, hoping that he'd be more interested in talking than dragging me around.

He leaned towards me, and his deep, icy voice hissed in a half-whisper,

“Try letting go of my hand once again, and I'll fuck your face, and then your pussy in that room over there. I won't let you cum. I will fuck you for my own enjoyment, not yours, so think again.”

I wanted to let his hand go, to see if he could really make me do it. I wanted to push his buttons even more. To see if he would really do it.

Taking a deep breath, I began to tell myself I shouldn't play these games, because tonight I was on a mission.

So I squeezed his hand as hard as I could.

I hoped it'd hurt him.

He leaned in and whispered:

“I knew you like it when I'm rough. Next time, simply ask me, *vita mea*, and I will make you scream with pain.”

I turned away, not wishing to let him see the expression I had, which I despised with all my guts. I felt like scratching it off my face. I wanted to hurt myself.

He came up and talked to everyone without introducing me. The scenario seemed to be repeating itself, and it made my stomach turn.

All faces seemed new, all names sounded hollow. I didn't recognize anyone, nor did I remember them. My feet ached from the clunky heels, making it difficult for me to concentrate on finding my prey.

Live music was playing. Waiters brought in food and cleared away empty plates. The tables were laden with appetizers.

Finishing another conversation, Eric suddenly let go of my hand and walked away, leaving me in the middle of the room without a word.

I headed for the bar and asked for a martini. I couldn't get through the night without alcohol.

I sat down at the bar and began to leisurely sip my drink. The alcohol felt smooth and didn't take my attention. I needed something stronger to give me courage.

A slow melody started playing. Couples began to fill the room.

A nasty feeling crawled into my chest like poison from a snake bite when I saw Eric with that same brunette. They were dancing together.

I couldn't take my eyes off them. She smiled and said something to him. He smiled back at her, listening carefully.

His smile hurt me.

I couldn't believe my eyes when I saw what happened next.

He broke into carefree laughter, like a boy.

I had no doubts left in me.

She was his girlfriend.

"Vodka," I asked the bartender, not looking away from them even for a moment.

They looked perfect together. A beautiful couple, a perfect match.

I wondered what she captivated him by that much. Her beauty, I guessed.

Her hair was so thick and long, so silky. It shined and glimmered. You could see a rich, dark hazel shade in them. It was a warm, eye-catching color.

My hair color looked dull and greyish in comparison, like a heap of straw. It's fuzzy and weirdly frizzy. If you were to compare my hair color with any other, mine would not win.

She was tall, which made her look sophisticated and feminine. I think men like women like her. Those just a little shorter than them. They're easier to kiss and hug. No need to lean towards them and fuss about.

She was slightly tanned. The tan enhanced her appearance, giving her a healthy look.

My skin looked pale. Any tan I had had already been washed away.

Her makeup made her look foxy. It looked expensive and elegant.

There were days when even makeup wouldn't help doll me up. And today was one of those days.

I bet she looked fresh and radiant with no makeup on.

If makeup makes her look like a sultry Venus, then she probably looks very attractive and inviting without it, too.

Her fingers were long and straight. Her manicured nails were painted red.

I looked down at my own fingers.

They looked small and crooked. One nail on my right hand got chipped and I only managed to file it down a bit.

I covered my right hand with the left.

Did she know he's sleeping with me?

She probably didn't care. Maybe she suspected it.

What if she knew and still accepted him just the way he was? Maybe she's okay with it and had someone on the side as well? Maybe they're in an open relationship? They allowed each other to sleep with others, but would only start a family with one another.

That must be a special connection, then. The one to survive anything, floods, fires or drought.

Anything.

Her hand wandered his neck, sending daggers into my heart.

He never brought any girl home, but he's never home himself. He could be away for weeks on end. Was he leaving to see her? Was he staying with her? Was he sleeping with her? Did he like sleeping with her more than with me?

Did he love her?

The song ended and my empty glass slipped from my hand, shattering into tiny pieces.

I only noticed it when people started turning their heads in my direction.

I kept staring at them. I watched her adjust his bow tie, grinning widely at him, when his gaze suddenly caught mine.

My eyes only dwelt on him for a few seconds. I turned back to the bar and stood up, heading for the refreshments.

I hated myself for waiting for him. I wanted him to come to me. I wanted him to say something nasty and pull me by my arm.

He told me I was his shadow. Then why wasn't I with him now?

I turned around to look for him, but he was nowhere to be found.

He's with her now.

They might be in the living room on the ground floor.

I wanted to burst in on them and see it with my own eyes. I wanted that because it'd have helped me stifle the anxious waves swaying inside me.

"Champagne?"

A familiar voice stopped me.

"Yes."

I looked up and saw August.

"Enjoying the cocktails?"

"You were right. This is the most interesting part."

He smiled and took a sip of champagne.

"I'm sorry I couldn't give you a proper goodbye the last time."

"I understand. Eric can be..."

"An asshole?"

He smirked.

"Blunt."

We both smiled.

Silence fell between us and I felt it was a good time to start the ball rolling.

"Have you heard anything about the attack on the university?"

"Yes."

My pulse quickened.

"I heard many students were killed."

"It's worse than that. Half of them went missing. Parents are still looking for their kids."

But why did they have to kill?

For revenge.

But upon who? And, most importantly, for what?

I put a crunchy shrimp tartlet in my mouth.

"It looked more like a targeted attack, than an act of revenge."

Bloody writing on the dorm bathroom mirror flooded my memory.

"Were you there?"

"Oh, no. No."

I looked at the floor, smiling.

"I'm just gathering rumors. My life's rather boring, so things like this take up all my attention. Conspiracy theories make life a lot more exciting than facing the real world."

"I like your way of thinking."

He smiled.

Something changed in his eyes, but I didn't know him well enough to understand what it was.

"Who do you think might have wanted it?"

"Do you wish to know if Eric was involved?"

"I know he was."

"And you are correct. Him and his business partners, if you can even call them that, had a hand in this. Some more. Others less.

I looked at the crowd, getting lost in thought.

“People are a commodity, aren’t they?”

“Yes. One can get good money for them.”

Goosebumps pierced my skin like needles.

“Have you taken part in the attack?”

“Are you suspecting me now?”

“Oh, no. I’m just curious. I don’t suspect anyone.”

He grinned and I got the willies.

“No. I’m interested in completely different things.”

“Like what?”

“Rare watches.”

He showed me his wrist with an expensive watch that screamed of a downtown penthouse.

“It’s terrific. I’ve been thinking about getting a watch myself for a while now, but Eric says it’s a waste of money. So now I’m just left dreaming of one like that.”

August smirked.

“Would you like me to give you a watch?”

“What? No. No way. This is too expensive. And it’s a men’s watch.”

“No-no. I’ll give my driver a call and he’d bring in a ladies’ watch. I bought it at an auction yesterday. There are only ten of those in the world.”

“Don’t you want to keep such a rare watch for yourself?”

“There are things that can’t be bought. I think that watch would flatter your eyes perfectly. I’d like for this to be the dawn of our friendship.”

“But could we keep it all...”

I pursed my lips.

“A secret? Definitely. Eric isn’t very fond of me, so the gift will stay between us.”

He picked up another champagne glass from a passing waiter.

“For the new friendship.”

“For the new friendship,” I echoed.

Our glasses met with a chime.

My lips barely touched the liquid when my eyes caught a gaunt blond girl with a banged bob.

She stood next to a tall man clearly a decade older than her. She was walking with a slight limp in her left leg, but her gait seemed incredibly familiar. The blonde turned her head towards me, staring into space. Her eyes looked tired and haunted.

Bell?

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CHAPTER 36

~~Shards of shattered hopes cut deep. They go in so deep it's next to impossible to pull them out on your own. The shards leave deep cuts, a reminder of how you once nurtured a hope within yourself. And next time you want to feel it, the scars of doubt will tug at your heart. After all, happiness without suffering is a myth, right?~~

“Do you know that man over there?”

I pointed at the tall man in white suit. His chestnut hair was short and curly. His skin was bronzed, as if he'd just come back from a vacation.

I watched as his smile quickly slipped off his face like a mask when he turned his back to walk away from a conversation.

He turned to the blonde and said something to her. I saw his left hand squeeze her shoulder. She buckled under the weight of his hand, and he pulled it away, patting her on the cheek.

My pulse was racing, sending a surge of anger and anxiety through my veins.

His glassy stare shot up and began scanning everyone in the room, like he was looking for someone.

He met my eyes and I immediately looked back at August.

“Yes. And I wouldn't recommend you to catch his eye.”

“Why?”

I frowned.

“Mortimer is a vicious man. Though calling him a man feels wrong sometimes. He has his rules, but you wouldn't find a code more twisted than his. Barely anyone agrees to work with him. Everyone he works with either dies or goes bankrupt and eventually disappears. He's a shadow player. He's always all smiles and big promises, but once you fall into his trap, he'll chew you up and leave no bones. He holds a lot of power in his hands: from regular people who work here as waiters and are probably

eavesdropping on us at this very moment, to politicians. He's got his people everywhere. The only reason he hasn't been dealt with yet is because he knows who to be friends with. He's got many enemies, but God save the soul of the one who decides to get in his way."

Fear set my imagination on edge.

"Do you think he'd allow me to make a friend of his girlfriend?"

"That's not his girlfriend. It's his wife."

Maybe I was wrong?

"You can try, but he doesn't like it when someone talks to her without him there. People like him have a lot of power and, likewise, just as many enemies. His paranoia knows no bounds. I heard he beats his wife and the staff. He killed his best man not too long ago and left his corpse to hang from a pole by his mansion, guts out and all."

I made one big gulp.

"That's horrible," I whispered.

"Yes. I think that was his way of showing what happens to those who go against him."

I looked down at my ring and began to roll it on my finger.

"I'm not gonna tell you about other things he did, some of which I got to see with my own eyes. I don't want to scare you."

August turned to me and gave me a sweet smile.

I quickly smiled back and turned my head to the blonde girl once again.

"Life's quite short, August. Don't you think?"

I finished my champagne and placed the glass on a table.

"It's even shorter in our world."

I saw a man approach Mortimer and they fell into an animated conversation.

This was a great opportunity for me to talk to the blond girl discreetly. I had to make sure it wasn't Bell.

"You know, sometimes it's worth taking a risk to see life in all its glory."

He smirked.

I excused myself from August and hastily walked towards the girl.

I came up and gently touched her shoulder.

She flinched in fear.

"Bell, is that you?" I asked, my voice barely above a whisper.

Her eyes widened in terror as tears began welling them up.

A thick layer of foundation could barely hide the bruises on her cheek, above one eyebrow, under her chin and on her neck.

Her beautiful natural hair color had been changed to straw blond. Her sweet cheeks became sunken. She was way too thin. She was a ghost of Bell I used to know.

“Let’s get out of here.”

I took her hand, ready to take her as far away from him as possible. I wanted to protect her, hide her, shield her from any harm.

“Where are you going, Laura?”

I could feel the fear grip me by the throat.

Bell’s hand was shaking in mine. She was ready to break and fall down at his feet begging for forgiveness.

I was gripping and relaxing her hand to remind her she was not alone, that I was by her side.

“She needs to go to the bathroom. I was gonna show her where it is.”

“She can hold it. Stay here and don’t you dare step away from me.”

His voice was stern and waspish. The man’s aura was terrifying enough to make me want to dash away from him.

He grabbed her arm and pulled her back with one rough jerk, like she was a thing he owned.

I could feel her hand slip out of mine. Her eyes were full of pain and despair. She looked like she had already resigned herself to her fate.

I turned away and headed back to the bar.

Thoughts were racing through my mind. It’s like I was standing on the edge of a cliff, trying to decide if I should jump or not.

This was his doing. He did this. He wanted to hurt me. To get back at me. Teach me a lesson.

Anger blurred my vision like an ominous veil. It ruled over my thoughts and actions.

Back at the bar, I noticed a knife lying on a board next to a lemon. I snatched it and went to the guest room.

I pushed the door hard enough for everyone in the room to turn their heads to me.

“I’m gonna kill you!”

I was pointing the knife at the reaper.

The room was dead silent. The men looked at me, blinking in confusion.

“Excuse me, gentlemen, I have to talk to my adorably sweet girlfriend. She’s clearly upset I’d left her alone.”

They slowly left the room, the last person closing the door behind him.

The reaper leaned against his chair, arms crossed. His eyes were on the knife in my hand.

“What’s the matter, Zoe?”

He sounded bored and a tad annoyed.

I gripped the knife tighter.

I was ready to kill him.

Right now.

Right here.

“What’s the matter?” I mocked him.

I drew upon him in rapid strides and put the knife to his throat.

“The matter is that I’m about to kill you.”

“You’re so sexy when you’re mad,” he said in a languid voice.

He held my waist in his arms as he pulled me closer.

The knife was digging into his neck.

“I don’t give a crap what’s going on in your depraved head. Because I know you’re a sick bastard and you’re gonna burn in hell.”

One corner of his lips perked up.

“*Vita mea*, you’re gonna burn with me.”

His hand began stroking my waist.

“Don’t you dare. Touch. Me.”

His jaw tightened, the mischievous spark gone from his eyes.

He slowly took his hand away and I took a step back.

“Are you gonna kill me? Right now? To pay me back?”

“Yes,” I spat.

There was now a sneer on his face that I couldn’t wait to wipe off.

“Bell. You knew he had Bell all along. Did you do this? Did you sell her to him? Was this your plan?”

He scowled.

“No. I don’t sell people.”

I smirked.

“Sure you don’t. And the fact you orchestrated an attack on my university with your mates. What’re you gonna say to that? You and your buddies killed for fun, taking some of the victims to sell and make a quick

buck off of. So don't you lie to my face saying you haven't been involved, as Bell's standing there right now when she's supposed to be safe."

I was almost screaming. My nerves were stretched to the limit.

His gaze grew dark.

"Who told you about the university?"

"Doesn't matter."

He moved up to me. His neck pressed against the knife, ready to be slashed and to bleed out.

I put the knife down.

"August."

"August," he said loathingly, "and what exactly did that bastard tell you?"

"Something you don't have the gut to tell me," I said accusingly.

Tension and anger radiated from his dark gaze.

"And what do I not have the gut to tell you?"

"The truth," I blurted out.

He sighed audibly.

"Zoe. How long have you known August for?"

I didn't answer.

"What makes you think you can trust him?"

"Why should I trust you, too? I've known him for as long as I know you, and his company brought me more joy in the short time I've had him around than yours ever could."

There was a lot of bitterness behind my words, and I spat it at him like venom.

His right hand grabbed me by the throat. I tried to cut him with a knife, but his left hand gripped my wrist so tight I dropped the knife with little pushback.

He was enraged. I could see it boiling behind his eyes. It sent shivers down my spine.

"I will say it again, if you didn't hear me the first time. I don't sell people. And Bell being here tonight isn't my doing. Because had I had a hand in this, I'd bring her dead body to you and watch you shatter into tiny pieces you'd never put back together."

I slapped him across the face.

The silence after the slap was deafening.

His head turned slightly to the side, more from the shock of it than from my blow. He slowly moved his hand from my neck and touched the flushed side of his face.

I'd long dreamed of doing this, and now I regretted not doing it sooner.

My newfound audacity was immediately replaced with fear when his eyes met mine. But the anger... the anger was too strong. It wasn't my life at stake, but the life of my Bell, after all. It gave me courage I didn't think I was capable of anymore.

"Zoe, do you remember what'd happen to you if you betrayed me?"

A wave of anxiety rose to the surface like a bloated carcass rising from the depths.

My body froze in place. I nodded.

"Then why the fuck are you on his side? Do you wanna die so bad?"

"I'm ready to die if Bell will be set free."

My emotions mixed into a concoction I couldn't make heads or tails of.

I looked into his eyes as tears welled up in mine, blurring my vision.

"He's beating her. I saw her powdered bruises. He forced her to chop off her hair and dye it. He even gave her a new name. And I don't know, why, but he made her his wife. She looks like a ghost. She lost so much weight I could barely recognize her. Her eyes were filled with so much fear and pain. She doesn't deserve this. She had a future. She worked so hard for that future."

I slowly knelt before him, crossing my palms pleadingly.

"Please, Eric, I beg of you. Save her. She has to live free. She should enjoy her life. She doesn't deserve to be wiped off like she never existed."

Tears were streaming down my face.

"Please, Eric. I'm begging you. Please. Eric, please."

I kept repeating it like a mantra.

"Zoe."

He said my name with a tinge of regret in his voice. He cringed like he was in pain.

I was wiping my tears away, because I could barely even see him at that point.

"You know I'm not a good man. Why do you keep looking for something I don't have in me?"

I sniffled.

“Because... because I can’t leave her. I can’t live with myself knowing she lives like this. She doesn’t deserve this. I’m the one who doesn’t have a choice. I should live her life. I should suffer and hide the bruises. I’m the one who should become a ghost. Not her. Don’t you get it?”

His jaw was clenched and there was not a hint of sympathy in his eyes.

I dropped my head and whispered:

“You don’t understand.”

I tried to stand up, which was hard to do in my dress.

He took my hand and helped me up. I stood up and jerked it out of his grip right away.

He handed me his white handkerchief. I took it, heading to the mirror hanging above the fireplace. I wiped my tear-stained cheeks.

Having wiped away my tears, I threw the handkerchief on the mantelpiece.

“I’m going to offer to take her place.”

I blurted it out and ran to the exit.

I opened the door, but he slammed it shut before I could get out.

“The fuck do you think you’re doing?” he hissed to the back of my head, “Who are you trying to give what’s mine?”

CHAPTER 37

~~I no longer have dreams where I can laugh, I've lost my voice. I no longer have dreams with a scenery, for I have no eyes. I no longer have dreams where I run into your arms, I can no longer walk. I no longer dream of love, I can't remember what it feels like. I only dream of the darkness I now call home.~~

I turned to face him.

Anger was choking me from the inside.

"I'm not your fucking property," I spat.

"You absolutely are."

He grabbed my arm and pulled me to the table.

I stumbled in my high heels, trying to keep up with his steps.

With one hand he swept everything off the table and easily sat me down on it.

"I won't be gentle with you like the first time."

I glared at him loathingly.

"Just make it quick."

"Oh. Don't act like you don't like it."

"I don't like anything you..."

My breath caught in my throat and I barely held back a scream as he quickly pulled my panties to the side and plunged three fingers inside me.

It was more than I could take.

I felt waves of pain mixed with pleasure.

I grabbed his shoulder, panting heavily into his neck, trying to hold back my moans as his thumb pushed and circled my clit.

His right hand grabbed my hair, wrapping it around his fist and pulling to make me face the ceiling. He ran his tongue from my clavicle to my chin.

"Now, tell me you don't want me."

"I... don't want..."

His fingers drilled me harder. I felt like my body got caught in the eye of the storm.

He bit my ear.

“How come you’re so wet, then? It’s like you’re fucking welcoming me.”

His fingers pulled out of me and I let out a heavy sigh, still holding back my moans.

I heard the sound of his belt unbuckling and my heart started racing, sending a new wave of arousal to my already swollen clit and hot walls.

Seconds flew by at a tortuously slow pace. I couldn’t wait for him to enter me. I didn’t just want him, I needed him.

My whole body was strained to the near-fatal peak.

It was ready. My body was waiting for him.

I didn’t have time to take a breath before he pushed himself into me in one fell swoop.

I cried out and immediately covered my mouth with my hand, falling on my back.

“Liar. Such a little fucking liar.”

He caught both my arms with one hand, crossing them. It put pressure on my sensitive breasts. They craved his touch like flowers craved the rays of sun.

His movements were rough. He pulled back, leaving just the tip inside me, then pushed in so deep it hurt.

I bit down on my bottom lip, trying to hold back my moans.

“Enjoying my company now?”

I opened my mouth to answer, and a lewd groan escaped my lips.

A grin stretched across his perfect face. Black hair slapped against his forehead.

His heavy breathing was my heavenly symphony. I wanted to remember him like this, at least for the small moment when I’m the only one he sees and wants.

He pulled out and thrust back into me. I bit down on my lower lip so hard I could no longer feel it.

“You’re burning inside. Your heat’s smothering me. Fuck. This is insane.”

And it absolutely was insane.

He, too, felt how the embrace of our bodies was driving us crazy. It's like we were lost opposites finally merging into one, destined to be together forever.

I was the day. He was the night.

I was the ocean. He was the desert.

I was a dream. He was the reality.

I could feel how hard his cock got. My sensitive walls enveloped it. They were squeezing it, my flesh singing euphorically.

There was so much desire and lust in his jet-black eyes, I couldn't believe I was the reason behind it all. I turned away, trying to catch my breath for a moment.

His left hand grabbed my face and turned my head down.

"Watch me fuck you."

I felt like my whole face was blushing profusely.

It was getting harder and harder to breathe.

Seeing him in a tuxedo with a perfect comb-out, hearing his low groans, feeling his intoxicating scent and watching the rage burn in his eyes drove me to my peak.

I stopped struggling and let my moans out.

"Good girl. So beautiful. So wet. Just for me. Show me how much you like it."

My brain switched off and my entire body became one big wave of lust.

I was moaning deliriously.

"Damn, Zoe. You're so hot. I can feel your walls clenching around my cock."

A loud moan escaped my throat.

"Louder. I want everyone to hear me fucking you."

I moaned even louder, feeling incredible freedom and relief. I didn't understand how I could have been hiding from it before.

"Eric. I... I... can't... hold it..."

I felt the tsunami coming. It was immense, hot and so welcome. I was dying from how much I craved it.

Eric pulled out of me abruptly and came all over my white dress, hissing through clenched teeth.

The wave of ecstasy gave way to a wave of disappointment washing over me.

I felt incomplete, impaired. My body still ached for him as my mind tried to quiet down and come to terms with the loss.

I had a thirst I tried to quench with water but it'd never go away.

He began to buckle his pants, looking at me with a victorious grin.

"What's wrong, *vita mea*? Why are you so sad?"

He grabbed my chin with his thumb and middle finger, and I immediately pulled away.

"Kiss my ass and go to hell, Eric."

He grabbed the back of my head and pulled me closer until our lips were barely an inch apart.

"Don't tempt me. I might take you up on the offer."

His eyes fell on my lips, then rose back to my eyes.

His right hand brushed against my terribly sensitive folds, and I let out a quiet moan.

He adjusted my underwear and pulled his fingers away, stroking my cheek with the back of his hand.

"Still hungry. Don't blame me for it. It's your fault."

I clenched my jaw, glaring at him wrathfully.

I swayed as I stood up and he grabbed my wrist.

"Looking for an excuse to touch me?" he smirked.

"Just let me fall," I spat.

"I like your stubbornness."

He tucked a lock of hair behind my ear.

"I'm definitely going to fuck it out of you though."

I looked up at him, and I knew what he saw in my eyes because I saw the same thing in his. It was like we were looking in a mirror.

We're addicted to one another.

I didn't know, how, but our desire rapidly morphed from chemistry into an obsession.

"Let me go," I whispered.

"I'm not holding you."

My gaze fell on his arm and I saw my fingers digging into his skin.

I let go of it, as if coming out of a trance, and took a couple steps back.

He left the room, closing the door behind him, and I took the handkerchief from the mantelpiece. I began wiping off his semen.

Emotions got twisted into a ball, leaving me with turmoil and inexplicable feelings. What we just felt terrified me to my very core.

Chances were, I was the only one who felt it. He felt nothing but sadistic glee as he watched me suffer.

Was that why he wanted someone next to him? Did he treat Norman the same way? What about Marta? The poor thing has been around him since the cradle.

I sighed audibly.

In all this mess, I knew one thing for sure, I regretted getting involved in this. I regretted even mentioning it. That I was the one who planted in him the seed that grew the baneful flower.

I had other options, but I foolishly decided to confide in him. I thought it was the right thing to do.

No. I didn't think of what's right. I was thinking about a quick solution, and that's what did me in. My emotions clouded my vision and I closed the doors to other possibilities. And now I had no choice but to reap the fruits of my decisions.

Crap.

The stain won't go away.

I got cleaned up and left the room.

A couple of people stood near the office. They gave me a disapproving look, as if I'd pounced at him in that room.

And it was I who should have given them the look for standing there and eavesdropping.

Perverts.

I walked towards the main hall, carefully folding the handkerchief.

Having found Eric, I began to make my way through the crowd.

He was already surrounded by people merrily chatting away with him.

"Eric, you forgot your handkerchief."

I put it in his pocket, carefully straightening out the tip.

One corner of his lips perked up ever so slightly.

Leaning in closer to him, I whispered, "Take your kids with you. I don't want them."

"Excuse me. You've got something on your dress," a man I've never seen before said.

My face went white.

"I had an ice-cream. It melted pretty fast."

"An ice-cream? Were they serving ice-cream here?"

I could see Eric smiling out of the corner of my eye. He was holding back a laugh.

“Yes. You can ask the waiters. But they only have vanilla.”

The man got distracted by someone else and finally lost all interest in me.

“Ask me for an ice-cream next time. I’ll definitely feed it to you and make sure every drop ends up in your mouth instead of staining your dress.”

I felt like I lost my voice.

My body got scalding hot.

Eric reached for me and touched my forehead.

“You’re flushed. Feeling hot, are you? Maybe you’d like an ice-cream?”

I took his hand away and hissed,

“I hope you die an agonizing death.”

“That’s not gonna happen. I’ll always have you by my side, after all.”

I turned away and saw the man in a white tuxedo with a fake smile.

Bell was standing next to him. My eyes fell on her and never left her frame.

I gripped Eric’s hand tight mindlessly.

“I don’t think we’ve met before. My name’s Mortimer.”

“Eric.”

They shook hands.

“I’d like to discuss a few supply issues with you.”

My hand was shaking in his grasp, giving away how panicked I was.

Eric stroked it with his thumb in an attempt to calm me down.

The wheels were turning in my head at breakneck speed.

I wanted to grab her hand and run. I wanted to hug her, stroke her hair, tell her it was gonna be okay. It pained me that I still had no plan to rescue her.

“Zoe?”

“What?”

I watched Bell walk away, getting lost in the crowd. I was about to let go of his hand to follow her, but he gripped my fingers tighter.

“He won’t let her go.”

I looked up at him in horror, staring at the mouth bearing the words that brought me so much pain.

“Do you see the man next to the waiter? His name’s Hector.”

My gaze fell on the man. He looked unassuming, but I knew he was anything but.

There wasn't a single regular or nice person in this room. Everyone here had their hands stained with blood.

Myself included.

"Go to him and invite him to follow you to the guest room."

I turned to look at him like he was talking gibberish.

"No. No. No, Eric."

Panic was pounding wildly in my chest, leaving sharp pain behind. My whole body was on high alert, as if the hands of a stranger were going to start strangling me at any moment.

"I'm not going anywhere with him."

I tried to keep my voice flat. My body was numb and my throat felt dry. My palms got sweaty.

"Don't make me repeat myself," he said, his voice cold as ice.

I looked up at him with terror-filled eyes and whispered,

"Please."

His jaw tightened.

Anger was looming behind his eyes, ready to burst.

I tried to speak, but my throat felt tight. My eyes froze like I'd just seen a ghost. My brain was locked up behind bars.

Turning away, I walked up to the man. My actions and words were no longer my own. It was like I was no longer present in my own body. I was just an observer, a performer, which was what Eric wanted me to be.

CHAPTER 38

~~I've always had trust issues. I've been betrayed too many times, and now it's hard for me to let my guard down and fully trust people. It's like I'm always waiting for them to show their true colors. And then I'd tell myself, "See, I knew I couldn't trust them." Because I'm just like you, I lie to everybody.~~

The adrenaline was rushing to my head, screaming that I had to run. That my life was in danger. I needed to defend myself, not sit there like a life model waiting for her next pose.

The sofa was too soft, I kept watching Hector pour us some wine. My eyes fell on the table Eric and I had sex on moments ago, sending a wave of pleasure across my body.

Loud music was playing, reminding me of the party still going on in the hall. Of the people outside the door. I couldn't convince myself of this, because all I could hear was my pulse thumping in my ears and a wail of panic inside.

Hector silently handed me a glass, and I drank it down, ignoring his attempt to toast.

After taking a couple of sips, he put his glass on the table and sat down next to me.

He leaned in to kiss me, but I moved away from him hastily.

He cringed.

"You're not gonna play coy, are you?"

I lifted my gaze to look at the door behind him.

"You called me here yourself, so spare me your games."

He threw his body at me, groping and trying to kiss me.

I pushed him off with my hands and he fell back onto the coffee table.

I heard the sound of broken glass.

"So you like it rough, huh? Fine."

I got up to run, but he grabbed my hair, dragging me down to the floor.

I was screaming and scratching him, trying to break free from his clammy mitts. But it was no use. My kicks were too weak, my screams too quiet.

I was spread on the cold floor when he was about to sit on me.

I tried to kick him in the balls, and I almost did, but he grabbed my head and hit it on the wooden floor full-force.

My vision went dark. I was on the verge of blacking out.

As I was trying to come around, slowly crawling to the door, he turned me over and began pulling my underwear down.

I tried to hold it, but he slapped me across the face with all his might. I cried out in searing pain spreading all over my face like an electric charge.

It's a shame I didn't pass out when he hit me on the floor.

I looked at the alabaster fretwork on the ceiling. It was marvelous. The only beautiful thing surviving this place for so long.

Pristine. Stunning. Untainted.

My body turned to stone when I heard his belt unclasping. My head felt hollow. All I could hear was my heart's feverish beating.

Before he could get on top of me, the front door slammed closed, tearing me out of my trance.

"What the?"

He got to his feet but, unfortunately for him, fell back to the floor straight away.

Eric punched him in the face hard enough to knock him down, his head meeting the floor much harder than mine did.

He took hold of his shirt and began beating him so bad I turned away, unwilling to watch it any more.

Hector was moaning, begging him for mercy.

For the first time ever, I didn't feel sorry for a person being beaten so savagely. It's like he wanted to make a human patty out of the guy.

I had an awful feeling blooming deep inside. I didn't want to deny it. It was the feeling of relish and triumph.

I wanted him to feel pain verging on death throes. The sadist in me wished he would suffer as long as possible.

"Please, I beg you. Stop. I didn't know."

Eric's eyes went wide with rage.

“Didn’t know what? That you can’t rape women? Or that she’s mine and no one gets to touch her? She’s a God-damn painting in a museum, you can look, but never put your dirty hands on it.”

He punched him into something now barely resembling a face. Hector was now talking with a lisp. His front teeth were gone. His whole face was now a bloody mess.

“It was her. She came up to me and called me here,” he lisped, choking on blood.

“And you immediately thought she would want to sleep with you? Are you stupid?”

He punched him again and the man moaned in pain.

Letting him go and kicking the guy in the balls for good measure, Eric glanced at me. His eyes began looking me over quickly.

He came up and helped me get up.

“I think I have a concussion.”

“Hush now.”

He carefully lifted my chin, turning my head to the right.

I thought I saw his pupils cover his entire irises, making his eyes look jet-black. The color of wrath.

He bent over and pulled my panties back up.

Why was he like this? Why would he show me the side of himself I’d fall for even harder than before?

He picked up my shoe and carefully slid it on my foot.

After he slowly sat me down on the sofa, he grabbed still whimpering Hector, throwing his ass in an armchair across from us.

I felt uneasy sitting opposite him. I wanted to cover my body, to hide, leave the room.

I crossed my legs and arms. Eric put his hand on my exposed leg and began to stroke it slowly.

I thought it’d be right for me to remove his hand, but it gave me the feeling of safety I needed so badly.

“You’re gonna work for me now. I want you to...”

His laugh interrupted Eric.

I was surprised he could talk, much less laugh.

“Do you really think I’m gonna betray Mortimer, Roncalli? No way in hell. I don’t have a death wish,” he spat, acting like Eric’s words offended him.

Eric smiled and held a phone up to him.

So Eric's surname was Roncalli? He owns my university? Why would he attack the students of his own university? What if he wasn't involved after all? Who was it then? And why would August lie to me? What did he say it for?

Damn. I was dumb to trust him like that. Really dumb.

Wait, what about Mortimer? Why did he need Mortimer all of a sudden? Was he... trying to help me?

Hector's bloodied, swollen face turned into a pale blob. I could see genuine fear in his eyes, and I loved it.

I liked the power Eric had over him.

I always wondered what people like him were scared of? What was their worst fear?

Eric put the phone away and placed a USB drive on the table. He continued to stroke my leg, making me relax and crave his touch even more. He was like a steel cocoon that shielded me from the outside world.

"I need access to all the cameras in his house, the warehouses, anywhere he stays or where he keeps people. As well as access to his phone and computer."

"What if he picks up on it?"

"Make sure he doesn't."

"Is that it?"

Hector was about to get up.

"No. Apologize to her."

I felt naked. All attention was on me. I was no longer invisible.

Hector gave me a hate-filled look and spat:

"She's a whore. I'm not apologizing to her."

"She's not some whore. She's my whore. She belongs to me. And I really don't like it when someone touches what's mine."

The man's bored glance fell back on me.

"Sorry."

"Sorry what?" Eric said.

"I'm sorry for trying to rape you."

"Lovely."

Eric got up and offered him a hand.

Hector took the flash drive, slowly got to his feet and shook Eric's hand.

When the man was about to pull his hand away, Eric twisted it hard enough for me to hear a disgusting crunch that made my stomach turn. That ghoulish sound got imprinted in my memory like a brand mark on flesh.

He broke his wrist.

The man was screaming at the top of his lungs, making my ears ring.

“Apologies accepted now.”

I didn’t notice when Norman came into the room. He grabbed Hector and got him out the door.

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CHAPTER 39

~~I have never thought what I live for. My life has always been a smooth sailing. I asked no questions, just conformed and followed. Whenever I had a choice to make, it was taken away from me and I didn't have to think what I should do for too long. But I do think about it these days. What do I do now?~~

I sat on my bed, holding an ice pack to my swollen cheek, staring at the door. I couldn't feel my left arm, or half of my face.

Everyone left and I never got to see Bell again. He probably took her away back when we were in the guest room.

Eric suddenly took an interest in Mortimer, and I was curious about what's going on in his head. I wanted to pry it open, like a jewelry box, to get all the answers.

My gaze landed on a pink box on my nightstand. The ice pack turned into a water balloon, so I threw it in the trash and picked up the leather box.

I sat down on the bed and opened it. Inside was a classic watch. They evoked the spirit of an era long past. They had a round dial and a slim silver strap decorated with a scattering of diamonds.

I closed the box.

This was way too expensive. The pawn shop might not have ten grand in cash on hand, much less sixty.

They'd come in handy for an escape, but not for mom's treatment.

I still had time. I could search the house once again. I knew he still had that necklace, but I couldn't find it.

If I could find it, we'd sell the watch at the pawn shop, and I'd cash the necklace in another city, where my parents and I'd have moved.

What did Eric want from Mortimer? Did he decide to help me, after all? It clearly wasn't that simple.

Eric didn't help anyone. He wanted something from Mortimer and I was worried sick for Bell.

My eyes fell on the clock. It was two in the morning.

I kicked my heels aside like a spoiled brat. I could feel the blood gradually flowing back to my feet.

I tried to unzip my dress, but all attempts made me sweat and get even angrier.

I was so mad. Annoyed with myself. Angry with my own feelings.

So mad at myself for looking at that damn door.

I turned off the light and went to bed.

A knock on the door woke me up.

"Oh, come in already," I croaked.

I opened my eyes slowly. It seemed like only a couple of minutes passed since I'd closed them.

"Um... the boss told me to bring you a dress and tell you that you'll be going to Mortimer's soon."

I jumped to my feet. All of a sudden, I was wide awake again.

Norman hung the dress and froze, looking like he wanted to say something.

I frowned.

"What?" I snapped.

"Why did you sleep in a dress?"

"Because I couldn't take it off."

I signed audibly and walked up to him, turning my back to the man.

"Unzip it."

Once Norman left, I got ready quicker than a pit crew could change tires on a race car.

I put on another white dress and black heels, the shoes hiding a bunch of band-aids on my feet.

I was about to leave when I turned back and saw the pink box.

I walked up to it and put the watch on, hiding it under the sleeve of my dress.

Running downstairs before the agreed time, I saw Norman and asked him to help zip my dress up.

I couldn't wrap my head around the fact there were no normal dresses that would allow me to deal with the damned zipper myself.

And why did I have to wear these stupid dresses all the time? The era when women were ostracized for wearing pants was long gone. He definitely had some kind of a fetish for dresses. Especially the white ones.

“What’re you doing?”

His voice sent pleasant shivers down my spine and that made me angry.

“Nothing. Let’s go,” I blurted out.

I threw on my wool coat and walked out, completely ignoring him.

A warm smell of leather greeted me as I got into the dark blue car.

I turned to the window.

Where were they? Why was it taking so long? Why aren’t they coming out yet?

I rolled the ring with my thumb.

Eric got in the car, Norman following close behind.

Norman was lifting the black divider, and I saw his broken nose in the rear mirror.

I was about to ask what the hell happened, but decided to keep my mouth shut. It all didn’t matter anyway.

The ride went on in silence, allowing me to think over all the options for how Bell and I were going to escape tonight.

I didn’t stop rolling the ring since the car started.

Eric rested his warm hand on mine.

“Don’t even think of saving her.”

I pulled my hand away, ignoring his gaze.

“I wasn’t going to save anyone. I’m just worried about her.”

I turned back to the window, looking at the woods outside.

“If you try to escape, he’ll first kill her, and then finish you.”

I swallowed hard.

My heart was beating out my chest.

“Why did you save me yesterday?”

I turned my head to look at him.

“Did you want me to stay out of it?”

“You could have said you did it ’cause I was your whore.”

“Would that answer satisfy you?”

“Are there other options?”

“There are.”

I frowned and turned back to the window.

“I don’t want to hear about them,” I said under my breath.

I was looking out the window when I got a strange feeling. I could feel him staring at me.

I turned and met his gaze.

“Roncalli, huh?”

He smiled.

“You didn’t attack your university. Do you even know who did?”

I saw him clench and relax his jaw. It obviously hit a nerve with him, but the topic wasn’t a joke to me, either.

“Yes.”

“Is he dead?”

“Not yet.”

Not yet.

So it’s Mortimer? That’s why he needed him all of a sudden.

He wanted revenge. Knowing Eric, he likes to get even. It’s his hobby, a pastime, his leisure.

If he killed Mortimer, what would happen to Bell?

He would never let her go.

“What did you show Hector on your phone?”

“A picture of his daughter standing next to me.”

He always knew where to hit people to make them do his bidding.

“Do you have a weakness?”

He looked me in the eye for a while before he replied:

“Just one.”

Why only one? What could it be? His business? People? His family? Was anyone in his family still around?

“Is it your family?”

“No.”

He said it like I’d just insulted him. As if having a family means being vulnerable, like it’s a flaw.

Of course. It’s her. That girl. She’s his weak spot.

I swallowed a heavy lump and kept rolling my ring with my left thumb.

I wanted to learn more about her. I wanted to know her name, what she liked, what she did.

I longed to know what she had that I didn’t.

“I believe you didn’t attack the university.”

He raised an eyebrow.

“Are you apologizing?”

“No. I’d rather swallow my tongue, than apologize to you.”
I blurted it out without thinking.
I saw his body tense up at my words.
My heart picked up the pace.
I looked down at my hands.
I expected him to grab me by the throat, snap back or threaten me.
He reached his hand out to my face and carefully tucked a strand of hair
away to take a look at my bruise.
His touch made my body blossom.
“You’ve hidden it well.”
“Eric.”
“I’m sorry I didn’t come yesterday. I had urgent matters to attend to.
Were you waiting for me?”
My heartbeat picked up and I looked away.
“No.”
I turned away from him and kept looking out the window.
I shouldn’t have spoken to him first. The ride should have been silent.

CHAPTER 40

~~Losing my life never scared me. The thought I'd made a mistake scared me way more. That everything I knew was a lie. It'd be impossible to come to terms with a life lived in delusion. After all, I've have lived it without ever discovering the real life. And that means I never really lived.~~

I jumped out of the car and walked briskly towards the front door.

Eric caught up to me and grabbed my arm.

“Don’t run,” he hissed in my ear.

I narrowed my eyes and brushed his hand off.

A woman welcomed us, showing us to the guest room.

The house was towering, just like the steel gates leading up to it. The place was swarming with guards, with security cameras both inside and outside the building.

It hurt me to think how long Bell stayed here and what he did to her.

“Finally, the Roncallis are here. Glad to see you,” Mortimer said merrily.

Was this a joke?

He shook Eric’s hand with a smile and gave me a nod. I was glad we didn’t have to touch one another.

We walked to the couch and I scowled at Eric.

He smiled at me.

We sat down, Mortimer opened a bottle of wine and began pouring the crimson liquid into glasses.

“I found most magnificent wine for you. It’s from 1970. My favorite. I only bring it out for my special guests. Such as yourself.”

His grin stretched from ear to ear.

I wondered if he hated us as much as we loathed him.

I raised the glass to my lips and took a small sip.

“It goes down like the blood of virgins, doesn’t it?”

I choked and some red drops fell on my lily-white dress.

“Excuse me,” I whispered.

I took a napkin and began patting the dress dry.

“It’s good,” Eric replied.

One of the guards approached Mortimer and whispered something in his ear.

“Excuse me. I’m going to have to leave you for a little while. Sarah’s going to serve the hors d’oeuvres. Make yourself at home.”

He gave us one of his fake smiles and vanished.

I put my glass down and turned to Eric.

“Why the hell does he think I’m your wife?” I hissed.

“Would it be better if he thought you’re a whore and that he could use you?”

I clenched my jaw and turned away.

“You could have said I was your sister.”

He smirked.

“What’s so funny?”

“My sister? Zoe, sisters don’t look at their brothers the way you did last night.”

“And how did I look at you?”

“You looked like you were watching your man cheat on you before your very eyes.”

“You’re seeing something that isn’t there.”

“Tell me, Zoe, did you want to be in her place?”

I took my glass of wine and drained it.

“Would you like to know what place I’d like to be in, Eric?”

I turned to look at him.

“Any place you’re not in.”

I shot up, but his rough pull sent me falling in his lap.

He rested his left hand on my leg.

“There are cameras all over this place. Even in the bathrooms.”

His hand was gliding up.

My pulse was pumping like crazy.

“If he catches you trying to save her, he’ll try to kill you.”

“Would you let him kill me?”

I turned to face him and he gave me a faint smile.

He gently tucked a strand of hair behind my ear.

“Did you answer the question to yourself?”

His hand wandered my thigh, his mesmerizing eyes and lips calling out to me stole all my thoughts.

His fingers circled the lace of my panties, teasing and awakening a shameful desire.

“What question?” I whispered, breathing heavily.

His lips moved closer to mine and I parted them slightly.

I felt his warm breath on my lips as he whispered,

“Why do you want to be with me so bad?”

I blinked rapidly, trying to process what he said.

I clenched my jaw and hisses through gritted teeth,

“You’ll be the next man I kill.”

I said it like a promise, which it basically was.

“I see you didn’t miss me here.”

Eric pulled his hand away, fixing my dress.

“We can get straight to the business. My wife doesn’t like to tag along for discussions. It’s too tiring for her.”

He smiled at me, and I returned the gesture with a smile that spelled “go fuck yourself.”

“Straight to the point. I like you already.”

Mortimer laughed and sipped some more wine.

“Sarah will come for you. She’ll keep you entertained. Ask anything you want.”

They got up and headed to his office.

I ran to Sarah the moment I saw her.

“Where’s Bell?”

“Who?” she asked, looking confused.

“Laura. I meant to say Laura.”

Sarah led me upstairs, to Bell’s room.

The moment I saw her I wanted nothing more than to run and hug her tight, but I had to remind myself of the cameras. Mortimer couldn’t find out we knew each other.

I slowly walked up to her, keeping my feelings to myself as they threatened to burst out and flood my face.

I gave her a small smile, swallowing down a lump of bitter helplessness.

She answered with a feeble smile, trying to hold the tears welling up in her eyes.

“Bell, the bruise is so big,” I whispered.

She had a mean purple shiner under one of her eyes. It looked fresh.
A tear ran down my cheek and I quickly wiped it away.

“There’s a camera in the corner. Let’s have a seat by the window, we won’t be seen as well there.”

I clenched my fists to try and stop myself from hugging her. I could feel it would break both her and I if I tried.

“Why are you here? Did he bring you?”

Bell didn’t just look worried, she seemed deeply haunted, like she was about to break down and scream bloody murder.

“No. Eric has some kind of business with Mortimer.”

“Eric? Oh, no, Zo. They’re both in on it. Did he hit you there?”

“No. It’s Hector. Eric doesn’t beat me. He... he has other means of torturing me.

My bruises aren’t visible because they’re way too deep inside.”

Bell’s face twisted in pain.

Tears welled up in my eyes, but I tried to hold them back.

“Mom’s in a coma because of Eric. Her car got hit by a truck. And Justin... he’s gone. I don’t know, if Eric was the one who did it, but I have a feeling it was him. I held his stone-cold body in my arms. He was lying there like he didn’t mean anything. Like his life meant nothing. I had to say goodbye so fast. It all happened so rapidly that I... I...”

My voice was filled with dread and I began to stutter.

I turned to the window.

I didn’t want to tell her I began sleeping with Eric by choice, because I detested myself for it.

I wasn’t ready to say it out loud, as that would mean I was confessing to it. That I accepted it. That I betrayed my parents and Justin.

Something that was supposed to turn into a plan morphed into a humiliating, sordid addiction. It corrupted my soul every time he touched me.

Shame paralyzed my body.

Taking a couple breaths, I turned to look at Bell.

“Was Mortimer behind the university attack?”

“No. He was merely a buyer,” Bell whispered dejectedly.

“I know Eric wasn’t involved. Then who’s done it? We weren’t the only ones taken. Is anyone looking for the others?”

“No one will be looking for them. Mortimer and the other buyers paid everyone off.”

I frowned and turned to look out the window.

“Back at the university no one was captured or taken to the vans. They were torturing and killing anyone they saw. It all looked like an attack. Like an act of revenge...”

“They were looking for certain traits to meet the clients’ demands.”

Bell’s eyes fell on her hands.

“He sees his wife in me.”

My face cringed in pain.

“But you’re not her. You aren’t Laura. Your name’s Bell. My Bell, who likes to study. Who dreams of teaching Philosophy and meeting a nice guy to start a family and get a Labrador with. My open-hearted, kind, compassionate and just a tiny bit pesky Bell.”

I nudged her a little and saw a glimpse of a smile on her lips.

“Don’t let him break you. Remember who you are. Do everything as he says, but keep it in mind.”

She wiped a tear off her cheek.

“I don’t think I’d ever escape anymore. I gave in to it all. I stopped trying. The things he does are so terrifying, I...”

Her voice broke, she began breathing heavily.

I gripped her hand tight.

“I thought you were dead. I was so scared to think about it,” I said, my voice barely a whisper.

“I pray for it every day.”

Her words broke my heart, leaving a sinking feeling behind.

“I was taken with the other girls almost immediately when these men broke into the university. They tied our hands, covered our mouths and eyes. The road there took a while. It was so stuffy I thought I’d pass out. We got to some kind of abandoned warehouse. They lined us up like cattle at the slaughterhouse and began looking us over. The girls who tried to run were battered and raped right in front of us. Once they were done, the girls were sent back to the line. Mortimer was the first. He chose me. I don’t know what happened to those who weren’t chosen. Once I stepped out of the line, he told me Bell no longer existed. There was only Laura now. No one’s looking for us and nobody will. And even if someone tried, they’d

never find anything. I wanted to tell you how my days are going around here, but it would kill me.”

Tears rained down her cheeks. She was trying to hold her pain in, but I could see he’d already crushed her.

I grabbed her arm with my other hand.

“Don’t you dare give up. I’ll save you. Now I know where you are. I’ll help you. We can escape.”

I lifted my sleeve and showed her the watch.

“This is our freedom. There’s an old antique shop not far from the bus terminal. I know my way around it. We’d go there, I’d sell the watch, we’d buy tickets and leave this damned place to go as far as we can.”

I took her face in my hands.

“I’ll make Eric invite you two to our place. I’ll get everything ready and we’ll run away.”

She moved my hands away.

“Don’t give me hope, Zoe. Please. I can’t bear it anymore,” she whispered.

I grasped her hand and gripped it tight.

“Don’t you dare give up now, when you got a chance with me by your side. You are not alone. I’ll get everything ready. All you need to do is take your chance.”

“How do you stay so optimistic? How can you still believe in freedom?”

“I wasn’t like this until I saw you at the reception. You gave me hope.”

Holding back the sobs, she said,

“I want to hug you so terribly bad, Zoe.”

“So do I, Bell.”

The door opened and we quickly let go of each other’s hands and began wiping our tears.

Sarah came in.

“Your husband’s looking for you.”

“Husband?” Bell whispered.

I shook my head faintly, letting her know it wasn’t true.

I gave her a warm glance, wished her goodbye and headed downstairs.

Eric was talking to Mortimer on the porch.

I forced a smile and walked up to Eric, wrapping one arm around his waist.

“You have a stunning house, Mortimer. I had the pleasure to meet Laura and exchange a few words with her about your wonderful interior decoration. She was very kind to tell me more about it. I’ve been talking Eric’s ear off about redecorating our bedroom. Maybe you two could come over for dinner sometime?”

Mortimer looked at me, smiling and listening closely.

“I’m all for it, if Eric doesn’t mind.”

I raised my head to look at him and said in a sickly sweet, singsong voice,

“Honey, will you invite Mortimer and Laura for dinner? Please,” I whined, batting my eyelashes at him.

He watched me and I noticed the corners of his lips twitch.

“Of course, darling.”

I squealed and gave him a peck on the cheek.

“Turns out, it really doesn’t take much to make a woman happy, Eric.”

They shook hands and we headed back to the car.

I was waiting forward for that dinner.

CHAPTER 41

~~I'm beginning to forget what friendship means. It now seems akin to a fern flower, an unusual and impossible sight. I have been lonely and isolated for far too long. So long I got used to the loneliness. I don't want a flower any more. Loneliness is my best friend.~~

I woke up, feeling like half my body had gone numb. I could feel Eric's hand stroking my head as I was lying in his lap.

It was dark in the car. The engine was no longer running, which meant we were back home.

How long have we been sitting in the car? Why didn't he wake me up?

I realized I'd never get the answers to simple questions, let alone complicated ones. That meant I had nothing to lose.

"Why do you hate me?"

My voice was still hoarse from the recent nap.

His hand stopped.

"Hate you? Why do you hate me?"

His question made me surprised and angry at the same time.

I got up and met his gaze.

"Why?" I hissed, "The list's almost endless. You took me, kept me in a basement with no food or water. You kidnapped and killed girls. Innocent girls who didn't do anything wrong. My mom's in a coma because of you, fighting for her life. And I had to sleep with you because we've got no money to pay for the injections that keep her going. You took my education away. My future. My life," I was almost screaming, "you could have saved Bell, but you're not *a hero*, you're a fucking villain. You're a black hole that kills and destroys everything good it comes in contact with. You're the evil walking the Earth unpunished. You're the worst a person could be."

"The list isn't that big, after all."

I was holding back rage, trying not to lay into him.

“Why?”

“You see, you need a reason to hate me. And I don’t need one. I hate you just for fun. The world’s unfair, isn’t it?”

I jumped out of the car, slamming the door full-force.

I kicked off the heels and headed to the woods. I did not want to be around him.

I heard the door slam behind me.

He caught up with me and grabbed my arm, but I pulled it away and ran deeper into the woods.

It was freezing, like the cold was brought forth by darkness itself. I tripped on a log and fell to the ground. I ripped my tights and scratched a knee. I jumped back to my feet and kept running, not knowing where to or why. I knew I couldn’t stop.

I kept running until my legs began hurting. Maybe he didn’t follow me?

I stopped to listen for his steps and give myself a break when he grabbed and knocked me to the ground.

I fell on the cold, hard soil with a scream.

He sat on me and held my hands at my chest.

“Let me go,” I was struggling, “let me go.”

He was too strong and heavy, I couldn’t move at all.

I was screaming and crying.

He leaned closer. The dull moonlight illuminated his face, making him look ominous.

“I want you to hate me. Hate me more than you’ve ever hated anyone in your life. I want to be your worst enemy. My dream is for you to wake up and go to sleep every day thinking how much you wanna kill me. I want to devour your mind and all your feelings. Hate me, Zoe. Hate me harder.”

I looked in his eyes filled with genuine hatred and no longer cared why, because I really hated him just as much as he did.

I was twisting and turning in bed, not getting even a wink of sleep.

Anxious thoughts of escape gnawed at me. Doubts weighed heavily on me.

But I knew we didn’t have a choice. I had to do it, if not for myself, then for Bell and my mom.

The idea of an only chance terrified me.

I let out a sigh and threw the blanket aside.

Going down to the kitchen, I poured myself a glass of water and began to drink slowly.

Hearing the footsteps, my body tensed up and I turned to the doorway.

Eric was standing next to me.

He put his hand on top of mine. His lips touched the glass and he drank the rest of the water.

His eyes were as cold as the nights beyond the Polar Circle.

When he let go of my hand, I slammed the glass down on the counter, not taking my eyes off him.

“I didn’t allow you to drink my water.”

“Your water?”

“Yes. I was drinking it. So it’s mine.”

“You live in my house. Wearing the clothes I’ve bought you. Standing in my kitchen. Drinking my God-damn water from my glass.”

Anger seethed in me, and I let it out.

I took off my silk nightie and threw it in his face.

“Now I don’t have anything of yours.”

I was quite literally naked. I was standing there, stark naked, while he still had his checkered pajama pants on.

He closed his eyes and hissed through gritted teeth, then grabbed and sat me down on the countertop. His hand gripped my hair, pulling back painfully.

His obsidian eyes stared into my soul.

“Your body belongs to me.”

His right hand squeezed my face while his left pulled at my hair wrapped around his fist.

“These lips are mine.”

He kissed me roughly, pushing his tongue deep into my mouth, without giving me a chance to move.

Both his hand and his lips moved to my neck.

“This neck is mine.”

He ran his tongue down my neck, biting it.

“These tits are mine.”

His left palm squeezed my right breast hard. His right hand held my left breast as he sucked and nipped at my nipple.

I bit my bottom lip, trying to stifle the moan building up in my throat.

His hand squeezed my nipple as two of his fingers slid into my heated core.

He moved my hand away and I bit down on my bottom lip hard to keep quiet.

His lips whispered venomously into mine.

“This pussy is mine. Your whole body belongs to me. You’re mine entirely.”

“Fuck you, Roncalli,” I spat, breathing heavily.

“Fuck you, Torn.”

My head hit the cabinet on the wall behind me as he pushed deep into me, covering my mouth with his hand.

His eyes were too close to mine as he thrust into me hatefully.

It’s like he wanted to hurt me, and I longed for it.

He didn’t know how hooked I was on pain and how much I hated it at the same time. Because it reminded me of him.

I could feel a wave of arousal lifting me to the peak. My eyes were ready to roll back.

“Show me how much my body wants to cum.”

I held back my arousal, not wishing to do what he told me.

He caught on to that and pulled out abruptly.

He pulled me to my feet, turning me around so my ass was facing him. He lifted my right leg on the countertop, his body pushing against mine, not letting me put it down. He roughly grabbed my hair and pulled my head back.

I didn’t have time to find support for my hand when he suddenly slid inside me and I cried out, covering my mouth with my hand.

He spanked me painfully on my right buttock, the stinging pain flooding the same raw spot until a tear fell down on my hand.

His thrusts were quick and vicious.

His hand found my breast and he squeezed my nipple hard, making me cum.

My body sank beyond the wave that pushed me to my peak.

“Fuck, Zoe,” he hissed through clenched teeth.

My body shook as I drowned in the waves of twisted passion.

He pulled out quickly, leaving me feeling barren.

As the afterglow of my orgasm washed over my body, I felt warm liquid running down my inner thigh.

My body felt stiff. I struggled to stand up straight. My legs wouldn't obey me. So I froze in the pose he left me in.

The haze of my orgasm was gradually replaced by a symphony of guilt, shame, repulsion and hatred. For what was meant for the man I loved, I gave to the man I loathe and despise.

I had good intentions, but it's in his nature to corrupt everything he laid his hands on, and I was no exception.

Our arrangement was supposed to help me, not drag my soul to hell.

These emotions were made even worse by the realization that I craved it. I liked pain. Liked his touch.

I hated myself. I was supposed to resist evil, but before I knew it, I took its side.

My body was sinful, it kept plunging itself deeper and deeper into darkness. I hated it because it betrayed me.

But I still held out hope for my soul. Because I'd never give it away. It's loyal to me. It belonged to me. It's mine.

After a while, I began to slide down to the floor, and Eric caught me in his arms.

I thought he'd left, but he'd been standing behind me all this time.

He was carrying me upstairs.

"Oh. Spare me from this. Just drop me already."

He pretended to drop me, and I clung to his neck for dear life, pressing myself against his body.

He smirked.

"You don't know what you want yourself."

The answer "your death" lingered on my tongue, but I still had some self-preservation left in me.

"I want you gone."

"Who'd carry you in his arms then?"

"Another man."

His hands gripped me tighter.

He put me down not far from my room.

We were standing halfway between our rooms.

It's like he gave me a choice where to go.

I looked at him, breathing heavily.

The fresh feeling of intimacy and anger hissed inside me like a pill in the water.

“I hate you.”

His eyes narrowed a little.

I turned away and was about to head to my room when he grabbed my arm, twisting me around to face him.

His hand grabbed my face roughly. His lips came closer to mine, his hot breath caressing my skin.

He stayed silent, his eyes burning with rage.

“Go. To sleep,” he hissed through gritted teeth.

He pushed me away and went to his room.

Asshole.

When I woke up the next day, I decided not to come out for breakfast. Marta brought it to my room, asking what was wrong. I told her I didn’t feel well, which wasn’t true, of course.

I was mad. Mad at Eric. I spent all morning imagining myself hurting him. How his face twisted in pain when he saw me hurt his beloved brunette. How he was suffering, falling in pain. How it ripped him apart. I longed to see it on his face.

I heard a car running and looked outside.

He left.

To see her?

I didn’t care.

I had time to get everything Bell and I needed ready for the escape.

I needed a phone. I had to charge it.

I went to the bathroom and looked in the bottom drawer of the cabinet, but it wasn’t there anymore.

Panic came over me. I began throwing all the paper rolls to the floor.

It had to be here. I put it here the last time. I wrapped it in toilet paper and put a bunch of rolls around to hide it.

I opened every drawer, throwing everything in them out.

It wasn’t there.

My fist hit the wall as I yelled out in anger.

There was a knock on the door.

I walked up and yanked it open.

It was Norman. He brought me a dress.

A white one. Again.

I stepped aside, arms folded on my chest.

I slammed the door shut and he turned around.

“Where’s my stuff?”

“In the wardrobe.”

“You think I’m stupid? I’m talking about the stuff I brought from the dorms.”

“Boss said to trash it.”

“Did you do it?”

“Of course.”

“Who was the last to come to my room while I was out? One of my things is missing.”

“Marta. No one else comes here but her.

She could have found it while cleaning. And if she did, she’d give it to Eric.”

Why did it have to happen today? When I was this close to freedom. All this time I refused to lose hope, tirelessly fighting demons both in the real world and in my head. I blindly cherished the thought that I’d make it out of here because I had no other choice. I had to do it. I believed I would escape and leave it all behind. That I would forget everyone and everything I went through here.

But why? Why?

I went downstairs and found Marta in the kitchen.

My gaze fell on the kitchen counter and my vile heart skipped a beat.

I cleared my throat and came up to Marta.

“I can’t find something in my room.”

“What are you looking for?”

“It... it was on the shelf under the sink, where the toilet paper is.”

“What did you keep on a toilet paper shelf?”

“Doesn’t matter. Did you take it?”

She huffed.

“How could I have taken something I know nothing about? I didn’t even go to that shelf. You put your things somewhere and forget about them. You have to remember, where you put stuff.”

I frowned.

Was she lying? No.

She’s one of the few people around here who would never play a double game, gaslight or mock me. That’s why I liked her more than others.

Was it Norman then?

Or Eric?

“I see you’re feeling better.”

“I’m still under the weather.”

“Sure. I see.”

I smiled and headed back to my room.

I took a shower and sat down to do my makeup.

I needed my phone. I had to call dad. I had to warn him to give them time to get away and hide.

Otherwise I wouldn’t be able to escape.

Would I have time to find another phone?

No. They had no phones here. Everyone carries their phone on them. I was incredibly lucky to even find a charger.

How soon could Eric kill my family? Would I at least have time to get Bell on a bus?

I rested my hand on the table, still holding the brush.

Too risky. Bell would have to escape alone. I’d give her the watch and tell her where to run. And in the meantime, I was going to distract them in any way I could.

I walked up to the white dress hanging in the wardrobe and tossed it to the ground.

I hated white. White was a premonition of failure.

I opened the wardrobe and began to rummage through the clothes, looking for a color I’d like. My hand paused at a silver-gray dress.

I took the cami dress off the hanger and put it on.

I was so glad the zipper was on the side.

I walked up to the mirror and saw how the minimalistic bodice accentuated my waistline and breasts, while the slit on the side stretched all the way down from my hip. The dress was made of heavy satin.

I pulled my hair into a sleek high ponytail. I opened the nightstand and pulled out the pink box.

I put the watch on and realized I had to hide it.

I took a white knitted cardigan from the wardrobe and put it on.

I went downstairs and headed to the dining room. When I got there, the room was empty and the lights were turned off.

I saw Marta walk straight ahead with quick and steady steps, so I followed her.

She entered a cozy living room with a burning fireplace and began setting the table.

Why did we never dine here?
“Why aren’t you wearing white?”
I turned to reaper’s voice.
“I am wearing white. The cardigan’s white.”
I heard a car approaching and quickly walked to the front door.
Eric stopped me, grabbing my arm.
I looked up at him, expecting another snide remark, only to see him
scowl as his gaze dropped to my wrist.
I tried pulling my hand away, but he gripped it tighter.
He lifted my sleeve and saw the watch.
Ice ran through my veins and my stomach sank.
“What the fuck is that?”

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CHAPTER 42

~~Nothing scary ever happens in my life anymore. No danger's lurking around the corner, I've got no enemies looking for me and no karma to catch up with. I couldn't feel fear anymore. All the worst case scenarios have already played out in my head.~~

"A gift," I uttered under my breath.

My body was paralyzed with fear and my mind went blank when I saw the rage in his eyes.

"From who?"

I looked down, pursing my lips.

"I'm asking you, who's it from?"

Not daring to look up, I muttered,

"From August."

"Take it off."

"No, please! It's just a watch. It doesn't mean anything."

"Zoe, take the watch off or I will," he hissed through gritted teeth.

I knew he'd not be happy with me if he saw it. Bewildered, I stupidly blurted out the truth outright.

I took it off and passed it to him.

He broke the watch in front of me and threw it into the burning fireplace.

I watched it get charred by the flames, mirroring my hopes for an escape.

Tears welled up in my eyes, blurring his frame as he walked away.

I caught up and angrily pushed him in the back.

"What's your problem? What is it?"

He turned to me and I hit him in the chest.

"That was my watch. Mine."

I nearly screamed as tears filled my eyes and anger built up in my chest.

He grabbed my wrists and shook me twice.

"You don't have your own things, and you won't have any."

He let go of me and ran a hand through his hair, looking away.

“August. Why the fuck is he giving you gifts?”

“Maybe I sleep with him, too.”

He grabbed me by the throat roughly and I hit my head against the wall.

His eyes became a reflection of wrath.

“Come again,” he said, his voice cold as ice.

“He’s fucking me, too.”

I saw his chest rise and fall rapidly, his grip on my throat getting too strong.

He closed his eyes and opened them after a few seconds. When they met mine, I saw two chunks of black ice that sent a wave of fear into the very depths of my mind.

“Pray to your God, Zoe. Pray it’s not true. Because if you really slept with him, I’m gonna tie you to my bed, put a chair with the bastard tied to it next to it and cut every part of his body right before your eyes. And then I’m gonna fuck you in front of him. I’ll keep going until there’s nothing left to slice off. I’m gonna make sure neither him, nor you black out. I will leave his eyes intact, to let him see who you belong to.”

I was panting from the vivid images in my head that scared me to my core.

“The guests have arrived,” Marta said.

His grip loosened up.

I turned my head towards the voice and she shot me a judgmental look.

Eric didn’t move an inch.

He took his hand away from my neck and his thumb moved closer to my cheek.

I flinched. His hand stopped, and his thumb wiped away a fresh tear on my left cheek.

He stepped away and I began to wipe away the remaining tears.

I got to take two deep breaths before I welcomed Bell in.

I forced a smile when I saw Mortimer.

“The Roncallis, I’ve missed you already,” Mortimer lilted.

The scariest type of people was never those who openly hate and throw punches at you. It’s the ones that smile at you and try to please you while they’re sharpening a knife behind your back. A knife you’d never see coming until it’s too late.

We sat down at the table. Bell sat across from me, and Mortimer was across from Eric.

I tried to hold myself back from staring at Bell too much.

Mortimer was cutting a piece of meat on his plate and wouldn't shut up.

"How did you two meet?"

I picked up my glass.

"In the woods," Eric replied calmly.

I took a big gulp of wine.

"Zoe enjoys walks in the woods."

I could barely hold my nervous giggle in.

"What an interesting encounter."

Mortimer was smiling, chewing on a piece of meat.

"Do you work, Zoe?"

"My wife doesn't work. She's a housewife."

I forced a smile, feeling the tension radiating from Eric's tone.

"What do you do in your spare time, then?"

"The house's big. A wife has plenty to do."

I didn't understand why he was so curt with him.

If he kept going like this, Mortimer would get up and leave, dragging Bell with him.

I kicked Eric's leg but he ignored me.

"How old are you? You look quite young."

"My wife's 27. Soon to be 28."

"And do you...?"

I was about to ask a question when I saw Eric pull out my phone, placing it on the table.

Noticing my shock, he asked,

"Is something wrong, my love?"

I looked up at him with a small smile.

"No. Everything's just fine."

I began to straighten up the already neat-looking napkin in my lap.

"You got a new phone?"

"Yes. I've been looking for it for a while and found it in the corner of my drawer. Buried under a pile of papers."

I smiled, still fixing my napkin.

I looked up and smiled at Mortimer.

"Excuse me, I'm going to have to leave you for a moment."

Eric got up and left the room.

My eyes fell on Bell. She barely ate anything. She was picking at peas on her plate with a fork, looking at me from under her eyebrows.

“You have to excuse Eric. He’s a little grumpy today. We had a small fight before your visit. He takes it hard when we fight.”

“I get it. It’s fine.”

We continued eating, and I began babbling away like a TV reporter. Mortimer feigned interest, but I could see boredom in his eyes.

After a while, Eric finally came back.

“Sorry for the wait.”

He leaned in and put a necklace on my neck. The same one I nearly paid for with my life.

“This is a very beautiful necklace. Looks expensive,” Mortimer said.

I wanted to tell him it really was expensive, though not because of its price, but decided against it.

Why did he give me the necklace?

I lifted my head to look at Eric and quickly forced a smile.

“Thank you,” I said under my breath.

He lightly touched my hair and sat back down.

“You look like a loving couple,” Mortimer remarked.

Eric rested his palm on my leg, squeezing and releasing it.

“And we are. Aren’t we, darling?”

I dug my nails into his hand, wishing to hurt him.

“Yes, honey.”

I turned my head, smiling at him and playing up to his sick game.

I felt like I was putting too much energy into small talk and that fake smile.

“I think we should leave you boys be so Laura and I can gossip a little in the guest room. Would you mind, Mortimer?”

I could see him getting tense. His smile was no longer as broad as it was a few seconds ago.

I felt that had Eric not been in the room with us, he’d have said no or simply brushed me off.

“Sure, but don’t go anywhere. I need to know, where Laura is.”

“Of course. We’ll be in the next room over,” I smiled.

Bell got up and kissed Mortimer mindlessly. I balled my hand into a fist to keep from grabbing a plate and chucking it at his head.

“Don’t you want to give me a kiss, baby?”

My head snapped towards Eric. I narrowed my eyes slightly and tried not to show anger in my expression with everything I had in me.

I leaned in towards him and our lips met in a quick kiss.

His right hand grabbed the back of my head and pulled my lips closer. He knew I wouldn’t resist him with Mortimer watching.

His lips covered mine. His tongue captured mine possessively, reminding me who was in charge here.

I wanted to convince myself I didn’t care, but that simply wasn’t true.

I wanted the kiss to go on, despite the oppressive feeling of guilt.

I pulled away and leaned closer to his ear.

“I hope to see you die.”

His smile grew wider.

“And I love you, too.”

I gave him a sweet smile back.

Bell and I left the living room.

We walked side by side.

“There are no cameras in the house,” I whispered.

We entered the guest room and I closed the double doors behind us.

We ran into each other’s arms and hugged tight.

“I’m gonna cry,” she said into my shoulder.

“If you start, I’m gonna cry, too, and it won’t stop.”

We sat on the couch, holding each other’s hands and choking our tears back.

I remembered my phone and felt my heart fall.

“The plan’s changed a bit. You will have to run alone.”

“What? But why?”

“Eric found my phone. He knew I had one, but never cared about it until today. I couldn’t call dad to tell him everything. If I run away, he’ll kill them.”

I could see panic in her eyes.

“I’m not going anywhere. I can’t do it alone. Not even gonna try.”

“Bell. I know you’re scared. So scared it feels like you’re gonna die. But don’t let your fear turn into panic. Panic is our enemy. You have to fight and run.”

Bell shook her head.

“This is suicide, Zo. I saw what he did to those who betrayed him. He does not forgive. I’ll be tortured until there’s nothing left of me. I’m scared... I...”

Her body was shaking. She was staring straight before her, as if Mortimer already knew everything.

I took her by the shoulders and turned her to make our eyes meet.

“My dream is in your hands now. I dream of escaping this place. I dream of kissing my mom and hugging my dad. I want to run away from here and get my freedom and my life back. And I will do it. And I believe it. No losing streak lasts forever. Evil can’t come out on top all the time. Luck has got to be on our side. Something good has to happen. And if the good times aren’t coming, we’ll bring them around ourselves.”

Tears were streaming down Bell’s cheeks.

I gripped her hands.

“But maybe you can still call them? Maybe we could find another phone?”

“No. They won’t have enough time to hide. The phone doesn’t matter at this point.”

Bell’s fingers were wiping my face. I didn’t even notice my tears falling down.

I flicked them away hastily.

“I’m gonna give you this necklace and tell you, where to run.”

“A necklace? What happened to the watch?”

“He found it right before you came. He broke it and threw the pieces in the fireplace. The watch was a gift from an acquaintance, a man he isn’t too fond of. He found out about it, and I lost my head and told him where I got it from.”

“He’s jealous.”

“What? No. He’s not jealous. He doesn’t like me.”

Bell smirked.

“And the *my wife* talk? He’s jealous of you and Mortimer.”

“No,” I scrunched my nose, “he’s a sick bastard who thinks my life belongs to him. He only knows how to boss around and manipulate people as if he owns them. He’s incapable of feeling jealous.”

Bell fell silent.

“It looked like you’d had a fight and he was apologizing to you.”

I frowned.

“The necklace seems like an apology.”

I touched the necklace.

“No.”

“Then why did he give it to you?”

“If he wanted to say sorry, he could have just said it instead of making a show of his gift. He just wanted to flaunt it, show you how good of a family we are.”

“What if it’s his way of apologizing? Maybe, to him, showing off is the act of saying sorry?”

“What makes you say that?”

A smile tugged at my lips.

“The way he looks at you?”

“What way would that be?”

Bell was about to reply, but I cut her to it.

“He’ll definitely take his necklace back. He knows I almost got killed over the damned thing. Giving it was either a threat to me, or an attempt to show off in front of Mortimer. He’s a good actor. Don’t trust him. And he’s got a girlfriend. He goes to see her every day. And... it doesn’t matter anyway.”

“Yes, sorry. I was just... surprised how different our lives were.”

“Now your life’s gonna change for the better.”

“When are you going to escape, Zoe? You aren’t staying here, are you?”

“No. Once you’re out of here and you feel certain you aren’t in danger anymore, I want you to call my dad and tell him everything.”

“Then you’d escape?”

Mortimer’s bound to find everything out sooner or later. And I hoped it wouldn’t come too soon. But once it did, Eric would know I did it. That I helped her escape.

Then he’d have two options, to tell him or to hide it.

If he told Mortimer the truth, I’d be dead.

If he covered it, I’d survive but I’d never get to see them again.

I was ready to make the sacrifice. I wanted to free them from him.

“Yes.”

I gave her a small smile.

“Once I get out, I’m gonna call the police and send them here. I’ll reach out to press and make a huge fuss about it. I’m not...”

“Bell. Don’t.”

“Why?”

“You told me yourself Mortimer was a dangerous and influential man. They’re both psychopaths. They’d pay everyone off. And they’d be able to track you down through them. I don’t want you to give yourself away.”

“And what do you want me to do, Zo? Act like you’re doing fine? That you’re living the dream? Do you want me to keep living like you don’t exist?”

Tears welled up in my eyes.

I tried to swallow the lump in my throat, but couldn’t.

“Yes. I want that. This is the price of freedom. Freedom I want you to get back. Live for me. Do everything you’ve ever dreamed of, or don’t, just keep living, okay?”

“How are you so cruel, Zo?”

A tear ran down her cheek.

“I’m sorry.”

I gave her a tight hug.

Tears blurred my vision.

Sniffling, I went on,

“I got you comfortable shoes. I don’t have any sneakers. Flats are the only heel-less shoes I’ve got here. Still, it’s better than running through the woods in high heels. I’ve packed you some food to get by for now and a knife.”

I saw a glimpse of fear in her eyes.

“You have to be ready for anything. I want you to fight. Fight for your life. Bell, choose yourself, not him. Choose your own life, not his. He wouldn’t choose yours. Do you understand?”

Bell nodded her head silently.

Fear was written all over her face, but I could also see a hint of determination now.

I left the room and headed to the living room to tell them that everything was fine and we were going to my room to try on some dresses.

I entered the room, but saw no one there.

I looked at the phone and saw the screen blink off. I tapped on it and saw ten missed calls from my dad.

The phone rang again, making me jump.

I picked it up and brought the phone to my ear.

“Zoe... Zoe, your mother... she’s gone.”

The phone fell out of my hand with a thud, hitting the tile floor and shattering into pieces.

Silence felt deafening. My whole body felt numb. I stared straight ahead, but saw nothing, like I was standing in a dark tunnel.

I could feel something coming. Something so horrible I would never outlast it.

I chose not to wait for it. I turned around and ran back to Bell.

The door opened, and I said,

“We’re leaving.”

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CHAPTER 43

~~Staying by myself became my goal. I no longer wanted to make friends, build relationships, or seek support. I put my faith in loneliness. After all, loneliness can't deceive you, it can't cheat on you or betray you. It would stay with you forever as a table for one for a quiet night out and a spacious bed meant only for you.~~

The chill no longer hurt our limbs. I couldn't feel mine. All I could feel were my burning lungs and a dull ache in my chest.

My heart was beating so fast I could no longer feel it. Like it was no longer working.

The woods were dark. The branches grabbed my arms like silhouettes of shadow people. They were trying to stop me. To suck me into the void and bury me there forever.

Darkness was crawling under my skin, wriggling its way into my head. The thought of us getting lost made my chest tighten up in panic.

But I couldn't trust my thoughts anymore. I simply kept running.

We didn't stop once throughout this time. Because the game was on the moment I entered the room. Our lives were at stake.

The loser would die.

I gave Bell my coat and put on Eric's black cloak. The same one I first saw him in. It still smelled of him. His scent gave me strength. Strength to run faster for a chance to never see him again.

It was drizzling. The rain stung our faces, getting in the eyes. It's like it was helping us wash our sins away to finally free ourselves and get our old lives back.

I held Bell's hand. Her warmth invigorated me. I could feel we were on the right track. I believed we'd make it.

I didn't know, how long we were running for, but we finally saw the yellow lights of the street lamps among the trees up ahead.

Once we were out of the woods, I felt our lustration ritual was over. The nature gave us another chance. It had faith in our rebirth.

We didn't stop running, now heading towards the pawn shop. Every move mattered. Every minute was precious.

We hastily ran into the pawn shop, panting heavily. Warm smell of old junk blasted our noses. I was struggling to unclasp the ice-cold necklace with trembling fingers. My hands were barely responsive, my eyes couldn't see, so Bell helped me with it.

"How much...", I was out of breath, "how much would you give us for it?" I asked in a single burst.

An old man with a gray beard and round glasses resting on his nose furrowed his long brows at us.

"Is someone after you?"

"We want to make it for the last bus," I blurted out, giving him a strained smile.

I inhaled the warm air, yet I couldn't get enough of it. The place felt like there was no air around at all.

He looked us over suspiciously and slowly took the necklace in his hand, examining it under a magnifying glass.

"Ladies, I don't have that much money."

He handed the necklace back to me.

"We'll take whatever you can give."

The man took the necklace to the back through a brown bead curtain and came back with a stack of cash. He placed it on the counter.

I grabbed it and we ran out of the pawn shop like it was on fire.

I was so grateful to all the Gods of this forsaken place for the pawn shop being so close to the bus terminal.

"Two tickets for any of the next buses."

The ticket booth was about to close, but luck was on our side. I hoped we hadn't run out of it and a losing streak wasn't in the cards for us tonight.

Bell sat down on a wooden bench. The paint was peeling off of it.

I was pacing the pavement, waiting for the bus, pushing and rolling the ring anxiously so hard it hurt.

It should be here any minute.

Those were some of the most agonizing minutes of my life.

Adrenaline was running high, swinging me around on the tallest roller-coaster.

It seemed to me that Mortimer would walk out of the woods any moment, like a serial killer, to gun us down.

Headlamps of the passing cars would make me freeze. It felt like Eric was about to show up. I wasn't afraid of him, but of what he might say. It was something I was too scared to even think about.

I looked up at the rusty clock hanging on the old bus station building. We've been gone for two hours already. They must be looking for us already.

Anxiety was gnawing at me, making my heart jump like a tennis ball on a racket.

Were they gonna go to the university first? Was it even open?

I prayed it was.

It was important for us to know when they realized we were gone. If it happened after an hour or so, we stood a chance. If they found out before then, we were already dead.

I kept rolling the ring hard on my middle finger. Pain kept my feet on the ground, not letting me get lost in my own thoughts. I was getting harder to fight them off.

Maybe we should have taken a car?

No. They'd have heard the car running straight away. And I wasn't sure the car would have been free of trackers. Even if we were to drive away, he'd still find us.

Maybe we should have hitch-hiked?

No. It's night-time. We're two girls wearing gowns. We might as well have stayed at the house.

"Zoe."

Bell pulled me out of the slough of my thoughts.

"Look."

For the first time in a long while I could see her genuine smile. Feeble sense of joy filled my mind, but it was still a long way away from actual relief.

The bus headlights illuminated the wet road ahead, and the sound of the old engine came closer, drowning out the silence.

I came up to her and hugged Bell tight.

"We made it, just as I promised you. We made it, see?"

Bell nodded, smiling to me. I could see tears of joy in her eyes, and I hugged her tight once more.

We stood there, holding hands, watching as the bus rolled up to the terminal.

Bell pulled me towards the doors.

“Let’s go.”

“You go first. I’ll make sure it’s okay.”

If someone shows up, I’ll hold them back. I would sacrifice myself for Bell. I promised her life, and she’d have it.

“Zoe?”

I turned my head to look at her.

“Thank you.”

My eyes spotted a shadow of a man by the bus.

I opened my mouth to warn her, but the bullet was faster. It exited Bell’s head and I saw a stream of blood flowing from her forehead down her nose and cheek. She fell on dirty pavement like she was never alive at all.

I ran up to her, my knees hitting the asphalt.

“Bell. Bell. Bell.”

I laid her head on my lap. Her open eyes glazed over. My hands were shaking, tears falling down on their own.

I couldn’t deny what I saw.

She was dead.

Life left her body fast and I was glad she got to have at least an illusion of happiness before she got killed like a wild animal.

I closed her eyes and began stroking her hair.

“I’m sorry. I’m so sorry, Bell. Please, forgive me.”

I kept whispering like she could still hear me.

I nestled her still warm body in my arms, rocking her back and forth, like a baby.

“Turns out you’re even dumber than I thought.”

The familiar voice made my body shudder. I’d hoped to never hear that voice again.

I lifted my tearful eyes to look at Mortimer.

He was wearing a dark-brown trench-coat, a gun still in his left hand.

“I’m going to kill you,” I hissed.

His grim laughter sounded muffled with the bus running next to us.

I gingerly laid Bell’s head on the ground. I slowly got to my feet and took a few steps towards him.

His ghoulish smile finally matched his true nature. We no longer had to play this stupid game.

When I was right in front of him, he pointed the gun at my chest.

My hand slipped into my right pocket, feeling about for the knife.

“Who do you think you are? A savior? Hero? You’re less than fucking nothing.”

“And who’re you? A murderer, rapist, psychopath...”

He pistol-whipped me in the temple.

I slipped and fell to the asphalt, hitting my elbow on the hard ground.

My vision went dark and I tried blinking the blackness away.

I touched my temple and felt warm blood seeping out.

“Wonder why he took you in. You’re a yappy cow who doesn’t know when to shut up. Did you like our interior? Did Laura show you our house? I saw you chat in her room. You never left it once. You knew one another.”

I tried getting up, but he kicked me in the stomach. My breath hitched as my back met the asphalt.

“Zoe Torn. I looked you up. A wife? Housewife? You’re a fucking loser. No education, no remarkable blood or a wink of power. Your family’s up to their ears in debt, your mom’s in a coma. You should worship Eric for taking someone like you under his wing.”

He pressed his foot on my stomach and leaned in.

“It’s your fault my Laura’s dead. My wife died today because of you, bitch.”

He kicked me in the ribs. I yelled out in pain, feeling one of them crack.

“Her name’s Bell. Bastard,” I hissed through the pain.

His foot collided with my face and everything started spinning. I was sure I’d pass out.

My eyes stared at the bleak star-filled sky.

He stepped on my broken rib and I screamed at the top of my lungs. He grabbed me by the hair, lifting me to my knees.

“She was my wife. Laura was my wife.”

I looked into his rage-filled eyes, realizing he actually believed his own ravings.

“She is not your wife,” I spat.

He slapped me.

The running engine muffled all the sounds.

“Any last words, bitch?”

“What do you value most in life?”

He looked at me like I was dirt under his shoes.

“What the fuck are you talking about?”

I gripped the knife tighter, slowly pulling it out of my pocket.

“You took her from me, and I’ll take the only precious thing you have left.”

I drove the knife into the neck with one swift stab. His eyes widened in shock. He dropped the gun, grasping at the knife in his throat. He was suffocating, choking on blood.

Fighting through the pain, I got back to my feet, feeling in control once again.

“Looks like you need help.”

I approached him confidently, jerking the knife out of his neck.

A stream of blood spurted out like a fountain as his choking got worse. He dropped to his knees, struggling to cover the wound with his hand.

I came closer and kicked him in the chest. He fell to the ground, quivering in agony.

He had seconds left to live, and I was going to make sure they felt like hell.

I sat on top of him and began stabbing the knife into his body. He whined, but his moans stopped soon after.

I kept stabbing and dragging the knife out until the body was nothing but a mess of blood and wounds staining my face, hands, cloak and dress. He wasn’t breathing anymore, but I kept thrusting the knife deep into his body.

I couldn’t stop. I wanted to keep killing him. Again. And again.

“Zoe.”

I froze, knife still in my hand.

“He can’t feel it anymore.”

Eric crouched down, but I wouldn’t look at him.

“Give me the knife.”

I ignored him.

“He’s dead. He can’t feel anything now.”

“Then why can’t I feel anything anymore, either?”

My gaze fell on my hands, still gripping the knife.

“Kill me.”

He stayed silent.

“Kill me,” I yelled.

His eyes, two black holes in outer space, stared at me.

“I ran away and betrayed you. You told me you’d kill me.”

He stared back in silence.

“Not today, Zoe.”

When? When would you kill me? I couldn’t wait any longer.

I wanted the pain to stop. The pain was unbearable, it broke my bones and ground them together with my innards.

I was on fire. My mind, my body and my soul were consumed by pain. They twisted and smoldered within me.

The pain wouldn’t go away. It got worse and worse.

I turned the knife over and my left hand gripped the right. I turned it on myself, but Eric’s warm hand didn’t let it dig into my flesh.

“Let go!”

“No.”

“I want to die!” I cried out through tears.

“You aren’t gonna die.”

“Let me die!”

He forcefully opened my hand and took the knife away. He threw it away and the knife hit the pavement with a clink.

“No!” I yelled at the top of my voice.

Wailing and sobbing took over my screams. They came from the bottom of my heart, crawling to my throat. My whole body was shaking. I wanted to leave this mortal frame and put it to rest for good.

Eric pulled me close, wrapping me in a warm embrace. I gripped his arm with both hands, choking on my tears.

I’d never experienced such all-consuming pain before. It tried to wipe me off the face of the earth but I kept breathing. I felt like I was in hell. And I truly was.

CHAPTER 44

~~The darkness was always close. It knew of my sins and held my hand. It whispered whose life I should take, slipping the knife in my hands. I didn't even notice when it merged with me and took over. I make no decisions anymore, it's in charge now.~~

I woke up in the same room, lying in the same position, still in the same clothes.

I couldn't sleep properly for an entire month.

My sleep was so superficial that I confused it with the silence in my head.

I hadn't cried since that day. I thought I was no longer capable of feeling anything, showing emotions or even crying.

Eric didn't trust me, so I had to sleep in his room. I didn't care where I slept. I just wanted to stay down.

I knew he was afraid of me taking my own life. But I was so exhausted I wasn't even sure I had the strength to do it by that point.

He took all the sharp objects from the bedroom and bathroom. He removed window handles. He wouldn't leave the manor as often.

Almost every night we'd fall asleep on our separate sides of the bed and wake up.

I couldn't remember the last time I left the room or went outside.

Eric took away the mirror hanging across from the bed and replaced it with a painting. I didn't know, why he did it, but I didn't care what to look at, be it a mirror, a painting or the bare wall. I couldn't care less what to look at, nothing brought out any emotions in me.

My days flew by as if they were on fast forward. They consisted of me opening my eyes, looking at the painting, and then closing them back. Every day was the same.

Marta brought me food. Sometimes I would eat something, but most of the time I didn't eat at all.

I didn't see why I needed to eat if I wasn't doing anything. I was just lying there all day, staring at the painting.

I didn't think I needed to eat. They'd better save the food and not waste it on me. Besides, I had no appetite, so I didn't really need it.

I almost stopped drinking water because going to the bathroom was tiring me out and took too much energy. And I needed that energy to finish the day, and then another one, and another one, and the one after that.

I realized I no longer liked walking. I didn't understand why I should walk or do anything if I could just lie down.

I'd wake up almost every night and stare into the darkness, imagining I could see the painting in it. When I closed my eyes, I'd open them when I could see it again.

I heard Eric enter the room. He usually returned when it got dark. When he was away, Norman or Marta came to check on me.

Marta kept scolding me for refusing to eat and staying in bed all the time. She was so mad and I couldn't see, why.

Her shouting wore me down fast, so I stopped paying attention to her.

I heard the plates clatter.

Eric walked up to me and lifted my pillow up a bit.

My pulse sped up and I didn't like it. I wanted to lie down and do nothing.

He sat on the bed and took a bowl of soup.

"Open your mouth."

I did, and he began spoon-feeding me.

I didn't need to be fed. He was wasting his time. It's no use.

I ate half the bowl of soup and slid down the pillow, turning my back to him.

He never made me talk, get up or eat on my own. He'd simply come in, feed me, cover me with a blanket and leave.

I didn't understand, why he wasn't mad at me, didn't hate me. He was supposed to be livid with me for disobeying him. I expected him to beat me up, throw me in a cage to starve. Or to yell at me, at least, boss me around, say something nasty, humiliate or gaslight me.

I could feel the soup warm me up on the inside. I felt the liquid moving through me. And I wanted to get rid of it. I didn't like feeling things.

“Do you want me to wash you?”

“Do I stink?”

“No.”

“No need, then.”

I lay down straight when I heard the door closing.

I kept looking at the painting.

I memorized every detail on it. It got imprinted in my head like a memorized poem. I could see it when I closed my eyes.

Was dad gone, too?

I could see the sunlight coming through the dark clouds.

Mom died because of me.

Fluffy clouds of gray and blue.

I couldn't save her.

Birds flying South.

Bell was dead because of me.

Green grass and a dense forest in the distance.

I killed them.

The sun made a gray cloud a little lighter, but they would never match one another.

They were dead because of me.

The gray cloud would always stay gray.

I sat on the bed and reached for the nightstand.

He took all the cutlery away.

How could I get myself to bleed out before the ambulance came?

He removed the bathroom door lock, but he was out, and he probably wouldn't be back soon.

I looked all over the room, but could see nothing that could do me any harm.

I should have taken a gun from Mortimer and shot myself in the head. This would have been the quickest way to go.

If I were to cut myself, there was a chance I'd get rescued, and the blood loss would leave me handicapped if I didn't do a good enough job.

I went to the bathroom and turned the light on. It was obscenely bright. It made my eyes hurt.

I looked up and saw a ghost staring at me in the mirror. My hair was dirty, clothes wrinkled, my face was pale-gray, and my eyes had a blank look to them.

I quickly looked away, but then turned back again.

The mirror was stuck to the wall, but maybe I could break it and get a piece. I just need one piece. Just a tiny shard.

I left the bathroom and went back to the bedroom. My gaze slowly searched the things in the room, but all of them were large and blunt.

I walked to the bedside chest and pulled out one of the drawers. It had a round steel knob. I came back to the bathroom and turned the knob to face the mirror.

I hit it once and saw a small crack. After two more hits, the mirror showed more cracks, but there was still no sign of breaking.

I dropped the drawer to the floor and it fell with a crash. The echo stunned me. I tried picking out the shards, but they were glued to the wall.

I sighed heavily, feeling insanely worn-out.

I got on my knees, and the cold tile floor sent shivers down my spine.

When my legs went numb, I staggered back to my feet. I walked to the bath and decided to get in. I sat in the bath in my clothes and pushed the plug into the drain hole.

I kept turning the water on and off. I liked the sound of it.

I left it running. Water began to fill the tub.

I made it hot enough to burn my skin. I could see it turn red.

Vapor was filling the room, making it hard to breathe. The cracked mirror was covered by white fog.

The water filled the tub to the brim and I turned the tap off.

I wondered how long I could hold my breath.

I bent my knees and was about to dive into the water when the bathroom door opened.

Eric's eyes immediately found mine and I turned away, making bubbles in the water.

I watched him walk to the drawer, pick it up and place it on the sink.

He saw the mirror was cracked.

Was he going to get angry?

He came closer to me and got on his knees.

"Did you get hurt?"

His eyes slid over my body.

He took my arms, checking them out.

"No."

He let go of me and began rolling up the sleeves of his dark blue shirt.

“Pull up a bit. I’ll undress you.”

I did as he said.

He took my nightgown off and threw it on the floor with a wet thud.

It laid there like a floor rag.

“What’s the point in living? I’m born, I go on to study, work, create a family and then die. What’s the point? Why do anything, if there’s nothing but darkness waiting for me in the end?”

I let out a strangled chuckle. It sounded filthy, like I’d just blown dust off a book cover.

“What was I born for? I want nothing and can’t do anything. I’m useless. I’m not even good for the tasks you give me. I can’t carry them out well at all.”

I lifted my head to look at him.

His brows were furrowed, jaw clenched tight.

“I like the way you carry out my tasks.”

I let my fingers slide across the water.

“You’re flattering me because I’m pitiful. I’ve got nothing to give you, but you still kept a loser like me instead of killing me.”

“Zoe?”

“Huh?”

I wouldn’t meet his gaze.

“You don’t have to ask or answer any questions right now. Just stay in the tub, and I’m gonna wash you.”

He reached for the bottle of shampoo and squeezed some into his hand.

“Did you kill my dad?”

“No.”

I should have felt relief, but only got a hint of anxiety.

He began lathering my hair with shampoo.

I’d never come back to him. I wasn’t going to try and escape again. I wasn’t going to try and save anybody. I’d stay here and save dad’s life. That’s the only way he could live without much trouble.

I knew he’d lose the two most important people in his life, just like I had.

Eric began to rinse the shampoo out of my hair. Then he lathered my hair again, massaging my scalp.

I refused to keep fighting. I was ready to do whatever he told me for a chance to feel something again. I wasn’t going to resist him. I gave up.

Eric rinsed the shampoo out and turned off the shower.

He took a towel and began to dry me gingerly.

“I’m a burden.”

“That’s for me to decide.”

“I like your smell.”

His hands paused for a moment, then he continued to dry me as if we were husband and wife.

He helped me out of the bath and wrapped the towel around me. I left the bathroom and lay back down on the bed.

He took the towel off me and put a loose black T-shirt on me.

“Does this mean I have to give you my nighty now?”

I saw the corners of his lips perk up.

I lied down, and he covered me with a blanket.

I patted him on the side.

“I broke a mirror, we’ve got seven years of bad luck ahead of us now.”

“We’ll get through it.”

He went to the closet.

I tried to push away the endless stream of burning questions.

It’s like my brain had been turned on and was working again.

I kept rolling the ring on my left middle finger.

I looked down at it. I rolled it around twice and got out of bed.

I turned the light in the bathroom on and came to the toilet.

I opened the lid, took the ring off and looked at it for a while.

You couldn’t keep your promise, and I forgive you. Because I can’t keep mine, either.

I dropped the ring into the toilet and flushed it.

I turned around and saw Eric. He was watching me closely.

I switched the light off and left the bathroom.

We got in bed and Eric turned the lights off.

I kept staring at the painting in the dark.

CHAPTER 45

~~Memories became my sanctuary. I'd dive into them for the pleasure they gave me. I'd flee to them to hide from all the pain I couldn't cope with. I liked to replay the sweet moments and live through them over and over like they were real, refusing to acknowledge my delusions.~~

Since that morning, I'd been replaying the memories of Bell's death like a vinyl record with a horror movie soundtrack.

I had to remember her movements, words, facial expressions, the color of her clothes and the weather.

I closed my eyes and remembered everything that happened seconds before the disaster in detail.

I remembered the knife slicing into Mortimer's body like butter.

It was making me nauseous.

I felt fear. I remembered how adrenaline, pain and fear rose up against me.

I swallowed hard at the memories.

I was a murderer. The death of Roosevelt, Mortimer, Bell and my mom was my fault.

I was so selfish. The most selfish creature on the planet.

I took Bell's hand and led her to her death. She didn't want to run. She knew she wouldn't make it out. She believed it, and I changed her mind.

I was so devastated by my own grief, I didn't even think of dad's life. I should be on my knees before Eric, praising him for sparing dad's life.

I had no excuse for myself. I was detestable. I made myself sick. I hated myself.

I threw the blanket to the side.

I was mad. I wanted to let my anger out. I wanted to hurt myself.

I rushed about the room, trying to find something useful. I wanted to punch myself. I wanted someone to punch me. I needed to punish myself. I

craved this pain.

When I couldn't find anything, I fell to the floor and began banging my head on it, screaming.

I felt my heart rise from the ashes, beating wildly. I felt alive again.

The stormy emotions began to subside, replaced by the pain in my head.

The door opened and I closed my eyes, pretending to be asleep.

I heard Eric's steps. His persistent scent preceded him.

He picked me up from the floor and took me to the bed.

He pulled the covers over me and went to the closet.

I opened my eyes to see him wearing a black long sleeve shirt and those same blue checkered pants.

I wasn't used to seeing him in home wear. I didn't think he even had any.

I looked up and met his eyes. He got in bed, not covering himself with a blanket.

I turned to face him.

"It isn't night yet."

"I know."

"Are you sleepy?"

"No."

I narrowed my eyes.

"Why are you in bed, then?"

"I can't lie down in my own bed?"

A chuckle escaped my throat.

"What's so funny?"

"You're so short-fused. Always a moment away from blowing up."

"So are you."

"That's not true."

I turned away from him.

Then turned back.

"It is true."

I saw a smile tug at his lips.

And all was quiet once again.

It was so comfortable I didn't want to break it. The aftertaste of our exchange felt like a stroke of a feather on bare skin.

"We'll never be equals, but we're alike. Right?"

I turned to look at him.

The corners of his lips lifted.

“Funny you should say that.”

“Why?”

He slowly dragged his gaze away from the painting.

“Because you can’t stand me.”

“As if you can’t say the same about me.”

“You’re constantly pushing my buttons.”

“I thought it was your job.”

He smiled.

I was admiring his smile. I liked that it tugged at my idle feelings.

“You’re very lucky to have me, you know.”

His smile grew wider.

“Look how many colors I added to your life. I’ve definitely spruced up your black vibe.”

“My what?”

“You are a fan of black, aren’t you?”

He laughed so loudly it made me smile, too.

His laugh was deep and velvety.

“I like your laugh.”

I felt stupid saying that.

Why did I say it?

“And my smell.”

“Your smell?”

A sharp wave of heat washed over my body.

“I wasn’t complimenting you. I was just trying to create a friendly environment, okay?”

“Okay. And I like your hair.”

My heart felt like it was being wound up. It was thumping faster than usual.

I turned to the painting.

“You’re flirting with me.”

“You started it.”

I turned towards him.

“I told you, I wasn’t flirting.”

“You are flirting.”

I threw back the covers and, covering the small distance between us, sat down on his lap.

“That’s flirting.”

My smile quickly faded as I realized what I had done.

I tried to pull back, but his hands grabbed my waist, holding me in place.

His face got serious.

"I... I can't," I whispered, staring at his black long sleeve.

"Then we won't," he whispered back.

His hands slid from my waist to my hips.

They were so warm, I could feel the heat radiating from them through the fabric of my cotton pants.

I swallowed down the tension.

"You're the only one I have left. The only one who understands."

He gently took my chin and lifted it to make our eyes meet.

His bottomless eyes looked at me fondly.

He pulled his hand away and tucked a loose strand of hair behind my ear.

His fingers slid along the strand, releasing it at the very end.

"Do you feel anything?"

I looked back down at his shirt.

"You already know," I whispered, running my fingers along the folds of his long sleeve.

"No. That's why I'm asking."

"Sometimes."

I looked up at him.

"Do you feel anything now?"

I looked down and kept running my fingers over one of the folds.

"Yes."

A weak smile found its way to my lips.

I picked another fold and began running my hands over it, straightening it to match the size of the first one.

"Don't ask me the next question."

"Was I going to?"

I lifted my gaze to give him a slightly judgmental look.

"You want to know, but I don't want to answer."

"I already know, so I don't need your answer."

My pulse was ringing in my ears.

"And I don't know your answer," I whispered.

He was about to say it, but I covered his mouth with my hand.

"I don't want to know."

His left hand gently took mine and kissed my palm, not looking away from my eyes even for a moment.

I lay down on his chest.

The beating of his heart brought me tranquility, like the sweeps of ocean tides. The heat of his body was as warm as the rays of morning sun. And his scent embraced me, giving me the feeling of safety.

“Don’t ask me any more questions. I’m tired.”

His right hand stroked my head until I fell asleep.

I woke up feeling too hot.

I realized that I was lying on the side while Eric held me close.

I kicked the covers off and laid my head on the pillow.

He used to instill so much fear in me that I thought it’d do me in eventually.

I felt like he could destroy me with a single glare.

Looking back, I realized how far we’d come. How our relationship had been altered not only by the passage of time, but also by the hardships we’d overcome together.

Had I forgiven him? No.

Did I hate him? I didn’t know.

It got hard for me to answer any questions.

I could wake up and regret doing it. And then I could laugh and act like it never happened two hours later.

My brain stopped working. I followed routine patterns of behavior.

I no longer felt fear, it gave way to suspicion.

I no longer trusted myself, and that feeling wouldn’t go away. It’s like I’d let myself down. It’s like I was doing it over and over again. Day after day.

And I had no idea what to do about it and whether anything had to be done at all.

I lived in uncertainty and couldn’t tell when it was about to get easier for me, or when life was ready to push me deeper into a hole.

I had no support. I’d fall down and struggle to get back up.

And it’d keep going day after day.

CHAPTER 46

~~My problem is that I find it hard to give up on my planned course. I can change my mind halfway through, but I can't give up. I strive to finish my tasks, wearing myself out in the process. I don't give a damn about anyone, myself included. After all, I can't let anything stand in my way.~~

I woke up and saw his hand on my waist.

Why hadn't he left yet?

I tried to scoot aside, but he just pulled me closer.

"Don't go," he whispered huskily.

My heart skipped a beat and started beating faster, waking me up and making me feel alive.

I lay there, trying to remember the last time I felt so alive. I was a kid back then. I remember how I felt when I got a doll.

I would dream about it from the moment I saw it at the store.

I kept telling my parents how much I wanted it. What dresses I'd dress her in, what shoes I'd choose, what handbags and hairstyles I'd pick for her.

Sometimes before bed I'd imagine how I would play it, where it would go and what it would do.

Then my birthday came.

When I woke up that morning, I saw mom and dad standing there with their hands behind their backs and smiles on their faces.

I remember squealing loud enough for the whole house to hear when they gave me the doll I'd been waiting for so long for.

She was perfect.

Tall, beautiful, with tons of clothes and accessories. I remember the thrill of waiting for a new day to come so I could play with her again.

Time passed and I thought she could use a few friends, a house and a car. I pestered mom and dad about it. And after a short while, when I finally got

other dolls and a house for them, I no longer felt the same pure joy I felt the day I got the first doll.

Thinking about it now, it felt like the problem was that I couldn't get what I wanted so badly for a long time. After all, I got the other toys so fast I didn't have time to dream about them.

I never got the pink car, but time flew by too quickly and I promised myself I'd buy a real one when I grew up.

"Don't you have to go to work?"

"No."

"It's Wednesday. You always leave on Wednesdays."

"Not this Wednesday."

But why?

"You haven't been sleeping this whole time."

"No."

"What were you thinking about?"

"A pink car."

He chuckled.

"A pink car?"

I turned to face him.

"What's so funny?"

There was a knock on the door and I quickly moved away from Eric, pulling the covers over my head.

I heard the clatter of plates and the creaking of wheels.

I knew it was Marta.

I did nothing wrong. Why did I feel so embarrassed then?

Did she think I was sleeping with him?

I could feel my face burn. This was so awkward.

When I heard the door close, I threw the blanket aside.

Eric walked around the bed and sat on my side. He moved a small table to the bed.

I lifted myself up to lean against the headboard.

He took a sip of coffee and bit into his sandwich.

Smile never left his face.

"What's with the smile?"

He handed me his sandwich and I took a bite.

"Do you care what Marta thinks of you that much?"

I could feel myself blush again.

“Don’t you judge me.”

He kept smiling, sipping his coffee.

“Did she wonder about us?”

The last word got stuck on the tip of my tongue. It felt weird to say it out loud. It sounded like a foreign word I’d only just learned.

“No. She’s just worried about you.”

He handed me a spoonful of porridge and I opened my mouth.

“Did you ask her about it?”

He furrowed his brows a bit.

“No.”

He scooped up a spoonful of porridge and ate it, licking the spoon.

“Since it’s your day off, what are you going to do today?”

“Nothing.”

He brought the spoon to my mouth and I opened it absentmindedly.

“You’re gonna be here all day?”

“Yes. Do you mind?”

He gathered the rest of the porridge and ate it.

I looked down at the ring on my middle finger that was no longer there.

“No. It’s just that I’m not used to being around someone all day.”

“It’s only a matter of time. You’ll get used to it soon.”

He finished his coffee and handed me a cup of tea.

And he was right. I did get used to having him around all the time.

We’d been falling asleep and waking up together for nearly a month. We had breakfast, lunch and dinner together. He washed me and brought me back to bed. I’d fall asleep wearing his clothes, snug in his arms.

He seamlessly blended into my life before I knew it.

Whenever he was gone for a long time, I’d begin to miss him.

I got used to our routine.

I liked it.

But most of all I liked how my body came alive when I was with him.

I felt my heart thumping steadily. I felt like kissing him.

It was addictive. I knew I wanted to live for him, after all. Everyday musings about him began to replace my own thoughts.

I was ashamed to admit it, but I craved his attention.

I’d pretend to be unwell just so he’d give me all his attention, care and a bit of affection. I got addicted to his touch.

This addiction began to consume me, driving me crazy.

Now I would lay in his arms, listening to the beating of his heart, feeling like the happiest girl in the world.

I felt inspired and elated. I greedily took his scent in.

I started to smell just like him. I wanted to crawl under his skin. I really wanted to merge and become one with him.

Before bed, instead of falling asleep right away, I'd imagine what kind of couple we could be. How great we'd look together. How he'd hold my hand in front of everyone. How he'd tell everyone I was his.

I realized I actually wanted it. I wanted him to tell everyone we were together, that I was his girlfriend. I wanted him to be all mine.

It sounded utterly selfish, but it's true. I wanted to possess him. Wanted him to belong to no one else but me. But I also wanted him to crave it as ravenously as I did.

"Your heart's beating too fast. What are you thinking of?"

"Just some silly things."

He let out a small chuckle into my hair.

His grip tightened as he pulled me even closer.

I was too hot, but I didn't move.

I liked to move away and wait for the cherished moments when he'd pull me back to him.

I loved his arms holding me. His breath in my hair.

I rested my hand on his arm and drifted off to sleep.

I woke up in an empty bed and turned around to make sure he really wasn't there.

It sent a faint wave of blues through my heart.

Sometimes I slept through the day just to wake up when I could see him again. My head was beginning to hurt from sleeping so much. So I stopped.

Today I decided to head to his closet. I took out every single thing he had hanging in there. I put it all on a small closet island and looked it over, trying to memorize everything.

I took out his black shirt and tried it on. He wore it and his scent clung to the fabric now. It was way too long and almost reached my knees.

I smiled as I looked at myself in the mirror.

"What are you doing?"

I jumped.

"Nothing."

"Doesn't look like nothing to me. Why is my stuff on the floor?"

“I... I was looking for some clothes to change into.”

I’d never come here for clothes before. He was the only one coming here to bring something out to me.

I began to put everything back in the glass wardrobe.

I felt his warm body press against mine from behind.

He buried his face in my hair and his arms wrapped around my waist.

I felt like my heart was ready to burst.

“Your heart beats so fast when I touch you.”

To say that I was afraid of him would have been stupid. He knew I wasn’t.

I decided to say nothing.

I turned to face him and met his obsidian eyes, dark as the vasts of the deep space, ready to suck me in and lock me there forever.

I stood on my toes and kissed him on the lips. He parted them and began to kiss me gently.

I realized I had to take the first step. So I let my tongue slip between his lips. His grip on my waist tightened.

I rested my hands on his neck.

I kissed him the way I’d long dreamed of. I ran my hand through his hair and pulled at it softly.

He let out a soft hiss and lifted me up into his arms, letting me wrap my legs around his waist.

He carried and put me on the island in the middle of the closet.

I began to take his clothes off, unbuttoning his shirt.

I broke the kiss to get lower, kissing his chin and moving towards his neck.

It felt like I was drowning in emotions, excitement and wild pleasure I could no longer keep hidden.

I ran my tongue over the scar on his shoulder and he growled.

He grabbed me by the neck, his thumb lifting my chin.

“Are you trying to drive me insane?”

I reached out to kiss him, but he pulled back, keeping one hand on my neck.

“What are you doing? Is this your new plan?”

I frowned a little.

“What does it look like to you?”

“Answer the question.”

His coldness confused me.

“I want...”

I hid my face in my hands.

“I can’t say it. It’s just too...”

His hand left my neck and I heard him step away from me.

I pulled my hands away and watched as he changed his clothes.

“Don’t start something you’re not ready to finish.”

He slammed the wardrobe door and I flinched.

He left the room, leaving me behind.

Shame paralyzed me. I couldn’t tell him what he wanted to hear so badly.

My emotions were overwhelming, but I still couldn’t bring myself to give in to them and tell him how I truly felt.

Did that make him mad? Did he want me to make up my mind on this? Make a choice?

I jumped off the island, turned off the lights and headed back to bed.

I lay on my side of the bed and felt him pull me close a few minutes later. His touch evoked emotions in me.

He made me feel so good every day that I began to take it for granted.

A new day arrived and I was thankful for it. I felt like I could breathe again. I had breakfast, took a shower and liked it.

I appreciated everything I did and the things around me.

Pulling back the curtains, I saw the sun breaking through the clouds, struggling to spill its warm light on the grass outside.

I made the bed, worked out and was lying on the bed again, staring at the door.

When was he coming back? Maybe he’d come early today?

Before I knew it, I was fast asleep once again, and when I woke up, I saw he wasn’t back yet.

I decided that I had to tell him what he wanted to hear.

I had to break this vicious cycle and bury the dagger of vengeance.

We should be together. It was obvious from the day we met. We were made for each other. A perfect match.

The rays of the sun no longer lit up the room. They got smothered by thick, dark clouds. They cast a grim shadow over the sky, but not over my mood.

After months spent cooped up in this room like a princess in a tower, I decided to get up and finally leave it.

I didn't think it'd be possible before. I thought I'd never get out again. It sucked my body in and glued it in place, taking away all the strength I had to leave.

Turns out, getting out was easier than I thought.

Despite the gloomy weather, I decided to go outside for a walk. More specifically, I was going to look for Eric.

I headed for the stairs, but heard something fall in his office.

My body quickly turned towards the sound.

I walked up to the door to his office and pulled the handle.

I opened it and felt all my feelings crumble at my feet like they'd been crushed and scattered.

I saw the brunette sitting on his desk, with him standing between her long legs. She was caressing his neck, the flesh I'd had under my fingers just a day earlier.

She saw me over his shoulder and her smile faded. It was replaced by the curiosity in her gaze. It's like she'd never seen me before. Like she had no idea who I was.

Her reaction drove sharp daggers into my heart, twisting them twice.

He demanded my commitment, while keeping me out of sight like an embarrassing secret. Like I wasn't even worth mentioning. Like I was nothing but a shadow. Hidden away, invisible, I'd only appear once certain conditions were met. Once he created these conditions.

His head turned.

He looked at me with a cold and detached gaze, like I was less than nothing.

"Close the door from the other side."

His voice gripped and tore my heart to pieces, letting it crush on the floor.

I closed the door and headed back to the bedroom, my body numb and frigid.

I lay down on the bed like a lifeless puppet, pulling the blanket over myself.

Did he do it because I didn't confess to him yesterday? Did he get mad and decide to get back at me? How could he do that? How could he sleep with her? How could he let her touch him after spending the night cuddling up to me?

Questions gnawed at me like starving coyotes.

I thought he stopped seeing her, but she'd been coming to see him all this time.

I thought he chose me, but he never did.

It was just wishful thinking. I was the one seeing something that wasn't there.

He never told me he liked me. He knew how I felt about him, and he wanted me to say it out loud yesterday. He got angry, because I didn't give him a chance to crush me.

Did he hate me that much? Was he that repulsed by me?

He never promised me anything. He never told me he liked me.

He just told me I wasn't his type once, and that's how it was.

But I thought I'd make it. That I would be special. That he'd change his mind and we'd be together.

I convinced myself he was going to stay with me forever. But forever didn't exist. He's sharing his forever with her.

Tears were rolling down my face, tickling my skin and soaking up the pillow.

He could never be mine, because I never really had him.

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CHAPTER 47

~~My life is short-lived. It races in top gear, burning through the tires. I know nothing's waiting for me at the end. I remember every sin of mine, and I know they cannot be atoned for. I floor the accelerator, ignoring the red lights because nothing really matters. There's no fear anymore, relief has taken its place.~~

Another month flew by and I couldn't understand why I was still sleeping in his bed. Perhaps it was hope, or maybe it's pure masochism.

Every night he tried to hug me and fall asleep cuddling, but I'd move away to the edge of the bed. If he didn't stop, I'd get up and lie down on the floor.

My genuine feelings were replaced by rage. His presence was infuriating, his scent was smothering me and his touch felt like poison.

I realized I needed to find new meanings if I didn't want to fall into the abyss again. I needed to push him out of my head and bury him forever.

My insomnia came back along with my old habits.

I'd watch the moonlight fall on the painting.

I lost count of how many times I imagined cutting through it with a knife, how the blade would slice through it softly, how I'd bring a lighter to it and let the fire engulf the canvas, turning it to ash.

We barely shared a word since that day.

Eric began dragging me to these stupid, pointless events again. He didn't boss me around or force me to do things I didn't want to do.

The parties bored me, tugging at my barely healed wounds.

At every event, I waited for him to leave me and go see her, but I didn't see her once since that day. I knew they were still together and it drove me insane.

Day after day, night after night, event after event, I realized that each time I was falling further and further back.

I was afraid of going back. Backslides brought out a primal fear in me.

So I found a new passion in alcohol.

I'd chug anything the waiters offered. The first thing I'd do was to head over to bars and ask them to pour me every drink they had on the menu.

I'd run away from Eric and get so drunk I couldn't even remember what happened the next day.

At one of the events, I got so drunk I screamed at the top of my lungs that Eric was sleeping with me and that I was his girlfriend, but he was ashamed of me.

After this incident, he began to monitor me, or what I drank, to be precise.

He took my drinks away and brought me juice, telling everybody I was pregnant. He made it clear to the staff that he'd chop off the hands of anyone who tried to bring me anything stronger than juice.

At every reception I'd try to bribe, blackmail and beg them to bring me booze, but people were too afraid of him.

He did it on purpose, as always.

He'd take away anything I really wanted. After all, I could have nothing, he said so himself.

I hoped he felt mortified every time I got plastered and began hitting on guys.

"Would you like some?" the waiter asked, holding out something hidden in his fist.

I smiled at him.

Let him die of shame.

I hid the tiny bag in my bra.

Finishing another glass of orange juice I could barely stand at that point, I headed to the bathroom when a warm hand grabbed me.

"What?" I hissed.

He narrowed his eyes.

I sighed dramatically and blew air in his face.

"Anything else?"

He came closer and my back hit the wall.

My damn heart picked up the pace.

His black eyes, cold as the frozen void, looked at me closely.

“Don’t you dare even take a shot, Zoe. I’ll throw you into the cage in the basement. You won’t just stop going to parties, I wouldn’t even let you see the light of day. Do you understand?”

“Have you forgotten? I’m pregnant. You can’t put me in a cage,” I smirked.

He leaned in and whispered,

“Do you want to be pregnant? I can help you with that. Then you’d stop guzzling down stupid crap for sure.”

Terror gripped me with its cold hands.

Every time I’d think it just couldn’t get any worse. And every single time I’d be proven wrong.

His gaze slid down to my lips.

I was ready to give in, but clenched my fists at the last moment, digging my nails into my palms.

“Can I go now?”

“Where to?”

“I need to pee. I’ve been drinking the damn orange juice all night.”

“Kiss me.”

I furrowed my brows, trying to ignore all my senses coming alive at his request.

I leaned in and gave him a quick kiss. It sent a wave of pleasure through me, waking up the addiction I’d been trying so hard to forget.

He pressed me against the wall and kissed me deeper, more aggressively. I could feel the heat rising in my body. My heart was pounding against his chest. His tongue dominated me, creeping in between my lips and circling mine. His hard-on was pressing against my abdomen. I felt my arousal make my heart race.

I pulled away.

“I need to pee,” I whispered, looking away.

I felt his black eyes on me, paralyzing me like thick tar poured over my body, impossible to get rid of. He was breathing heavily, staring me down.

He nodded slowly and I left.

I ran into the bathroom stall and locked it behind me. I put the toilet seat down and sat on it, trying to come to my senses. I rested elbows on my knees, holding my head in my hands.

Once my heartbeat went back to normal, I got up and pulled the white bag from my bra. I wiped the surface with my sleeve and poured all the powder out. I didn't know what it was or how much I needed to snort.

I hesitated a little, but brought my nose closer and snorted a line.

I was wiping my nose when I felt a jolt of energy hit me.

Euphoria spread throughout my body. Happiness swept me over. I was drowning in it.

I laughed.

"Holy shit, why haven't I tried this before?"

I left the stall and headed back to the ballroom. As I made my way through the crowd, I bumped into a man.

"What's the rush, gorgeous?"

I smiled.

"Couldn't wait to see you, obviously."

His smile grew wider.

I took his hand and pulled him into a room where the music wasn't as loud.

My entire body got too sensitive. I felt like it was on fire. My body burned with a desire for revenge.

We walked into the room and I let go of him the second I saw a decanter of whiskey.

What a lovely night this was turning out to be!

I poured myself whiskey with trembling hands, spilling some onto the table. He came up to me from behind and began kissing my neck. I giggled, downing the delicious alcohol.

I turned to face him. He lifted me up and sat me on the table. He kept kissing my neck, pulling my thong down and moving to my breasts.

I felt so amazing I thought I was going to die from it.

I leaned back on my hands and laughed, staring at the ceiling.

The door burst open, making me jump.

Eric raised a gun and shot the man in the leg. The man dropped to the floor, groaning in pain.

Damn. That didn't last.

He walked up to me, staring me down. He wasn't just angry. He was enraged. His chest heaved with anger. His eyes were darker than a moonless night. His knuckles turned white from gripping the gun so tight.

“I didn’t sleep with her. I didn’t...”

Never taking his eyes off me, Eric fired twice. I swallowed audibly.

My thoughts were a mess and I couldn’t get them together and realize I now had another death on my hands.

His silence was unnerving. I was on the verge of losing it.

Why wasn’t he yelling? Why wasn’t he threatening to throw me in a cage? Why wouldn’t he say anything? Why?

He pulled out his phone and called Norman.

“Get the car to the back.”

He put the phone back in his pocket and I slowly got to my feet.

My thong was hanging off my left leg. I shook my foot to kick it off.

Eric bent down and picked it up, putting it in his pocket.

I turned to look at the body on the floor.

My heart was pounding wildly, my head spinning.

We left the room and I headed towards the exit, but Eric grabbed my arm.

“We aren’t leaving.”

“Where are we going then?”

Adrenaline made my head pound while endorphins were flowing through my body like sunbeams on sand. All my senses got so sharp it made me sick.

Eric dragged me from one room to another. My heels wouldn’t let me walk quickly, so I stumbled, grabbing onto him for support.

We stormed into the kitchen and saw the waiters. They were sitting around, chatting excitedly, but once they saw us, the room fell silent immediately.

Eric turned to look at me and asked through gritted teeth,

“Who was it?”

“What?”

He shot the guy I’d never seen before. Screams filled the kitchen. The waiters scattered, but he managed to shoot some of them in the back.

I blinked rapidly, opening and closing my mouth in an attempt to pull myself together and say something.

He turned towards me, but my mouth still hung open as I tried to get the words out. It’s like I forgot how to speak.

Another shot followed. Another dead body hit the floor with a thud. Women screamed, trying to cover themselves with their hands.

“Then I’ll kill everyone.”

One by one, they fell to the ground until there was no one left to scream.

“He’s not here,”

I finally managed to whisper, but only after there was no one left alive.

Eric grabbed my hand and pulled me further into the kitchen. In there, other waiters were hiding behind the metal tables.

Every one of them got a bullet to the head.

I turned away and threw up orange juice.

I crouched down, spitting bile, and my eyes met the gaze of that same waiter.

I could see terror written on his face. He put a finger to his lips. His hands were shaking.

I sat there, staring at him, trying to collect my thoughts.

I looked up at Eric and then down at the floor.

He walked up to the table and I stood up, grabbing his hand.

“Please, don’t. You’ve killed so many people. They’re innocent. They just carry snacks around.”

He grabbed my face, squeezing painfully.

“Innocent? Have you fucking seen yourself? You look like a motherfucking junkie. Your pupils are so dilated I can’t even see your irises. How much did you snort? How much?”

He was yelling and I shuddered.

He hissed under his breath and let me go.

Flipping the table over, he grabbed the guy as he began begging for mercy.

He stepped on his hand and I heard a crunch that made me throw up a second time.

He shot both his legs. The poor waiter screamed like a madman, hurting my ears. I covered them with my hands.

Eric put the gun to his forehead and I turned away, not ready to see what was about to happen.

A shot followed, and the screaming stopped.

I stood there, staring at the wall, too scared to turn around and face what I'd done.

My whole body was shaking and my brain was about to explode.

Eric grabbed my arm and pulled me towards the exit.

People shot wary glances our way, but he didn't care.

Eric opened the door and almost threw me into the car, slamming it behind me.

It stunned me, sending a sharp pain through my head. I felt like it was going to split in two.

During our ride back home, I kept rubbing each finger on my left hand. It hurt, but I didn't stop.

An hour passed, and he didn't say a single word.

"Do you want me to apologize?"

I looked at Eric, but he stayed silent, ignoring me.

And I knew I got what I wanted. I wanted to pay him back. Hurt him as much as he'd hurt me.

I pouted, tilting my head to the side, and said mockingly,

"I hope you hate me as much as I hate you now."

He turned to look at me.

His face was expressionless.

"Not as much as you hate yourself."

My mouth opened and I quickly turned away from him, looking out the window.

Winter's frigid claws had already gripped the world around us. The frost pinched my cheeks. Snowflakes fell from the sky, melting on the glass. The beautiful, unique white flakes turned into droplets of water, swept away by a powerful gust of wind.

CHAPTER 48

~~I always get angry when things don't go according to plan. I'd think things through for a while, wasting time and energy to clear the coast for myself. But life swoops in and throws me onto a rough path filled with obstacles. I'd get angry and curse everything, but once I reach my goal, I do feel grateful.~~

I sat in the living room with my arms crossed, swinging my leg. I stared at the wine rack.

Eric took me to another meeting despite me begging him to let me stay home.

I told him I had a headache. That I had hangover, which, of course, wasn't true.

But I was careless and lost whatever trust he still had in me.

The reaper saw right through me. He refused to leave me alone even for a little while at that point.

He'd leave Norman to babysit me. Norman's loyal to him. Too much so. There was no negotiating with him, no way to blackmail him or pull at his heartstrings.

I jumped to my feet and headed towards the rack.

Norman grabbed my arm and yanked me back onto the couch.

"Your boss won't like it when he finds out how you treat his property," I hissed.

"My boss allowed me to treat you like this," he replied calmly.

"What do you mean he allowed it?" I snapped back.

"You've upset him."

I huffed, crossing my arms over my chest.

"He needs to chill, then," I mumbled under my breath.

The telephone rang. Norman took the call and got up, heading to the door. There he stopped and turned back to me.

“You’re coming with me.”

I sighed audibly.

My good pal *red semisweet* was going to have to stay behind the rack.

We were about to leave when the sound of gunshots from the room further down the hall stopped us in our tracks.

I instinctively ducked.

Heartbeat was ringing in my ears.

“Get back,” Norman whispered, clicking the safety switch.

I ran back in and closed the door behind me.

I paced back and forth, rubbing the fingers on my left hand.

Eric was going to be okay, right? They couldn’t have killed him, could they?

I quickly ran to the shelves, looking for anything sharp.

I slammed open the cabinets, rummaging through them and praying I’d find something useful.

There was nothing.

I stood up and began looking around the room. My eyes fell on a large bronze figurine. It depicted a lion with a beautifully wavy mane. Its mouth was wide open, revealing the sharp teeth, and its large paws with sharp claws stood on the paws of a wolf that looked more like a hyena. It reminded me of the sculpture called *Animals Fighting*.

I grabbed it as a man stormed into the room, pointing a gun at my head.

I froze.

My gaze fell on his left hand. Blood was dripping from it, falling onto the floor.

“Drop it,” he said in an even tone.

I swallowed a lump of panic hard and threw the figurine next to me without any sudden movements.

It fell with a loud thud. The floor beneath me shook under its weight.

I froze, as if I’d turned into the statue lying at my feet.

The wooden floor creaked under his quick steps. He came up to me and wrapped his left arm around my neck, pulling me closer.

The icy barrel was pressed against my temple.

I became speechless and my head felt empty. And it was never empty. There was always chaos, storm, a whirlwind, but not emptiness. This emptiness scared me as much as his weapon.

We stood silently, staring at the door.

I felt the blood from his arm soaking up my lily-white dress like a sponge.

I hated this color.

There was a clatter of shoes and Eric ran into the room, with Norman following suit.

My eyes darted all over him, trying to figure out if he was hurt.

But he was unharmed.

The realization hit me over the head like a baseball bat.

Eric wasn't going to keep me alive. He wasn't going to sacrifice his goal for me, especially when it could be solved with just one bullet. He told me I'd have to die if he told me to. And that day was finally here.

I was going to die with a gun to my head, and then Eric would kill him. That's the end. That's how I die.

The feeling of freedom made my body relax.

I was going to win after all, right? I would finally be free, wouldn't I?

"You're out of luck. You're gonna die today."

"Shut up," the man hissed, pushing the gun barrel to my temple harder.

"I hate to break it to you, but you have nothing to offer him. You're a deadman. And to be fair, so am I," I uttered the last sentence under my breath.

"What do you want?" Eric asked.

My gaze turned towards him.

I watched him closely, trying to guess what was on his mind.

What was he doing? Was he going to negotiate with him? But why?

Eric I knew would never cave in to anyone. Especially when someone gave him an ultimatum. He didn't like losing control over everything.

"You know what. Just your signature."

"Norman, get the papers," Eric said, looking at the man.

"What are you doing?"

Why was he complicating things? Why was he betraying his principles?

Anger from the unanswered questions boiled inside me.

Norman left as quickly as he'd return, handing the papers to Eric.

"You don't give a crap about me."

He looked up at me with his dark eyes and turned to Norman.

"I need a pen."

Norman nodded and left the room.

"Why do you act like you give a damn?"

I saw his jaw clench.

“Let him shoot me, like you would anyone else standing here. Act like you always do,” I was almost screaming.

“Zoe...”

I wasn’t just angry, I was enraged.

“You told me once I’ll have to die if you say so. Now’s the perfect time to let me die. Sacrifice me.”

I was panting. I could feel my limbs shake from all the adrenaline. My ears throbbed.

It pissed me off to know he wasn’t willing to sacrifice me. Wasn’t ready to let me go. Because that meant he cared.

Than I was important for him, and I didn’t want to be. I didn’t want to mean anything. I wanted to be a nobody. Wanted to free myself from him.

“Zoe, please, shut up,” he said coldly, not even looking at me.

I snapped.

“You want me to shut up?” I blurted out, “Fuck you, Eric!”

I thrashed about, trying to free myself.

“Shoot. Shoot me. He’s gonna kill you the moment you sign the papers anyway. Shoot,” I shouted.

“Stop fucking fidgeting,” the man yelled.

He gripped me tighter.

My heart was throbbing, muffling the voices.

“Say you don’t care if I die.”

He wasn’t looking at me.

“Eric.”

He raised his eyes to look at me.

“Say it.”

Norman brought a pen and Eric signed the papers with a swift motion of his hand.

Everyone lowered their guns. The man was no longer holding me.

Eric handed him the papers and he came closer to pick them up.

I was panting heavily, trying to accept the fact that he actually gave a damn about me.

My gaze fell on the gun in the man’s belt.

I quickly ran up to him and grabbed it.

I pulled the gun on my attacker.

“Zoe, what are you doing?” Eric growled.

“Answer my question.”

Eric let out a heavy sigh.

He pulled out a gun and shot the guy twice in the chest. The man dropped dead.

My eyes widened in horror. My chin was shaking.

I put my hand down and let the gun fall at my feet.

Another death that could've been avoided.

When will it stop? When will there no longer be blood on my hands?
When will my dress stay white?

I raised my eyes to look at him.

He put the gun down with a calm expression, ignoring me outright.

I walked up to him quickly.

“What are you doing? You were supposed to let him kill me. Isn't this my job? Or do I no longer work for you? If I no longer work for you, does it mean I can leave?” I hissed through gritted teeth.

“Did I tell you to die? Did I let you sacrifice your life? Or provoke him?”

He was yelling at me, no longer holding his anger back.

“The problem is, you really care. You never have before. You always walked all over me. I was less than nothing to you. But why now?”

My voice was quivering.

“Why have I become important to you now?” I saw something behind the anger in his eyes, something new.

It was doubt.

I had never seen doubt in his eyes before.

That's when I realized. He didn't know the answer to this question, either.

It was getting harder to breathe.

I couldn't bear it anymore. I wasn't going to enter his circle of affection.

I hastily walked towards the door on the opposite end of the room.

I ran downstairs to the nearest door, but it was closed. I hurried to another door and pulled the iron handle.

It opened and the icy air hit my face.

In the distance I saw a gazebo and decided to hide there.

On my way there, I slipped a few times, falling on the cold ground and staining my white dress.

I ran into the gazebo, panting heavily.

Thoughts swirled in my head like a blizzard.

What now? What was he going to do now? Maybe he'd kill me himself at this point?

No. Had he wanted to, he'd have finished me back there, in that room.

Was I his type? Could he really have feelings for me? Did I want him to have feelings for me? Could we end up together? What about the brunette?

I stopped pacing around the table and sat down on the cold wooden steps of the gazebo.

Tiny snowflakes fell to the ground, trying to cover it with a blanket of fluffy snow.

I held my hand out and a couple snowflakes landed in my palm. They melted the second they met my skin.

That's what happens when two worlds collide. One of them dies.

On the floor to my right lay a pack of cigarettes, a lighter and an ashtray.

I took out a cigarette and struggled to make the lighter work.

My thumb got tired of clicking the wheel.

I shook the lighter and tried again. A small fire flared up and I quickly pushed the cigarette towards it.

Taking a drag, I felt the bitter taste invade my mouth. The burning sensation in my throat was choking me, and I coughed violently.

It was horrible! How could anyone smoke that?

I cleared my throat and sighed heavily, but left the cigarette to smolder in my mouth.

When was anything good going to happen? When were the changes coming? When was it going to get easier? When would I finally get the chance to live the life I'd been dreaming of? When?

I no longer wanted to run away after the Judgement night at that party. I didn't want to escape because there was no point in it anymore.

It scared me half to death that I'd lost faith in myself. Faith in freedom. Faith in my future. Faith in having a life of my own.

Why wouldn't anything change? Why wasn't it getting better? Why was everything getting more complicated when time should have cleared things out? Why do we get attached to those we're supposed to hate? Why do we care about people who don't deserve it?

I was looking at the snowflakes on the snow-covered ground when I heard the crunch of someone's approaching footsteps in the snow.

Eric covered my shoulders with a heavy fur coat.

The wooden steps creaked under his weight.

He took the pack of cigarettes and began clicking the lighter.
The lighter wouldn't obey him, either, and it made me smile.
He threw it aside and came closer to me, trying to light his cigarette on mine.

His dark eyes looked into mine and I didn't want to look away. I enjoyed staring into them.

My stomach twisted with excitement and a sudden rush of heat.

He turned away and blew smoke.

"I'm surprised you didn't snatch my cigarette."

He chuckled and took a drag, blowing the smoke.

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CHAPTER 49

~~I hate you.~~ I hate you. I hate you. I hate you. I hate you. I hate you. I hate
you. I hate you. I hate you. I hate you. I hate you. I hate you. I hate you. I
hate you. I hate you.

“Did you know your name means *life* in Greek?”

“Life,” I smirked, “how ironic.”

I took the cigarette out of my mouth and ashed it.

“What does *vita mea* mean?”

I saw the corners of his lips rise slightly, but he didn't smile.

“I’ll save the answer for our next conversation.”

My pulse was pounding in my ears as if I'd been on a morning jog.

Every time I saw even a glimpse of his smile, my breathing would hitch and my pulse picked up pace.

The snowfall got heavier, building a snow-bound veil and obscuring the forest in the distance.

The white flakes turned into fluff, falling steadily onto the still barely covered ground.

We watched the white fog in silence.

“Do you ever get lonely?”

“Sometimes.”

“Killing condemns you to eternal loneliness. I felt that.”

His eyes met mine and I immediately looked away, looking at the snowflakes landing on a wooden step.

“Have you thought about what happens next?”

“I do, every day.”

He blew the smoke out his mouth, ashing his cigarette onto the snowy ground.

“Thinking of the future terrifies me.”

He took a drag and blew the smoke out of his nose.

I stubbed out my unsmoked cigarette and threw it into the ashtray.

“Are you afraid of dying?”

“No.”

I pulled another cigarette out.

“I am,” I said, my voice barely a whisper.

He turned to me and looked into my eyes.

“Weren’t you ready to die today?”

“That doesn’t cancel my fear out. I’m afraid, because I know no one’s gonna meet me on the other side when I die.”

He looked down and turned away.

“Is there still time for redemption? Or is it too late?” I asked quietly.

“Do you want the redemption?”

“Yes. I don’t want to die a bad person.”

He stubbed out his cigarette and took out another one.

He took a lighter out of his coat pocket and lit it.

“You told me I wasn’t going to end up like you. You were wrong.”

“No. Because you didn’t.”

“Do you seek redemption?”

“No. My soul belongs to the darkness, you said so yourself.”

“This doesn’t mean you can’t wish for it.”

“I don’t need redemption to feel good about myself.”

I twirled the new cigarette in my hands, breaking it and crumbling the tobacco between my fingertips.

“I don’t think you’re evil anymore.”

He raised his cosmic void-colored eyes to look at me.

“But you’ll remain exactly that in my story. I know you don’t care for my forgiveness,” I turned my head to him, meeting his gaze, “but I will never forgive you.”

I took another cigarette, slowly ripping the paper and grinding the tobacco between my fingers. A small pile of tobacco had already gathered at my brown boots.

“Do you have feelings for me?”

I felt my pulse speed up as a wave of heat washed over my body.

“Yes, hatred. Just as you wanted.”

“Anything else?”

“Anger, disdain, disgust, resentment, fear...”

That wasn’t all, but I had no reason to go on talking.

“And?”

Jealousy, attraction, desire, passion. Maybe even infatuation.

I could feel his eyes on me.

“You still like me.”

Hearing him say that made me mad.

“No,” I replied, barely holding back my frustration.

I stared silently at the tobacco in my hand, my thoughts and feelings spinning in circles.

“It doesn’t matter, how I feel. My body may be attracted to you. But it only does so because I’ve betrayed it and it’s kicking me back. Its desires can’t dictate the terms of my life. It’ll pass, I know it. Like a disease. A long, violent illness with complications. My body is sick now, but maybe it would heal tomorrow. I just need to wait it out and be patient. And then all of it will fade away, and it won’t matter anymore. After all, I’ll break free, knowing I didn’t betray myself. That I didn’t betray my soul. It’ll stay loyal to me. It will never be yours. I’ve never chosen you and never will. I will never be yours.”

I turned to look at him. He stared straight at the snow-bound forest.

I kicked away a handful of tobacco and began to wipe my fingers.

His fingers touched a strand of my hair and I froze. He tucked it behind my ear.

My thoughts disappeared. Desire took their place. My body ached in anticipation of his touch after so many months apart.

He came closer to kiss me. My lips parted, inviting him. He kissed me deliberately, softly and languidly. He gently touched my bottom lip, licking and sucking it. A moan rose in my throat, but I balled my hand into a fist to keep it down.

He kissed me once again and pulled away.

“You should go,” he whispered.

He wasn’t going back home?

Eric stood up and offered me his hand to help me up.

I felt my legs go numb from sitting down on cold steps for too long.

I wasn’t dressed for the weather at all, and the frost was freezing and chilling me to the bone.

My fur coat fell to the ground and he bent down to pick it up and helped me put it on.

His pleasant aroma enveloped me. I wanted to cling to him and drown in his arms.

I looked up at him, but he wasn't looking at me.

I didn't know why, but I really wanted to take his hand, and I did.

His eyes met mine, but they looked as cold as they did the day we first met.

How could such a warm color be so cold?

I let go of his hand, ashamed of myself for giving in to these impulses.

I walked down the steps and was about to head back to the house when he suddenly grabbed my arm.

My entrancement got mixed in with an unbearable pain in my chest. I looked down and saw a knife sticking out of my chest.

Tears began streaming down my face. I tried to push him away, but he held me tight, still looking at me with those ice-cold eyes.

The searing pain overwhelmed me, but the pain of his betrayal felt deadly.

I could taste blood in my mouth.

I coughed, staining his black coat.

Why?

Why now?

I pushed him once again, and he released me.

I fell on my side onto the snow-covered ground.

A wave of pain rushed from the kick-back to the bleeding wound, forcing me to fight the darkness creeping in.

I moaned, but it only made the pain worse.

I wanted to embrace the darkness, but couldn't give up just yet. I lay there, trying to reach for the knife as tears blurred my vision. But the pain of every movement crushed me.

I tried to get up, but only wasted whatever energy I still had left. Lying there, all I could do was weep and wail.

I could feel my strength leaving me with every little twitch.

I heard the crunch of snow and saw black shoes stop in front of me.

He crouched down and brushed a strand of hair from my face.

"You trusted me. I like looking into your eyes as I crush that fragile trust of yours. What's it like, to be betrayed by the man you love?"

His lips curved into a smile that looked more like a sinister grin.

“It hurts, I’m sure. I hope the pain’s insane, unbearable even. I stabbed the knife just above your heart on purpose, to make sure you’ll suffer till your last moment. I wanted your death to be slow. I want you to feel it with your whole body. I’ve been planning it for a long time. I’ve thought everything through, down to the last detail. Every day I’d imagine my revenge and fall asleep thinking about it. I became obsessed with it.”

His warm hand caressed my cheek.

With the last of my strength, I pushed his hand away from my cheek like it was filthy.

He gave me a weak smile.

His fingers slid down to my neck, clavicle and then my breasts. With one sweep, he jerked and pulled the knife out.

My body was in agony.

I screamed so loud it felt like my vocal cords were going to burst.

“Now you truly know how I felt.”

I didn’t know what he was talking about.

“And now. I’m going to sit back and watch as life slowly leaves your body.”

“You, monster,” I whispered.

“If I’m a monster, then who are you, Zoe?”

“What are you talking about?”

My eyelids grew heavy. I was on the verge of blacking out.

A wide grin appeared on his face. It was chilling. A smile of the true evil, a murderer.

“I’ll be waiting for you, *vita mea*.”

The darkness enveloped me, inviting me to fade into it.

A piercing monotonous sound hurt my ears.

Was this what my fate was going to be? Was I in hell? Was this my eternal punishment?

I tried to open my eyelids, but they were too heavy.

My whole body ached and whined. I felt incredible weakness and fatigue in every muscle.

I forced my eyes open with great effort.

My vision was blurry. I blinked and moved my eyes slowly. Once my vision came back to life, I saw a painting in front of me. It was The Dark Cloud.

Was I in his room? Didn’t he kill me? Why did he do this?

I slowly looked around the room.

I saw a large open window. A cool breeze blew the sheer curtains about. The room was milky white and my bed had no canopy. Pictures and paintings hung on the walls around the room.

Under the painting stood a tall oak chest of drawers. To the left was a stack of records and a record player.

Tears welled up in my eyes, stinging and giving me mixed feelings.

I was in my room.

At my own house.

I was home.

Tears ran down my cheeks, tickling my chin and neck.

Memories fell into place in my head like puzzle pieces.

The realization of everything that'd happened crushed my throat and chest.

I could barely breathe.

He did it.

I wanted to call for help, but could only let out a quiet, unintelligible moan.

I couldn't move my neck.

I looked down, searching for a call button. Thankfully, it was left in my hand.

I tried pushing it, but my hands were too weak. I kept trying and trying, but my hands wouldn't work.

I tried shifting in bed at least a little bit. My body wouldn't move.

Arista entered the room. She was deep in thought until her eyes met mine.

Her eyes went wide when she saw me.

"I'll call the doctor."

I mumbled.

"What..."

She frowned, watching me with a worried look in her eyes.

"You've been paralyzed. You can't talk or move. You've been in a coma for almost six months. I call the doctor."

I moaned incoherently, because that's what my screams sounded like.

Tears rolled down my cheeks as I kept moaning and sobbing.

6 months ago

The walls were vibrating from the basses.

My ears rang from the booming music.

The face was flushed from the alcohol.

I carried my shoes in my hand as I climbed the cold marble steps on the way to my room.

The cold steps sent pleasant sensations throughout my body.

Once I opened the door, a terribly familiar scent invaded my nostrils, though I couldn't exactly pinpoint, who it reminded me of.

Fear was building up, sending alarm signals all over my body.

The warm light of the bedside lamps barely lit up the room.

Did he come to kill me? How did he get past the guards? Why did nobody notice him?

I hired five more security guards in the last six months. It all felt like a waste of money.

I didn't know, where he was hiding, but I was sure he'd come for me.

"The guards will be here any minute, you should leave while you still can."

I threw the shoes aside.

He was standing there like a statue, transfixed by the painting hanging across from my bed.

"I remember this painting. What's it called?"

"I did not invite you. Leave."

"You've invited over a hundred people. You could've forgotten to put me on the list."

"I didn't invite you," I spat through gritted teeth.

"The Dark Cloud."

He went silent.

His silence unnerved me.

I was trying to remember where I'd left the dagger. My eyes dashed from the desk to my closet, from the closet to the nightstand.

He calmly turned to face me. His dark-brown eyes looked jet-black. The freezing cold look in his eyes made the hair on the back of my neck stand up.

I squeezed each finger on my left hand with my thumb.

"I brought you a gift."

"I don't want anything from you," I blurted out.

"You've been dreaming of it for a while. You'll like it."

My gaze fell on a black folder with a pink bow left on the dresser.

I let out a heavy sign.

Why now?

He's lying. It's empty.

But what if it's not?

I made two steps and stopped.

"Don't you wanna see, what's inside?"

My palms got sweaty. Heartbeat was ringing in my ears. My mouth felt dry.

He smirked.

"Why did you bring it now?"

"Wanted to wait till your birthday."

"Bullshit," I spat.

He smiled, looking down at the floor, and then slowly looked up from under his eyebrows.

He turned around and walked to my record player.

Squatting down next to it, he began looking through the records like they were his and he was in his room.

His composure was creeping me out.

I felt every hair stand up on the back of my neck.

I could sense the impending danger. It was breathing down my neck.

He put one record on and the song filled the room.

"Shall we dance?"

He held out his hand, waiting for me.

He made it clear he wasn't going anywhere.

I couldn't see what he was hiding in his belt behind him. He might be armed.

He might as well have killed me the moment I entered the room.

What did he want then? What was he waiting for? Maybe he came for a truce?

No. There could be no truce. Not after the things he did.

He raised his hands and turned around slowly, showing me he wasn't armed.

"Do you believe me now?"

Never.

I was on my turf. Maybe it was just dumb luck that he could pass through. But how was he going to leave unnoticed?

He would never make it.

I forced a smile and came up to him.

His hand enveloped mine. He hugged my waist with his left hand, roughly pushing me to his body.

Too close.

A slow song was playing.

His body heat warmed up my already heated flesh.

“What’re you gonna do when you find out what’s inside?” he asked, his voice smooth as ever.

“Depends on what’s in there.”

He smirked.

“You’re smart. Stunning. Yet so...”

“What?”

“Cruel.”

He twirled me, pulling me closer once more.

“I’m glad I’m not your type.”

“You don’t know my type.”

He twirled me again.

The song ended, and we came to a stop.

I pulled my hands away from him, taking a step back.

My gaze fell on the folder behind him.

“Tell me something.”

I looked away, meeting his gaze.

“Do you regret what you’ve done at all?”

My anger was rising like lava, ready to erupt from the volcano.

“I don’t regret doing it. Never will. I did what I had to. Did it for him. For myself. You don’t get to talk about regrets, you held a gun to his head. Now get out of my way and let me get my hands on whatever’s inside the damned folder already.”

His raven black eyes, so dark even the light would get lost in them, looked at me closely. After a moment, he stepped aside without a word.

I walked to the dresser and picked the folder up.

The moment I opened the first page, I felt a sharp pain at the back of my head. Numbness was spreading through my body fast.

I was clutching my neck, turning to face Eric with a stagger. His silhouette was blurry, as was the rest of the room.

I dropped to my knees, still gripping the folder. I tried resisting it, but my body went limp.

Darkness fell over me.

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Catch me if you can

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Thank you! Thank you! Thank you!

If *In A Bubble* resonated with you, I'd be deeply grateful if you shared your thoughts in a review. Even the smallest reflection can help this story find its way into other hearts.

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